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Galatians

Galatians 1:1

Section 1:1–5: Paul greeted the Christians in Galatia

This section is the introduction to Paul's letter to the Galatians. In this introduction, Paul followed the customs of that time for writing a letter. The custom was to put the writer's name first and then write the names of the people to whom the letter was sent. After that the writer greeted them with a wish for their well-being. So, Paul began this letter with his own name in 1:1. Then in 1:2 he mentioned the people to whom he was sending the letter. In 1:3 he greeted these people with a wish for their well-being. Among Christians, this wish was often a prayer for God's blessing.

In this section, Paul briefly introduced two main themes of his letter.

1. It was God and Jesus who had made Paul an apostle. It was not other people who had called him to become an apostle. That gave him very high authority. This authority is one of the themes of his letter, and he discussed it more fully in chapter 2.
2. In 1:4, Paul reminded the Galatians that we Christians are saved because Jesus died for our sins. The main theme of the whole letter to the Galatians is that we are saved by the grace of God and by believing in Jesus.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Greeting

Greetings from Paul

1:1a

Paul, an apostle—

- ¶ From Paul, an apostle. (NCV)
- ¶ This letter is from me, Paul, an apostle.
- ¶ I, Paul am writing/sending this letter to you^(plur). I am an apostle.

Paul: Paul began this letter with his name. He did not use a verb. But you may need to add a verb to help your readers understand that Paul was the person who wrote the letter. For example:

This letter is from Paul (NLT)

I, Paul, am writing this letter to you.

an apostle: The word apostle refers to a person whom someone sends with his authority. He sends him to give a message or to accomplish a particular task. Here, the word apostle refers to a man whom Jesus chose and gave authority. After Jesus returned to heaven, his apostles were the leaders of the people who believed in him.

If you have already translated the Gospels, you can probably use the same term for apostle as you used there.

Some ways to translate apostle are:

a special messenger

a representative

a person with authority from Jesus

a chief leader of Jesus's work

See also apostle in the Glossary for more information.

1:1b

sent not from men nor by man,

- My call to be an apostle did not come from men. It did not come/pass through a man/mediator.
- Men did not commission me to be an apostle. An intermediary did not send/choose me.
- It was not human beings who chose me to be an apostle. It was not through a middle man that Jesus chose me.

sent: In Greek, there is no verb in 1:1b. Many languages may need to supply a verb here as the BSB does. Here are some other examples of English versions that supply a verb here:

not sent from men (NASB)

I was not chosen to be an apostle by human beings (NCV)

I was not appointed by any group (NLT)

whose call to be an apostle did not come from human beings (GNT)

not from men nor by man: There are at least two ways to interpret these two phrases:

1. The focus is on the difference in meaning indicated by the two prepositions from and by. According to this interpretation, the phrase not from men means that no human being chose/commissioned Paul to be an apostle. The phrase nor by man means that there was no intermediary between God/Jesus and Paul when he chose/commissioned Paul to be an apostle. On the road to Damascus, Jesus spoke directly to Paul without going through any human being. For example:

It was not men who made me an apostle. It was not an intermediary who made me an apostle. Adapted from the French version Parole de Vie: "Ce ne sont pas des hommes qui m'ont fait apôtre. Je ne le suis pas par l'intermédiaire d'un homme...."

1. The focus is on the plural and singular nouns men and man. According to this interpretation, the first phrase means that no group of men (such as the church in Antioch or Jerusalem) chose/commissioned Paul to be an apostle. The second phrase means that no individual man (such as Ananias, Peter, Barnabas, or James) chose/commissioned him to be an apostle. For example:

chosen not by any group or individual (GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is the interpretation that most English commentaries follow. For example, Moo says that the two phrases have "sparked discussion because of the way Paul shifts the wording. He moves from the preposition apo to dia and from the plural anthropon to the singular anthropou. The latter change may signal a move from general to particular: Paul does not owe his apostolic status to 'human beings' in general; nor does he owe it to any particular human being—perhaps someone such as James or Peter (e.g., Martyn 1007:84). Such a distinction is possible, but it is perhaps more likely that the shift from plural to singular is simply stylistic. The change from apo to dia might also be stylistic, since the two prepositions have a semantic overlap in the idea of 'ultimate origin'.... However, dia more often refers to an intermediate agent: 'through' rather than 'from' or 'by'.... Paul therefore is probably making two slightly different points in these phrases: the ultimate source of his apostleship was not human; nor did he receive it from, or through, any human being ('source' vs. 'agency').... This interpretation fits Paul's general use of the two prepositions...and satis-

factorily explains why he uses both phrases" (pages 67–68).

Some other ways to translate these phrases are:

My call to be an apostle did not come from men.
It did not come through an intermediary

Men did not commission me to be an apostle. Jesus did not use an intermediary to chose/appoint me.

1:1c

but by Jesus Christ and God the Father,

- Rather, it came directly from Jesus Christ and God the Father.
- Instead Jesus Christ and God the Father commissioned/chose me.
- It was Jesus the Christ and God the Father who chose me.

but: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between those (in 1:1b) who did not send Paul and God, who did send him. Languages have different ways to indicate this negative-positive type of contrast. One of the functions of the Greek conjunction ἀλλά is to signal this negative-positive type of contrast. Some of the ways are:

- With the conjunction "but."
- With a conjunction other than "but." This is a common way in English to show this type of contrast. For example:

rather

on the contrary

instead

- With no conjunction. For example:

^bI was not chosen to be an apostle by human beings, nor was I sent from human beings. ^cI was made an apostle through Jesus Christ... (NCV)

by Jesus Christ and God the Father: This phrase means that Paul was chosen and sent through/by Jesus Christ and God the Father. His authority as an apostle came directly from God.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

by Jesus Christ himself and by God the Father (NLT)

I was chosen to be an apostle by Jesus Christ and by God the Father (CEV)

Jesus Christ and God the Father chose me to be an apostle

Jesus Christ: In the phrase Jesus Christ, Jesus is a personal name, and Christ is his title. Christ is not the surname of Jesus.

One way to show this is:

Jesus the Christ/Messiah

In some languages, people say the title before the name. For example:

Christ Jesus

Christ: The title Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word “Messiah.” The Jews used this title to refer to the person whom God had appointed and promised to send as king and savior.

Some ways to translate Christ are:

- Use a title or a descriptive phrase in your language that has the same meaning as Christ. For example:

the Messiah

the Promised Deliverer

the Rescuer/Ruler whom God appointed

- Transliterate Christ and include a phrase that explains the meaning. For example:

Christ, the appointed one

Cristo, the Savior whom God promised to send

Christ, he comes from God

- Transliterate Christ and indicate in some way that it is a title. For example:

the Christ

Kirisita

If you do not indicate the meaning of Christ in the text, you may want to include a footnote to explain it. Or you may want to explain the meaning in a glossary. For example:

The word/title “Christ” refers to the one whom God had promised to send. He would be both king/ ruler and savior.

God the Father: In some languages, it may be more natural to translate God the Father as:

Father God

God our Father

1:1d who raised Him from the dead—

- It is he who raised him from death.
- He made Jesus to live again.

who raised Him from the dead: This is a relative clause. In some languages, a literal translation of this relative clause may imply a wrong meaning. It may imply that there is one God who raised Jesus from the dead, and another God who did not raise Jesus. If this is true in your language, you should translate this clause as a separate sentence. For example

He raised Him from the dead

He made Jesus to live again

General Comment on 1:1b–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of some of the clauses in 1:1b–d. For example:

^{1c}I was chosen to be an apostle by Jesus Christ and by God the Father, ^{1d}who raised him from death.

^{1b}No mere human chose or appointed me to this work. (CEV)

Galatians 1:2

Section 1:1–5: Paul greeted the Christians in Galatia

This section is the introduction to Paul’s letter to the Galatians. In this introduction, Paul followed the customs of that time for writing a letter. The custom was to put the writer’s name first and then write the names of the people to whom the letter was sent. After that

the writer greeted them with a wish for their well-being. So, Paul began this letter with his own name in 1:1. Then in 1:2 he mentioned the people to whom he was sending the letter. In 1:3 he greeted these people with a wish for their well-being. Among Christians, this wish was often a prayer for God's blessing.

In this section, Paul briefly introduced two main themes of his letter.

1. It was God and Jesus who had made Paul an apostle. It was not other people who had called him to become an apostle. That gave him very high authority. This authority is one of the themes of his letter, and he discussed it more fully in chapter 2.
2. In 1:4, Paul reminded the Galatians that we Christians are saved because Jesus died for our sins. The main theme of the whole letter to the Galatians is that we are saved by the grace of God and by believing in Jesus.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Greeting

Greetings from Paul

1:2a and all the brothers with me,

- I and all the brothers in Christ who are with me here
- This letter is also from all the fellow-believers in Christ who are together with me.

and all the brothers with me: This clause means that other believers joined with Paul in sending this letter. It implies that they supported Paul and agreed with what he wrote. They joined with Paul in sending their greetings to the Galatians.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

All the believers who are here join me in sending greetings (GNT)

All the brothers and sisters here join me in sending this letter (NLT)

This phrase does not mean that the brothers were writers with Paul. Do not imply that the brothers helped Paul to write the letter.

brothers: In the letters of the New Testament, the word brothers refers to brothers in the faith. It refers to fellow believers. It is often restricted to the leading

men in the local church. It does not refer to Paul's biological brothers.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

fellow-believers

my companions in the faith

the Lord's followers (CEV)

1:2b To the churches of Galatia:

- are sending this letter to you^(plur) who are in the churches in Galatia.
- We^(excl) are sending this letter to you^(plur) who are in the groups of believers in the province of Galatia.

To the churches of Galatia: This phrase tells to whom Paul was sending his letter. These churches were located in the Roman province of Galatia.

In Greek, this phrase has no verb. In many languages, it will be more natural to include a verb here. For example:

I am writing this letter to the churches in Galatia

We are sending this letter to the believers in the province/region of Galatia

churches: The word churches refers to groups of believers. It does not refer to church buildings.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

the groups of believers in Christ

the congregations

the people/followers of Christ

See church in the Glossary for more information.

of Galatia: Galatia was one of the provinces/regions in the Roman Empire. It is not the name of a town. To make this clear, you may say:

in the province/region of Galatia

General Comment on 1:1–2

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses in 1:1–2. Some ways to reorder these verses are:

- Begin the letter by stating that Paul and all the brothers with him sent it. For example:

This letter is from the apostle Paul and from all the brothers who are with me here.

- Begin the letter by stating that Paul sent it to the Galatian believers. Then state those who joined with Paul in sending this letter. For example:

I, Paul, am writing to you, all the believers in Galatia. All the brothers who are with me join in sending greetings to you.

Galatians 1:3

Section 1:1–5: Paul greeted the Christians in Galatia

This section is the introduction to Paul's letter to the Galatians. In this introduction, Paul followed the customs of that time for writing a letter. The custom was to put the writer's name first and then write the names of the people to whom the letter was sent. After that the writer greeted them with a wish for their well-being. So, Paul began this letter with his own name in 1:1. Then in 1:2 he mentioned the people to whom he was sending the letter. In 1:3 he greeted these people with a wish for their well-being. Among Christians, this wish was often a prayer for God's blessing.

In this section, Paul briefly introduced two main themes of his letter.

1. It was God and Jesus who had made Paul an apostle. It was not other people who had called him to become an apostle. That gave him very high authority. This authority is one of the themes of his letter, and he discussed it more fully in chapter 2.
2. In 1:4, Paul reminded the Galatians that we Christians are saved because Jesus died for our sins. The main theme of the whole letter to the Galatians is that we are saved by the grace of God and by believing in Jesus.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Greeting

Greetings from Paul

Paragraph 1:3–5

In this paragraph, Paul asked God to bless the Galatians. He also praised Jesus for what he has done for us.

1:3

Grace and peace to you from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ,

- ¶ I May God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ give you grace and peace. (NLT)
- ¶ I I pray that our^(incl) Father God and the Lord Jesus the Christ will be kind to you^(plur) and give you^(plur) peace in your hearts.

Grace and peace to you: This phrase was a common greeting among Christians at that time. This greeting was like a prayer or a blessing. Paul prayed to God and asked him to bless the Galatians.

In Greek, this greeting has no verb. In some languages, it may be more natural to add a verb. (The verbs are underlined below.) For example:

May God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ give you grace and peace. (NLT)

I pray that God our^(incl) Father and the Lord Jesus Christ will bless you^(plur) with his favor. I pray that he will give you^(plur) peace in your hearts.

Some languages translate the words Grace and peace as long phrases. If that is true in your language, you may want to use something shorter in this greeting. Here Paul was not actually teaching about grace and peace. So it may not be necessary to include all the elements normally associated with these terms.

Grace: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Grace refers to kindness that is shown to people freely. In this context, the word refers to God's grace. He is kind to people because he loves them. People have not done anything to deserve his kindness.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

kindness

generous help

favor

See also grace, Meaning 1 in the Glossary.

peace: The Jewish concept of peace includes both an absence of war and a state of well-being, safety, health, and economic prosperity. All this comes from God for those who are in a relationship with him.

Some languages may have one word to describe the absence of war or conflict. These languages may have a different word to describe a general state of well-being or an inner peace of the heart. If that is the case, choose the word that describes a state of wholeness or well-being.

from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ:

There is a textual issue here. Different Greek texts have the pronoun our in different places.

1. Some texts have our Father. For example:

God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ (NRSV)
(BSB, NRSV, NIV, GNT, NASB, NCV, NLT, ESV)

1. Some texts have our Lord Jesus Christ. For example:

God the Father and our Lord Jesus Christ (RSV)
(RSV, NJB, NET, REB, KJV, GW, CEV, JBP)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This is the option followed in the UBS Greek New Testament.

God our Father: In some languages, it may be more natural to translate God our Father as:

God our heavenly Father

our Father God

the Lord Jesus Christ: In the term Lord Jesus Christ, Jesus is a personal name, and Lord and Christ are both titles.

The word Lord means “master” or “one who has authority over others.” It is a title.

As mentioned in 1:1c, the title Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word “Messiah.” It is also a title.

Some other ways to translate the Lord Jesus Christ are:

the Lord Jesus the Christ

Jesus the Lord and Christ

the Master and Messiah Jesus

Galatians 1:4

Section 1:1–5: Paul greeted the Christians in Galatia

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In this section, Paul briefly introduced two main themes of his letter.

1. It was God and Jesus who had made Paul an apostle. It was not other people who had called him to become an apostle. That gave him very high authority. This authority is one of the themes of his letter, and he discussed it more fully in chapter 2.
2. In 1:4, Paul reminded the Galatians that we Christians are saved because Jesus died for our sins. The main theme of the whole letter to the Galatians is that we are saved by the grace of God and by believing in Jesus.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Greeting

Greetings from Paul

Paragraph 1:3–5

In this paragraph, Paul asked God to bless the Galatians. He also praised Jesus for what he has done for us.

1:4a

who gave Himself for our sins

- Jesus gave himself to be killed for our^(incl) sins
- Jesus willingly died as a sacrifice to pay for our^(incl) sins.
- Jesus surrendered himself and died so that our^(incl) wrong/evil deeds might be forgiven.

In this verse Paul introduced one of the themes in his letter: salvation is based on Christ’s death on the cross.

who: The pronoun who refers to Jesus. It connects verses 3 and 4. In some languages, it may be natural to make this connection by starting a new sentence that has Jesus as the subject. For example:

Jesus gave himself for our sins (NCV)

gave Himself: This phrase means that Jesus “voluntarily gave his life,” “willingly died,” or “chose to die” on the cross.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

Christ...gave himself as a sacrifice (CEV)

He yielded/surrendered his life

Jesus was willing to be punished and killed

for our sins: This phrase means “to pay for our sins” or “to take the punishment for our sins.”

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

on account of our sins

so that our sins might be forgiven

sins: The word sins means the things that we do when we disobey God’s standard of what is right or good. Sins include acts, thoughts, and attitudes that are not what God wants or approves. A person can also sin by not doing what God wants him to do.

Use a general term that can include any wrongdoing against God. For example:

disobedience

wrong acts

offenses against God

evil deeds

In some languages it may be natural to translate the word sins with a phrase that includes a verb. For example:

wrong things that we have done

Here are problems to avoid:

1. The term should not imply that only crimes like murder or stealing are sins. Actions like gossip and greed are also sins.

2. The term should not include accidents or mistakes that are not against God’s will.

1:4b

to rescue us from the present evil age,

- in order to deliver/rescue us^(incl) from the evil/sin that is in this world.
- He did this so that he might free us^(incl) from the wickedness that is now on the earth.

to rescue us from the present evil age: This clause states the purpose of Jesus’ giving himself to die for our sins (1:4a). He gave himself in order to deliver us from the evil that dominates our world. He freed us from being slaves to sin.

Some other ways to express this purpose are:

^{4a}Christ gave himself for our sins ^{4b}in order to deliver us from the present evil age.

^{4a}Christ gave himself for our sins ^{4b}so that he might deliver us from the present evil age.

to rescue us: The phrase to rescue us means “to free us.”

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

to deliver us (ESV)

to rescue us (NIV)

to redeem us

This phrase does not mean that Jesus removes us from this world.

the present evil age: At times Paul used this phrase to refer to the evil period of time in which Christians lived. He also used it to refer to the evil way that people lived during this period. In this context, this phrase focuses on the sinful and wicked way of life in our world.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the sinful way that people live in this world

this evil that is in this world

the wickedness that is now on the earth

the evil ways in which human beings think and act (SSA)

1:4c

according to the will of our God and Father,

- He did this to obey/follow the will of God our^(incl) Father
- He did this because that is what our^(incl) Father God wanted him to do.

according to the will of our God and Father: This clause gives the background and reason for Jesus giving his life to set us free (in 1:4a–b). It means that it was God’s will that Jesus die for our sins in order to deliver us.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Christ did this to obey the will of our God and Father.

because that was what our God and Father wanted (GW)

See the General Comment below for some other ways to translate this clause.

our God and Father: This phrase describes God in two ways: he is our God, and he is also our Father. It does not refer to two different beings. Only the KJV translates the Greek phrase *theou kai patros humon* literally as “God and our Father.” Some versions say “God our Father” (CEV, NLT) or “God the Father” (NCV), perhaps to avoid giving the impression that God and Father are not one and the same. All other versions understand the pronoun *our* to go with both God and Father, i.e. “our God and Father.”

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

God our Father (CEV)

our God, who is our Father

our Father God

General Comment on 1:4a–c

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses in this verse. For example:

^{4a}Jesus gave his life for our sins, ^{4c}just as God our Father planned, ^{4b}in order to rescue us from this evil world in which we live. (NLT)

^{4c}Christ obeyed God our Father ^{4a}and gave himself as a sacrifice for our sins ^{4b}to rescue us from this evil world. (CEV)

Galatians 1:5

Section 1:1–5: Paul greeted the Christians in Galatia

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Some other possible headings for this section are:

Greeting

Greetings from Paul

Paragraph 1:3–5

In this paragraph, Paul asked God to bless the Galatians. He also praised Jesus for what he has done for us.

1:5

to whom be glory forever and ever. Amen.

- who is glorious/great forever. Amen.
- God always has greatness/heaviness. Let it be so.

to whom be glory forever and ever: In this clause, the word *glory* refers to the “greatness” or “magnificence” of God. Here Paul stated a fact: God is always glorious, great, or magnificent. He always has glory/greatness. Paul was not praying that people recognize God’s glory.

In Greek, there is no verb here, so English versions supply one. In some languages, it will also be necessary to supply a verb here. For example:

God has greatness forever.

God is always great!

In some languages, the word glory is expressed by the figurative use of a particular word. For example:

God always has heaviness.

Bigness is/belongs to God forever.

to whom: The pronoun whom refers to God.

forever and ever: This phrase emphasizes the idea of forever. Some other ways to say this are:

without end

endlessly

Amen: The word Amen means “let it be so.” Many languages transliterate this word.

Galatians 1:6

Section 1:6–10: Paul rebuked the Galatians for turning away from the true gospel

In this section, Paul began his plea with the Galatians to turn back to the true gospel. He did this in several ways:

1. He rebuked them for turning away from the true gospel.
2. He condemned anyone who proclaimed any other gospel.

At this point in most of Paul’s other letters, he thanked God for his readers. The fact that he does not do that in Galatians shows how concerned and upset he was.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Do not follow false teaching

Do not turn away from the true gospel

Follow the Good News We Gave You (GW)

There Is No Other Gospel (NRSV)

1:6a–c

(reordered) I am very surprised at you^(plur). God called you to experience/know Christ’s grace/kindness. But you quickly started to desert him and have started to follow another gospel.

In some languages, it will be more natural to put parts of 1:6a and 1:6c together. In order to do this, the order of some of the clauses in 1:6 will have to be changed. For example:

^aI am very surprised at you. ^bGod called you to live in the grace of Christ. ^aBut you quickly started to desert him ^cand started to follow another gospel.

1:6a–b

the One who: The words the One who refer to God the Father. Paul claimed that the Galatians were not only deserting the true gospel. They were deserting God himself.

Some other ways to translate these words are:

him who

God who

God. He

1:6a

I am amazed how quickly you are deserting the One

- ¶ I am very surprised that you^(plur) are so quickly abandoning/rejecting him
- ¶ I am shocked that you are turning away so soon from God, (NLT)
- ¶ I am amazed at what you^(plur) are doing. You quickly started to turn your backs on God.

I am amazed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as amazed means “astonished” or “surprised.” The context determines whether the reaction is favorable or unfavorable. In this context it is unfavorable.

Paul had expected the Galatian believers to remain faithful to the true gospel. It was hard for him to believe that they were deserting the gospel. Translate this verb in a way that expresses a bad surprise. For example:

I am dismayed/disappointed

I am shocked (CEV)

I am very surprised

how quickly you are deserting: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as deserting here refers to switching from one side/team to another. Here it refers to a change of religious belief and practice. It indicates that the Galatians had started “turning away from” or “abandoning” the true gospel. The Greek tense of this verb indicates that the “turning away” was not yet complete.

The phrase how quickly indicates that the Galatians started to turn away from the gospel soon after Paul had taught it to them.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

that you are turning away so soon (NLT)

that you are so soon turning your backs on

that you are so quickly changing your minds and abandoning/leaving

1:6b

who called you by the grace of Christ

- who called you^(plur) to live/experience the kindness of Christ
- who called you to experience/know Christ’s kindness.
- He invited you to experience/feel/taste the good/kind things that Christ does for us.

who called you by the grace of Christ: There is a textual issue in this clause. In some Greek manuscripts, this clause includes the Greek word for “Christ.” (1) Most English versions follow the Greek manuscripts that include the word Christ. For example: who called you by the grace of Christ (NIV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, ESV, NET, RSV, KJV, NASB, NJB, GW, NLT, JBP)(2) Some English versions follow Greek manuscripts that do not include the word Christ. For example: who called you by grace (REB) (REB, CEV) It is recommended that you follow option (1) and the majority of English versions. There are at least two ways to interpret the phrase that the BSB translates as by the grace of Christ.

1. It refers to the purpose for which God called us. God called us so that we should live in the grace of Christ. The rendering “live in the grace of Christ” is supported by other uses of the Greek word translated “call” in connection with the Greek

preposition meaning “in” or “with.” Compare with 1 Corinthians 7:15, where many English versions supply the word “live” to fill out the Greek phrase that may be literally translated “called you/us in(to) peace.” Note also 1 Thessalonians 4:7, where again the Greek phrase literally translated is “called in(to) holiness,” but some versions add the word “live” to make the meaning clearer in English. In other words, God called the Galatians to experience Christ’s kindness. For example:

called you to live in the grace of Christ (NIV11) (NIV11, KJV) This interpretation is supported by Moo, p. 77; Fung, p. 44, Burton, p. 21, Schreiner, p. 85, and Rogers, p. 22.

1. It refers to the means by which God called us. God called us through/by the grace of Christ. For example:

called you by the grace of Christ (NIV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NET, NASB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Interpretation (1) has more commentary support than interpretation (2). Many English versions literally translate this phrase as “in the grace of Christ.” So they may also be following interpretation (1), but that is not certain.

When you translate 1:6b, you may want to use the NIV11 as your source text. It says:

called you to live in the grace of Christ (NIV11)

Here the word “live” is used in a figurative sense. Some languages can translate this figurative sense as something like “experience the grace of Christ.” In other languages, this idea is expressed by one of the verbs related to the senses. For example: see, hear, touch, smell, taste/drink, or know the grace of Christ.

Some other ways to translate 1:6b are:

called you to live/experience/know the kindness of Christ

called you to experience/feel/taste the good that Christ does for us

invited you to know that Christ helps us

invited you to receive Christ's kindness/help

called you: Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

invited you

summoned you

the grace of Christ: The phrase grace of Christ means "Christ's kindness, generosity, or favor." Christ shows his kindness to people who do not deserve it.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

Christ's kindness

the kind/good things that Christ does for you

See also grace, Meaning 2 in the Glossary.

1:6c

and are turning to a different gospel—

- and are believing another gospel.
- You are following a different way that pretends to be the Good News. (NLT)
- You^(plur) are accepting a different message that you think is the Good News.

and are turning to a different gospel: This phrase further explains what the Galatians were doing when they started to desert God. They started turning to a different gospel. This means that they started to believe, accept, and follow a message that was different from the true gospel.

The BSB uses two verbs, "deserting" (in 1:6a) and turning (here), to translate one Greek verb. Most English versions also use two verbs.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

and are accepting another gospel (GNT)

and are following a different gospel (NET)

You have believed another message (CEV)

a different gospel: This phrase refers to a false gospel or false message. It contrasts with the true good news that Paul taught.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

a different kind of good news (GW)

a different way that pretends to be the Good News (NLT)

a different teaching that you think is good news

See also gospel in the Glossary.

Galatians 1:7

Section 1:6–10: Paul rebuked the Galatians for turning away from the true gospel

In this section, Paul began his plea with the Galatians to turn back to the true gospel. He did this in several ways:

1. He rebuked them for turning away from the true gospel.
2. He condemned anyone who proclaimed any other gospel.

At this point in most of Paul's other letters, he thanked God for his readers. The fact that he does not do that in Galatians shows how concerned and upset he was.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Do not follow false teaching

Do not turn away from the true gospel

Follow the Good News We Gave You (GW)

There Is No Other Gospel (NRSV)

1:7a

which is not even a gospel.

- Actually, there is no "other gospel," (GNT)
- However, there really is no other Good News.
- But there is no other doctrine/teaching that can be called Good News.

which is not even a gospel: This clause indicates that the "different gospel" is not the gospel at all. It is not good news. A different gospel does not really exist.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Actually, there is no "other gospel," (GNT)

not that there really is another gospel (NET)

but is not the Good News at all (NLT)

1:7b

Evidently some people are troubling you

- except in the minds/thinking of some men who are confusing you^(plur)
- But/However some people are troubling your minds.
- But some people are causing you trouble. (CEV)

Evidently: The Greek phrase that BSB here translates as Evidently is more literally “if not” or “except.” In most of the other places in the New Testament where this phrase occurs, it is translated as “except.” In those places, this phrase introduces an exception to the previous clause. Here this phrase also introduces an exception. Moo says, “The other gospel to which the Galatians are tempted to transfer their allegiance is a gospel only in the sense that some ‘agitators’...are claiming it to be a gospel” (p. 79).

Some ways to connect 1:7a and 1:7b are:

- Use the word except. This option probably follows the Greek most closely. It introduces 1:7b as an exception to 1:7a. For example:

^{7a}There is no other gospel ^{7b}except in the minds/thinking of some who trouble you ^{7c}and want to distort the gospel of Christ.

- Use a conjunction such as but or however. For example:

^{7a}not that there really is another gospel, ^{7b}but there are some who are disturbing you ^{7c}and wanting to distort the gospel of Christ (NET) If you follow this option, you may want to change the order of some of the clauses in 7b and 7c. For example:

^{7a}not that there really is another gospel. ^{7b}But there are some who ^{7c}want to distort the gospel of Christ into another gospel. ^{7b}They are disturbing you.

- Use no conjunction or other word to introduce 1:7b. For example:

^{7a}But what some people are calling good news is not really good news at all. ^{7b}They are confusing you. ^{7c}They want to distort the Good News about Christ. (GW)

some people are troubling you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as troubling also means “confuse.” This verb is in the present tense. When Paul wrote this letter, some men (who were false teachers) were in the process of trying to confuse the Galatians.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

some people are confusing you (NCV)

You are being fooled by those... (NLT)

some people are causing you trouble (CEV)

1:7c

and trying to distort the gospel of Christ.

- and trying to change the gospel of Christ. (GNT)
- They want to change/twist the message about Christ.
- They want to distort the Good News about Christ. (GW)

and trying to distort the gospel of Christ: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as distort means to change a good thing into a bad thing.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

and trying to change the gospel of Christ (GNT)

and are trying to pervert the gospel of Christ (NIV)

by those who deliberately twist the truth concerning Christ (NLT)

the gospel of Christ: This phrase means the Good News about Christ.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the message about Christ

the Good News about Christ (GW)

See gospel in the Glossary for more information.

Galatians 1:8

Section 1:6–10: Paul rebuked the Galatians for turning away from the true gospel

In this section, Paul began his plea with the Galatians to turn back to the true gospel. He did this in several ways:

1. He rebuked them for turning away from the true gospel.
2. He condemned anyone who proclaimed any other gospel.

At this point in most of Paul's other letters, he thanked God for his readers. The fact that he does not do that in Galatians shows how concerned and upset he was.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Do not follow false teaching

Do not turn away from the true gospel

Follow the Good News We Gave You (GW)

There Is No Other Gospel (NRSV)

1:8–9

In these verses, Paul strongly condemned anyone who teaches a false gospel. The true gospel is the only gospel. It is more important than any person.

No one, including Paul, may change the gospel. Paul said that God would curse anyone who would change the gospel. He emphasized this by stating a situation that was not real. Neither Paul nor the brothers with him had preached a different gospel to the Galatians.

This contrasts with the real situation of the false teachers who were teaching a false gospel. Paul was warning those who were listening to the false teachers.

1:8

Before you translate 1:8, carefully consider what is the most natural order in your language for the clauses in this verse. In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of some of the clauses. Compare the order of the clause in the BSB and GW:

^aBut even if we or an angel from heaven ^bshould preach a gospel contrary to the one we preached to you, ^clet him be under a curse! (BSB)

^bWhoever tells you good news that is different from the Good News we gave you ^cshould be condemned to hell, ^aeven if he is one of us or an angel from heaven. (GW)

See other examples in the Display under 1:8a–c re-ordered.

1:8a

But even if we or an angel from heaven

- But even if we^(excl) or an angel from heaven/God
- Suppose that we^(excl) or an angel from heaven
- Consider/imagine the false situation in which we or an angel

But: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between the “gospel of Christ” that Paul preached and the “different gospel” that some men were preaching. With this contrast, Paul continued to show that there is only one gospel.

Some English versions indicate this contrast with the conjunction But. Other English versions do not translate this conjunction here. However, the contrast is still shown by the expressions for the true gospel and the false gospel.

even if: The phrase even if introduces a situation that is not real. The following situation never happened. The Greek grammar clearly shows that what follows is a hypothetical statement.

Some other ways to translate this are:

suppose

consider/imagine the false situation in which

if we or an angel from heaven should preach to you a gospel contrary to the one we preached to you but we have not done that

we: The pronoun we refers to Paul and his companions. Paul used it to emphasize that he himself is included. This pronoun does not include the Galatians.

an angel from heaven: The Greek word that the BSB translates as angel means “messenger.” It can be either a human messenger or a divine messenger. The phrase from heaven shows that here it refers to a divine messenger.

Here, heaven is a figure of speech that represents God who lives in heaven. So the phrase angel from heaven refers to a “messenger from heaven” or “messenger from God.”

Some ways to translate this phrase are:

- Use a descriptive word or phrase. For example:

messenger from heaven/God

good/holy spirit-being from above

- Use a local term that fits the biblical meaning. If you use a term for angel that people cannot confuse with an ordinary messenger, then it would not be necessary to add from heaven. For example:

angel

- In some areas the churches may already be using a borrowed term or a transliterated word for angel. Be sure that this term fits the biblical meaning. If some people do not understand the right meaning from this term, you may need to indicate the meaning with a descriptive phrase. For example:

an angelos messenger from heaven

a sacred angelos spirit from above

Be sure that your term for angel is different from your terms for “prophet” and “apostle.”

See also angel in the Glossary for more information.

1:8b

should preach a gospel contrary to the one we preached to you,

- preach to you^(plur) a gospel that is different than the gospel that we had preached to you^(plur),
- teach you^(plur) a message that is not the same as good news that we^(excl) first taught you,
- teach you something that does not agree with the good news that we first taught you.

should preach a gospel contrary to the one we preached to you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as contrary to can also be translated as “that is opposed to” or “that does not agree with.”

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

should preach to you a gospel that is different from the one we preached to you (GNT)

should preach a gospel other than the one we preached to you (NIV)

should preach/teach you a doctrine that does not agree with the gospel we already taught you

1:8c

let him be under a curse!

- let/may that person be cursed.
- may God’s curse/punishment fall on that person.
- If that should happen, I pray that God will punish/destroy that person.

let him be under a curse: This clause is a type of prayer. Paul asked God to punish or condemn the person who changed the true gospel and preached another gospel.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

may he be cursed

Let God’s curse fall on anyone (NLT)

I pray that God will punish (CEV)

may he be condemned to hell (GNT)

Paul was not casting a spell on someone. Do not use an expression in your language that would imply casting a spell.

him: The pronoun him refers to anyone who might preach a false gospel.

Some ways to translate this more clearly are:

that person

that messenger

1:8a–c

(reordered) I pray that God will punish anyone who preaches anything different from our message to you! It doesn’t matter if that person is one of us or an angel from heaven. (CEV)

- (reordered) Let God’s curse fall on anyone, including us or even an angel from heaven, who preaches a different kind of Good News than the one we preached to you. (NLT)

Galatians 1:9

Section 1:6–10: Paul rebuked the Galatians for turning away from the true gospel

In this section, Paul began his plea with the Galatians to turn back to the true gospel. He did this in several ways:

1. He rebuked them for turning away from the true gospel.
2. He condemned anyone who proclaimed any other gospel.

At this point in most of Paul's other letters, he thanked God for his readers. The fact that he does not do that in Galatians shows how concerned and upset he was.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Do not follow false teaching

Do not turn away from the true gospel

Follow the Good News We Gave You (GW)

There Is No Other Gospel (NRSV)

1:9

In 1:9, Paul focused on the real situation in Galatia. There were false teachers who were teaching the Galatians a false gospel. The believers were deserting the true gospel to follow that false gospel. Paul used the clauses in 1:9a to draw attention to how serious the situation was in Galatia. He used very strong language to condemn the false teachers.

1:9a

As we have said before, so now I say again:

- I say again what we have said before: (NLT)
- We^(excl) said this before, and now I say it again:

As we have said before, so now I say again: There are two ways to interpret these two clauses:

1. It refers to a message that Paul had given on a previous visit to Galatia.
2. It refers to the curse Paul has just pronounced in 1:8.

Most commentators believe that Paul was referring to what he and Barnabas had told the Galatians on a previous visit. This visit was several months or a few years before he wrote this book. If possible, translate in a way that either interpretation could be understood. If you must make a choice, choose interpretation (1).

Some other ways to translate these clauses are:

I say again what we have said before (NLT)

We said this before, and now I say it again

1:9b

If anyone is preaching to you a gospel contrary to the one you received,

- If anyone preaches to you^(plur) a gospel that is different from the one you received,
- Whoever teaches you^(plur) a message that is not the same as good news that you believed,
- Anyone who teaches you^(plur) something that does not agree with what you believed,

If anyone is preaching to you: This clause is similar, but not identical, to 1:8b. It is no longer a hypothetical statement about what "we or an angel" might do. Instead, it is a statement about what some people were actually doing.

To make this clear, it may be better in some languages to begin this clause with something other than If. For example:

Whoever is preaching to you

may anybody who preaches (JBP)

anyone who preaches (CEV)

a gospel contrary to the one you received: The Greek word that the BSB translates as contrary to is the same word as in 1:8b. It can also be translated as "that is opposed to" or "that does not agree with." You should translate it here as you did in 1:8b.

The phrase the one you received refers to the true gospel that the Galatians had originally believed and accepted from Paul.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

a gospel that is different from the one you accepted (GNT)

a gospel that is not the one you already received from me

a message that does not agree with the good news that you believed

1:9c

let him be under a curse!

- let/may that person be cursed.
- may God's curse/punishment fall on that person.
- I pray that God will punish/destroy that person.

let him be under a curse: This is exactly the same clause as in 1:8c. You should translate it the same way.

General Comment on 1:9b–c

In some languages, it will be more natural to change the order of the clauses in 1:9b–c. For example:

^cI hope God will punish ^banyone who preaches anything different from what you have already believed (CEV)

1:9b–c

(reordered) I pray that God will punish anyone who preaches anything different from the message you^(plur) have already believed.

Galatians 1:10

Section 1:6–10: Paul rebuked the Galatians for turning away from the true gospel

In this section, Paul began his plea with the Galatians to turn back to the true gospel. He did this in several ways:

1. He rebuked them for turning away from the true gospel.
2. He condemned anyone who proclaimed any other gospel.

At this point in most of Paul's other letters, he thanked God for his readers. The fact that he does not do that in Galatians shows how concerned and upset he was.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Do not follow false teaching

Do not turn away from the true gospel

Follow the Good News We Gave You (GW)

There Is No Other Gospel (NRSV)

1:10a

Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God?

- ¶ Am I saying this now because I am trying to win the approval of people or to win the approval of God?
- ¶ Does what I just said show that I am trying to please people? No, I am trying to please God.

- ¶ I am not trying to please people. I want to please God. (CEV)

In 1:10 Paul explained why he had the authority to speak so harshly in 1:6–9. He was Christ's servant, and he was trying to please God, not men. He said this because he wanted the Galatians to have confidence that he taught the true gospel. Some English versions introduce this explanation by translating the Greek conjunction at the start of the verse. (See next note.) Some other ways to introduce it are:

I speak like this because

When I speak like this

Does what I just said show

This verse begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as "for." Some English versions, such as the ESV, translate it that way. The BSB has not translated this conjunction, and some other versions, such as the NIV and NET, also do not translate it. Connect 1:10a to 1:9c in a way that is natural in your language.

Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God:

This is a rhetorical question. Paul used this rhetorical question to emphasize that he was not trying to win the approval of people. He was seeking the approval of God.

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- Use a rhetorical question or questions. For example:

Am I saying this now to win the approval of people or God? (GW)

Am I trying to please people? If not that, am I trying to please God?

- Use a rhetorical question followed by a statement. For example:

Does this sound as if I am trying to win human approval? No indeed! What I want is God's approval! (GNT)

Do you think I am trying to make people accept me? No, God is the One I am trying to please. (NCV)

- As two statements. For example:

I am not trying to please people. I want to please God. (CEV)

Use the most natural form in your language to emphasize that Paul is not trying to win the approval of people.

now: This word shows that Paul was referring to what he had just said in 1:6–9.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

Am I saying this now (GW)

Does what I just said show

When I speak like this

seeking the approval of: In this context, the Greek verb that the BSB translates as seeking the approval of also means “try to please.” Normally this word means “persuade” (as in the KJV). In this context, it is best to consider this word to be close in meaning to the next verb phrase, “seeking to please.”

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

trying to please (CEV)

seeking the favor of (NASB)

trying to make people accept me (NCV)

trying to make people praise me

men: The word men refers to people in general.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

man

people

human beings

1:10b

Or am I striving to please men?

- Do you think I am trying to please people? (CEV)
- I am not trying to please people,
- I am not trying to get people to praise me,

Or am I striving to please men?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used this rhetorical question to further emphasize that he did not try to please people. This question is similar to the first part of the rhetorical question in 1:10a.

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- Use a question. For example:

Do you think I am trying to please people? (CEV)

- Use a statement. For example:

I am most certainly not trying to please men.

Use a natural way in your language to emphasize that Paul did not try to please people.

In some languages, it may be more natural to combine this rhetorical question with the first part of the rhetorical question in 1:10a. For example, the NLT translates both 1:10a and 1:10b as:

Obviously, I’m not trying to win the approval of people, but of God. (NLT)

Your solution to this issue depends on how your language uses repetition. If repetition adds emphasis, then you may keep both rhetorical questions. But if it is bad style or adds confusion, then it is enough to say this once and use other means to show the emphasis. Paul wanted to emphasize that it is God he wants to please rather than people.

Or: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Or here introduces a question that repeats the first part of the question in 1:10a. It does not indicate an alternative situation. Some English versions do not translate this word. For example:

Am I trying to please people? (GW)

men: As in 1:10a, the word men refers to people in general. Translate it in the same way.

1:10c

If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ.

- If I were still trying/seeking to please people, I would not be a servant of Christ.
- because if I were still doing that, but I’m not, then I would not be a servant of Christ.

If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ: This is a conditional sentence. (A conditional sentence is a sentence with an “if” clause.) Paul used this conditional sentence to state the opposite of what was true. He did this to emphasize the truth. The truth is that he was no longer trying to please people, because he had become a servant of Christ. Before Paul became a Christian, he did try to please people. But then he became a servant of Christ. So he was no longer trying to please people.

Some other ways to translate this sentence are:

If I were still trying to please people, though I’m not, I would not be Christ’s servant.

Suppose I were still trying to please people. Then I would not be a servant of Christ.

I am no longer trying to please people. If I were, I would not be the servant of Christ.

servant of Christ: The Greek word that the BSB translates as servant can also be translated as “slave.” In the same way that a slave serves and obeys his master, Paul served and obeyed Christ.

Galatians 1:11

Section 1:11–24: Paul received his message from Jesus himself

In this section, Paul stressed that the gospel that he preached came from Jesus Christ himself. No human being taught it to him. Therefore, his message had God’s authority. Paul’s purpose in writing this section was to convince the Galatians that the true gospel is the one that he preached.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul’s Message Comes from Christ (NLT)

Jesus Alone Gave Paul the Good News He Spreads (GW)

Paul’s Authority is from God (NCV)

God is the source of Paul’s authority and message

Paragraph 1:11–12

In this paragraph, Paul stressed that the gospel that he preached came from Jesus Christ. It did not come

from a human being. This implies that the gospel that Paul preached had God’s authority, and so the Galatians should not turn away from it.

1:11a

For I certify to you, brothers,

- ¶ Brothers, I say this because I want you^(plur) to know/understand
- ¶ My dear fellow-believers, I want to make sure that you^(plur) know/recognize

For: In this section, Paul explained why the Galatians should follow the gospel that he preached. The Greek introduces this explanation with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For. This conjunction connects this explanation to Paul’s plea in 1:6–10.

Another way to introduce this explanation is:

I say all this because

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it is not necessary to use a conjunction here either.

I certify to you: This clause indicates that Paul wanted to make sure that the Galatians knew the following information.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I want you to know (CEV)

I want you to understand (NLT)

I want to make sure that you know

brothers: The word brothers refers to the Galatian believers. It includes both men and women. Paul used this word to show his love for the believers.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

brothers and sisters (NRSV)

my dear fellow believers

fellow believers in Christ

my dear friends,

In many languages, it may be more natural put the word brothers at the beginning of this verse. For example:

Brothers and sisters, I want you to know (NCV)

My friends, I want you to know (CEV)

My friends, I say all this because I want to make sure that you know

1:11b

that the gospel I preached was not devised by man.

- that the gospel/message that I preached to you did not come from a human.
- that the good news about Jesus that I preached to you did not come/originate from the mind/thoughts of a human being.

the gospel I preached: In the Greek this phrase is more literally “the gospel having been preached by me.” This is a passive clause in Greek. Some ways to translate it are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the gospel which was preached by me (RSV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

The good news that I tell people (EASY)

the good news that I preached to you when I was there

the gospel that you heard me preach

Paul used the past tense to refer to the time when he had preached the good news to the Galatians before he wrote this letter. The past tense does not indicate that Paul had stopped preaching the gospel or had changed his message.

was not devised by man: This phrase means that the gospel was not made up by any person.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

did not come from a human being

did not come from the mind/thoughts of a human being

is not of human origin (GNT)

is not something that man made up (NIV)

Galatians 1:12

Section 1:11–24: Paul received his message from Jesus himself

In this section, Paul stressed that the gospel that he preached came from Jesus Christ himself. No human being taught it to him. Therefore, his message had God’s authority. Paul’s purpose in writing this section was to convince the Galatians that the true gospel is the one that he preached.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul’s Message Comes from Christ (NLT)

Jesus Alone Gave Paul the Good News He Spreads (GW)

Paul’s Authority is from God (NCV)

God is the source of Paul’s authority and message

Paragraph 1:11–12

In this paragraph, Paul stressed that the gospel that he preached came from Jesus Christ. It did not come from a human being. This implies that the gospel that Paul preached had God’s authority, and so the Galatians should not turn away from it.

1:12a

I did not receive it from any man,

- I say this because I did not receive/get the gospel from any human,
- I did not learn/find the message that I preached from any person,

This verse begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “for.” Some English versions, such as the ESV and NET, translate it that way. Some other ways to represent this conjunction and connect this verse to 1:11b are:

It is not man’s gospel , because

In other words

The BSB has not translated this conjunction, and some other versions, such as the NIV and NLT, also do not

translate it. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either. Connect 1:12a to 1:11b in a way that is natural in your language.

I did not receive it from any man: This clause means that Paul did not receive/get the gospel from a human. The gospel that he preached was not something that he learned from a human being.

This clause is similar to the clause in 1:11b, but it is more specific.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I did not receive it from any human being (GNT)

I did not learn it from someone.

No one told/showed it to me.

1:12b

nor was I taught it;

- and I was not taught the gospel by a human teacher.
- and no one taught/showed it to me.

nor was I taught it: This clause means that a human teacher did not teach Paul the gospel. Paul did not learn the gospel from a human.

This clause is passive. Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

nor was I taught the gospel

I was not taught the gospel by a human teacher

- Use an active verb. For example:

nor did a human teacher teach/show me the gospel

I did not learn the gospel from a human teacher

1:12c

rather, I received it by revelation from Jesus Christ.

- But/Rather, I received it from Jesus Christ. He revealed/showed it to me.
- Instead, it was Jesus Christ himself who revealed/showed it to me.

Verse 1:12c is Paul's main point in paragraph 1:11–12. To make this clear, it may be necessary in some

languages to put 1:12c earlier in this verse. See the General Comment below for an example.

rather: There is a contrast between 1:12a–b and 1:12c. The contrast is between where Paul did not get the gospel, and where he got it. Languages have different ways to indicate this negative-positive type of contrast. One of the functions of the Greek conjunction *ἀλλά* is to signal this negative-positive type of contrast. Some of the ways are:

- With the conjunction “but.”
- With a conjunction other than “but.” This is a common way in English to show this type of contrast. For example:

rather (BSB, NIV)

on the contrary

Instead (GNT)

- With no conjunction. For example:

^aI did not receive it from any human being, ^bnor did anyone teach it to me. ^cIt was Jesus Christ himself who revealed it to me. (GNT)

I received it by revelation from Jesus Christ: This clause means that Jesus Christ revealed/showed the gospel to Paul. For example:

Jesus Christ revealed it to me (GW)

Jesus Christ showed it to me (NCV)

Jesus Christ: In the phrase Jesus Christ, Jesus is a personal name, and Christ is his title. Christ is not the surname of Jesus.

One way to show this is:

Jesus the Christ/Messiah

In some languages, the title is put before the name. For example:

Christ Jesus

This same phrase occurs in 1:1c. You should translate it here as you did there.

General Comment on 1:11–12

The main point of 1:11–12 is 1:12c. In some languages, it may be more natural to show this by changing the order of the clauses in 1:12. For example:

^{11a}I want you to know, brothers, that ^{11b}the gospel that I preach is not something that a human being made up. ^{12c}It was Jesus Christ himself who revealed this gospel to me. ^{12a}I did not receive it from any human being, ^{12b}nor did any human teach it to me.

Galatians 1:13

Section 1:11–24: Paul received his message from Jesus himself

In this section, Paul stressed that the gospel that he preached came from Jesus Christ himself. No human being taught it to him. Therefore, his message had God's authority. Paul's purpose in writing this section was to convince the Galatians that the true gospel is the one that he preached.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul's Message Comes from Christ (NLT)

Jesus Alone Gave Paul the Good News He Spreads (GW)

Paul's Authority is from God (NCV)

God is the source of Paul's authority and message

Paragraph 1:13–14

In this paragraph, Paul reminded the Galatians of what he had done as a very devoted Jew. He had eagerly kept the law. He hated Christians and persecuted them. This introduces the conflict between his former religion, Judaism, and the gospel. Paul was so committed to Judaism that only God could have changed him.

1:13a

For you have heard of my former way of life in Judaism,

- ¶ You^(plur) have heard of the way that I formerly lived/behaved when I followed the Jewish religion.
- ¶ You^(plur) know how I behaved/acted in the past. During the time that I obeyed the religion/customs of the Jews,

For: Verses 1:13–21 are the evidence/basis for Paul's claim in 1:12c that he had received the gospel directly

from Jesus Christ. In Greek, this evidence/basis is introduced with a conjunction that the BSB translates as *For*.

Many English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, no conjunction will be necessary here either.

you have heard of: Paul used the expression you have heard of to remind the Galatians of something they already knew. He reminded them that they knew about his actions before he became a Christian.

Some other ways to translate this are:

You heard about (GW)

You know how (CEV)

You have been told (GNT)

my former way of life in Judaism: This phrase refers to Paul's life/actions before he became a Christian. The word Judaism refers to the Jewish religion. It includes the Jewish customs and traditions.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the way I once lived when I followed the Jewish religion (GW)

what I was like when I followed the Jewish religion (NLT)

how I used to live as a Jew (CEV)

the story of my life in the Jewish customs before I became a Christian

1:13b

how severely I persecuted the church of God

- I was causing the group of God's people who believe in Jesus to suffer greatly,
- I attacked with force the group of God's people who follow Jesus Christ.

how severely I persecuted: The verb persecuted means "caused people to suffer" because of their religious beliefs. The form of the Greek verb implies that Paul persecuted Christians for some time.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

how badly I was causing to suffer

I was violently attacking

that for some time I greatly harmed

severely: The Greek word that the BSB translates as severely means “in an extreme way.”

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

very much

really

violently (ESV)

with force/strength

without mercy (GNT)

the church of God: This phrase refers to the group of God’s people who believed that Jesus was the Christ. This phrase contrasts with the Jewish religion. Here the word church does not refer to a building.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the group of God’s people who believe in Christ

people of God who follow Jesus Christ

Be careful to translate this phrase in a way that refers specifically to the group of Jewish Christians, not to Jews in general. All Jews believed in God. So do not translate this only as “people/group who believed in God.”

The word church first occurs in 1:2b. See also church in the Glossary for more information.

1:13c

and tried to destroy it.

- and I tried to destroy/spoil their group.
- I tried to end/finish their group/faith.

and tried to destroy it: The pronoun it refers back to the phrase “the church of God.” By persecuting believers, Paul hoped to destroy or break up the group of believers. Paul contrasted the church of God with the Jewish religion. Paul made this clear in 1:23 when he said that people recognized he had tried to destroy

the faith. This does not just mean that he tried to kill all individual believers. He tried to cause the Christian faith/religion to no longer exist.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

and was trying to destroy the church

and was trying to spoil the group of believers

and tried to cause the church to end

Galatians 1:14

Section 1:11–24: Paul received his message from Jesus himself

In this section, Paul stressed that the gospel that he preached came from Jesus Christ himself. No human being taught it to him. Therefore, his message had God’s authority. Paul’s purpose in writing this section was to convince the Galatians that the true gospel is the one that he preached.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul’s Message Comes from Christ (NLT)

Jesus Alone Gave Paul the Good News He Spreads (GW)

Paul’s Authority is from God (NCV)

God is the source of Paul’s authority and message

Paragraph 1:13–14

In this paragraph, Paul reminded the Galatians of what he had done as a very devoted Jew. He had eagerly kept the law. He hated Christians and persecuted them. This introduces the conflict between his former religion, Judaism, and the gospel. Paul was so committed to Judaism that only God could have changed him.

1:14a

I was advancing in Judaism beyond many of my contemporaries

- I surpassed many of the Jews of my generation in following our religion,
- I was becoming a leader in the Jewish customs more than many of those in my age group,
- In the things concerning the Jews’ worship of God, I had few equals among my companions.

I was advancing in Judaism beyond many of my contemporaries: This clause means that Paul was far ahead of most of the Jews his own age in becoming a Jewish religious leader. He had learned more about the Jewish religion than most of the other men his age. And he obeyed the Jewish laws and kept the Jewish customs better than most of the others.

Some other ways to translate this sentence are:

I surpassed many of my companions in following the Jewish religion

I was ahead of my age-mates in things concerning the religious customs/beliefs of us Jews

I was becoming a leader in the Jewish religion, doing better than most other Jews of my age. (NCV)

Judaism: This word refers to the religion of the Jews/Israelites. For example:

the Jewish religion (GNT)

Some other ways to translate this word are:

the Jews' worship of God

the beliefs/doctrines of the Jews

the traditions/customs of the Jews

1:14b

and was extremely zealous for the traditions of my fathers.

- and I tried very hard to follow the traditions of my ancestors.
- and I obeyed the ways of my ancestors with all my heart/strength.
- The customs of my ancestors were extremely dear/precious to me.

was extremely zealous for the traditions of my fathers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as zealous also means "eager." Paul followed all the religious traditions/customs of his ancestors with energy and enthusiasm. He was completely committed to the Jewish religion. In everything he did, he wanted to obey, defend, and promote the Jewish religion.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

was extremely eager to keep the traditions of my ancestors

followed the customs/ways of our ancestors with all my heart/strength

tried harder than anyone else to follow the teachings handed down by our ancestors (NCV)

General Comment on 1:14a–b

In some languages, it may be natural to combine 1:14a and 1:14b. In other languages, it may be natural to change the order of these clauses. For example:

^{14b}I followed very much the customs of my ancestors. ^{14a}I surpassed how the other Jews of my age group followed them.

Galatians 1:15

Section 1:11–24: Paul received his message from Jesus himself

In this section, Paul stressed that the gospel that he preached came from Jesus Christ himself. No human being taught it to him. Therefore, his message had God's authority. Paul's purpose in writing this section was to convince the Galatians that the true gospel is the one that he preached.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul's Message Comes from Christ (NLT)

Jesus Alone Gave Paul the Good News He Spreads (GW)

Paul's Authority is from God (NCV)

God is the source of Paul's authority and message

Paragraph 1:15–17

In this paragraph, Paul again wrote that he received the gospel from God and not from men. When God revealed Jesus to him, he did not go to Jerusalem to learn the gospel from the apostles.

In Greek, 1:15–17 is a long, complex sentence. Before you translate this complex sentence, it is important to understand its structure.

This long sentence begins with a time clause:

^{15a}But when God ... ^{15c}was pleased ^{16a}to reveal his Son to me

In the middle of this time clause (after the phrase “But when God”) are two clauses that describe God. (These two clauses are relative clauses):

...who set me apart from my mother’s womb and who called me by his grace...

The main clauses are in 1:16c-17c:

^{16c}I did not rush to consult with flesh and blood
^{17a}nor did I go up to Jerusalem ... ^{17b}but I went into Arabia ^{17c}and later returned to Damascus.

In many languages it will be necessary to divide this long Greek sentence into several shorter sentences. It may also be necessary to change the order of some of the clauses in this long sentence. Examples are given in the notes below.

1:15

In Greek, 1:15 begins with the clause “But when God was pleased/decided.” This is a time clause. Many English versions put parts of this time clause later in 1:15. Some versions even put this time clause in 1:16.

The KJV shows the literal Greek order. You should compare the Greek/KJV order with the other options below. Then decide how to structure this verse and where the most natural place is in your language for the parts of this time clause. Some examples are:

¹⁵But when it pleased God, who separated me from my mother’s womb, and called me by his grace, ¹⁶To reveal his Son in me (KJV)

^{15a-b}But God in his grace chose me even before I was born, and called me to serve him. ^{15c}And when he decided ¹⁶to reveal his Son to me... (GNT)

^{15a}But when he who had set me apart before I was born, ^{15b}and who called me by his grace, ^{15c}was pleased ^{16a}to reveal his Son to me (ESV)

1:15a

But when God, who set me apart from my mother’s womb

- ¶ But God had chosen me while I was in my mother’s womb,
- ¶ But in spite of that, before I was born, God had chosen me to do his work.

But: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between what Paul formerly was (1:13-14) and what Paul became (1:15-24). Most English versions indicate this contrast with the conjunction But.

Some other ways to begin this verse are:

Nevertheless

But in spite of that

But then something happened! (NLT96)

who set me apart from my mother’s womb: This clause is a relative clause. It describes something that God did.

Be careful to translate this clause in a way that does not imply that there is another God, a God who did not set Paul apart. In some languages, it will be natural to translate this clause as a complete sentence. For example:

God set me apart from birth.

Even before I was born, God chose me.

set me apart: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as set me apart means “appointed me” or “chose/selected me.” For example:

appointed me (GW)

chose me (NLT)

In some languages, it may be necessary to state what God had chosen Paul to do. For example:

chose me to do his work

from my mother’s womb: The BSB translates this Greek phrase literally.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

while I was in my mother’s womb

before I was born (ESV)

from birth (NIV)

1:15b**and called me by His grace,**

- and had called me because of his kindness.
- Because he is kind, he had called/made me to be his servant/child.
- He was good/kind to me and called me to be an apostle.

and called me by His grace: This is another relative clause. It also describes something that God did. As in 1:15a, be careful to translate this clause in a way that does not imply that there is another God, a God who did not call Paul. In some languages, it will be natural to translate this clause as a separate sentence. For example:

He called me through his grace (NCV)

called: The verb called means “invited” or “chose someone for a special purpose.” In this case, God called Paul to be his servant/apostle.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

He called me to serve him.

He invited me to be his servant/apostle.

Paul did not mean “call” in the sense of “shouted” or “yelled.”

by His grace: The word grace means “showing kindness, generosity, or favor to someone who does not deserve it.”

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

by/through his kindness/favor

because of his kindness

He was kind/good to me

See also grace, Meaning 2 in the Glossary.

1:15c**was pleased**

- So when it pleased him
- So then, God was glad/happy
- Then it was good to him

Notice that some English versions are like the BSB and place “was pleased” at the end of 1:15. Other versions

place this phrase at the beginning of 1:16. You should do what the major language version in your area does.

was pleased: The Greek word that the BSB translates as was pleased basically means “took pleasure in” or “considered something to be good.” It can have the additional meaning of “was pleased with something and so decided to do it.” God wants and likes to reveal Jesus to human beings, and here he decided to do reveal Jesus to Paul.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

Then it pleased him (NLT)

when God was delighted

when God considered it good

when he decided (GNT)

Galatians 1:16**Section 1:11–24: Paul received his message from Jesus himself**

In this section, Paul stressed that the gospel that he preached came from Jesus Christ himself. No human being taught it to him. Therefore, his message had God’s authority. Paul’s purpose in writing this section was to convince the Galatians that the true gospel is the one that he preached.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul’s Message Comes from Christ (NLT)

Jesus Alone Gave Paul the Good News He Spreads (GW)

Paul’s Authority is from God (NCV)

God is the source of Paul’s authority and message

Paragraph 1:15–17

In this paragraph, Paul again wrote that he received the gospel from God and not from men. When God revealed Jesus to him, he did not go to Jerusalem to learn the gospel from the apostles.

In Greek, 1:15–17 is a long, complex sentence. Before you translate this complex sentence, it is important to understand its structure.

This long sentence begins with a time clause:

^{15a}But when God ... ^{15c}was pleased ^{16a}to reveal his Son to me

In the middle of this time clause (after the phrase “But when God”) are two clauses that describe God. (These two clauses are relative clauses):

...who set me apart from my mother’s womb and who called me by his grace...

The main clauses are in 1:16c–17c:

^{16c}I did not rush to consult with flesh and blood
^{17a}nor did I go up to Jerusalem ... ^{17b}but I went into Arabia ^{17c}and later returned to Damascus.

In many languages it will be necessary to divide this long Greek sentence into several shorter sentences. It may also be necessary to change the order of some of the clauses in this long sentence. Examples are given in the notes below.

1:16a

to reveal His Son in me

- to show his Son to me
- to cause me to know his Son
- to make me to understand who his Son really is.

to reveal His Son in me: This clause means that God showed Paul that Jesus was his/God’s son.

The verb reveal does not just mean that Paul saw Jesus with his eyes. It means that God caused Paul to understand who Jesus really was. This happened on the road to Damascus.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

to show me his Son (CEV)

to cause me to know his Son

to make me to understand who his Son really is

His Son: The phrase His Son refers to God’s Son, Jesus. “The Son of God” or “God’s Son” is a title that was often used to refer to a savior who would be a descendant of King David. God would send this savior to rescue his people. This person was often referred to as the “Messiah” or “Christ.”

The title “the Son of God” also indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. The relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship with Mary that resulted in her becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus. The Son of God existed eternally as the Son with his Father.

In areas where people do not understand the title “the Son of God” in this way, you may want to include a footnote that explains the correct meaning. Here is a suggested footnote:

This title refers to Jesus. It indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It does not mean that God the Father had a sexual relationship with Mary that resulted in her becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus. Mary became pregnant with Jesus in a miraculous way by the Holy Spirit of God.

In some languages, it is natural to speak of a son as a “child,” without specifying male or female. If that is true in your language, you may use a more general term, such as:

his ChildA translation of the title “the Son of God” must include a familial term such as “son” or “child.” Translations such as “the man who is God,” “the divine man,” or “the God man” are not acceptable, since they do not retain familial language. Examples of acceptable translation options include “the Son who comes from God,” and “the divine/unique/eternal Son of God.”

Other verses will usually make clear that Jesus was a male child. If you use a phrase such as “his male child,” be sure that it does not imply that God had another child who was female.

1:16b

so that I might preach Him among the Gentiles,

- so that I might preach about him to the Gentiles,
- so that I might preach/announce the good news about him to the non-Jews.
- He did this so that I could tell the news about his Son to people who are not Jews.

so that I might preach Him among the Gentiles: This clause tells God’s purpose in revealing Jesus to Paul. God showed Jesus to Paul so that Paul would tell the good news about him to the Gentiles.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

so that I would announce his message to the Gentiles (CEV)

so that I might tell the Good News about him to those who are not Jewish (NCV)

so that I would tell people who are not Jewish that his Son is the Good News (GW)

Gentiles: The word Gentiles refers to all people who were not Jews. This is the first time that this word occurs in Galatians.

Some ways to translate this word are:

the people who are not Jews

non-Jews

See Gentiles, Meaning 1 in the Glossary.

1:16c–17

The main clause of 1:15–17 begins in 1:16c. This clause first states what Paul did not do, and then it states what he did do immediately after God revealed Jesus to him. This is the main clause:

...^{16c}I did not immediately consult with anyone
^{17a}nor did I go up to Jerusalem ...^{17b}but I went into Arabia...

Paul's main point is that he did not receive the gospel from people. Your translation should make this main point clear. In some languages, this will be clearer if you first translate what Paul did. For example:

^{17b}I immediately went into Arabia ^{16c}without consulting any man ^{17a}or going up to Jerusalem to see those who were apostles before me. ^{17c}Later I returned to Damascus.

1:16c

I did not rush to consult with flesh and blood,

- I did not go to anyone and ask him to teach me the good news.
- When this happened, I did not ask anyone to teach me the gospel.

I did not rush to consult with flesh and blood: This clause means that Paul “did not ask for information

from someone” or “did not ask for instruction from someone.” Paul did not go to anyone to ask them to tell him or teach him or give him advice about the good news.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I did not go to anyone for advice (GNT)

I did not ask anyone to teach me about the gospel

When all this happened to me, I did not rush out to consult with anyone else (NLT96)

rush: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rush relates to all three clauses in 1:16c, 1:17a, and 1:17b. In the first two clauses Paul told us what he did not do. In the third clause, he told us what he did do. In some languages, it may be more natural to place the word rush in the third clause (the one that tells us what Paul did do). For example:

but right away I departed to Arabia (NET)

Galatians 1:17

Section 1:11–24: Paul received his message from Jesus himself

In this section, Paul stressed that the gospel that he preached came from Jesus Christ himself. No human being taught it to him. Therefore, his message had God's authority. Paul's purpose in writing this section was to convince the Galatians that the true gospel is the one that he preached.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul's Message Comes from Christ (NLT)

Jesus Alone Gave Paul the Good News He Spreads (GW)

Paul's Authority is from God (NCV)

God is the source of Paul's authority and message

Paragraph 1:15–17

In this paragraph, Paul again wrote that he received the gospel from God and not from men. When God revealed Jesus to him, he did not go to Jerusalem to learn the gospel from the apostles.

In Greek, 1:15–17 is a long, complex sentence. Before you translate this complex sentence, it is important to understand its structure.

This long sentence begins with a time clause:

^{15a}But when God ...^{15c}was pleased ^{16a}to reveal his Son to me

In the middle of this time clause (after the phrase “But when God”) are two clauses that describe God. (These two clauses are relative clauses):

...who set me apart from my mother’s womb and who called me by his grace...

The main clauses are in 1:16c–17c:

^{16c}I did not rush to consult with flesh and blood
^{17a}nor did I go up to Jerusalem ...^{17b}but I went into Arabia ^{17c}and later returned to Damascus.

In many languages it will be necessary to divide this long Greek sentence into several shorter sentences. It may also be necessary to change the order of some of the clauses in this long sentence. Examples are given in the notes below.

1:17a

nor did I go up to Jerusalem to the apostles who came before me,

- Neither did I go up to Jerusalem to talk to those who became apostles before me.
- Also, I did not go to Jerusalem to learn from those who were apostles before I became an apostle.

nor did I go up to Jerusalem to the apostles who came before me: This clause indicates that Paul did not go and get his message from the other apostles. These apostles were in Jerusalem. They had authority as the spiritual leaders of the church. It might be expected that Paul would go to them to learn the gospel. But he did not go to them.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Nor did I go up to Jerusalem to consult with those who were apostles before I was (NLT)

I did not go to Jerusalem and learn from those who were apostles before I was

go up to Jerusalem: The city of Jerusalem was built on a hill. So anyone going to the city had to walk up the hill.

In some languages, it is important to say whether people walk up or “down” when they travel. In other languages, this will be unusual or may be confusing. If it is confusing in your language, you should simply say:

go to Jerusalem (GNT)

The same Greek verb occurs in 1:18b and 2:1a.

apostles who came before me: This phrase refers to the leaders of the church in Jerusalem. These men had become apostles before Paul became an apostle. Three of them are mentioned by name in 2:9b (Cephas, John, and James, who was the brother of Jesus).

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

chosen to be apostles before I was chosen to be an apostle

became apostles before I became an apostle

The word “apostle” first occurs in 1:1a. See also apostle in the Glossary for more information.

1:17b

but I went into Arabia

- Instead, I immediately went into Arabia.
- Rather, I went directly to the region of Arabia.

but: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between what Paul did not do (in 1:16c–17a) and what he did. Languages have different ways to indicate this negative-positive type of contrast. One of the functions of the Greek conjunction *ἀλλά* is to signal this negative-positive type of contrast. Some of the ways are:

- With the conjunction “but.”
- With a conjunction other than “but.” This is a common way in English to show this type of contrast. For example:

rather

on the contrary

Instead (GNT)

- With no conjunction.

I went into Arabia: This clause states what Paul did after God revealed Jesus to him. He went to Arabia.

Arabia is the name of a region. It was far away from Jerusalem. None of the apostles were in Arabia. This showed that God worked directly in Paul's life apart from any connection to the apostles in Jerusalem. Paul's point is that the gospel he preached came from God.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I went immediately into Arabia (NIV)

I went away to the region of Arabia

Notice the word "immediately" in the NIV example above. This word actually occurs in 1:16 in Greek (the BSB translates it as "rush" there). In English it is more natural to put the word "immediately" with the action that a person does rather than the action that the person did not do.

1:17c

and later returned to Damascus.

- Afterwards, I returned to Damascus.
- Then after some time there, I went back to the city of Damascus.

and later returned to Damascus: Damascus is the name of a city. It was also far from Jerusalem. It was on the road to Damascus that God first revealed Christ to Paul (Acts 9:1–19). When Paul left the region of Arabia, he went back to the city of Damascus. Paul did not say how long he stayed in Arabia before he returned to Damascus.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

and later I returned to the city of Damascus (NLT)

and afterwards I went back to the city of Damascus

and then came back to Damascus (GW)

Galatians 1:18

Section 1:11–24: Paul received his message from Jesus himself

In this section, Paul stressed that the gospel that he preached came from Jesus Christ himself. No human being taught it to him. Therefore, his message had God's authority. Paul's purpose in writing this section

was to convince the Galatians that the true gospel is the one that he preached.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul's Message Comes from Christ (NLT)

Jesus Alone Gave Paul the Good News He Spreads (GW)

Paul's Authority is from God (NCV)

God is the source of Paul's authority and message

Paragraph 1:18–20

In this paragraph, Paul stated that even though he eventually went to Jerusalem, he stayed there only fifteen days. He wrote about this short visit to show that he did not receive his message and authority from the apostles in Jerusalem.

Although he chose not go to Jerusalem when God first revealed the gospel to him, he did meet with the leaders later.

1:18a

Only after three years

- ¶ When three years had passed, then
- ¶ Three years after God revealed Jesus to me,
- ¶ It was not until three years later that

Only after three years: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Only introduces the next event that Paul wrote about. Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

Then after three years (NIV)

Next, three years later

Paul also used this same conjunction in 1:21 and 2:1, where the BSB translates it as "later."

after three years: This phrase refers to three years from the time when God revealed Jesus to Paul. It does not refer to three years from the time when he returned to Damascus from Arabia.

If your language requires you to identify which event the three years was counted from, you could say something like:

Three years after God revealed his Son to me...

1:18b**did I go up to Jerusalem to confer with Cephas,**

- I went up to Jerusalem to get to know Peter.
- I went to Jerusalem to meet Peter, (NCV)
- I finally went to Jerusalem to become acquainted with Peter.

did I go up to Jerusalem to confer with Cephas: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as to confer means “to visit for the purpose of getting to know someone.”

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I went up to Jerusalem to visit Cephas (ESV)

I went to Jerusalem to get to know Peter (NLT)

I went to Jerusalem to meet Peter (NCV)

I went to Jerusalem to become personally acquainted with Cephas (GW)

Cephas: Here Paul used the Aramaic (Jewish) name Cephas instead of the Greek name “Peter.” Both names mean “rock,” and both names refer to the same man. Several English versions, including the CEV, GNT, NIV, and NLT, say “Peter” here.

If the major language version in your area says “Cephas,” then you may want to use the name Cephas. You should then use a footnote to explain that this is another name for Peter. Otherwise, you should say “Peter” here.

1:18c**and I stayed with him fifteen days.**

- I remained with him fifteen days.
- and I stayed with him there for two weeks.
- I stayed with him for only two weeks.

and I stayed with him fifteen days: The phrase fifteen days can also be translated as:

two weeks (GNT)

Compared with three years (1:18a), fifteen days is a very short period of time. Paul emphasized that he only visited with Peter for a short time. He wanted the Galatians to know that he met with Peter, but he did not receive the gospel from Peter.

If, in your language, fifteen days is regarded as a long time, you may want to translate this phrase as:

and stayed with him only two weeks.

Galatians 1:19**Section 1:11–24: Paul received his message from Jesus himself**

In this section, Paul stressed that the gospel that he preached came from Jesus Christ himself. No human being taught it to him. Therefore, his message had God’s authority. Paul’s purpose in writing this section was to convince the Galatians that the true gospel is the one that he preached.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul’s Message Comes from Christ (NLT)

Jesus Alone Gave Paul the Good News He Spreads (GW)

Paul’s Authority is from God (NCV)

God is the source of Paul’s authority and message

Paragraph 1:18–20

In this paragraph, Paul stated that even though he eventually went to Jerusalem, he stayed there only fifteen days. He wrote about this short visit to show that he did not receive his message and authority from the apostles in Jerusalem.

Although he chose not go to Jerusalem when God first revealed the gospel to him, he did meet with the leaders later.

1:19**But I saw none of the other apostles except James, the Lord’s brother.**

- I did not see any of the other apostles. However I did see James, the brother of the Lord.
- I also met James, the younger brother of the Lord Jesus. But I did not see any of the other apostles.

But: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between whom Peter saw and whom he did not see. The Greek indicates this contrast with a conjunction that the BSB translates as But.

I saw none of the other apostles except James:

There are two ways to interpret the clause that the BSB translates as I saw none of the other apostles except James:

1. Paul considered James to be one of the apostles. He saw two of the apostles, Peter and James, but none of the other apostles. For example:

The only other apostle I saw was James (CEV)
(BSB, ESV, RSV, GNT, CEV, NLT, NCV, NASB, REB, NET)

1. Paul did not consider James to be one of the apostles. He saw the apostle Peter, but no other apostle. The only other person he saw was James. For example:

I didn't see any other apostle. I only saw James,
the Lord's brother. (GW) (NIV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The majority of English versions follow this interpretation.

I saw none of the other apostles: Paul wrote this tell the Galatians that he had almost no contact with the apostles in Jerusalem. They did not teach the gospel to him.

The word “apostle” first occurs in 1:1a. See also apostle in the Glossary for more information.

James, the Lord's brother: Church groups differ in what they believe about James and in what sense he was the Lord's brother. The three main views are:

1. James was the son of Joseph and Mary, born after Jesus.
2. James was Jesus' cousin. For a good presentation and analysis of the various views, see Arndt's commentary on Luke 8:19.
3. James was Jesus' half-brother. He was the son of Joseph from a previous marriage.

If possible, use a general word for brother that could apply to any of the views above.

If your language must distinguish between “older” and “younger” brother, it is recommended that you use a term for “younger brother” here.

If your language does not use terms that distinguish male and female, you can use a term for “sibling” or “younger-sibling.”

the Lord's brother: Paul used the title “Lord” to refer to Jesus. If this is not clear in your language, you could say:

the brother of the Lord Jesus

General Comment on 1:19

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses in this verse. You may need to say that Paul also saw James before mentioning that he did not see any other apostles. For example:

I also saw James, the Lord's brother. But I did not see any of the other apostles at that time.

Galatians 1:20

Section 1:11–24: Paul received his message from Jesus himself

In this section, Paul stressed that the gospel that he preached came from Jesus Christ himself. No human being taught it to him. Therefore, his message had God's authority. Paul's purpose in writing this section was to convince the Galatians that the true gospel is the one that he preached.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul's Message Comes from Christ (NLT)

Jesus Alone Gave Paul the Good News He Spreads
(GW)

Paul's Authority is from God (NCV)

God is the source of Paul's authority and message

Paragraph 1:18–20

In this paragraph, Paul stated that even though he eventually went to Jerusalem, he stayed there only fifteen days. He wrote about this short visit to show that he did not receive his message and authority from the apostles in Jerusalem.

Although he chose not go to Jerusalem when God first revealed the gospel to him, he did meet with the leaders later.

1:20

I assure you before God that what I am writing to you is no lie.

- I declare before God that what I am writing to you is not a lie. (NLT)
- God is my witness that what I'm writing is not a lie. (GW)

In this verse, Paul wrote an oath. He used this oath to emphasize that what he had written about his visit to Jerusalem was true. He wanted to convince the

Galatians that although he saw Peter and James, they did not teach him the gospel.

I assure you before God: The phrase before God is a natural way in some languages to emphasize that what was said is the truth. In other languages, it may be more understandable to translate this phrase as:

I declare before God (NLT)

God is my witness (GW)

And in the presence of God I swear (CEV)

is no lie: This clause also emphasizes that what Paul wrote concerning his visit to Jerusalem was true.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

these things I write are not lies (NCV)

what I am writing to you is true

I am telling the truth (CEV)

Galatians 1:21

Section 1:11–24: Paul received his message from Jesus himself

In this section, Paul stressed that the gospel that he preached came from Jesus Christ himself. No human being taught it to him. Therefore, his message had God's authority. Paul's purpose in writing this section was to convince the Galatians that the true gospel is the one that he preached.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul's Message Comes from Christ (NLT)

Jesus Alone Gave Paul the Good News He Spreads (GW)

Paul's Authority is from God (NCV)

God is the source of Paul's authority and message

1:21

Later I went to the regions of Syria and Cilicia.

- ¶ After that visit I went to the provinces of Syria and Cilicia.

- ¶ When I left Jerusalem, I travelled to the regions of Syria and Cilicia.

Later: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Later introduces what Paul did after his short visit to Jerusalem.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

After that visit

Then, from Jerusalem

When I left Jerusalem

I went to the regions of Syria and Cilicia: The words Syria and Cilicia are the names of two regions/districts. These regions were far away from Jerusalem. They were far away from the place where the apostles lived and where the church began.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I went to the districts of Syria and Cilicia

I went to the areas of Syria and Cilicia (NCV)

Galatians 1:22

Section 1:11–24: Paul received his message from Jesus himself

In this section, Paul stressed that the gospel that he preached came from Jesus Christ himself. No human being taught it to him. Therefore, his message had God's authority. Paul's purpose in writing this section was to convince the Galatians that the true gospel is the one that he preached.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul's Message Comes from Christ (NLT)

Jesus Alone Gave Paul the Good News He Spreads (GW)

Paul's Authority is from God (NCV)

God is the source of Paul's authority and message

1:22

I was personally unknown, however, to the churches of Judea that are in Christ.

- The groups of people in Judea who believe in Christ had never met me.
- The people who trusted in Christ in Judea had not yet seen me.
- During that time, the groups of Christians in the region of Judea did not know me personally.

Paul had spent only two weeks in Jerusalem. So the believers in the district of Judea did not know him. (Jerusalem is in the district of Judea.) However, they did hear about his ministry. Paul told the Galatians about the reaction of the Judean believers when they heard about his preaching in Syria and Cilicia.

Some ways to begin this verse are:

At that time (GNT)

During that time

So

I was personally unknown, however, to the churches of Judea that are in Christ: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as personally unknown is literally “being unknown by the face.” Paul meant that the believers in Judea had not yet met him. They had not yet seen his face.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

In Judea the churches in Christ had never met me. (NCV)

And still the Christians in the churches in Judea didn't know me personally. (NLT)

In this clause, Paul continued to focus on the fact that he did not receive the gospel from people. He wanted to emphasize that he was not under the authority of the leaders in Jerusalem. (The city of Jerusalem is in the district of Judea.)

the churches...that are in Christ: This phrase refers to the groups of people who believe in Christ.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

group of people who believe in Christ

believers in Christ

Christians

The word churches does not refer to church buildings.

The word church first occurs in 1:2b. See also church in the Glossary for more information.

Galatians 1:23

Section 1:11–24: Paul received his message from Jesus himself

In this section, Paul stressed that the gospel that he preached came from Jesus Christ himself. No human being taught it to him. Therefore, his message had God's authority. Paul's purpose in writing this section was to convince the Galatians that the true gospel is the one that he preached.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul's Message Comes from Christ (NLT)

Jesus Alone Gave Paul the Good News He Spreads (GW)

Paul's Authority is from God (NCV)

God is the source of Paul's authority and message

1:23a

They only heard the account:

- They had only heard,
- Nevertheless, they had been told that
- However, someone had told them that

They only heard the account: This clause indicates how the believers in the district of Judea knew about Paul. Even though they had not met him (1:22), they had heard about his ministry in regions far away from them.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

They only were hearing it said (ESV)

They had only been told

only: The word only distinguishes between knowing Paul personally and knowing about his ministry. The believers in Judea did not know Paul personally. They only knew about his work.

Some other ways to translate this are:

However, they heard the report that

Nevertheless they heard about me

The word only does not refer to the content of the report (1:23b–c). It does not mean, “Here is the only thing they heard about Paul.”

1:23b

“The man who formerly persecuted us is now preaching the faith

- “The man who used to cause us^(incl) to suffer is now preaching about faith in Christ
- “This man formerly attacked us believers. But he is now telling people to trust/believe in Christ.
- I previously harmed the church. Now I tell people to believe the good news

In 1:23b, Paul wrote what the Judean Christians were hearing about him. Introduce what they were hearing in a natural way in your language. One way is to use indirect speech. For example:

^{23a}They had only heard that ^{23b}the man who formerly persecuted them was now preaching the faith...

The man who formerly persecuted us: This clause means that Paul formerly caused the Christians to suffer. The word persecuted also occurs in 1:13b. Translate it here as you did there. For example:

This man who was attacking us (NCV)

the man who caused us to suffer during previous times

that I, the one who once harmed the church

is now preaching the faith: This clause means that Paul had begun to tell people to have faith or believe in Christ to be saved. He was preaching the good news about Christ.

Some other ways to translate this clause is:

was now preaching the message (CEV)

is now telling people how to have faith in Christ

is now teaching the gospel in which we have faith

See faith, Meaning 2 in the Glossary.

1:23c

he once tried to destroy.”

- that he had previously tried to destroy/spoil.”
- He had previously tried/wanted to destroy people who believe such things.”
- that, before, I wanted to make people stop believing.

he once tried to destroy: This clause refers to “the faith,” that is, the gospel. The good news about Christ that Paul was preaching was the same good news that he had previously wanted to destroy.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

he previously tried to destroy/spoil

that at one time he had wanted to finish/end

In some languages, it is not natural use the verb destroy with something like “faith” or “gospel.” These languages may have to translate this as:

He had previously tried to destroy the people who believed such things.

Before, he wanted to make people stop believing these things.

The same word for destroy also occurs in 1:13c.

once: The Greek word that the BSB translates as once means “formerly” or “before.” It does not mean “one time.” Paul had tried many times to destroy the gospel. It is the same word that Paul used in 1:23b.

General Comment on 1:23b–c

In Greek, this is one sentence with three clauses. In some languages, it may be more natural to divide these clauses into separate sentences. For example:

^bPaul, who formerly persecuted us, is now preaching the faith. ^cHe had once tried to destroy that faith.

^bPaul formerly persecuted us. Now he is preaching about faith in Christ. ^cHe had once tried to destroy that faith.

Galatians 1:24

Section 1:11–24: Paul received his message from Jesus himself

In this section, Paul stressed that the gospel that he preached came from Jesus Christ himself. No human being taught it to him. Therefore, his message had God's authority. Paul's purpose in writing this section was to convince the Galatians that the true gospel is the one that he preached.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul's Message Comes from Christ (NLT)

Jesus Alone Gave Paul the Good News He Spreads (GW)

Paul's Authority is from God (NCV)

God is the source of Paul's authority and message

1:24

And they glorified God because of me.

- So they were praising God because of what he had done for me.
- Because of this report about me, they were giving thanks to God.

And they glorified God because of me: This clause tells the result of 1:23. The believers in Judea heard the report about Paul's ministry (1:23). As a result, they glorified/praised God:

1. for changing Paul and
2. for working through him to spread the faith (1:23b).

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

So they praised God for what had happened to me. (GW)

Therefore they were praising God for what he had done in my life.

Because of this news about me, they gave thanks to God.

glorified God: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as glorified means "praised" or "gave thanks." The form of the Greek verb indicates that the believers regularly praised God. They did it more than one time.

One other way to translate this verb is:

were praising God

Galatians 2:1

Section 2:1–10: The church leaders accepted Paul's apostleship and his message

In this section, Paul explained to the Galatians one reason why they should hold firm to the gospel that he had taught them. He did this by telling them about the meeting that he had in Jerusalem with the apostles there. At this meeting, the apostles recognized Paul's authority as an apostle. They also agreed that he preached the true gospel.

This meeting became necessary because of the message of some false teachers. These false teachers insisted that a person was not truly saved unless he also became circumcised and kept the laws of Moses. (See Acts 15:1–2 and Galatians 2:4.) At the meeting, the apostles agreed with Paul. They agreed that no one should force non-Jewish believers to be circumcised and obey the Law that God gave to Moses. This showed the Galatians that these teachers were wrong.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul Was Accepted as an Apostle by the Leaders in Jerusalem (GW)

The apostles accept Paul

Paul's apostleship and message

The Jerusalem leaders recognized Paul's apostleship and message

Paragraph 2:1–5

In this paragraph, Paul told about the meeting that he and Barnabas had with church leaders in Jerusalem. In this meeting, Paul wanted to see whether the leaders would accept the message that he was teaching to Gentiles. The fact that the leaders did not require Titus, a Greek, to be circumcised showed that they accepted Paul's message. They accepted his message in spite of some opposition from false brothers.

2:1a

Fourteen years later I went up again to Jerusalem, accompanied by Barnabas.

- ¶ Then fourteen years later, I went up to Jerusalem again. This time, Barnabas went with me.

- ¶ Then fourteen years after my first visit to Jerusalem, I returned to Jerusalem. I took Barnabas with me.

Fourteen years later: There are two ways to interpret the phrase Fourteen years later:

1. It means fourteen years after Paul's previous visit to Jerusalem to see Peter in 1:18.
2. It means fourteen years from Paul's conversion in 1:16.

If possible, you should translate as generally as in the BSB and the Greek. In other words, you should not specifically state from which event these fourteen years are counted. However, if you cannot leave it ambiguous, follow interpretation (1). Most scholars agree with interpretation (1).

Another way to translate this phrase is:

Then fourteen years after my visit to Jerusalem

I went up again to Jerusalem: The verb that the BSB translates as went up indicates that the city of Jerusalem was built on a hill. So anyone going to Jerusalem had to walk up or ascend the hill.

In some languages, it is important to say whether people go up or go "down" when they travel. In other languages, this will be unusual or may be confusing. If it is confusing in your language, you should simply say:

I went to Jerusalem again (GW)

The same Greek verb occurs in 1:18b.

again: The word again indicates that this was another visit that Paul made to Jerusalem.

Some ways to translate this entire clause are:

I ascended to Jerusalem again

I went back to Jerusalem once again

I returned to Jerusalem

accompanied by Barnabas: The word Barnabas is the name of a man. Barnabas had accompanied Paul on his mission trip to Galatia. He went again with Paul on this trip to Jerusalem.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

this time with Barnabas (NCV)

taking Barnabas as a companion

Barnabas went with me

2:1b

I took Titus along also.

- Titus also went with me.
- I also took Titus along with me/us.

I took Titus along also: The verb took...along implies that Paul and Barnabas invited Titus to go with them to Jerusalem.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

and we took Titus with us (JBP)

I also took Titus with me. (NCV)

Titus: Titus was a Greek man who became a Christian as a result of Paul's ministry. As a Greek, a non-Jew, he was not circumcised.

Galatians 2:2

Section 2:1–10: The church leaders accepted Paul's apostleship and his message

In this section, Paul explained to the Galatians one reason why they should hold firm to the gospel that he had taught them. He did this by telling them about the meeting that he had in Jerusalem with the apostles there. At this meeting, the apostles recognized Paul's authority as an apostle. They also agreed that he preached the true gospel.

This meeting became necessary because of the message of some false teachers. These false teachers insisted that a person was not truly saved unless he also became circumcised and kept the laws of Moses. (See Acts 15:1–2 and Galatians 2:4.) At the meeting, the apostles agreed with Paul. They agreed that no one should force non-Jewish believers to be circumcised and obey the Law that God gave to Moses. This showed the Galatians that these teachers were wrong.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul Was Accepted as an Apostle by the Leaders in Jerusalem (GW)

The apostles accept Paul

Paul's apostleship and message

The Jerusalem leaders recognized Paul's apostleship and message

Paragraph 2:1–5

In this paragraph, Paul told about the meeting that he and Barnabas had with church leaders in Jerusalem. In this meeting, Paul wanted to see whether the leaders would accept the message that he was teaching to Gentiles. The fact that the leaders did not require Titus, a Greek, to be circumcised showed that they accepted Paul's message. They accepted his message in spite of some opposition from false brothers.

2:2a

I went in response to a revelation

- I went because God showed me I should go. (NCV)
- God had showed me that I should go up to Jerusalem, so I went.
- I went there because God had told me to go. (CEV)

I went in response to a revelation: The word revelation means that God “revealed” or “showed” something to Paul. He showed him that he should go to Jerusalem. The apostles in Jerusalem did not send for Paul. Paul wrote this to show that he was under God's authority, not under the authority of the apostles.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I went there because God revealed to me that I should go. (NLT)

I went because God showed me I should go. (NCV)

I went there because God had told me to go (CEV)

God told me to go to Jerusalem, so I went there.

2:2b

and set before them the gospel that I preach among the Gentiles. But I spoke privately to those recognized as leaders,

- When I got there, I gave a report of the gospel that I had been preaching to the Gentiles. I did this privately/only in front of the men who were leaders.
- When we^(excl) arrived there, I met alone with the leaders of the church. I explained to them the message that I preach to the non-Jews.

Before you translate 2:2b, compare the BSB with the ESV. Notice where each version puts the clause that

includes the word “privately.” (This clause is underlined below.)

and set before them the gospel that I preach among the Gentiles. But I spoke privately to those recognized as leaders (BSB)

and set before them (though privately before those who seemed influential) the gospel that I proclaim among the Gentiles (ESV)

In 2:2b, the BSB follows the Greek order more closely than the ESV. Many languages will probably want to follow the BSB order here.

and set before them: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as set before also means “declared,” “communicated,” “explained,” or “made clear.” When Paul arrived in Jerusalem, he explained to the church leaders what he was teaching to the Gentiles. He wanted to get their response. He did this so that everyone would know that he and the church leaders were in agreement about the message that he preached.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

I explained (GNT)

shared with them (NLT)

I told their leaders (NCV)

them: The pronoun them refers to the leaders in the Jerusalem church. This is the first time in this passage that Paul referred to these men. In 2:9, he named them: James, Peter, and John. Elsewhere in this passage he referred to them as “the ones who seemed influential” (2:2, 2:6a, 2:6d) and “those who seemed to be pillars” (2:9).

In many languages, you must first introduce people using a noun, not a pronoun. If your language is like that, you will need to:

- Use a noun phrase here. For example:

the church leaders in Jerusalem

- Change the order of the clause so that the clause “those recognized as leaders” comes before the pronoun them. For example:

I had a meeting alone with those men who were influential. I explained to them the message that I preach to the non-Jews

the gospel that I preach among the Gentiles: The word Gentiles: is the same word that Paul used in 1:16b. See also Gentiles, Meaning 1, in the Glossary for more information.

But I spoke privately: The word privately indicates that Paul explained his message only to certain people. It implies that the meeting did not include the entire church.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I explained this only to those who were leaders

I did this alone with the church leaders

to those recognized as leaders: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as to those recognized as leaders refers to the men who were recognized as important leaders of the church in Jerusalem. These leaders included Peter, James, and John. (See Galatians 2:9 and Acts 15:6.)

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the influential people (NET)

those esteemed as leaders (NIV11)

the leaders of the church (NLT96)

the leaders (GNT)

A few English versions (such as the ESV and NIV) translate this phrase as “those who seemed to be leaders.” Such a translation can give the false impression that these men only “seemed” to be leaders, but they were really not leaders. Most commentaries agree that this phrase refers to recognized leaders. For example, Bruce says that the Greek word often translated as “seemed” here “carries no insinuation of sarcasm or irony, as though they only seemed to be leaders but were not really so” (p. 109). In your translation, do not imply that Paul was questioning whether these men were actually leaders of the church.

2:2c for fear that

- I gave this report so that I could be sure

- I did that because I did not want
- I did that so that

for fear that: The Greek words that the BSB translates as for fear that introduce Paul’s purpose in explaining his message to the church leaders. Paul explained his message to the leaders (2:2b) in order to be sure that they agreed with his work (2:2c).

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

in order that

so that I could be sure/certain

I wanted to make sure that we were in agreement (NLT)

In Greek, these words are more literally “so that not.” So another way to translate these words are:

so that I might not be running, or have run the race, in vain (HCSB)

Paul did not want his work to be for nothing. If the church leaders and Paul did not agree about the content of the gospel, then the spread of the gospel would be hindered. He did not want division between the Jewish believers and the Gentile believers.

2:2d

I was running or had already run in vain.

- that they agreed with me and that I was not running or had run my race in vain.
- the work that I am doing and the work that I have done to be like a race that I had run for nothing.
- the work that I had done, and the work that I was doing, were not worthless.

I was running or had already run in vain: This clause is a metaphor. In this metaphor, Paul compared his work of preaching the gospel to a person running a race. A preacher and a runner are similar in that both people work hard, and neither wants his work to be in vain. A person who runs a race works hard to win. Paul worked hard to preach the gospel. He wanted the gospel that he preached to have lasting effects, and he wanted the leaders to agree that it was the true gospel.

Some ways to translate this metaphor are:

- Keep the metaphor. In most languages, it will be good to add some explanation. For example:

all my work was not in vain and I was running the race for nothing.

- Translate the metaphor as a simile. For example:

all the work that I had done was not like a race that I had run or was running in vain

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

I did not want my past work and the work I am now doing to be wasted. (NCV)

what I had done and proposed doing was acceptable to them (JBP)

in vain: The phrase in vain means “useless,” “for nothing,” “without result,” or “without effect.”

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

wasted (NCV)

useless

Galatians 2:3

Section 2:1–10: The church leaders accepted Paul’s apostleship and his message

In this section, Paul explained to the Galatians one reason why they should hold firm to the gospel that he had taught them. He did this by telling them about the meeting that he had in Jerusalem with the apostles there. At this meeting, the apostles recognized Paul’s authority as an apostle. They also agreed that he preached the true gospel.

This meeting became necessary because of the message of some false teachers. These false teachers insisted that a person was not truly saved unless he also became circumcised and kept the laws of Moses. (See Acts 15:1–2 and Galatians 2:4.) At the meeting, the apostles agreed with Paul. They agreed that no one should force non-Jewish believers to be circumcised and obey the Law that God gave to Moses. This showed the Galatians that these teachers were wrong.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul Was Accepted as an Apostle by the Leaders in Jerusalem (GW)

The apostles accept Paul

Paul’s apostleship and message

The Jerusalem leaders recognized Paul’s apostleship and message

Paragraph 2:1–5

In this paragraph, Paul told about the meeting that he and Barnabas had with church leaders in Jerusalem. In this meeting, Paul wanted to see whether the leaders would accept the message that he was teaching to Gentiles. The fact that the leaders did not require Titus, a Greek, to be circumcised showed that they accepted Paul’s message. They accepted his message in spite of some opposition from false brothers.

2:3

In 2:3, Paul gave some evidence that he had not run in vain. He gave some evidence that the leaders in Jerusalem approved the gospel that he preached. Paul did not state this explicitly, but he showed that they agreed by telling the Galatians that the leaders did not force Titus to be circumcised.

2:3a

Yet not even Titus, who was with me, was compelled to be circumcised,

- But I was not running in vain. Titus, who was there with me, was not even forced/required to be circumcised,
- And they agreed with me. This was clear because no one even insisted/demanded that my companion Titus should be circumcised.

Yet: There is a contrast between 2:2 and 2:3. The contrast is between what Paul feared might happen and what actually happened. He was concerned that the leaders would not agree with him. He was concerned that he had “run in vain” (2:2). But the leaders did agree with him and his message. Paul did not directly state that they agreed. He showed that they agreed with him by telling about Titus.

Some English versions, such the BSB and NIV, indicate this contrast with the conjunction Yet. Other English versions, such the ESV and NASB, indicate this contrast with the conjunction “but.”

In some languages, it might be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

But I was not running in vain.

And they did agree (NLT96)

not even Titus, who was with me, was compelled to be circumcised: The words not even focus attention on the proof that the church leaders agreed with Paul's message. The proof was that they did not even require a Gentile to be circumcised. If the church leaders had not agreed with Paul, they would have required that Titus be circumcised. He was right there when they made the decision. But they did not require him to be circumcised. This proved that they agreed with Paul that God accepted Gentile Christians even if they were not circumcised.

Another way to translate this clause is:

They did not even demand that my companion Titus be circumcised (NLT96)

Titus, who was with me: The clause who was with me is a relative clause. It describes Titus. In some languages, using this type of relative clause here would imply that there was another Titus, a Titus who was not with Paul. Even though there were certainly other men with that name, that is not the point here. In those languages, it would be better to translate these words without using a relative clause. For example:

Titus was with me (GW)

my companion Titus (NLT)

was compelled: The phrase was compelled is passive. Some ways to translate this phrase are:

- Use a passive clause. For example:

he was not forced (NCV)

- Use an active clause. For example:

no one forced (GW)

they did not require/demand

they did not insist

circumcised: The word circumcised means “cut off the loose skin at the end of a boy's penis.” Jews circumcised their sons as an act of obedience to the law.

In some cultures, it may be acceptable to use an explicit expression that means “cut off the loose skin at the end of a boy's penis.” In other cultures, it may be

necessary to use a euphemism to describe this event. Some examples are:

cut off some of the skin

receive the mark

ritual cutting

a mark of cutting

This is the first time that Paul mentioned circumcision in Galatians.

2:3b even though he was a Greek.

- even though he was a Greek.
- Titus was a Greek and had never been circumcised.

even though he was a Greek: The fact that Titus was a Greek implies that he was not a Jew. So he had never been circumcised. (Most of the first Christians were Jews and had already been circumcised.) Nevertheless, the church leaders did not require Titus to be circumcised in order to be accepted as a believer.

In some languages, it may be clearer to put this clause earlier in the verse. For example:

^{3a}Titus went to Jerusalem with me. ^{3b}He was a Greek, ^{3a}but still he wasn't forced to be circumcised. (CEV)

^{3a}Titus was with me, ^{3b}and although he is Greek, ^{3a}no one forced him to be circumcised. (GW)

Galatians 2:4

Section 2:1–10: The church leaders accepted Paul's apostleship and his message

In this section, Paul explained to the Galatians one reason why they should hold firm to the gospel that he had taught them. He did this by telling them about the meeting that he had in Jerusalem with the apostles there. At this meeting, the apostles recognized Paul's authority as an apostle. They also agreed that he preached the true gospel.

This meeting became necessary because of the message of some false teachers. These false teachers insisted that a person was not truly saved unless he also became circumcised and kept the laws of Moses. (See Acts 15:1–2 and Galatians 2:4.) At the meeting, the

apostles agreed with Paul. They agreed that no one should force non-Jewish believers to be circumcised and obey the Law that God gave to Moses. This showed the Galatians that these teachers were wrong.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul Was Accepted as an Apostle by the Leaders in Jerusalem (GW)

The apostles accept Paul

Paul's apostleship and message

The Jerusalem leaders recognized Paul's apostleship and message

Paragraph 2:1–5

In this paragraph, Paul told about the meeting that he and Barnabas had with church leaders in Jerusalem. In this meeting, Paul wanted to see whether the leaders would accept the message that he was teaching to Gentiles. The fact that the leaders did not require Titus, a Greek, to be circumcised showed that they accepted Paul's message. They accepted his message in spite of some opposition from false brothers.

2:4a

This issue arose because some false brothers had come in under false pretenses

- This issue/matter arose because some false brothers had secretly come
- We talked about circumcision because some men who said that they were believers (but they were not) secretly came into the group.
- But some people wanted Titus circumcised. They were some men who pretended to be believers. They sneaked/came into our meeting.

This issue arose: This phrase is not in the Greek. Most commentators agree that in 2:4–5, Paul was responding to the pressure to have Titus circumcised. In 2:4, Paul began a sentence that he never finished. To make it a complete sentence, the BSB has added some words at the beginning of this verse. Some other English versions do the same. For example:

This matter arose (NIV)

We talked about this problem (NCV)

Even that question came up only (NLT)

although some wanted it done (GNT)

issue The word issue in the BSB refers to the issue of circumcision. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this more explicit. For example:

We talked about the issue of circumcision

But some people wanted him to get circumcised.

because some false brothers: The term false brothers refers to Jews who pretended to be Christian brothers. In fact, they were not Christian brothers. Their message was also a false message.

Some other ways to translate this term are:

false/fake Christian brothers

those who pretended to be followers (CEV)

some men who pretended to be our brothers in Christ

had come in under false pretenses: In the Greek, the words that the BSB translates as had come in under false pretenses is actually two separate phrases. The Greek literally says “the false brothers brought in secretly, came in by stealth.” There are two ways to interpret the Greek word literally translated as “brought in secretly”:

1. It has an active sense and describes what the false brothers themselves did. They brought themselves secretly into the meeting. According to this interpretation, this word and the Greek word that is literally “came in by stealth” refer to the same action. Most English versions that follow this interpretation translate both Greek words as one English verb. For example:

had sneaked in among us (CEV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NET, NJB, REB, NLT96, CEV, JBP)

1. It has a passive sense and describes what other people did for the false brothers. Other people brought the false brothers into the meeting secretly. According to this interpretation, this word refers to a different action than the Greek word literally translated as “came in by stealth.” Most English versions that follow this interpretation

translate the two Greek words with two different English expressions. For example:

False Christians were brought in. They slipped in (GW) (ESV, RSV, KJV, NASB, GW, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The phrase had come in under false pretenses suggests that the false brothers came into the meeting of their own initiative.

You should use a verb that describes the actions of spies/traitors who “sneak” into groups and their meetings.

Some other ways to translate this entire expression are:

these men slipped into our group (GNT)

some false brothers had infiltrated our ranks (NIV)

some false brothers had secretly joined/attended our meeting

some false believers had come into our group secretly. They came in (NCV)

2:4b

to spy on our freedom in Christ Jesus,

- to spy on us^(excl) and take away the freedom that we^(incl) have because we believe in Christ Jesus.
- They came to spy on us in order to destroy the freedom which Christ Jesus has given to us^(incl) because we believe
- We^(incl) are free from obeying the law because we believe in Christ Jesus, but they wanted observe/watch us^(excl) in order to take that away from us.

to spy on: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as to spy on means “to watch or observe.” The context determines whether it was for good or for evil. In this context, the false brothers certainly came to watch with evil intentions. They wanted to destroy the freedom of the new Christians. In some languages, it may be good to make this more explicit. For example:

to spy on us and take away (NLT)

as spies. They had come to take away (CEV)

to observe us and destroy/remove

our freedom in Christ Jesus: This clause refers to the freedom that believers have, because they believe in Christ Jesus, from obeying the law of Moses. As believers in Christ, the Galatians were not obligated to be circumcised as the Jews who were under the law were. They were free from those types of religious laws.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

the freedom that Christ Jesus had given us (CEV)

We are free from the law because we believe in Christ Jesus

Christ Jesus: In 1:1c, 1:3, and 1:12c, the order of this phrase is “Jesus Christ.” This is the first time the order is Christ Jesus. In most English translations and other national language translations, “Jesus Christ” and “Christ Jesus” are translated in the same order as they occur in the Greek.

Remember that Christ is a title, and Jesus is a name. Some languages will always put a title before a name. So, in some languages, it may be natural always to use the same order.

2:4c

in order to enslave us.

- They did this to make us^(incl) slaves.
- in order to make us slaves to the law of Moses.
- They wanted to enslave us and force us to follow their Jewish regulations. (NLT)

in order to: The words in order to introduce the purpose for the false brothers’ action in 2:4b. Paul is saying:

^{4b}The false brothers wanted to take our liberty away from us ^{4c}in order that they could make us slaves.

In some languages, it will be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

They wanted to make us like slaves.

enslave us: This clause means that the false brothers wanted to make the Galatian believers slaves to the law of Moses. The false brothers wanted Gentile Christians to follow all the rules of the Jewish law. They especially wanted them to be circumcised. If Gentile

Christians did what the false brothers wanted, they would become like slaves who are required to obey a master.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

to make us slaves to the law

They wanted to enslave us and force us to follow their Jewish regulations. (NLT)

Galatians 2:5

Section 2:1–10: The church leaders accepted Paul's apostleship and his message

In this section, Paul explained to the Galatians one reason why they should hold firm to the gospel that he had taught them. He did this by telling them about the meeting that he had in Jerusalem with the apostles there. At this meeting, the apostles recognized Paul's authority as an apostle. They also agreed that he preached the true gospel.

This meeting became necessary because of the message of some false teachers. These false teachers insisted that a person was not truly saved unless he also became circumcised and kept the laws of Moses. (See Acts 15:1–2 and Galatians 2:4.) At the meeting, the apostles agreed with Paul. They agreed that no one should force non-Jewish believers to be circumcised and obey the Law that God gave to Moses. This showed the Galatians that these teachers were wrong.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul Was Accepted as an Apostle by the Leaders in Jerusalem (GW)

The apostles accept Paul

Paul's apostleship and message

The Jerusalem leaders recognized Paul's apostleship and message

Paragraph 2:1–5

In this paragraph, Paul told about the meeting that he and Barnabas had with church leaders in Jerusalem. In this meeting, Paul wanted to see whether the leaders would accept the message that he was teaching to Gentiles. The fact that the leaders did not require Titus, a Greek, to be circumcised showed that they

accepted Paul's message. They accepted his message in spite of some opposition from false brothers.

2:5a

We did not give in to them for a moment,

- We^(excl) did not at all accept what they were saying,
- But we^(excl) never agreed with what they wanted to do.

We did not give in to them for a moment: This clause means that Paul and some other people did not at all agree with the false teachers who wanted Gentile believers to be circumcised. They did not ask Gentile believers such as Titus to get circumcised.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

we did not yield/submit to them even a little bit

we refused to give in to them for even a minute

we did not at all accept what they wanted to do

we did not agree with them at all

In some languages, it may be natural to state this without using the word not. For example:

we completely disagreed with them

we were completely against them

we were absolutely opposed to them

not...for a moment: This phrase means “never” or “not at all.” Paul never accepted the teaching of the false brothers.

to them: The pronoun them refers to the false brothers in 2:4a.

2:5b

so that the truth of the gospel would remain with you.

- so that the true gospel might remain with you.
- in order that the true message would not be changed/distorted for you.
- We were determined to keep the true Good News pure for your sake/benefit.

so that: The Greek word that the BSB translates as so that indicates that 2:5b is the purpose for 2:5a. Paul

refused to yield to the false teachers (2:5a) so that the truth of the gospel might be preserved (2:5b).

In some languages, it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

We wanted the truth of the Good News to continue for you. (NCV)

We did that because we wanted to preserve the truth of the gospel for you.

the truth of the gospel: This phrase refers to the “true gospel” as opposed to the “false gospel” that the false brothers taught. It means “the message of the true gospel” or “the truth that is the gospel.”

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the true gospel

the true Good News

the true teaching that is the good news about Jesus

would remain: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as would remain means “might remain” or “might continue.” Paul did not want any false doctrines added to the true gospel. He did not want the true gospel changed in any way. He wanted the gospel to remain or “continue to be” the only message.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

continue (NCV)

should be maintained (REB)

would not be changed/distorted

would not be mixed with false teaching

with you: Certain Gentiles had already received the true gospel. The BSB translates this phrase as with you to indicate that Paul wanted the true gospel to remain “with them.”

This phrase can also mean “for the sake/benefit of Gentile believers” like the Galatians. Paul did not want the good news of salvation by faith to be changed. He did not want the church to require Gentile believers

to be circumcised. He fought hard to keep the gospel pure and unchanged for the benefit of Gentile believers like the Galatians. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

for you (ESV)

General Comment on 2:5

The most prominent part of this verse is that the truth of the gospel be preserved for the Galatians. In some languages, it may be more natural to put 2:5b before 2:5a to show that prominence. For example:

^{5b}We wanted the true gospel to be preserved for you, ^{5a}so we never gave in to them.

Galatians 2:6

Section 2:1–10: The church leaders accepted Paul’s apostleship and his message

In this section, Paul explained to the Galatians one reason why they should hold firm to the gospel that he had taught them. He did this by telling them about the meeting that he had in Jerusalem with the apostles there. At this meeting, the apostles recognized Paul’s authority as an apostle. They also agreed that he preached the true gospel.

This meeting became necessary because of the message of some false teachers. These false teachers insisted that a person was not truly saved unless he also became circumcised and kept the laws of Moses. (See Acts 15:1–2 and Galatians 2:4.) At the meeting, the apostles agreed with Paul. They agreed that no one should force non-Jewish believers to be circumcised and obey the Law that God gave to Moses. This showed the Galatians that these teachers were wrong.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul Was Accepted as an Apostle by the Leaders in Jerusalem (GW)

The apostles accept Paul

Paul’s apostleship and message

The Jerusalem leaders recognized Paul’s apostleship and message

Paragraph 2:6–10

In this paragraph, Paul wrote about two results from the meeting in Jerusalem.

The first result of that meeting (2:6) was that the apostles and elders did not find it necessary to add circumcision or anything else to Paul's message. They agreed that the gospel that Paul preached was true and complete.

The second result (2:7-9) was that the apostles agreed that Paul had full authority as an apostle. They recognized that God had given him authority to preach the gospel to the Gentiles.

2:6

The most important idea in 2:6 is in 2:6d. It is that the church leaders did not add anything to Paul's message. In some languages, it will be more natural to show that 2:6d is the important idea by putting it earlier in the verse. Compare the BSB with the GW:

^aBut as for the highly esteemed—^bwhatever they were makes no difference to me; ^cGod does not show favoritism 2:6 Literally God does not accept the face of man—^dthose leaders added nothing to me. (BSB)

^aThose who were recognized as important people ^ddidn't add a single thing to my message. ^b(What sort of people they were makes no difference to me, ^csince God doesn't play favorites.) (GW)

2:6a

But as for the highly esteemed—

- ¶ As for those men who were leaders,
- ¶ Concerning/Regarding those men who were leaders of the church,
- ¶ But the leaders of the church

But as for: Paul began this paragraph by mentioning the leaders of the church. These leaders contrast with the "false brothers" and their views.

Some other ways to begin this verse are:

And from (ESV)

But from (NASB)

the highly esteemed: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the highly esteemed is almost identical to a phrase in 2:2b. As mentioned there, this phrase refers to the men who were recognized as important leaders of the church in Jerusalem.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

those who were influential (NET)

those who were held in high esteem (NIV11)

the leaders of the church (NLT)

Those who were recognized as important people (GW)

2:6b

whatever they were makes no difference to me;

- The type of people they were previously does not matter to me.
- (It is not important to me what their position/status was before,

whatever they were makes no difference to me:

This clause refers to the fact that many people considered the leaders in Jerusalem to be superior to Paul. They considered them superior because they had been with Jesus. To Paul, what was important was a current relationship with Jesus. The fact that some people were with Jesus while he was on the earth was not important. Notice that Paul said "whatever they were." He did not say "whatever they are."

The leaders of the church in Jerusalem were important men, and Paul thought that it was important to meet with them. But he did not consider their status to be any different from his own status.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

the type of people they were previously does not matter to me

it is not important to me what their status/position was before

I do not consider important the type of person they were before

2:6c

God does not show favoritism—

- God doesn't have any favorites! (CEV)
- because God does not look at a person's appearance.)
- because to God everyone is the same.)

God does not show favoritism: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as God does not show favoritism is an idiom in Greek. A literal translation of this Greek

idiom would be something like “God does not accept/receive the face of a man.” This idiom means that God does not judge a person based on outward things such as wealth or status.

Paul used this idiom to say that, in God’s eyes, the church leaders were not more important than he was. The church leaders had been with Jesus when he was on the earth. Paul had not been with Jesus. But God did not consider them to be more important than Paul.

Some other ways to translate this idiom are:

God shows no favoritism between people (NET)

God doesn’t have any favorites! (CEV)

To God everyone is the same (NCV)

2:6d

those leaders added nothing to me.

- they did not have anything to add to my message.
- they did not ask me to change anything that I teach.
- did not tell me to teach something different/else.

This verse is reordered in the Display, so see this verse part between 2:6a and 2:6b.

those leaders: In Greek, this clause is “the highly esteemed,” which is the same expression that Paul already used in 2:6a. For this reason, the BSB translates the clause here as those leaders. Translate this clause in a way that would be natural in your language. Because it repeats the same wording, if it would be natural in your language, you can follow the example of the BSB or you can combine the two phrases into one. For example:

^aThose who were recognized as important people
^ddidn’t add a single thing to my message. (GW)

added nothing to me: This clause refers to the fact that the church leaders in Jerusalem did not add something to Paul’s message or change it. They agreed that he preached the true and complete gospel.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

None...added anything to my message. (CEV)

did not change the Good News that I preach (NCV)

did not tell me to teach something else

did not criticize my teaching

Galatians 2:7

Section 2:1–10: The church leaders accepted Paul’s apostleship and his message

In this section, Paul explained to the Galatians one reason why they should hold firm to the gospel that he had taught them. He did this by telling them about the meeting that he had in Jerusalem with the apostles there. At this meeting, the apostles recognized Paul’s authority as an apostle. They also agreed that he preached the true gospel.

This meeting became necessary because of the message of some false teachers. These false teachers insisted that a person was not truly saved unless he also became circumcised and kept the laws of Moses. (See Acts 15:1–2 and Galatians 2:4.) At the meeting, the apostles agreed with Paul. They agreed that no one should force non-Jewish believers to be circumcised and obey the Law that God gave to Moses. This showed the Galatians that these teachers were wrong.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul Was Accepted as an Apostle by the Leaders in Jerusalem (GW)

The apostles accept Paul

Paul’s apostleship and message

The Jerusalem leaders recognized Paul’s apostleship and message

Paragraph 2:6–10

In this paragraph, Paul wrote about two results from the meeting in Jerusalem.

The first result of that meeting (2:6) was that the apostles and elders did not find it necessary to add circumcision or anything else to Paul’s message. They agreed that the gospel that Paul preached was true and complete.

The second result (2:7–9) was that the apostles agreed that Paul had full authority as an apostle. They recognized that God had given him authority to preach the gospel to the Gentiles.

2:7a

On the contrary, they saw that

- But instead, those leaders realized that

- Rather than adding something to my message, they recognized that

This verse begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “but.” Some English versions, such as the NASB and NCV, translate it that way in order to introduce the contrast between what the leaders might have done (2:6b) and what they actually did (2:7a). The BSB has not translated this conjunction, and many other versions, including the ESV, NIV, NET, and NLT, also do not translate it. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either. Connect 2:7a to 2:6b in a way that is natural in your language.

On the contrary: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as On the contrary introduces the unexpected way that the leaders responded to what Paul told them. The leaders may have been expected to teach Paul some things and add to his message. But instead of doing that, they agreed with his message.

Some other ways to introduce the leaders’ unexpected response are:

Instead (NLT)

But instead of adding something to my message

But rather than adding something to my message

they saw that: The Greek verb that the BSB literally translates as saw means “realized,” “understood,” or “accepted.” The leaders recognized that the gospel that Paul preached was true and complete.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

They realized that (CEV)

they recognised that (JBP)

they understood that

Do not use a word that implies that the leaders literally saw something.

2:7b

I had been entrusted to preach the gospel to the uncircumcised,

- I had been given the work of telling the gospel to people who are not circumcised,
- God had given me the message about Jesus Christ to preach to people who are not Jews,

- God had given me the work of telling the good news to the Gentiles. He gave me that work

I had been entrusted to preach the gospel to the uncircumcised: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as entrusted means “given the work/responsibility of.” This word is related to the word for “trust” or “have faith in.” God had given Paul the task of preaching the gospel to the Gentiles. He trusted Paul to be faithful in doing the task.

This is a passive clause. Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

I had been given the work of telling the Good News to those who are not Jewish (NCV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

God had given me the responsibility of preaching the gospel to the Gentiles (NLT)

God had sent me with the good news for Gentiles (CEV)

the uncircumcised: This phrase refers to non-Jews. They were people who were not circumcised.

If your word for circumcised is a long phrase, you may want to translate the phrase the uncircumcised in another way. For example:

those who are not Jewish (NCV)

Gentiles (CEV)

2:7c

just as Peter had been to the circumcised.

- just as Peter had been given the work of telling the gospel to people who are circumcised.
- as he had given Peter the message about Jesus for the Jews.
- as he had given Peter the work of telling that same good news to the Jews.

just as Peter had been to the circumcised: The phrase that the BSB translates as just as links Paul’s ministry with Peter’s ministry. It means that God had entrusted Paul with the gospel in the same way that he had entrusted Peter with the gospel. They both preached the same gospel, but they preached it to

different groups of people. Peter preached to the circumcised.

Here Paul used the word circumcised to refer to Jews.

This is a passive clause. Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

as Peter had been entrusted to tell it to those who are circumcised (GW)

- Use an active verb. For example:

just as he had given Peter the task of preaching the gospel to the Jews (GNT)

just as Peter had the work of telling the Jews (NCV)

Galatians 2:8

Section 2:1–10: The church leaders accepted Paul's apostleship and his message

In this section, Paul explained to the Galatians one reason why they should hold firm to the gospel that he had taught them. He did this by telling them about the meeting that he had in Jerusalem with the apostles there. At this meeting, the apostles recognized Paul's authority as an apostle. They also agreed that he preached the true gospel.

This meeting became necessary because of the message of some false teachers. These false teachers insisted that a person was not truly saved unless he also became circumcised and kept the laws of Moses. (See Acts 15:1–2 and Galatians 2:4.) At the meeting, the apostles agreed with Paul. They agreed that no one should force non-Jewish believers to be circumcised and obey the Law that God gave to Moses. This showed the Galatians that these teachers were wrong.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul Was Accepted as an Apostle by the Leaders in Jerusalem (GW)

The apostles accept Paul

Paul's apostleship and message

The Jerusalem leaders recognized Paul's apostleship and message

Paragraph 2:6–10

In this paragraph, Paul wrote about two results from the meeting in Jerusalem.

The first result of that meeting (2:6) was that the apostles and elders did not find it necessary to add circumcision or anything else to Paul's message. They agreed that the gospel that Paul preached was true and complete.

The second result (2:7–9) was that the apostles agreed that Paul had full authority as an apostle. They recognized that God had given him authority to preach the gospel to the Gentiles.

2:8a–b

In 2:8, Paul continued to compare himself to Peter. Believers at that time recognized that God was working through Peter. Peter did miracles, and his preaching resulted in people believing in Jesus. Paul also did miracles, and people also came to believe in Jesus through Paul's ministry. Through his ministry, people also received the Holy Spirit. So Paul's ministry was equal to Peter's ministry. This evidence supports Paul's statement in 2:7 that God had entrusted him with the gospel.

Because Paul compared himself to Peter, it may be more natural in some languages to put Paul first (as in 2:7b–c). In other words, it may be more natural to change the order of 2:8a and 2:8b. For example:

^bGod is working through my ministry to the Gentiles ^ajust as he is working through Peter's ministry to the Jews.

2:8a

For the One who was at work in Peter's apostleship to the circumcised

- God worked through Peter to make successful his ministry/work as an apostle to the people who are circumcised.
- Just as God helped Peter to do well his work as an apostle among the Jews,

For: Verse 2:8 supports and further explains Paul's statement in 2:7b–c. There he stated that God had given him the work of spreading the gospel. God had given him this work just as he had given this work to Peter. Here, Paul explained and supported this statement by saying that God worked through his ministry just as he worked through Peter's ministry.

The Greek introduces this explanation with a conjunction that the BSB translates as *For*. Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some

languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

the One who was at work in Peter's apostleship:

There are two ways to interpret the clause that the BSB translates as the One who was at work in Peter's apostleship:

1. It means that God worked in/through Peter in his ministry as an apostle. This means that God made his ministry as an apostle effective/successful. For example:

God helped Peter work with the Jews (NLV)

God who had done such great work in Peter's ministry for the Jews (JBP) (BSB, NIV, ESV, RSV, NLT, JBP, KJV, NASB, RSV)

1. It means that God worked in Peter's life and made him an apostle. God called/made Peter to be an apostle. For example:

The one who made Peter an apostle to Jewish people (GW) (GNT, GW, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The majority of English versions follow this interpretation. And this interpretation is a stronger argument. Paul's point is that his ministry was equal with Peter's. His ministry had the same results as Peter's ministry.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

God worked through Peter to make his work as an apostle successful.

God caused Peter to do well his work as an apostle.

God blessed Peter's work as an apostle.

the One who: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the One who refers to God. For example:

God, who was at work in Peter as an apostle (NIV)

apostleship: The Greek word that the BSB translates as apostleship refers to the ministry/work that an apostle does.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

the ministry...as an apostle (NIV)

the work of an apostle

to the circumcised: The word circumcised refers to "Jews." You should translate this word as you did in 2:7c.

2:8b

was also at work in my apostleship to the Gentiles.

- In the same way, he also worked through me to make successful my ministry to the Gentiles.
- he also helped me to do my work well as an apostle among the non-Jews.

was also at work in my apostleship to the Gentiles: This entire clause means that God also worked through Paul and made his ministry as an apostle successful. As a result, Paul, like Peter, did miracles. And many people also became Christians because of his ministry.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

He also worked through me to make my work as an apostle successful.

God also caused me to do well my work as an apostle.

He also blessed me and my work as an apostle.

Gentiles: The word that the BSB translates as Gentiles refers to people who are not Jews. This word first occurs in 1:16b. See also Gentiles, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

Galatians 2:9

Section 2:1-10: The church leaders accepted Paul's apostleship and his message

In this section, Paul explained to the Galatians one reason why they should hold firm to the gospel that he had taught them. He did this by telling them about the meeting that he had in Jerusalem with the apostles there. At this meeting, the apostles recognized Paul's authority as an apostle. They also agreed that he preached the true gospel.

This meeting became necessary because of the message of some false teachers. These false teachers insisted that a person was not truly saved unless he also became circumcised and kept the laws of Moses. (See Acts 15:1-2 and Galatians 2:4.) At the meeting, the

apostles agreed with Paul. They agreed that no one should force non-Jewish believers to be circumcised and obey the Law that God gave to Moses. This showed the Galatians that these teachers were wrong.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul Was Accepted as an Apostle by the Leaders in Jerusalem (GW)

The apostles accept Paul

Paul's apostleship and message

The Jerusalem leaders recognized Paul's apostleship and message

Paragraph 2:6–10

In this paragraph, Paul wrote about two results from the meeting in Jerusalem.

The first result of that meeting (2:6) was that the apostles and elders did not find it necessary to add circumcision or anything else to Paul's message. They agreed that the gospel that Paul preached was true and complete.

The second result (2:7–9) was that the apostles agreed that Paul had full authority as an apostle. They recognized that God had given him authority to preach the gospel to the Gentiles.

2:9a

And recognizing the grace that I had been given,

- And understanding the work that God had graciously/kindly given me,
- These men saw that God had been kind to me and given me this work:
- People realized that God was kind/good to me and chose me to spread the good news.

recognizing: The Greek word that the BSB translates as recognizing also means “knowing.” It indicates what the leaders knew and understood.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

perceived (ESV)

realized (CEV)

understood (NCV)

saw (JBP)

the grace that I had been given: Here the word grace means the “kindness,” “generosity” or “favor” that God gave/showed to Paul. God was kind to Paul in the sense that he had given him a special ministry. God gave him the gifts and power to be an apostle and spread the gospel.

In Greek this phrase is more literally “the grace having been given to me.” This is a passive clause. Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Use a passive clause. For example:

the favor that had been shown to me

the kindness that had been given to me by God to be an apostle

- Use an active clause. For example:

God had given me this special task (GNT)

God was good to me and gave me the work of spreading the gospel

See also grace, Meaning 3 in the Glossary.

2:9b

James, Cephas, and John—those reputed to be pillars—

- the men who were like pillars of the church, James Peter and John,
- James, Peter, and John, who were the most important men in the church.
- These people were the important/big men in the church: James, Peter, and John.

James, Cephas, and John: These three men were the leaders in the church at Jerusalem. James was the younger brother of Jesus. (Paul had already mentioned him in 1:19.)

Cephas is Peter's Jewish name. Both names (Peter and Cephas) mean “rock” and refer to the same man. In your translation, you should use the more familiar name, Peter. If the readers of your translation know the name Cephas in the national language version, you should include a footnote in your translation to explain the difference. For example:

James, Peter, and John (CEV)

Peter and John were close disciples of Jesus while he was on earth.

those reputed to be pillars: This clause is a metaphor. It compares the leaders of the church to pillars.

A “pillar” is a huge stone post or wood column that supports the roof of a building. Paul compared the church leaders to pillars. They are similar in that both have a very important role in their respective structures. Pillars are a very important part of the building. The three men had much responsibility in the church.

Some possible ways to translate this metaphor are:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

those men who were recognized as important/
strong like pillars

- Use another idiomatic expression for leaders. For example:

these men are...the backbone of the church (CEV)

- Translate the meaning. For example:

the most important people (GW)

those reputed: This is the fourth time that Paul used the Greek word that the BSB here translates as reputed to refer to the church leaders. See what word(s) you used in 2:2b and 2:6a. As mentioned there, this term refers to the men who were “recognized” as important leaders of the church.

Some other ways to translate this are:

who had a reputation (NET)

those esteemed (NIV11)

who were known (NLT96)

2:9c

gave me and Barnabas the right hand of fellowship,

- shook hands with Barnabas and me to show that we were all fellow workers.
- They shook hands with Barnabas and me as a sign that they agreed with us.
- They told Barnabas and me that they were partners with us in the work.

gave me and Barnabas the right hand of fellowship:

This clause means that James, Peter, and John shook the hands of Paul and Barnabas. Shaking hands was a cultural action that showed that these three men agreed that they were partners together with Paul in ministry. It showed that the leaders agreed with Paul and Barnabas, accepted them, and supported them.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

they shook hands with Barnabas and me, agreeing to be our partners (GW)

they shook hands with Barnabas and me to show that we were companions in God’s work

In some cultures, shaking hands may not show that people agree with one another. If that is the case in your language, you may need to translate the meaning directly. For example:

they told/showed Barnabas and me that they agreed with us and were partners with us

If you do this, you should include a footnote saying that they actually shook hands to show their partnership.

2:9d

so that we should go to the Gentiles, and they to the circumcised.

- They agreed that we^(excl) should go preach to the Gentiles, and they should go preach to the Jews.
- We agreed that Barnabas and I would go work among the non-Jews, and they would go to the Jews.
- They encouraged us to keep preaching to the Gentiles, while they continued their work with the Jews. (NLT)

so that we should go to the Gentiles, and they to the circumcised:

This clause shows what the agreement was between the leaders and Paul and Barnabas. They would be partners in the work of spreading the gospel, but they would work among different groups of people.

In some languages, it will be good to make clear that this clause gives the content of the agreement. Some ways to do that are:

We agreed that Barnabas and I would work among the Gentiles and they among the Jews. (GNT)

They encouraged us to keep preaching to the Gentiles, while they continued their work with the Jews. (NLT)

we...they: The pronoun we refers to Paul and Barnabas. The pronoun they refers to Peter, James, and John.

Galatians 2:10

Section 2:1-10: The church leaders accepted Paul's apostleship and his message

In this section, Paul explained to the Galatians one reason why they should hold firm to the gospel that he had taught them. He did this by telling them about the meeting that he had in Jerusalem with the apostles there. At this meeting, the apostles recognized Paul's authority as an apostle. They also agreed that he preached the true gospel.

This meeting became necessary because of the message of some false teachers. These false teachers insisted that a person was not truly saved unless he also became circumcised and kept the laws of Moses. (See Acts 15:1-2 and Galatians 2:4.) At the meeting, the apostles agreed with Paul. They agreed that no one should force non-Jewish believers to be circumcised and obey the Law that God gave to Moses. This showed the Galatians that these teachers were wrong.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul Was Accepted as an Apostle by the Leaders in Jerusalem (GW)

The apostles accept Paul

Paul's apostleship and message

The Jerusalem leaders recognized Paul's apostleship and message

Paragraph 2:6-10

In this paragraph, Paul wrote about two results from the meeting in Jerusalem.

The first result of that meeting (2:6) was that the apostles and elders did not find it necessary to add circumcision or anything else to Paul's message. They agreed that the gospel that Paul preached was true and complete.

The second result (2:7-9) was that the apostles agreed that Paul had full authority as an apostle. They recog-

nized that God had given him authority to preach the gospel to the Gentiles.

2:10a

They only asked us to remember the poor,

- They only requested one thing from us: that we should continue to remember the poor.
- The only thing that they asked us to do was to continue to remember to help the needy believers in Jerusalem.
- The only other thing that they said was that Barnabas and I should not forget to help the poor Jewish believers in Jerusalem.

They only asked us: This clause means that James, Peter, and John had only one request for Paul and Barnabas. It implies that they did not add anything to Paul's message.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

They asked only one thing (NRSV)

They requested only (NET)

When they welcomed us as partners, they only told us one other thing

Here the word asked does not mean "asked a question."

to remember the poor: This clause means "remember to help the poor." The phrase the poor refers to the poor Jewish Christians living in Jerusalem. At that time, they were having a difficult time getting enough food.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

to remember to help the poor (NCV)

remember the needy in their group (GNT)

that we should not forget to help the poor Jewish believers in Jerusalem

2:10b

the very thing I was eager to do.

- This was the same thing that I had always tried to do.
- I have always worked hard to do that.
- This was the same matter/issue that I wanted to continue to do.

the very thing I was eager to do: The Greek word that the BSB translates as was eager means “make every effort” or “work hard.” Paul wanted to continue to help the poor, as he had done in the past. Acts 11:29–30 tells of a collection for the poor that Paul and Barnabas took to Jerusalem. In your translation, do not imply that Paul only began to help the poor after the Jerusalem leaders welcomed him as a partner.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

This was the same thing that I had always worked hard to do.

This is what I wanted to continue to do.

Galatians 2:11

Section 2:11–21: Paul corrected Peter in Antioch

In this section, Paul told his readers what the true gospel is. It is salvation by faith in Christ alone. Obeying the law is not part of the true gospel. Doing what the law demands does not justify anyone.

Paul told how Peter had deserted the true gospel. He wanted the Galatians to understand how they too were deserting the true gospel. They had started to think that it was necessary to obey the law to be justified. Paul wanted them to read about his rebuke to Peter so that they could recognize how their own situation was similar. They must completely reject justification through the law. He emphasized that justification is by faith in Christ alone.

This section also shows that Paul’s authority as an apostle was at least as great as Peter’s was. This section is also an indirect rebuke of the false teachers who had come to the Galatian churches and required the non-Jews to adopt Jewish traditions to be accepted as true Christians.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul rebukes Peter

Paul defended the truth of the gospel

Paul shows how Peter was wrong

Paragraph 2:11–13

In this paragraph, Paul wrote about an event that happened when he and Barnabas were teaching together in Antioch. (Acts 11:25–30 also talks about their time in Antioch.) During that period, Peter came to visit.

While he was there, a group of Jewish Christians from Jerusalem also arrived. They did not accept uncircumcised non-Jewish believers as true Christians. While these people were in Antioch, Peter, Barnabas, and some of the other Jewish Christians decided to stop having fellowship with the uncircumcised non-Jewish believers.

Peter’s actions did not follow the truth of the gospel. So Paul rebuked him for his actions.

2:11a

When Cephas came to Antioch, however,

- ¶ During the time when Peter was in Antioch,
- ¶ One day, Peter came/went to visit the believers in Antioch. While he was there,

When Cephas came to Antioch: According to 2:12–13, Cephas (Peter) had been in Antioch for some time before Paul opposed him. (As was mentioned in 2:9b, Cephas is Peter’s Jewish name.) In your translation, avoid implying that Paul rebuked Peter as soon as he arrived in Antioch.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

During the time when Peter was in Antioch

One time Peter came/went to Antioch. While he was there

Antioch: Antioch was an important city in the region of Syria. It was far from Jerusalem. Paul and Barnabas were members of the church in Antioch. See also Acts 13:1–3.

however: This verse is the beginning of a new section. In Greek, this verse begins with a conjunction that English versions sometimes translate as “but” and which the BSB translates as however. The BSB has put the word after the mention of Peter coming to Antioch, but in Greek it comes at the start of the sentence. The English words “but” and however indicate a contrast. It is true that there is some contrast between this section and the previous section. In the previous section, Peter agreed that circumcision was not necessary for salvation. In this section, he separates himself from uncircumcised believers. So his actions were not consistent with his words.

However, the contrast is not completely obvious. It is perhaps better to consider the Greek conjunction as functioning to introduce a new development in Paul’s letter. In such a case, this word does not need to be translated in many languages. Many English versions (such as the NIV) do not translate this word here.

2:11b**I opposed him to his face,**

- I rebuked him face-to-face,
- I reprimanded/scolded him in front of the other believers,

I opposed him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as opposed refers to confronting, correcting, and rebuking.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

I rebuked him

I scolded/reprimanded him

I told him...that he was wrong. (CEV)

to his face: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as to his face means “in his presence.” Paul did not criticize Peter behind his back.

In many cultures, including Jewish, a person is taken aside and rebuked privately. But this situation was so serious that Paul decided to rebuke Peter in front of other believers (2:14).

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

face to face (CEV)

openly (GW)

in front of the other believers

2:11c**because he stood to be condemned.**

- because what he had done was wrong.
- because he had done something that was not right/good.

because: The word because introduces the reason why Paul rebuked Peter. Paul rebuked Peter (2:11b) because he was wrong (2:11c).

In some languages, it is more natural to put the reason clause in 2:11c before 2:11b. For example:

^{11a}When Peter was in Antioch, ^{11c}he acted in a way that was clearly wrong. ^{11b}So I opposed him to his face.

he stood to be condemned: The Greek word that the BSB translates as stood to be condemned indicates that what Peter did was wrong.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

he was completely wrong (GW)

he was clearly wrong (GNT)

he had done something that was not right

Galatians 2:12**Section 2:11–21: Paul corrected Peter in Antioch**

In this section, Paul told his readers what the true gospel is. It is salvation by faith in Christ alone. Obeying the law is not part of the true gospel. Doing what the law demands does not justify anyone.

Paul told how Peter had deserted the true gospel. He wanted the Galatians to understand how they too were deserting the true gospel. They had started to think that it was necessary to obey the law to be justified. Paul wanted them to read about his rebuke to Peter so that they could recognize how their own situation was similar. They must completely reject justification through the law. He emphasized that justification is by faith in Christ alone.

This section also shows that Paul’s authority as an apostle was at least as great as Peter’s was. This section is also an indirect rebuke of the false teachers who had come to the Galatian churches and required the non-Jews to adopt Jewish traditions to be accepted as true Christians.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul rebukes Peter

Paul defended the truth of the gospel

Paul shows how Peter was wrong

Paragraph 2:11–13

In this paragraph, Paul wrote about an event that happened when he and Barnabas were teaching together in Antioch. (Acts 11:25–30 also talks about their time in Antioch.) During that period, Peter came to visit. While he was there, a group of Jewish Christians from Jerusalem also arrived. They did not accept uncircumcised non-Jewish believers as true Christians. While these people were in Antioch, Peter, Barnabas, and

some of the other Jewish Christians decided to stop having fellowship with the uncircumcised non-Jewish believers.

Peter's actions did not follow the truth of the gospel. So Paul rebuked him for his actions.

2:12a–b

For before certain men came from James, he used to eat with the Gentiles.

- I did that because Peter frequently/always ate with the Gentile believers before/until certain men came from James.
- When Peter first arrived, he regularly ate with those believers who were not Jews. But then some Jews arrived whom James had sent.

The clause “certain men came from James” (in 2:12a) describes what happened after Peter had been eating with the Gentiles (2:12b). In some languages, it will be more natural to change the order of these two clauses. For example:

^bHe ate with people who were not Jewish ^auntil some men James had sent from Jerusalem arrived. (GW)

^bPeter used to eat with the Gentiles, ^abut then some men from James arrived.

2:12a

For: Verse 2:12 explains why Paul rebuked Peter. The Greek introduces this explanation with a conjunction that the BSB translates as *For*.

Some other ways to introduce this explanation are:

I rebuked him because

I did this because

Here's what was happening:

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. For example:

Before certain men came from James (NIV)

In some languages, it may not necessary to use a conjunction here either.

before certain men came from James: There are two ways to interpret the way that these certain men were connected to James:

1. They were sent from/by James. (James was the leader of the church at Jerusalem.) And they came with a message from James. For example:

Before some men who had been sent by James arrived there (GNT) (GNT, CEV, GW, NCV)

1. They came from the church in Jerusalem where James was the leader. But they came with their own message, not a message from James. According to this interpretation, these Jewish believers are the same men mentioned in Acts 15:24. This verse in Acts tells us that these men were not sent by the leaders in Jerusalem, although they had come from the church there. For example:

some Jewish friends of James came (NLT96)

Many English versions are ambiguous, and so it is not possible to tell which interpretation they follow. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), with the majority of English versions that express a specific interpretation.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

until some men James had sent from Jerusalem arrived (GW)

when some Jews arrived whom James had sent

As mentioned above, it may be more natural to put this clause after 2:12b. See an example above and in the Display.

certain men: The phrase certain men refers to some Jewish believers.

2:12b

he used to eat with the Gentiles: This clause indicates that, in the past, Peter had regularly eaten with the Gentiles, but then he stopped.

Jews were not allowed to eat with non-Jews, because they thought that they became unclean by doing so. When Peter, a Jew, ate with the Gentiles, it showed that he accepted them and had close fellowship with them. This was how Peter behaved when he first arrived in Antioch.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Peter had been eating with the Gentile believers (GNT)

at first, he always/regularly ate with Gentile Christians

the Gentiles: Here, the phrase the Gentiles refers to the Christians in Antioch who were not Jews and did not follow the Jewish laws.

Another way to translate this clause is:

Gentile believers

2:12c

But when they arrived,

- But after these men came,
- After these men arrived in Antioch,

But when they arrived: There is a contrast between Peter eating with the Gentile believers and Peter separating himself from them. Many English versions introduce this contrast with the word But.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

But after these men arrived (GNT)

After they came to Antioch

2:12d

he began to draw back and separate himself,

- he gradually withdrew and began to keep himself away from the Gentile believers,
- he began to avoid eating with the Gentile believers and began to not associate with them.
- Peter started retreating little by little from the non-Jewish believers.

he began to draw back and separate himself: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as draw back also means “withdraw” or “retreat.” This verb and the verb that the BSB translates as separate himself are very similar in meaning. These verbs imply that Peter stopped eating with the Gentiles.

The forms of both Greek verbs also imply that Peter gradually began to draw back and separate himself from the Gentile believers at meals. He did not do it all at once.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Find synonyms to translate these two verbs. For example:

he gradually withdrew and began to keep himself away from the Gentile believers

- Translate one verb as “stopped eating.” For example:

he gradually avoided/stopped eating with the Gentile believers and began to not associate with them

little by little Peter started retreating from the non-Jewish believers and no longer ate with them

- Translate both verbs as one. For example:

he gradually distanced himself from believers who were not Jews

soon stopped eating with Gentiles (CEV)

2:12e

for fear of those in the circumcision group.

- because he feared those people who believed that all Christians should be circumcised.
- He/Peter did this because he was afraid of those Jews who said that all men must be circumcised in order to be right with God.

for fear of those in the circumcision group: There are at least two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the circumcision group:

1. It is a specific term referring to the group of Jews who insisted that a man must be circumcised in order for God to accept him. For example:

He was afraid of those who insisted that circumcision was necessary. (GW) (BSB, GNT, NET, GW, NLT)

1. It is a general term for all Jews. (All Jewish men were circumcised.) For some unspecified reason, Peter was afraid of, or concerned about, these people. For example:

Peter was afraid of the Jews (CEV) (CEV, NCV, JBP, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In Galatians, Paul showed that it is not necessary for a man to be circumcised in order to be saved, and interpretation (1) is consistent with that.

Furthermore, this circumcision party could have been:

1. a group of Jewish Christians in Jerusalem whom the men from James told Peter about.

2. Jewish militants who were not Christians and were persecuting Jewish Christians. It is possible that the men from James told Peter about these men.
3. the men from James themselves

In your translation, you should not specify which group it was.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

He was afraid of those who insisted that circumcision was necessary. (GW)

he was afraid of those who were in favor of circumcising them (GNT)

He was afraid of criticism from these people who insisted on the necessity of circumcision. (NLT)

Peter was perhaps afraid that this group would not approve of him eating with Gentile believers. He was perhaps afraid of what they would think or say about him. He was not afraid that they would physically harm him. If this party was (b) above, he may have even feared that his actions could cause Jewish militants to persecute Jewish believers.

Galatians 2:13

Section 2:11–21: Paul corrected Peter in Antioch

In this section, Paul told his readers what the true gospel is. It is salvation by faith in Christ alone. Obeying the law is not part of the true gospel. Doing what the law demands does not justify anyone.

Paul told how Peter had deserted the true gospel. He wanted the Galatians to understand how they too were deserting the true gospel. They had started to think that it was necessary to obey the law to be justified. Paul wanted them to read about his rebuke to Peter so that they could recognize how their own situation was similar. They must completely reject justification through the law. He emphasized that justification is by faith in Christ alone.

This section also shows that Paul's authority as an apostle was at least as great as Peter's was. This section is also an indirect rebuke of the false teachers who had come to the Galatian churches and required the non-Jews to adopt Jewish traditions to be accepted as true Christians.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul rebukes Peter

Paul defended the truth of the gospel

Paul shows how Peter was wrong

Paragraph 2:11–13

In this paragraph, Paul wrote about an event that happened when he and Barnabas were teaching together in Antioch. (Acts 11:25–30 also talks about their time in Antioch.) During that period, Peter came to visit. While he was there, a group of Jewish Christians from Jerusalem also arrived. They did not accept uncircumcised non-Jewish believers as true Christians. While these people were in Antioch, Peter, Barnabas, and some of the other Jewish Christians decided to stop having fellowship with the uncircumcised non-Jewish believers.

Peter's actions did not follow the truth of the gospel. So Paul rebuked him for his actions.

2:13a

The other Jews joined him in his hypocrisy,

- The other Jewish believers followed Peter's actions. They were all hypocrites.
- Then the other Jewish believers there joined with Peter. They also began to act in a way that they knew was not right/correct.
- The other Jewish believers in Antioch also stopped eating with the Gentiles believers. They behaved in a way that was not right just like Peter.

The other Jews: This phrase refers to the other Jewish believers in Antioch who were also eating with Gentiles.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

The other Jewish believers (GNT)

The other Christians in Antioch who were Jews

joined him in his hypocrisy: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as hypocrisy is related to the word "hypocrite." It refers to believing/saying one thing but doing something different. Here, it indicates that Peter and the other Jews in Antioch knew that eating with Gentiles was a good thing. But in front of the Jews from Jerusalem, they pretended that they believed that it was not good. They acted in a way that they did not believe was correct. They did that because they wanted to please other people.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

acted/behaved in a way that was not right

they began doing things that they knew were not correct

joined him: This phrase indicates that the other Jewish believers followed Peter's example. They, too, began to have less fellowship with the Gentile believers.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

along with him (ESV)

followed Peter's example

2:13b

so that by their hypocrisy even Barnabas was led astray.

- As a result, their hypocrisy influenced/convinced even Barnabas to do the same thing!
- They led even Barnabas away from doing what was right.
- They caused even Barnabas to follow/join them in doing what was wrong.

so that: In this context, the Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as so that indicates a result. Peter and the other Jewish believers stopped eating with the Gentiles, and as a result, Barnabas also stopped eating with them. Here is another way to translate this:

with the result that (NASB)

Some English versions, such as the NCV, do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it may not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

even Barnabas was led astray by their hypocrisy:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as hypocrisy is a noun form of the verb "acted hypocritically," which Paul used in 2:13a. (The BSB translates the verb there with the noun "hypocrisy"). It refers to the actions of Peter and the other Jews: they started to do what they knew was wrong. Their wrong actions caused even Barnabas to do what was wrong.

This clause is passive. Some ways to translate it are:

- Use a passive clause. For example:

even Barnabas was influenced to join them in their hypocrisy (NLT96)

Even Barnabas was influenced by what these Jewish believers did. (NCV)

- Use an active clause. For example:

Their hypocrisy led even Barnabas astray.

What they did fooled/deceived even Barnabas into doing what was wrong.

Even Barnabas went along with their hypocrisy.

Even Barnabas followed them in doing what was wrong.

even Barnabas: The Greek word that the BSB translates as even indicates that Paul was surprised at Barnabas' actions. Because they had worked closely together, he did not expect Barnabas to do such a thing. Here is another way to translate this:

Barnabas himself

was led astray: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as led astray is used in a figurative sense. It has the meaning of being led down the wrong moral path. Barnabas was led away from the truth of the gospel to follow the example of Peter and the other Jewish believers. He, too, stopped eating with the Gentile believers. He should have known better, but he yielded to the pressure of the others.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

was carried/pulled/dragged along

was influenced (NCV)

Galatians 2:14

Section 2:11–21: Paul corrected Peter in Antioch

In this section, Paul told his readers what the true gospel is. It is salvation by faith in Christ alone. Obeying the law is not part of the true gospel. Doing what the law demands does not justify anyone.

Paul told how Peter had deserted the true gospel. He wanted the Galatians to understand how they too were deserting the true gospel. They had started to think that it was necessary to obey the law to be justified. Paul wanted them to read about his rebuke to Peter so that they could recognize how their own

situation was similar. They must completely reject justification through the law. He emphasized that justification is by faith in Christ alone.

This section also shows that Paul's authority as an apostle was at least as great as Peter's was. This section is also an indirect rebuke of the false teachers who had come to the Galatian churches and required the non-Jews to adopt Jewish traditions to be accepted as true Christians.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul rebukes Peter

Paul defended the truth of the gospel

Paul shows how Peter was wrong

Paragraph 2:14–21

In this paragraph, Paul asked Peter and the other Jewish believers to live according to the true gospel. This meant that they had to reject the idea that they were justified by obeying the law. Paul emphasized that justification is by faith in Christ alone. Peter's actions had implied that it was also necessary to keep the law. That would make Christ's death meaningless and nullify the grace of God.

In 2:14c, Paul began to speak directly to Peter. There are at least three ways to interpret where Paul's direct speech to Peter ends:

1. It ends after verse 21. (NIV, NASB, CEV)
2. It ends after verse 14. In verses 15–21, what Paul said to Peter is indirect speech. (BSB, ESV, NET, RSV, JBP, GNT, NJB, GW, NCV)
3. It ends after verse 16. (NLT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). In 2:15, it is possible that Paul began to also talk to the other people who were there. But he was still also talking to Peter. So Paul's speech does not end until verse 21. Schreiner on page 150 says, "The first question to be asked is where Paul's words to Peter, which began in 2:11, end. Since quotation marks are lacking in the original manuscripts, certainty eludes us. Possibly the words directed to Peter conclude after 2:14, 2:15, 2:16, 2:18, or 2:21. I personally argue that it makes most sense to see all of 2:14–21 as addressed to Peter. At least four pieces of evidence support this conclusion. (1) Verse 15 is not clearly set off from 2:11–14. (2) The first person plural pronouns in 2:15–17 most naturally refer to Jewish Christians and would speak to such people in Antioch. (3) Verse 17 may reflect the charges

against Peter. (4) A new subject commences on 3:1, where the Galatians are addressed directly."

If you choose option (2), your translation should still show that Paul is indirectly speaking to Peter in 2:15–21. For example, at the beginning of 2:15, the JBP says:

And then I went on to explain that (JBP)

2:14a

When I saw that they were not walking in line with the truth of the gospel,

- ¶ But when I saw that they were not acting according to the true gospel,
- ¶ But when I saw that those people were not following the true message of the gospel,
- ¶ But when I discovered that they were not obeying the true gospel,

This verse begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as "but." Most English versions translate it that way in order to show that there is a contrast between 2:11–13 and 2:14–21. The contrast is between Peter's wrong way to think and act and the right way. Here is another way to show this contrast:

However

The BSB has not translated this conjunction, and some other versions, such as the NIV and NLT, also do not translate it. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either. Connect 2:14a to 2:13b in a way that is natural in your language.

When I saw: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as I saw includes the meaning of "discovered" or "found out." Paul discovered that Peter was acting hypocritically and rebuked him.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

When I discovered

When I noticed/observed

that they were not walking in line with: In Greek, this verb phrase is more literally "they were not walking straight to." It means that "they did not act/live rightly." When Peter, Barnabas, and other Jewish believers at Antioch separated themselves from the Gentile believers, they were not living according to the truth of the gospel.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

they were not walking a straight path in line with (GNT)

that they were not following (NLT)

that they were not really obeying (CEV)

they were not walking: This phrase refers to the actions of Peter, Barnabas, and the other Jewish believers who had separated themselves from the Gentile believers.

the truth of the gospel: This phrase means “the message of the true gospel” or “the truth that is the gospel.”

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the true gospel

the true Good News

the true message from God

Paul used this same phrase in 2:5b.

2:14b

I said to Cephas in front of them all,

- I said to Peter in front of everyone,
- I rebuked Peter publicly. I said to him,

I said to Cephas in front of them all: This clause introduces Paul’s words of rebuke to Cephas (Peter). One way to make it clear that Paul was rebuking Peter is:

I rebuked Peter in front of everyone and said

in front of them all: This phrase indicates that Paul rebuked Peter where everyone in the Antioch church would also hear what he said.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

publicly

so that everyone could hear (JBP)

Peter’s actions had affected the whole church in Antioch. It was a serious problem. Paul had to rebuke Peter publicly.

2:14c

“If you, who are a Jew, live like a Gentile and not like a Jew,

- “Even though you^(sing) are a Jew, you behave/live like a Gentile and not like a Jew.
- “You^(sing) are a Jew, but you live/act like a Gentile. You do not live/act like a Jew.
- “Peter, you are a Jew, but you live like a Gentile. (CEV)

If you, who are a Jew, live like a Gentile and not like a Jew: In this “if” clause, there is an embedded phrase who are a Jew. In some languages, it will be easier to put this embedded phrase first. For example:

You are a Jew. But if you live like a Gentile and not like a Jew

The clause If you...live like a Gentile was true. Peter was living like a Gentile in the sense that he was eating with Gentiles. He was not separating himself from Gentiles during meals like Jews were supposed to do. He was probably eating food that was not acceptable to Jews.

In some languages, it will be easier to translate this clause without using “if.” For example:

Even though you are a Jew, you are behaving like a Gentile and not like a Jew.

Peter, you are a Jew, but you live/act like a person who is not a Jew. You do not live/act like a Jew.

Notice that the phrase a Jew is repeated. In some languages, it is not necessary to repeat it. For example:

Peter, you are a Jew, but you live like a Gentile. (CEV)

2:14d

how can you compel the Gentiles to live like Jews?”

- So why do you^(sing) force the Gentiles to live like Jews?
- You^(sing) must not force non-Jewish believers to follow Jewish customs.

how can you compel the Gentiles to live like Jews?:

This is a rhetorical question. It is a rebuke. When Peter stopped eating with the Gentile Christians, his actions implied (falsely) that believers needed to follow Jewish laws. In that way, he was forcing the Gentiles to

obey those laws and thus to live like Jews. So Paul rebuked him for his behavior.

Some ways to translate this rebuke are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

How can you require Gentile believers to live like Jews?

So why do you now try to force those who are not Jewish to live like Jews? (NCV)

- As a statement. For example:

It's wrong for you to force Gentile believers to live like Jews.

- As a command. For example:

You must not force Gentiles to follow Jewish customs!

Translate this rebuke in a natural way in your language.

compel: The word compel means “require.” It is the same word that Paul used in 2:3a.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

force

push

the Gentiles: In this clause the word Gentiles refers to non-Jewish Christians.

to live like Jews: The Greek word which the BSB translates as live like Jews refers to becoming Jewish.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

to become Jews

to follow Jewish customs (NIV)

Galatians 2:15

Section 2:11–21: Paul corrected Peter in Antioch

In this section, Paul told his readers what the true gospel is. It is salvation by faith in Christ alone. Obeying the law is not part of the true gospel. Doing what the law demands does not justify anyone.

Paul told how Peter had deserted the true gospel. He wanted the Galatians to understand how they too were deserting the true gospel. They had started to think that it was necessary to obey the law to be justified. Paul wanted them to read about his rebuke to Peter so that they could recognize how their own situation was similar. They must completely reject justification through the law. He emphasized that justification is by faith in Christ alone.

This section also shows that Paul's authority as an apostle was at least as great as Peter's was. This section is also an indirect rebuke of the false teachers who had come to the Galatian churches and required the non-Jews to adopt Jewish traditions to be accepted as true Christians.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul rebukes Peter

Paul defended the truth of the gospel

Paul shows how Peter was wrong

Paragraph 2:14–21

In this paragraph, Paul asked Peter and the other Jewish believers to live according to the true gospel. This meant that they had to reject the idea that they were justified by obeying the law. Paul emphasized that justification is by faith in Christ alone. Peter's actions had implied that it was also necessary to keep the law. That would make Christ's death meaningless and nullify the grace of God.

In 2:14c, Paul began to speak directly to Peter. There are at least three ways to interpret where Paul's direct speech to Peter ends:

1. It ends after verse 21. (NIV, NASB, CEV)
2. It ends after verse 14. In verses 15–21, what Paul said to Peter is indirect speech. (BSB, ESV, NET, RSV, JBP, GNT, NJB, GW, NCV)
3. It ends after verse 16. (NLT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). In 2:15, it is possible that Paul began to also talk to the other people who were there. But he was still also talking to Peter. So Paul's speech does not end until verse 21. Schreiner on page 150 says, “The first question to be asked is where Paul's words to Peter, which began in 2:11, end. Since quotation marks are lacking in the original manuscripts, certainty eludes us. Possibly the words directed to Peter conclude after 2:14, 2:15, 2:16, 2:18, or 2:21. I personally argue that it makes most

sense to see all of 2:14–21 as addressed to Peter. At least four pieces of evidence support this conclusion. (1) Verse 15 is not clearly set off from 2:11–14. (2) The first person plural pronouns in 2:15–17 most naturally refer to Jewish Christians and would speak to such people in Antioch. (3) Verse 17 may reflect the charges against Peter. (4) A new subject commences on 3:1, where the Galatians are addressed directly.”

If you choose option (2), your translation should still show that Paul is indirectly speaking to Peter in 2:15–21. For example, at the beginning of 2:15, the JBP says:

And then I went on to explain that (JBP)

2:15–16

In these verses, Paul reminded Peter of the issues that they had already agreed upon. They agreed that Christ accepted both Jews and non-Jews through faith in him. It is impossible to be justified by obeying the law.

2:15

We who are Jews by birth and not Gentile “sinners”

- We^(incl) were born Jews and are not Gentile sinners.
- We^(incl) were born Jews and know God. We are not Gentiles, those people who do not know God.
- We^(incl) are Jews because our parents were Jews. We are not people who do not follow the law that God gave to Moses.

We who: The Greek pronoun that the BSB translates as We who is emphatic.

Another way to translate this Greek word is:

As for us, we

Paul used this pronoun to identify those who know God. He included himself, Peter, and all Jewish Christians.

We: Note that if you consider verses 15–21 to be direct speech, the pronoun We here is inclusive. If you consider these verses to be indirect speech, then the We is exclusive, since Paul would be reporting to the Galatians what he went on to tell Peter.

are Jews by birth: The Greek word that the BSB translates as by birth implies that being born a Jew was a special privilege. It was special because it was only to the Jews that God had given the law.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

were born Jews

were born Jews and had the law

are Jews and know God because our parents are Jews

and not Gentile “sinners”: The Jews commonly used the expression “Gentile sinners” to show their disdain for anyone who was not a Jew. This phrase referred to those who did not know God and lived without the law.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

and not Gentile sinners who do not know God

we do not have evil behavior like those who do not know the law of God

This traditional attitude of the Jews was not something that Paul would agree with after he met Jesus and understood the gospel. One way to make this clear is:

and not “Gentile sinners,” as they are called (GNT)

Gentile: Here the word Gentile refers to those who did not know God. This is in contrast to the Jews who did know God.

Galatians 2:16

Section 2:11–21: Paul corrected Peter in Antioch

In this section, Paul told his readers what the true gospel is. It is salvation by faith in Christ alone. Obeying the law is not part of the true gospel. Doing what the law demands does not justify anyone.

Paul told how Peter had deserted the true gospel. He wanted the Galatians to understand how they too were deserting the true gospel. They had started to think that it was necessary to obey the law to be justified. Paul wanted them to read about his rebuke to Peter so that they could recognize how their own situation was similar. They must completely reject justification through the law. He emphasized that justification is by faith in Christ alone.

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In this paragraph, Paul asked Peter and the other Jewish believers to live according to the true gospel. This meant that they had to reject the idea that they were justified by obeying the law. Paul emphasized that justification is by faith in Christ alone. Peter's actions had implied that it was also necessary to keep the law. That would make Christ's death meaningless and nullify the grace of God.

In 2:14c, Paul began to speak directly to Peter. There are at least three ways to interpret where Paul's direct speech to Peter ends:

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If you choose option (2), your translation should still show that Paul is indirectly speaking to Peter in 2:15–21. For example, at the beginning of 2:15, the JBP says:

And then I went on to explain that (JBP)

2:16

This verse contains many clauses. Some of the clauses at the end of the verse repeat information from the beginning. In some languages, it may be more natural

to avoid repeating the information. One way to do this is:

^aknow that a man is not justified by works of the law, ^bbut by faith in Jesus Christ. 'So we, too, have believed in Christ Jesus. ^dWe did this that we may be justified.

2:16a

know that a man is not justified by works of the law,

- However, we^(incl) know that a person is not justified by means of obeying the law,
- In spite of that, we know that God does not consider a person as blameless because of his obeying the law of Moses.
- However, we know that following the law does not make anyone right with God.

In 2:16, Paul said something that people would not normally expect a Jew to say. The unexpected statement was that he and Peter (who were born Jews and had lived by the law) knew that a person was not justified by obeying the law. Paul introduced this unexpected statement with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as "but." Some other ways to translate this conjunction are:

however

yet (ESV)

nevertheless (NASB)

in spite of that

The BSB has not translated this conjunction, and some other versions, such as the NIV, also do not translate it. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either. Connect 2:16a to 2:15 in a way that is natural in your language.

know that a man is not justified: The Greek word that the BSB translates as justified means that God has made us acceptable to him. It means "acquitted," "pronounced and treated as righteous," or "accepted as righteous before God." A person who is justified is found to be in perfect conformity to God's law. He no longer has his sins counted against him. God forgives him and considers him to be a righteous person.

Some other ways to translate the word justified are:

accepted as righteous by God

considered straight before God

made right with God

a person's sins are taken care of

See also justify in the Glossary.

This clause is passive. Some ways to translate it are:

- Use a passive clause. For example:

we know that a person is justified not by the works of the law (NRSV)

- Use a clause that is not passive. For example:

we know that a person is made right with God not by following the law (NCV)

we know that God does not consider a person as blameless because he follows the law

by works of the law: The phrase by works of the law refers to obeying the law of Moses. It indicates that a person is not justified by means of obeying/following the law.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

through keeping the law

if/when he obeys the law

because of his following the law

by following the law

the law: The word law refers to “the law of Moses” or “the law that God gave through Moses.” Note that some translations such as GNT capitalize the letter “l” in law. This is to show that the word law here refers specifically to the “law of Moses” and not to just a church or government law. Although it may help a few educated readers to see a capital letter, you should not rely on capital letters to indicate significant meaning differences. The question to ask is, “Can the word be understood with the correct meaning if it is not capitalized?” Since there are many individual

laws within the law of Moses, some languages may have to use the plural form “laws.”

Some other ways to translate this word are:

the law of Moses

the laws God gave through Moses

the Jewish law

the laws God gave

2:16b

but by faith in Jesus Christ.

- but only by means of believing in Jesus Christ.
- God considers him blameless because of his trust in Jesus Christ.
- The only way to be made right with God is to believe/trust in Jesus Christ.

but: There is a contrast between 2:16a and 2:16b. The contrast is between the way that we are not justified (2:16a) and the way that we are justified (2:16b). The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction but.

Some other ways to indicate this contrast are:

but only

Instead,

Some words from the previous clause are implied but not repeated here. In some languages, it may be more natural to repeat some of those words from the previous clause. For example:

but that he is justified

Instead, we know that the only way to be justified is

by: The preposition by introduces the way that a person is justified. Justification is by means of faith in Jesus Christ.

Some other ways to translate this preposition are:

through

if/when

because of

faith in Jesus Christ: The term faith, when applied to Jesus Christ, refers to “belief” or “trust” in Jesus Christ.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

believing/trusting in Jesus Christ

belief/trust in Jesus Christ

See faith, Meaning 1 in the Glossary.

General Comment on 2:16a–b

In some languages, it may be natural to change the order of 2:16a and 2:16b and put the way to be justified first. For example:

^{16a}We know that a man ^{16b}is only justified by faith in Jesus Christ. ^{16a}He is not justified by observing the law.

2:16c

So we, too, have believed in Christ Jesus,

- So, we^(incl) too have believed in Christ Jesus,
- That is why we^(incl) also, like the non-Jews, have trusted in Christ Jesus,
- Therefore, we Jews, we^(incl) also have trusted in Jesus Christ,

So: Verse 2:16c is the main clause in 2:16. It is the result of 2:16a–b. Some versions are like the BSB and add the conjunction So to show how the clauses are connected.

Some other ways to begin this clause are:

That is why

For that reason

we, too, have believed in Christ Jesus: The pronoun we refers to Peter, Paul, and all Christian Jews. The word too implies that these Jews had done like the Gentiles: they also had trusted in Christ Jesus for their salvation.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

we, too, have put our faith in Christ Jesus (NCV)

we Jews have also trusted in Christ Jesus

See faith, Meaning 1 in the Glossary.

Christ Jesus: Here in Greek, the word Christ comes before Jesus. In 2:16b, the order is “Jesus Christ.” The order of these two words makes no difference in the meaning.

In some languages, it may be possible to follow the Greek order. In other languages, it will be necessary to change the order. For example:

^bbut only by believing in Jesus Christ. “So we also believed in Jesus Christ (GW)

2:16d–e

In 2:16d–e, Paul repeated what he said in 2:16a–b. He said that the way we are justified is by faith. It is not by obeying the law. He repeated it because it is very important.

See the example above under 2:16 for a way to avoid the repetition.

2:16d

that we may be justified by faith in Christ

- in order that we may be justified by believing in Christ,
- so that God might consider us as blameless because of our trusting in Christ.
- because the only way to be made right with God is to trust in Christ.

that we may: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as that introduces the purpose of believing in Christ.

Some other ways to connect this clause are:

so that

in order that

be justified: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as be justified is the same word as in 2:16a. Translate it in the same way.

This verb is a passive verb. Some ways to translate this verb are:

- Use a passive clause. For example:

so that we may be made right with God

- Use an active clause. For example:

so that God might justify us

by faith in Christ: The phrase that the BSB translates as by faith in Christ means by/through “believing” or “trusting” in Jesus Christ. It is the same phrase that is used in 2:16b.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

by means of trusting/believing in Christ

if/when we believe in Christ

because of our belief/trust in Christ

2:16e

and not by works of the law,

- and not by obeying the law,
- God does not consider us blameless because of our obeying the law.
- We are not made right with God if/when we follow the law.

and not by works of the law: This phrase is the same phrase that is used in 2:16a. Translate it here as you did there.

2:16f

because by works of the law no one will be justified.

- because no one will be justified by obeying the law.
- We trusted in Christ because we know that God will not consider anyone as blameless because of his obeying the law.
- We have believed in Christ because no one will be made right with God if/when he follows the law.

because: The conjunction because introduces the reason why Paul and Peter and others believed in Christ. They believed in Christ because they knew it was impossible to be justified by obeying the law.

Another way to introduce the reason is to begin a new sentence here:

We trusted in Christ because

by works of the law no one will be justified: This was the third time Paul made this point. This was important because the Galatians had added obeying the law to faith. Paul wanted them to understand clearly that it is impossible to be justified by works of the law.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

no one will be justified by means of following the law

we know that God will not justify anyone because of his obeying the law

will be justified: This is the same word as in 2:16a and 2:16d. You should translate it in the same way.

In 2:16a, Paul used the present tense when he said that “man is not justified by works of the law.” Here he used the same verb in the future tense. Some ways to translate this verb in the future tense are:

will be considered as blameless in the sight of God

will be accepted as righteous by God

will be considered straight with God’s law

will be made right with God

2:16a–f

(reordered) However, we know that a person is made right with God by believing in Jesus Christ and not by obeying the law. So we also believed in Christ Jesus in order that God would make us right.

Galatians 2:17

Section 2:11–21: Paul corrected Peter in Antioch

In this section, Paul told his readers what the true gospel is. It is salvation by faith in Christ alone. Obeying the law is not part of the true gospel. Doing what the law demands does not justify anyone.

Paul told how Peter had deserted the true gospel. He wanted the Galatians to understand how they too were deserting the true gospel. They had started to think that it was necessary to obey the law to be justified. Paul wanted them to read about his rebuke to Peter so that they could recognize how their own situation was similar. They must completely reject justification through the law. He emphasized that justification is by faith in Christ alone.

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In this paragraph, Paul asked Peter and the other Jewish believers to live according to the true gospel. This meant that they had to reject the idea that they were justified by obeying the law. Paul emphasized that justification is by faith in Christ alone. Peter's actions had implied that it was also necessary to keep the law. That would make Christ's death meaningless and nullify the grace of God.

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It is recommended that you follow option (1). In 2:15, it is possible that Paul began to also talk to the other people who were there. But he was still also talking to Peter. So Paul's speech does not end until verse 21. Schreiner on page 150 says, "The first question to be asked is where Paul's words to Peter, which began in 2:11, end. Since quotation marks are lacking in the original manuscripts, certainty eludes us. Possibly the words directed to Peter conclude after 2:14, 2:15, 2:16, 2:18, or 2:21. I personally argue that it makes most sense to see all of 2:14–21 as addressed to Peter. At least four pieces of evidence support this conclusion. (1) Verse 15 is not clearly set off from 2:11–14. (2) The first person plural pronouns in 2:15–17 most naturally refer to Jewish Christians and would speak to such people in Antioch. (3) Verse 17 may reflect the charges against Peter. (4) A new subject commences on 3:1, where the Galatians are addressed directly."

If you choose option (2), your translation should still show that Paul is indirectly speaking to Peter in 2:15–21. For example, at the beginning of 2:15, the JBP says:

And then I went on to explain that (JBP)

2:17a–c

But if, while we seek to be justified in Christ, we ourselves are found to be sinners, does that make Christ a minister of sin? Certainly not!: In Greek, 2:17 is a complex sentence. Before you translate this

complex sentence, it is important to understand its grammatical structure.

The main part of this verse is the rhetorical question at the end of the verse: does that make Christ a minister of sin? This rhetorical question begins with an if clause. In the middle of this if clause, there is an embedded clause: while we seek to be justified in Christ.

Your translation may be easier to understand if you put this embedded clause first. For example:

We are endeavoring/seeking to be justified in Christ. But if, while doing that, we too are found to be sinners, is Christ then a servant of sin? Certainly not!

The parts of this verse are explained below.

2:17a

But if, while we seek to be justified in Christ,

- But if, while we are seeking to be made right with God by believing in Christ,
- While we are looking/trying to have God make us right/straight with him because of our faith in Christ,
- We want God to make us right with him by our faith in Christ.

But: There is a contrast between the clause "not Gentile 'sinners'" (in 2:15) and "if...we ourselves are found to be sinners" (here in 2:17). The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction But.

This contrast is between two clauses that are separated by several verses. So some English versions do not indicate this contrast with a conjunction. In some languages, no conjunction will be necessary here either.

while we seek to be justified in Christ: The Greek word that the BSB translates as while we seek means "we are seeking/looking." It implies success.

The clause to be justified in Christ has the same meaning as "we may be justified by faith in Christ" (2:16d). It means that God makes us right with him because we believe in Christ.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

we seek to be made right with God through faith in Christ (NLT)

we try to be put right with God by our union with Christ (GNT)

we want God to consider us righteous because of our faith in Christ

2:17b

we ourselves are found to be sinners,

- we also are found/discovered to be sinners,
- they regard/count us also to be sinners,
- While doing that, we have become sinners like the Gentiles in the eyes of some Jews.

we ourselves are found to be sinners: The pronoun we refers to Paul, Peter, Barnabas, and other Jews who became Christians.

There are several ways to interpret this clause. Two of the main interpretations are centered on the Greek word that the BSB translates as are found:

1. It has a passive meaning. Peter, Paul, and other Jewish Christians were found to be sinners by other Jews who still followed the law. One example of this was when the men from James arrived in Antioch and found Peter and other Jews eating with Gentiles. They found that they were not obeying the law. The men from James found/considered Peter and other Jewish Christians to be sinners just as the Gentiles were sinners. This interpretation is sometimes called the post-conversion view. According to Moo, “Neither interpretation is without its problems” (p. 164), but the post-conversion view has fewer problems. Of this interpretation, Schreiner says, “In the first view, the charge leveled against Paul and other Jewish Christians is unfounded. They were accused of being sinners since they had abandoned the Torah, but Paul was not a sinner, since he had died and been raised with Christ” (p. 167).
2. It has a reflexive meaning. Peter, Paul, and other Jewish Christians found themselves to be sinners. This happens when they were searching to be right before God and they realized that the law would not save them. They realized that they themselves were sinners just like the Gentiles. This interpretation is sometimes called the pre-conversion view. Of this interpretation, Schreiner says, “The second view...argues that the charges are in fact true. Paul accepts in the ‘if’ clause the reality of the charge. In other words, Peter and Paul had been found to be sinners in seeking to be justified in Christ, and they recognized that they were no better than Gentiles” (pp. 167–168). For example:

we discovered that we are sinners too (CEV)

Most English versions are ambiguous, and it is not possible to tell which interpretation they follow. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation suits the context of 2:16 and also the previous paragraph about the men from James.

According to interpretation (1), some Jews accused Peter and Paul of being sinners because they had abandoned the law of Moses. But their accusation was not true. Peter and Paul were not sinners in God’s eyes. Paul did not agree with their accusation, but he included it to show that its conclusion was not logical.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Use a passive clause. For example:

we ourselves have also been found to be sinners (NET)

- Use an active clause. For example:

they found/regarded us also to be sinners

some Jews considered us also to be sinners

found: Here, the word found means “considered” or “regarded.” Jews who followed the law “regarded” Jewish Christians as sinners. This word does not mean “found” in the sense of lost and then found.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

considered/regarded

counted

looked upon

sinners: Here the word sinners refers to someone who does not follow all the Jewish laws. One example is Peter. The men from James found Peter to be a sinner because he ate with Gentiles. He also probably ate their food. These things were against Jewish laws. The Jews considered Peter and the other Jewish believers to be sinners, but they were not sinners in God’s eyes.

To make this meaning clear, it may be necessary to add some information. For example:

sinners in the eyes of some Jews

found by some Jews to be sinners

2:17c

does that make Christ a minister of sin? Certainly not!

- then does Christ encourage us to sin? Never!
- then does Christ lead us to sin? No, never!
- If that were true, that would mean that Christ made us sinners. But it is not true!

does that make Christ a minister of sin?: The phrase a minister of sin refers to someone who “serves sin” or “works for sin.” A person who works for sin is someone who encourages other people to sin.

This clause is a rhetorical question. Paul used this rhetorical question to emphasize that Christ does not serve sin. He does not encourage people to sin.

Some ways to translate this rhetorical question are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

does that mean that Christ encourages us to sin?
(GW)

Would that mean Christ has led us into sin? (NLT)

Does this mean that Christ is the one who makes us sinners? (CEV)

- As a statement. For example:

This does not in any way mean that Christ encourages us to sin.

Use whichever form is most natural in your language to emphasize that Christ does not serve sin.

Certainly not!: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Certainly not is a strong response, “No!” to the rhetorical question.

Some ways to translate this are:

Never!

Absolutely not!

No, no, no!

Galatians 2:18

Section 2:11–21: Paul corrected Peter in Antioch

In this section, Paul told his readers what the true gospel is. It is salvation by faith in Christ alone. Obeying the law is not part of the true gospel. Doing what the law demands does not justify anyone.

Paul told how Peter had deserted the true gospel. He wanted the Galatians to understand how they too were deserting the true gospel. They had started to think that it was necessary to obey the law to be justified. Paul wanted them to read about his rebuke to Peter so that they could recognize how their own situation was similar. They must completely reject justification through the law. He emphasized that justification is by faith in Christ alone.

This section also shows that Paul’s authority as an apostle was at least as great as Peter’s was. This section is also an indirect rebuke of the false teachers who had come to the Galatian churches and required the non-Jews to adopt Jewish traditions to be accepted as true Christians.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Paul rebukes Peter

Paul defended the truth of the gospel

Paul shows how Peter was wrong

Paragraph 2:14–21

In this paragraph, Paul asked Peter and the other Jewish believers to live according to the true gospel. This meant that they had to reject the idea that they were justified by obeying the law. Paul emphasized that justification is by faith in Christ alone. Peter’s actions had implied that it was also necessary to keep the law. That would make Christ’s death meaningless and nullify the grace of God.

In 2:14c, Paul began to speak directly to Peter. There are at least three ways to interpret where Paul’s direct speech to Peter ends:

1. It ends after verse 21. (NIV, NASB, CEV)
2. It ends after verse 14. In verses 15–21, what Paul said to Peter is indirect speech. (BSB, ESV, NET, RSV, JBP, GNT, NJB, GW, NCV)
3. It ends after verse 16. (NLT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). In 2:15, it is possible that Paul began to also talk to the other people who were there. But he was still also talking

to Peter. So Paul’s speech does not end until verse 21. Schreiner on page 150 says, “The first question to be asked is where Paul’s words to Peter, which began in 2:11, end. Since quotation marks are lacking in the original manuscripts, certainty eludes us. Possibly the words directed to Peter conclude after 2:14, 2:15, 2:16, 2:18, or 2:21. I personally argue that it makes most sense to see all of 2:14–21 as addressed to Peter. At least four pieces of evidence support this conclusion. (1) Verse 15 is not clearly set off from 2:11–14. (2) The first person plural pronouns in 2:15–17 most naturally refer to Jewish Christians and would speak to such people in Antioch. (3) Verse 17 may reflect the charges against Peter. (4) A new subject commences on 3:1, where the Galatians are addressed directly.”

If you choose option (2), your translation should still show that Paul is indirectly speaking to Peter in 2:15–21. For example, at the beginning of 2:15, the JBP says:

And then I went on to explain that (JBP)

2:18a
If I rebuild what I have already torn down,

- For if I build up again what I had destroyed,
- What I mean is, if a person returns to obeying the law in order to be right with God, it is as if he rebuilds a building that he had destroyed.
- If we^(incl) stop obeying the law in order to be made right with God, then we start obeying it again,

In 2:18, Paul explains why Christ did not cause Christian Jews to be sinners (2:17). A sinner is not someone who abandons the law and believes in Jesus to make him righteous. A sinner is someone who returns to following the law after abandoning it. Paul introduces this explanation with a Greek conjunction is often translated as “for,” as in many English versions. Some other ways to introduce this explanation are:

What I mean is that

Rather (NLT)

The BSB has not translated this conjunction, and some other versions, such as the NIV and GNT, also do not translate it. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either. Connect 2:18a to 2:17c in a way that is natural in your language.

If I rebuild what I have already torn down: This “if” clause contains a metaphor. In this metaphor, Paul compared justification by following the law to a building. He compared abandoning the law as a means

of justification to tearing down the building. And he compared returning to obeying the law as a means of justification to rebuilding the building. This can be charted as follows:

Paul’s metaphor	nonmetaphorical form
a building	Jews believe that a person is made right with God by obeying the laws of Moses.
I destroyed the building	When I became a Christian, I stopped believing that it was necessary to obey the law to be right with God.
If I rebuild the building	If I return to again believing that it is necessary to obey the law to be right with God,

Some possible ways to translate this metaphor are:

- Translate the metaphor. In some languages, it will be more natural to change the order of the terms rebuild and torn down. For example:

if I tear down something and then build it again (CEV)

- Use a simile. For example:

If I return to obeying the law for justification, it is as if I rebuild a building that I had destroyed.

- Translate the meaning. For example:

If I stop following the law in order to be justified, and then I start following it again

If I believe that it is necessary to believe in Christ for justification instead of following the law, and then I change and start following the law again for justification

I: When Paul used the pronoun I here, he used himself to represent Peter and the other Jewish believers in 2:13a. These were the people who implied that obeying the law was necessary for justification. Paul used the pronoun I here to be polite and indirect.

Some languages can use the pronoun I in this way. In English and many other languages, the pronoun I is

confusing here. Some languages use other means to be polite and indirect. For example:

If a person rebuilds what he destroyed

If we rebuild what we destroyed

If someone destroys something then rebuilds it again

In this verse, use whichever form is most natural in your language. You will also need to translate “I” in 2:18b in the same way.

2:18b

I prove myself to be a lawbreaker.

- I show that I am someone who breaks God’s law.
- By doing that, he shows that he is a person who did not follow/obey the law.
- we^(incl) show that we are sinners.

I prove myself to be a lawbreaker: The Greek word that the BSB translates as prove means “demonstrate” or “show.” A lawbreaker is a person who transgresses/breaks the law. In this clause, Paul stated that people who return to obeying the law for justification show that they are lawbreakers.

Paul was probably still thinking of what Peter did. Peter broke Jewish laws when he ate with Gentiles. (He tore down the building.) Then he started to follow the law again when he stopped eating with them. (He rebuilt the building.) When he returned to following the law, he showed that he had broken the law. He showed that he was a lawbreaker. So Christ was not the one who led him to sin. Peter’s own actions showed that he had become a sinner.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

then I show myself to be someone who breaks the Law (GNT)

then he shows that he did not follow/obey the law

we show that we are sinners

I: You should use the same pronoun or word as you used in 2:18a.

Galatians 2:19

Section 2:11–21: Paul corrected Peter in Antioch

In this section, Paul told his readers what the true gospel is. It is salvation by faith in Christ alone. Obeying the law is not part of the true gospel. Doing what the law demands does not justify anyone.

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3. It ends after verse 16. (NLT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). In 2:15, it is possible that Paul began to also talk to the other people who were there. But he was still also talking

to Peter. So Paul's speech does not end until verse 21. Schreiner on page 150 says, "The first question to be asked is where Paul's words to Peter, which began in 2:11, end. Since quotation marks are lacking in the original manuscripts, certainty eludes us. Possibly the words directed to Peter conclude after 2:14, 2:15, 2:16, 2:18, or 2:21. I personally argue that it makes most sense to see all of 2:14–21 as addressed to Peter. At least four pieces of evidence support this conclusion. (1) Verse 15 is not clearly set off from 2:11–14. (2) The first person plural pronouns in 2:15–17 most naturally refer to Jewish Christians and would speak to such people in Antioch. (3) Verse 17 may reflect the charges against Peter. (4) A new subject commences on 3:1, where the Galatians are addressed directly."

If you choose option (2), your translation should still show that Paul is indirectly speaking to Peter in 2:15–21. For example, at the beginning of 2:15, the JBP says:

And then I went on to explain that (JBP)

2:19–20

In these verses, Paul explained that the law had no place in his life because he was fully justified in Christ. Christ fulfilled the law and by his death he destroyed the power of the law. Christ's death resulted in Paul's death to the law and his justification in Christ. Paul no longer lived by obeying the law. He lived by faith. Paul had more to say about the topic of "dying to sin and to the law" in Romans 6:1–11 and 7:1–6. It may be helpful to study these passages before doing the translation of Gal 2:19–20.

In these verses, the pronoun "I" refers to Paul. He related his personal experiences to make his point.

2:19a

For through the law I died to the law

- Because of the requirements of the law, I died to the law,
- I am like a dead person, and the law no longer has power over me. The law itself required that I die.
- The law's power over me has ended because Christ died to pay the penalty of the law and because I died with him.

For: In this verse, Paul further explained his statement in 2:18. This statement was that a person sins when he rebuilds the law. A person does not sin when he abandons the law. Paul has a new relationship with the law.

The Greek introduces this explanation with a conjunction that the BSB translates as *For*. Another way to translate this conjunction is:

For you see that

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

through the law: There are at least two ways to interpret the phrase that the BSB translates as *through the law*:

1. It refers to Christ paying for the requirements of the law. The law requires death for those who do not keep the entire law. Christ fulfilled those requirements by dying in Paul's (and our) place to pay the penalty for the failure to keep the law. Paul was crucified with Christ (2:20a), and he died with him. So because of the requirements of the law, Paul considered himself dead (with Christ), and, therefore, dead to the law. For example:

It was the Law itself that killed me (CEV) (GNT, CEV, NCV) Of this interpretation, Fung says, "This death is accomplished 'through the law'; this is more specifically expressed in the clause 'I have been crucified with Christ,' which refers not in an ethical sense to a subjective experience in Christian consciousness, but to the believer's objective position in Christ. By virtue of his incorporation into Christ (cf. v. 17) and participation in Christ's death Paul has undergone a death whereby his relation to the law has been decisively severed and the law has ceased to have any claim on him (cf. Rom. 7:4, 6). But since the vicarious death of Christ for sinners was exacted by the law (cf. Gal. 3:13) and was 'first an affirmation of [the law's] verdict,' Paul's death to the law through participation in Christ's death can be said to be 'through the law.' This death 'through the law...to the law' means not only that the law as a false way of righteousness has been set aside but also that the believer is set free from the dominion of the law (under which there is transgression, Rom. 4:15) for a life of consecration to God (cf. Rom. 7:6)" (p. 123).

1. It refers to Paul realizing that he could not keep the requirements of the law. Paul tried to keep the law, but eventually he realized that he failed. In other words, it was through/in trying to keep the law that he realized that the law could not justify him. For example:

when I tried to keep the law, I realized I could never earn God's approval (NLT96) (NLT96, GW)

Many English versions translate this phrase literally, and it is not possible to tell which interpretation they follow. If possible, you should also translate this phrase in a way that both interpretations can be understood. The end result of both interpretations is the same: Paul died to the law. If you must make a choice, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation fits well with the context of 2:20a, “I have been crucified with Christ.”

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

because of the requirements of the law

because Christ died to pay the penalty of the law and because I died with him

the law caused me (to die to it)

I died to the law: This clause is a metaphor. In this metaphor, Paul compared being released/freed from obeying the law to dying to the law. They are similar in that the law no longer had any control over Paul when he became a believer. Paul did not have to obey the law to be right with God.

Paul used similar metaphors in phrases such as dying to sin, the world, and self. In each case, he meant that these things no longer had control/power over him.

Some other ways to translate this metaphor are:

- Keep the metaphor and also explain the meaning. For example:

I “died”, and now I am dead to the Law’s demands (JBP)

I died and now the law no longer has control of me.

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

it is as if I died to the law

I became like a dead person regarding the law

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

I was released/freed from obeying the law

the law’s power over me came to an end

In your translation, do not imply that Paul died physically or that the law actually killed him.

I: Paul used an emphatic pronoun in this verse. He wrote about his personal experience of justification by faith apart from the law. He used his personal experience to reinforce that justification is by faith and not by works of the law.

Some ways to show this emphasis are:

Me, I

As for me

General Comment on 2:19a

In some languages, it might be more natural to change the order of the two clauses in 2:19a (and begin a new sentence at 2:19b). For example:

I died to the law because of the requirements of the law.

I am like a dead person, and the law no longer has power over me. The law itself required that I die.

I am no longer under the law. It was the law itself that did this to me.

2:19b

so that I might live to God.

- in order that I might live for God.
- Now I live for God and do what he wants.
- As a result, I live to serve God.

so that I might live to God: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as so that indicates that this clause gives the purpose for dying to the law. Paul died to the law so that he might live for God.

Living to/for God means to live a life under the control of God. Paul meant that because he believed in Christ, he was justified and had a new relationship with God.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

so that I might live for God (NIV)

in order to live to serve God

that I can now live to follow God

Galatians 2:20

Section 2:11–21: Paul corrected Peter in Antioch

In this section, Paul told his readers what the true gospel is. It is salvation by faith in Christ alone. Obeying the law is not part of the true gospel. Doing what the law demands does not justify anyone.

Paul told how Peter had deserted the true gospel. He wanted the Galatians to understand how they too were deserting the true gospel. They had started to think that it was necessary to obey the law to be justified. Paul wanted them to read about his rebuke to Peter so that they could recognize how their own situation was similar. They must completely reject justification through the law. He emphasized that justification is by faith in Christ alone.

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It is recommended that you follow option (1). In 2:15, it is possible that Paul began to also talk to the other people who were there. But he was still also talking to Peter. So Paul's speech does not end until verse 21. Schreiner on page 150 says, "The first question to be asked is where Paul's words to Peter, which began in 2:11, end. Since quotation marks are lacking in the original manuscripts, certainty eludes us. Possibly the words directed to Peter conclude after 2:14, 2:15, 2:16, 2:18, or 2:21. I personally argue that it makes most sense to see all of 2:14–21 as addressed to Peter. At least four pieces of evidence support this conclusion. (1) Verse 15 is not clearly set off from 2:11–14. (2) The first person plural pronouns in 2:15–17 most naturally refer to Jewish Christians and would speak to such people in Antioch. (3) Verse 17 may reflect the charges against Peter. (4) A new subject commences on 3:1, where the Galatians are addressed directly."

If you choose option (2), your translation should still show that Paul is indirectly speaking to Peter in 2:15–21. For example, at the beginning of 2:15, the JBP says:

And then I went on to explain that (JBP)

2:20a

I have been crucified with Christ,

- With Christ, I have been crucified
- It's like I too have died on the cross with Christ.
- It's as if I was nailed on the tree and died together with Christ.

Some English versions (such as the CEV, GNT, and NJB) put the clause "I have been crucified with Christ" at the end of 2:19 rather than at the beginning of 2:20. You should follow the example of the national version when you decide in what verse to place these words.

I have been crucified with Christ: This clause is a metaphor. In this metaphor, Paul compared freedom from his previous life under the law to Christ's death. They are similar in that both experienced the end of the law.

Paul did not physically die on a cross with Christ. He did not die at the same time as Christ.

Some ways to translate this metaphor are:

- Keep the metaphor. This is what most English versions do. For example:

I have been nailed to the cross with Christ. (CEV)

I was put to death on the cross with Christ (NCV)

My old self has been crucified with Christ. (NLT)

- Translate it as a simile. For example:

It is as if I have died with Christ on the cross

Do not try to make explicit who crucified Paul.

2:20b

and I no longer live, but Christ lives in me.

- and it is no longer I who live but it is Christ who lives in me.
- I myself am no longer alive. Rather it is Christ who is alive in me.
- It's as if I am not alive, but Christ is alive in me.

and I no longer live: This clause continues the metaphor. In this metaphor, Paul compared freedom from his previous life under the law to no longer being alive. Obviously, Paul was still living when he wrote this, but his old self was no longer living. The person who was under the law was no longer alive.

In Greek, the pronoun I is emphasized.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

and as for me, I live no longer

it's as if I myself am no longer alive

it's as if I am not alive

I have died (CEV)

but Christ lives in me: In this clause, Paul clearly stated that the source of his life is Christ. In the same way that he died with Christ, he lives with Christ.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

rather it is Christ who lives in me

instead Christ makes me alive

but Christ is the one who lives in me

2:20c

The life I live in the body, I live by faith in the Son of God,

- The life that I now live/have in my body, I live/have by trusting in the Son of God,

- The time that I am alive in this world, I live/have through trust/belief in Jesus Christ, God's Son.

The life I live in the body: This whole clause refers to living here on earth.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

My life now

The way I now live

During my time here on the earth

The things that I now do

See flesh, Meaning 2 in the Glossary.

I live by faith in the Son of God: The phrase by faith means "by believing" or "by trusting." Whatever Paul does, he does it while trusting in Jesus, the Son of God.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I live by means of trusting in the Son of God

I am alive through trust in the Son of God

it's possible because I believe in the Son of God

it is based on my faith in the Son of God

I live believing in the Son of God

See faith, Meaning 1, in the Glossary.

the Son of God: The phrase the Son of God is a title for Jesus. This title indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It also indicates that the relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship that resulted in Mary becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus.

Some ways to translate this phrase are:

Jesus Christ, God's Son

the Son of God, Jesus Christ

Jesus is referred to as “His Son” (God’s Son) in 1:16. For further information, see the note on that phrase at 1:16.

2:20d

who loved me and gave Himself up for me.

- who loved me and gave his life for me.
- He loved me so much that he willingly died on my behalf.

who loved me: This clause describes the Son of God. Be careful that the way you translate this clause does not imply that God had another son who does not love Paul.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

who showed his love for me

Jesus/He loved me

and gave Himself up for me: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as gave Himself up for me refers to Christ choosing to die for Paul.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

and gave his life for me

and chose to die for me

sacrificed himself for me (JBP)

took the punishment for my sins (GW)

Galatians 2:21

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3. It ends after verse 16. (NLT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). In 2:15, it is possible that Paul began to also talk to the other people who were there. But he was still also talking to Peter. So Paul’s speech does not end until verse 21. Schreiner on page 150 says, “The first question to be asked is where Paul’s words to Peter, which began in 2:11, end. Since quotation marks are lacking in the original manuscripts, certainty eludes us. Possibly the words directed to Peter conclude after 2:14, 2:15, 2:16, 2:18, or 2:21. I personally argue that it makes most sense to see all of 2:14–21 as addressed to Peter. At least four pieces of evidence support this conclusion. (1) Verse 15 is not clearly set off from 2:11–14. (2) The first person plural pronouns in 2:15–17 most naturally refer to Jewish Christians and would speak to such people in Antioch. (3) Verse 17 may reflect the charges against Peter. (4) A new subject commences on 3:1, where the Galatians are addressed directly.”

If you choose option (2), your translation should still show that Paul is indirectly speaking to Peter in 2:15–21. For example, at the beginning of 2:15, the JBP says:

And then I went on to explain that (JBP)

2:21

In this verse, Paul concluded his rebuke of Peter and the other Jewish believers who separated themselves from the non-Jews. He said that their actions implied that Christ died for nothing.

But Christ's death did accomplish its purpose. Therefore the actions of Peter and the other men were wrong. Paul refused to reject God's grace as they had done. He used "I do not" as an indirect way of rebuking Peter for what he did.

2:21a

I do not set aside the grace of God.

- I do not reject God's grace,
- I do not refuse God's favor/kindness like those who return to obeying the law.

I do not set aside the grace of God: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as set aside means to "reject" or "refuse."

The word grace means "kindness," "generosity" or "favor" that is shown to someone who does not deserve it. This word also occurs in 2:9a. See grace, Meaning 2, in the Glossary.

Paul implied that Peter had rejected God's grace. Peter did that when he separated himself from the non-Jews. When he did this, he acted as if it were necessary to obey the Jewish laws in order for God to accept him. That was rejecting grace as the means of being made righteous.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I don't reject God's kindness. (GW)

I don't turn my back on God's gift of undeserved grace. (CEV)

I do not refuse the grace of God like those who return to obeying the law

2:21b

For if righteousness comes through the law,

- for if people could become righteous through obeying the law,

- because if obeying the law could make a person right with/before God,
- If a person could be made acceptable to God because of obeying the law,

For: This part of 2:21 explains why Paul does not reject the grace of God. The Greek introduces this explanation with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For.

Some other ways to begin this explanation are:

I do not reject the grace of God , because

I do not do this , because

In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction. In other languages, it will be more natural to change the order of 2:21b–c and 2:21a. For example:

^bIf righteousness were through the law, ^cthen Christ died for no purpose. ^aBut righteousness is not through the law. It is through grace. So I do not reject the grace of God.

if righteousness comes through the law: This clause means "if a person could become righteous through/by obeying the law of Moses."

The word if introduces a statement that is not true. Paul used this "if" sentence to show the consequences of Peter's action. Peter's actions implied that a person could become right with God by means of obeying the law.

Some other ways to translate this sentence are:

if a person could become righteous by obeying the law

if obeying the law could make a person right with God— but it cannot

suppose righteousness could be gained/found through the law

righteousness: The word righteousness refers to the character trait of being "upright," "blameless" or "just." A person can never be made right with God by obeying the law.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

right with God

acceptable to God (CEV)

uprightness/blamelessness in the sight of God

See righteous in the Glossary for more information.

2:21c

Christ died for nothing.

- then Christ's death had no purpose."
- then that would make Christ's death worthless."
- it was useless for Christ to die."

Christ died for nothing: In this context, the phrase for nothing means "for no purpose." This clause states the consequence that would result if 2:21b were true. Since it is impossible to be made right with God by means of obeying the law, then it is equally not true that Christ died for nothing.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

then Christ's death was pointless (GW)

then that would that make Christ's death worthless! But it was not worthless.

it was useless for Christ to die (CEV)

Galatians 3:1

Section 3:1-14: We are justified by believing, not by obeying the law

In this section, Paul contrasted "doing" and "believing." He began by rebuking the Galatians because they had forgotten something. They had forgotten that they had been made right with God (justified) and had received the Holy Spirit by believing. They should not then begin to do/obey the law to be made right with God.

Being made right with God (justification) has always been an issue of believing. Abraham himself was justified because he believed. People who are Abraham's children are those who believe. They are the ones who are blessed. People who try to be made right with God by obeying the law are cursed, because no one can obey the entire law.

Paul wanted the Galatians to change their ways. He was convinced that if they thought about their actions and understood the truth, they would change.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

Justification by Law or by Faith? (NET)

Law or Faith

Paragraph 3:1-5

This paragraph contains the strongest rebuke in the book of Galatians. (It is perhaps the strongest rebuke in the whole New Testament.) Paul rebuked the Galatians using several rhetorical questions. He used these rhetorical questions to tell the Galatians that he was very unhappy with them. He was unhappy because they had turned away from believing/trusting in Christ.

3:1

In Greek, 3:1a-c is one sentence. This whole sentence is a rhetorical question. For example:

You foolish Galatians, who has bewitched you, before whose eyes Jesus Christ was publicly portrayed as crucified? (NASB)

Most English versions are like the BSB and divide 3:1a-c into several sentences. For example:

You foolish Galatians! Who has bewitched you? Before your very eyes Jesus Christ was clearly portrayed as crucified. (NIV)

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses in this verse. For example:

^{1a}You foolish Galatians! ^{1c}Before your very eyes Jesus Christ was clearly portrayed as crucified.

^{1b}Who has bewitched you?

^{1b}Who has bewitched you, ^{1a}you foolish Galatians?

^{1c}Before your very eyes Jesus Christ was clearly portrayed as crucified.

3:1a

O foolish Galatians!

- ¶ Are you Galatians mad/crazy?
- ¶ You Galatians are so foolish!

O foolish Galatians: The Greek word that the BSB translates as O has several functions. One of its functions is to introduce a rebuke. Paul used this word

to introduce his rebuke of the Galatians believers because they began to follow the law.

Many English versions do not translate this word. Instead, they use an exclamation point to show that Paul began to rebuke the Galatians. They also supply the pronoun “you.” For example:

You foolish Galatians! (NIV)

Many English versions do not show that 3:1a–c is a rhetorical question until 3:1b. However, it is also possible to translate 3:1a as a rhetorical question. For example:

Are you Galatians foolish/mad?

foolish: The Greek word that the BSB translates as foolish refers to someone who can think, but who fails to do so. It is the opposite of the word “wise.” Paul used this word to show the Galatians that they were not thinking clearly. They had allowed themselves to be misled. They had accepted false teaching without properly thinking about the consequences.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

fools

crazy/mad

stupid (CEV)

lost your heads/minds

3:1b

Who has bewitched you?

- Why did you allow people to put a spell/curse on you?
- You permitted someone to deceive you. Why did you do that?
- You should not have allowed people to deceive/blind you.

Who has bewitched you?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used this rhetorical question to rebuke the Galatians for their wrong thinking. Their thinking was so wrong that it was as if they were bewitched. (See an explanation of the word bewitched below.)

Some ways to translate this rebuke are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Who put a spell on you? (GNT)

What magician has cast an evil spell on you? (NLT96)

Why did you allow people to deceive/trick you?

- As a statement followed by a rhetorical question. For example:

You permitted someone to bewitch you. Why did you do that?

- As an exclamation. For example:

You should not have allowed someone to trick you!

Use whichever form is most natural in your language to rebuke someone for wrong thinking.

bewitched: The Greek word that the BSB translates as bewitched refers to putting a magical spell or curse on someone. The Galatians were turning away from the true gospel. It was as if someone had put a magical spell or curse on them. This word can also refer to someone who is “misled” or “deceived.”

Some other ways to translate this word are:

put a spell/curse on

deceived

blinded

The Galatians did not literally have a curse or spell put on them. If the people who read your translation understand the word bewitched only in its literal meaning, you should not use it. Instead, look for a way to translate the idea of being misled or deceived.

3:1c

Before your very eyes Jesus Christ was clearly portrayed as crucified.

- The crucifixion of Jesus Christ was explained as clearly as if it happened before your eyes.
- I openly explained to you how Jesus Christ died on a cross. It was as if you had seen it with your own eyes.
- I clearly taught how and why they nailed Jesus Christ on a cross. It that not true? It was as clear as if you had seen it with your own eyes.

Before your very eyes: This phrase refers to the time when Paul personally preached to the Galatians. His message about Christ's death was so clear that it was as if they had actually seen Christ on the cross before/with their own eyes.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

it was as if you had seen it with your eyes

Jesus Christ's death was made as clear to you as if you had seen a picture (NLT)

Jesus Christ was clearly portrayed as crucified: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as clearly portrayed can refer to a public poster. On this poster, information was written or even painted so that everybody could go and look at it.

Paul used this phrase in a metaphorical way to refer to his preaching. He explained Christ's crucifixion in detail. It was as if the Galatians had been there and could see it.

This clause is passive. Some ways to translate it are:

- Use a passive clause. For example:

You...were told very clearly about the death of Jesus Christ on the cross. (NCV)

Jesus Christ's death was made as clear to you as if you had seen a picture of his death on the cross (NLT)

- Use an active clause. For example:

I told you exactly how Jesus Christ was nailed to a cross. (CEV)

I clearly explained to you how Jesus Christ died on a cross.

Not only did the Galatians understand how Christ was crucified, they had understood the purpose of Christ's death. Christ's death was the means of their being made right with God. It may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

I clearly explained how Jesus Christ was crucified, and the reason why he was crucified.

as crucified: This phrase refers to Christ being nailed on a cross and dying.

This phrase is also passive. Some ways to translate it are:

General Comment on 3:1c

- Use a passive. For example:

was nailed to a cross (CEV)

was killed on a cross

- Use an active clause. For example:

how they nailed Jesus Christ on a cross

how they killed Jesus Christ

In Greek, 3:1c is a part of the rebuke and rhetorical question that begins in 3:1a. The BSB translates 3:1c as a statement. But in some languages, it may be natural to translate 3:1c as a rhetorical question. For example:

Wasn't Christ Jesus' crucifixion clearly described to you? (GW)

I clearly explained to you how they nailed Jesus Christ to a cross, did I not? It was as if you had seen it with your own eyes.

Galatians 3:2

Section 3:1–14: We are justified by believing, not by obeying the law

In this section, Paul contrasted “doing” and “believing.” He began by rebuking the Galatians because they had forgotten something. They had forgotten that they had been made right with God (justified) and had received the Holy Spirit by believing. They should not then begin to do/obey the law to be made right with God.

Being made right with God (justification) has always been an issue of believing. Abraham himself was justified because he believed. People who are Abraham's children are those who believe. They are the ones who are blessed. People who try to be made right with God by obeying the law are cursed, because no one can obey the entire law.

Paul wanted the Galatians to change their ways. He was convinced that if they thought about their actions and understood the truth, they would change.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

Justification by Law or by Faith? (NET)

Law or Faith

Paragraph 3:1–5

This paragraph contains the strongest rebuke in the book of Galatians. (It is perhaps the strongest rebuke in the whole New Testament.) Paul rebuked the Galatians using several rhetorical questions. He used these rhetorical questions to tell the Galatians that he was very unhappy with them. He was unhappy because they had turned away from believing/trusting in Christ.

3:2a

I would like to learn just one thing from you:

- I want to learn only one thing from you. (GW)
- Tell me this one thing: (GNT)
- Let me ask you this one question: (NLT)

I would like to learn just one thing from you: Paul used this clause to introduce the rhetorical question in 3:2b. The purpose of this clause was to make the readers think about what they had done. If they thought about these things, they would know the truth.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Let me ask you this one question (NLT)

Tell me this one thing (GNT)

I want you to think about this:

3:2b–c

Did you receive the Spirit by works of the law, or by hearing with faith?: This is a rhetorical question. In this rhetorical question, Paul emphasized how the Galatians had received the Spirit. They had not received it by obeying the law. They had received it by faith. The Galatians already knew this. So they should not have returned to obeying the law.

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. In some languages, it may be necessary to divide this rhetorical question into two or three questions. For example:

Did you receive God's Spirit by doing what the law requires? Or was it by hearing the gospel and believing it?

How did you receive God's Spirit? Was it because of obeying the law? Or did you receive the Spirit because of believing what you heard?

- As an exclamation. For example:

You certainly did not receive the Spirit by observing the law! You received it by believing what you heard.

- As a rhetorical question with a response. For example:

Did you receive the Spirit by observing the law? Of course not! Instead, you received the Spirit by believing what you heard.

Use whichever form is most natural in your own language.

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order the clauses. For example:

^{2b}Did you receive the Spirit ^{2c}by believing what you heard or ^{2b}by observing the law?

Also, you should consider how to present an “either-or” idea. In an “either-or” idea, only one part is true. Some possible ways to translate this are:

- Use a conditional statement. For example:

^{2c}If you received the Spirit by means of believing, ^{2b}then you could not have received the Spirit by means of works of the law.

- Make it clear which part is not true and which part is true. For example:

^{2b}Did you receive the Spirit by means of observing the law? No, you did not. ^{2c}Instead, you received the Spirit by means of believing the good news of Jesus.

3:2b**Did you receive the Spirit by works of the law,**

- Did you receive the Holy Spirit by obeying the law?
- How did you receive God's Spirit? Was it because of obeying the law of Moses?
- You certainly did not receive the Spirit through obeying the law that God gave to Moses.

the Spirit: The word Spirit refers to the "Holy Spirit."

Some other ways to translate this word are:

the Holy Spirit

God's Spirit (GNT)

by works of the law: This phrase refers to obeying the law. This is the same phrase that Paul used in 2:16a. The Galatians did not receive the Spirit by means of obeying/keeping the law.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

by means of following the law

through keeping the law

if/when you obeyed the law

because of your following the law of Moses

following the law that God gave to Moses

You should translate this phrase in the same way that you did in 2:16a.

3:2c**or by hearing with faith?**

- Or was it by believing what you heard?
- Or did you receive it because of believing the good news that you heard?
- Rather, you received the Spirit through believing what you heard.

or by hearing with faith: This phrase refers to believing what the Galatians had heard about Jesus Christ. Paul reminded them that they had received the Spirit by means of believing what they heard about Jesus Christ.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

by believing what you heard (NIV)

because of hearing the gospel and believing it

See faith, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

Galatians 3:3**Section 3:1–14: We are justified by believing, not by obeying the law**

In this section, Paul contrasted "doing" and "believing." He began by rebuking the Galatians because they had forgotten something. They had forgotten that they had been made right with God (justified) and had received the Holy Spirit by believing. They should not then begin to do/obey the law to be made right with God.

Being made right with God (justification) has always been an issue of believing. Abraham himself was justified because he believed. People who are Abraham's children are those who believe. They are the ones who are blessed. People who try to be made right with God by obeying the law are cursed, because no one can obey the entire law.

Paul wanted the Galatians to change their ways. He was convinced that if they thought about their actions and understood the truth, they would change.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

Justification by Law or by Faith? (NET)

Law or Faith

Paragraph 3:1–5

This paragraph contains the strongest rebuke in the book of Galatians. (It is perhaps the strongest rebuke in the whole New Testament.) Paul rebuked the Galatians using several rhetorical questions. He used these rhetorical questions to tell the Galatians that he was very unhappy with them. He was unhappy because they had turned away from believing/trusting in Christ.

3:3

Before you translate 3:3a–c, there are three issues to consider:

Issue 1: The number of sentences

In Greek, 3:3a–c is one sentence. This whole sentence is a rhetorical question. In some languages, it may be possible to translate this Greek sentence as one sentence. For example:

^aAre you foolish enough to think that ^bafter you began by the Spirit, ^cyou can finish by the flesh?

All English versions translate 3:3a as a separate rhetorical question. These versions then translate 3:3b–c as one or two additional sentences. (Examples are given in the Notes on 3:3a–c below.) In many languages, it will probably be natural to also translate 3:3a–c as two or three sentences.

Issue 2: The contrasting parallels

Notice that there are two parallels in this verse. These parallels contrast. The first contrasting parallels are “starting” and “finishing.” They are underlined below:

After starting in the Spirit, are you now finishing in the flesh?

The second contrasting parallels are “with the Spirit” and “with the flesh.” They are underlined below.

After starting in the Spirit, are you now finishing in the flesh?

It is good to recognize these contrasting parallels even if you cannot translate them literally in your language.

Issue 3: The order of the clauses

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of these clauses. For example:

^{3b}After starting with the Spirit, ^{3a}it’s foolish ^{3c}to attempt to finish by human effort.

^{3b}You began your life in Christ by the Spirit. ^{3c}Now are you trying to make it complete by your own power? ^{3a}That is foolish. (NCV)

3:3a

Are you so foolish?

- Are you mad/crazy?
- Why are you so foolish?
- Don’t be so foolish!

Are you so foolish?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used this rhetorical question to rebuke the Galatians for being foolish.

Some ways to translate this rebuke are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why are you so foolish?

Are you mad/crazy?

- As a tag question. For example:

You are not that foolish, are you?

- As an exclamation. For example:

You should not be so foolish!

- As a command. For example:

Do not be so foolish!

Use whichever form is most natural in your language to express a rebuke.

foolish: This is the same word that Paul used in 3:1a. You should translate it in the same way.

3:3b

After starting in the Spirit,

- You^(plur) began with the Holy Spirit.
- You started to live for Christ when you^(plur) received the Holy Spirit.
- You began your life as Christians by receiving the Holy Spirit, did you not?

Verse 3:3b is the beginning of a rhetorical question that ends in 3:3c.

After starting in the Spirit: The phrase in the Spirit is another way of saying “receive the Spirit” in 3:2b. Paul reminded the Galatians that their lives in Christ began when they received the Holy Spirit.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

- As the first part of the sentence that continues in 3:3c. For example:

After beginning with the Spirit (NIV)

After starting your Christian lives in the Spirit (NLT)

- As a separate sentence. For example:

You began your life in Christ by the Spirit. (NCV)

You received the Holy Spirit when you started to follow Jesus.

- As a separate rhetorical question. In this part of the rhetorical question of 3:3b–c, Paul emphasized that the Galatians had begun their Christian lives with the Holy Spirit. For example:

You began your life as Christians with the Spirit, did you not?

the Spirit: As in 3:2b, the word Spirit here means the “Holy Spirit.”

3:3c

are you now finishing in the flesh?

- Do you now want to finish with/using your own strength/effort?
- Now, do not try to use your own power/strength to finish/end.
- Why do you finish by trying to use your own strength?

are you now finishing in the flesh?: Before you translate 3:3c, there are two issues to consider:

Issue 1: The interpretation issue

There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as finishing:

1. It means the finish or end of their lives either by death or Christ’s return. The idea of finishing here contrasts with the idea of “starting” in 3:3b. According to this interpretation, Paul asked the Galatians, “Are you now going to change from the way you began your Christian life and use your own efforts to continue until the end?” For example:

are you now trying to finish by human effort?
(NET) (BSB, NIV11, NET, RSV, GNT, NJB)

1. It means to perfect and refers to the Galatians adding something to their spiritual lives to become perfect. For example:

why are you now trying to become perfect by your own human effort? (NLT) (ESV, NLT, NASB, REB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The thought here is similar to Philippians 1:6, which says, “He who began a good work in you will carry it on to completion until the day of Christ Jesus.” (BSB)

Issue 2: The rhetorical question

Paul again used a rhetorical question to rebuke the Galatians. He wanted them to realize that it made no sense to begin by/with the Spirit and then change to

their own strength. They were foolish to try to live their Christian life in the flesh.

Some ways to translate this rebuke are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

do you now want to finish by your own power?
(GNT)

Do you think that you can finish with your own strength?

- As a statement. For example:

Now you are foolishly trying to finish/end by your own effort.

- As a command. For example:

Do not be so foolish as to try to finish by your own strength.

Use whichever form is most natural in your language to express a rebuke.

in the flesh: The phrase in the flesh is another way of saying “by obeying the law.” It refers to people trying to save themselves by their own human effort. This phrase contrasts with “by the Spirit” (in 3:3b).

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

by your own actions

because of your own efforts

using your own strength/power

For more information, see flesh, Meaning 5 in the Glossary.

Galatians 3:4

Section 3:1–14: We are justified by believing, not by obeying the law

In this section, Paul contrasted “doing” and “believing.” He began by rebuking the Galatians because they had forgotten something. They had forgotten that they had been made right with God (justified) and had received the Holy Spirit by believing. They should not then begin to do/obey the law to be made right with God.

Being made right with God (justification) has always been an issue of believing. Abraham himself was justified because he believed. People who are Abraham's children are those who believe. They are the ones who are blessed. People who try to be made right with God by obeying the law are cursed, because no one can obey the entire law.

Paul wanted the Galatians to change their ways. He was convinced that if they thought about their actions and understood the truth, they would change.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

Justification by Law or by Faith? (NET)

Law or Faith

Paragraph 3:1–5

This paragraph contains the strongest rebuke in the book of Galatians. (It is perhaps the strongest rebuke in the whole New Testament.) Paul rebuked the Galatians using several rhetorical questions. He used these rhetorical questions to tell the Galatians that he was very unhappy with them. He was unhappy because they had turned away from believing/trusting in Christ.

3:4a

Have you suffered so much for nothing,

- Have you suffered so many things in vain?
- You have suffered so much for the Good News. (NLT96)

Have you suffered so much for nothing: Before you translate 3:4a, there are two issues to consider:

Issue 1: The interpretation issue

There are three ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as suffered:

1. It refers to the bad things that the Galatians had experienced. In other word, it refers to the persecution that they had suffered. In this interpretation, the verb is understood in a negative sense. It is likely that the Galatian believers had previously suffered for their faith because of persecution. For example:

Have you suffered so many things for nothing? (NET) (BSB, NIV, ESV, NET, GW, KJV, NASB, NLT96, JBP)

1. It refers to the good and bad things that they had experienced. In this interpretation, the verb is understood as either positive or negative experiences. For example:

Did you experience so many things in vain? (RSV) (NIV11, RSV, GNT, NLT04, NCV, REB)

1. It refers to the good experiences they have had since they believed in Christ. In this interpretation, the verb is understood in a positive sense. For example:

Have all your great experiences been in vain...? (NEB) (NEB, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). "Suffered" is the normal meaning of this word in the New Testament. And this is the meaning that Paul intended in all other places in his letters where he used this word.

Issue 2: The rhetorical question

This is Paul's fourth rhetorical question in this chapter. Like the other rhetorical questions, it is a rebuke. The Galatians suffered because they believed in Jesus. Paul rebukes them and says that if they turn away from that faith, they have suffered for nothing.

Some ways to translate this rebuke are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Did you suffer so much for nothing? (GW)

- As a statement. For example:

You have suffered so much for the Good News. (NLT96)

- As a command. For example:

Do not allow your suffering to be for nothing.

Use whichever form is most natural in your language.

for nothing: This word refers to something that is useless or without purpose.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

no use/value

in vain

wasted

3:4b

if it really was for nothing?

- I don't believe that it was for nothing.
- Surely it was not in vain, was it? (NLT96)

if it really was for nothing: Paul added this phrase to his rhetorical question to express his hope that the suffering of the Galatians was not in vain. It was not too late for them to return to the true gospel.

Some ways to translate this phrase are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Surely it was not in vain, was it? (NLT96)

- As a statement. For example:

I do not believe that it was for nothing!

I hope not! (NCV)

Galatians 3:5

Section 3:1–14: We are justified by believing, not by obeying the law

In this section, Paul contrasted “doing” and “believing.” He began by rebuking the Galatians because they had forgotten something. They had forgotten that they had been made right with God (justified) and had received the Holy Spirit by believing. They should not then begin to do/obey the law to be made right with God.

Being made right with God (justification) has always been an issue of believing. Abraham himself was justified because he believed. People who are Abraham's children are those who believe. They are the ones who are blessed. People who try to be made right with God by obeying the law are cursed, because no one can obey the entire law.

Paul wanted the Galatians to change their ways. He was convinced that if they thought about their actions and understood the truth, they would change.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

Justification by Law or by Faith? (NET)

Law or Faith

Paragraph 3:1–5

This paragraph contains the strongest rebuke in the book of Galatians. (It is perhaps the strongest rebuke in the whole New Testament.) Paul rebuked the Galatians using several rhetorical questions. He used these rhetorical questions to tell the Galatians that he was very unhappy with them. He was unhappy because they had turned away from believing/trusting in Christ.

3:5

In Greek, this verse begins with a conjunction that makes it clear this verse is Paul's conclusion or summary of this paragraph.

Some ways to translate this conjunction to introduce this conclusion are:

So then (NASB)

So tell me

Therefore (KJV)

Does God lavish His Spirit on you and work miracles among you because you practice the law, or because you hear and believe?:

In this verse, Paul again used a rhetorical question. This rhetorical question emphasized something that the Galatians already knew, that they had received the Spirit by faith. This question is similar to the rhetorical question in 3:2.

Paul began the rhetorical question by summarizing two things that God did for the Galatians:

1. he gave them his Holy Spirit
2. he worked miracles among them

Paul continued the rhetorical question by asking the Galatians two questions: had they received these things:

1. by obeying the law or
2. by faith in Jesus Christ?

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As one or two rhetorical questions. For example:

Does God give you the Spirit and work miracles among you because you do what the Law requires or because you hear the gospel and believe it? (GNT)

Does God give you the Spirit and work miracles among you because you do what the Law requires? Or is it because you hear the gospel and believe it?

- As a question followed by a statement. For example:

Does God give you the Spirit and work miracles among you because you follow the law? No, he does these things because you heard the Good News and believed it. (NCV)

- As a statement followed by a question. For example:

God gives you his Spirit and works miracles in you. But does he do this because you obey the Law of Moses or because you have heard about Christ and have faith in him? (CEV)

- As a statement. For example:

God gives you his Spirit and works miracles in you. He does not do it by means of your obedience to the law. Instead it is by means of your faith in what you heard.

3:5a

Does God lavish His Spirit on you and work miracles among you

- Does God give you the Spirit and do miracles among you
- So, God gives you the Holy Spirit and does miracles among you.
- God gives you his Spirit. He does amazing things among you.

lavish His Spirit on you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as lavish means “give.” God gave the Holy Spirit to the Galatians. For example:

give you the Holy Spirit (NLT)

gives you his Spirit (CEV)

work miracles among you: This clause means that God did miracles among the Galatians. These miracles were things such as healing people or causing them to prophesy and speak in other languages. The miracles were also giving people spiritual qualities such as faith, hope, and love.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

does miracles in your midst

does amazing things among you

3:5b

because you practice the law, or because you hear and believe?

- because you do what the Law requires or because you hear the gospel and believe it? (GNT)
- Does he do that through your obedience to the law of Moses? No. He does it through your faith in what you heard.
- He does not do this because you obey the law of Moses. He does it because you believe what you heard.

because you practice the law: In Greek, this is the same phrase as in 3:2b. You should translate it in the same way. For example:

by obeying the Law (CEV)

through keeping the law

because of keeping the law

following the law that God gave to Moses

because you hear and believe: In Greek, this is the same phrase as in 3:2c. You should translate it in the same way. For example:

by means of your faith in the gospel you heard

because of trusting in Christ when you heard the Good News.

See faith, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

Galatians 3:6

Section 3:1–14: We are justified by believing, not by obeying the law

In this section, Paul contrasted “doing” and “believing.” He began by rebuking the Galatians because they had forgotten something. They had forgotten that they had been made right with God (justified) and had received the Holy Spirit by believing. They should not then begin to do/obey the law to be made right with God.

Being made right with God (justification) has always been an issue of believing. Abraham himself was justified because he believed. People who are Abraham's children are those who believe. They are the ones who are blessed. People who try to be made right with God by obeying the law are cursed, because no one can obey the entire law.

Paul wanted the Galatians to change their ways. He was convinced that if they thought about their actions and understood the truth, they would change.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

Justification by Law or by Faith? (NET)

Law or Faith

Paragraph 3:6–9

The implied response to Paul's rhetorical questions in 3:1–5 is that the Galatians received the Spirit by faith in Christ. Paul then talked about Abraham to support his case that salvation is by faith. Abraham was a familiar example of a person with great faith.

Paul explained that God accepted Abraham as righteous because of his faith. Salvation never depended on keeping the law.

3:6a–b

So also, "Abraham believed God, and it was credited to him as righteousness": This verse is a quotation from Genesis 15:6. It proves that God considered Abraham as righteous by means of faith. Abraham's righteousness did not depend on anything that he did.

You may want to make it clear that this is a quotation from Genesis. One way to do this is to put the reference in a footnote at the end of the verse (as in the BSB). A sample footnote is:

This is a quotation from Genesis 15:6.

3:6a

So also, "Abraham believed God,

- ¶ Think about Abraham. "He trusted God,
- ¶ Remember Abraham our^(excl) father/ancestor. "He put his faith/trust in God

So also: There are at least three ways to interpret the function of the Greek word that the BSB translates as So also:

1. It introduces an example. The example is Abraham and his faith. For example:

Abraham serves as an example. (GW) (BSB, NIV, GNT, GW, REB, JBP)

1. It introduces a quotation from the Old Testament. Here, it is a shortened introduction. The longer introduction would be "just as it is written" (as in Romans 1:17). For example:

The Scriptures say that God accepted Abraham because Abraham had faith. (CEV) (ESV, CEV, NCV, GNTGNT says, "Consider the experience of Abraham; as the scripture says..." So the GNT follows both interpretation 1 and interpretation 2.)

1. It introduces a comparison. The comparison is between Abraham in 3:6 and "those who believe" in 3:7. They were both God's people because they believed. For example:

⁶Just as Abraham believed God, and it was credited to him as righteousness,⁷so then, understand that those who believe are the sons of Abraham. (NET) (NET, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

Some other ways to translate this word are:

Consider Abraham (NIV)

Think of Abraham

Remember Abraham

Abraham: Abraham is an important Jewish ancestor written about in the Old Testament. Paul often referred to him as an example of a believing person.

In some languages, it is natural to use a title or description along with the name of important people like Abraham. For example:

Abraham of old

our^(excl) father Abraham

the prophet Abraham

believed God: Paul used the word believed to refer to faith in God. It does not refer to just accepting a statement as true.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

trusted God

had faith in God

put his faith in God (NJB)

See faith, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

3:6b

and it was credited to him as righteousness.”

- and God regarded him as righteous.”
- and because of that, God considered him to be a blameless/straight person.”

and it was credited to him as righteousness: The clause it was credited means “was calculated,” “was reckoned,” or “was regarded/considered.” God considered Abraham to be righteous because of his faith.

This clause is passive. Some ways to translate it are:

- Use a passive clause. For example:

he was counted/considered to be righteous

- As an active verb: For example:

and God accepted Abraham’s faith, and that faith made him right with God (NCV)

and because of his faith God accepted him as righteous (GNT)

as righteousness: The word righteousness refers to the character trait of being “upright,” “blameless,” or “just.”

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

upright/blameless

a just/straight man

See also righteous in the Glossary for more information.

Galatians 3:7

Section 3:1–14: We are justified by believing, not by obeying the law

In this section, Paul contrasted “doing” and “believing.” He began by rebuking the Galatians because they had forgotten something. They had forgotten that they had been made right with God (justified) and had received the Holy Spirit by believing. They should not then begin to do/obey the law to be made right with God.

Being made right with God (justification) has always been an issue of believing. Abraham himself was justified because he believed. People who are Abraham’s children are those who believe. They are the ones who are blessed. People who try to be made right with God by obeying the law are cursed, because no one can obey the entire law.

Paul wanted the Galatians to change their ways. He was convinced that if they thought about their actions and understood the truth, they would change.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

Justification by Law or by Faith? (NET)

Law or Faith

Paragraph 3:6–9

The implied response to Paul’s rhetorical questions in 3:1–5 is that the Galatians received the Spirit by faith in Christ. Paul then talked about Abraham to support his case that salvation is by faith. Abraham was a familiar example of a person with great faith.

Paul explained that God accepted Abraham as righteous because of his faith. Salvation never depended on keeping the law.

3:7

In 3:7, Paul explained how his quotation from Genesis about Abraham related to the Galatians. Because the Galatians believed in Christ, they were spiritual descendants of Abraham. God considered both Abraham and the Galatians as righteous by means of faith.

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of parts of 3:7a and 3:7b. For example:

^aSo you should know that ^bthe true children of Abraham are ^athose who have faith. (NCV)

3:7a**Understand, then, that those who have faith**

- So, you^(plur) should know that it is those who have faith
- So then, you^(plur) should understand that the people who believe in Christ
- Therefore, know/understand that if you^(plur) trust in Christ,

Understand, then, that: These words are a command or encouragement to draw a conclusion from the example of Abraham and his faith.

Some other ways to translate these words are:

So you should know that (NCV)

And so, you should understand that (CEV)

those who have faith: This phrase means “it is those people who have faith” or “the people who believe in Christ.”

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

it is the people who have faith

the people who believe in Christ are the ones

if you believe

See faith, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

3:7b**are sons of Abraham.**

- who are the children of Abraham.
- are counted/considered the true descendants of Abraham.
- then you^(plur) are the real descendants of Abraham.

are sons of Abraham: The expression sons of Abraham is a figure of speech. It means “to be like Abraham.” The Galatians are like Abraham in that they have faith. Because of that faith, they are considered to be in the line of Abraham’s descendants.

All Jews are physical descendants of Abraham. But Paul did not consider them to be descendants of Abraham if they did not have faith. He focused on the spiritual relationship and not on the physical relationship.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the true children of Abraham (NCV)

are counted as Abraham’s children

are children of Abraham

3:7a–b

(reordered) So you should know that the true children of Abraham are those who have faith. (NCV)

Galatians 3:8**Section 3:1–14: We are justified by believing, not by obeying the law**

In this section, Paul contrasted “doing” and “believing.” He began by rebuking the Galatians because they had forgotten something. They had forgotten that they had been made right with God (justified) and had received the Holy Spirit by believing. They should not then begin to do/obey the law to be made right with God.

Being made right with God (justification) has always been an issue of believing. Abraham himself was justified because he believed. People who are Abraham’s children are those who believe. They are the ones who are blessed. People who try to be made right with God by obeying the law are cursed, because no one can obey the entire law.

Paul wanted the Galatians to change their ways. He was convinced that if they thought about their actions and understood the truth, they would change.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

Justification by Law or by Faith? (NET)

Law or Faith

Paragraph 3:6–9

The implied response to Paul’s rhetorical questions in 3:1–5 is that the Galatians received the Spirit by faith in Christ. Paul then talked about Abraham to support his case that salvation is by faith. Abraham was a familiar example of a person with great faith.

Paul explained that God accepted Abraham as righteous because of his faith. Salvation never depended on keeping the law.

3:8a**The Scripture foresaw that**

- Furthermore, in the Scripture, God saw ahead of time that
- What's more, in God's book, it says that he looked ahead/forward to the time when
- The God of the holy book/writings saw into the future. He saw that

In verse 3:8, Paul added some more information to his statement about the people who are the true sons of Abraham. He stated that Gentiles would be included in the people who are the true sons of Abraham. Paul introduces this added information with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as "and." Some English versions, such as the ESV and NET, translate it that way. Here are some other ways to introduce this added information:

Furthermore

In addition

What's more (NLT)

The BSB has not translated this conjunction, and some other versions, such as the NIV and GNT, also do not translate it. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either. Connect 3:8a to 3:7b in a way that is natural in your language.

The Scripture: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as The Scripture is more literally "the writing." It refers to the words that God directed someone to write.

In this verse, the Scripture "foresaw" (3:8a) and "foretold" (3:8c) things to Abraham. There was no Scripture when Abraham was alive. (It was centuries later when Moses wrote about these things.) So in this verse, it is best to understand The Scripture to mean "In the Scripture, God."

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

It is written in the Bible that God

In God's book, it says that he

God's written word says that he

The God of Scripture

foresaw that: The Greek word that the BSB translates as foresaw means "seeing something before it happens" or "seeing into the future."

Some other ways to translate this word are:

saw ahead of time that (GW)

looked forward to this time when (NLT)

3:8b

God would justify the Gentiles by faith,

- he would make the Gentiles right by means of their faith.
- he would cause the non-Jews to be blameless/straight because they believe in Christ.
- he will consider right the people who are not Jews. He will do this through their trust in Christ.

God would justify the Gentiles by faith: The Greek word that the BSB translates as justify means "cause/make to be acceptable/right." The noun form of this word occurs in 3:6b. There it is translated as "righteousness."

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

God would make the non-Jewish people right through their faith (NCV)

God would consider the Gentiles straight by means of their faith

it is because of their faith/belief that God would regard the Gentiles as right/straight

Paul's point is that a person's faith is the means by which he is made right with God. It is not by obeying the law.

This clause does not imply that God would justify the Jews by some other means. Here the focus is on the Gentiles.

See justify in the Glossary for more information.

the Gentiles: This is the same word that Paul used in 1:16b and 2:2b. It refers to non-Jewish people. For example:

non-Jewish people (GW)

See also Gentiles, Meaning 1, in the Glossary.

by faith: In Greek, this is the same phrase as in 2:16d, 3:2c, and 3:5b.

Some ways to translate this phrase are:

by means of their faith in Christ

if/when we they believe in Christ

because of their belief/trust in Christ

3:8c

and foretold the gospel to Abraham:

- So he announced the good news to Abraham in advance when he said,
- So he told Abraham the good news before it happened. He said,
- God/He told this good news to Abraham ahead of time. He said that

There are several ways to interpret the way that 3:8c is connected to 3:8b:

1. It is the result of 3:8b. For example:

So Scripture announced the Good News to Abraham ahead of time (GW) (NJB, GNT, CEV, GW)

1. It is an additional statement that says something similar to 3:8b. According to this interpretation, these two clauses can be connected by (a) the conjunction “and” or (b) made into two separate sentences with no conjunction joining them. For example:

and announced the gospel in advance to Abraham (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NLT, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

and foretold the gospel to Abraham: The subject of the verb foretold is the noun “Scripture” in 3:8a. So this part of the verse is saying that “the Scripture foretold the gospel to Abraham.”

As mentioned in 3:8a, the written Scriptures did not yet exist when Abraham lived. So in this verse, it is best to understand “the Scripture” to mean “in the Scripture, God foretold” or “the God of Scripture foretold.”

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

This Good News was told to Abraham beforehand, as the Scripture says (NCV)

The Scripture says that God told this good news to Abraham before it happened

and foretold the gospel: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as foretold the gospel means “preached the gospel before it happened.” For example:

announced the Good News to Abraham ahead of time (GW)

announced the future gospel (NJB)

the gospel: Paul often used the expression the gospel to refer to the good news of the Messiah’s death for our sins and his victory over death. Here Paul used the gospel in a much broader sense. Here it refers to salvation for everyone whom God justifies because of their faith. Salvation will be for all people, including Gentiles. This is also part of the good news.

3:8d

“All nations will be blessed through you.”

- “All nations/people will be blessed because of you.”^(sing)
- “I will give something good to the people of all the nations of the world through you.”
- all nations would be blessed because of him. (CEV)

All nations will be blessed through you: This is a quotation from the book of Genesis. It occurs in Genesis 12:3, 18:18, and 22:18, with slight variations. In Genesis 22:18 the words “in/through your offspring” occur instead of just through you. These words help us understand that the blessing will reach all the peoples of the earth through one of Abraham’s descendants. We know that the descendant is Jesus.

This quotation is passive. Some ways to translate it are:

- Use a passive clause. For example:

All nations will be blessed in you (NASB)

All nations will be blessed because of you

- Use an active clause. For example:

Through you God will bless all people (GNT)

God will cause/use you to bless all the people of the earth

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate this quotation as indirect speech. For example:

all nations would be blessed because of him (CEV)

he/God will bless all nations through him/Abraham

nations: In Greek, this word is the same as the word “Gentiles” in 3:8b. But here it has a broader meaning. Here it refers to the people of all nations. It includes Jews and non-Jews.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

all the people of the world (GW)

all people (GNT)

See Gentiles, Meaning 2 in the Glossary for more information.

will be blessed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as will be blessed means “will be given something good” or “something good will be done to...” It can be a material or a spiritual thing. God blesses us when he gives us eternal life. He also blesses us when he gives us our daily food.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

will be given good things

God will do good things to...

See bless, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

Galatians 3:9

Section 3:1–14: We are justified by believing, not by obeying the law

In this section, Paul contrasted “doing” and “believing.” He began by rebuking the Galatians because they had forgotten something. They had forgotten that they had been made right with God (justified) and had received the Holy Spirit by believing. They should not then begin to do/obey the law to be made right with God.

Being made right with God (justification) has always been an issue of believing. Abraham himself was justified because he believed. People who are Abraham’s children are those who believe. They are the ones who are blessed. People who try to be made right with God by obeying the law are cursed, because no one can obey the entire law.

Paul wanted the Galatians to change their ways. He was convinced that if they thought about their actions and understood the truth, they would change.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

Justification by Law or by Faith? (NET)

Law or Faith

Paragraph 3:6–9

The implied response to Paul’s rhetorical questions in 3:1–5 is that the Galatians received the Spirit by faith in Christ. Paul then talked about Abraham to support his case that salvation is by faith. Abraham was a familiar example of a person with great faith.

Paul explained that God accepted Abraham as righteous because of his faith. Salvation never depended on keeping the law.

3:9a

So those who have faith are blessed

- So, those who have faith are blessed
- Therefore, everyone who believes in Christ shares in the blessing of being made right
- So then, God will do good to everyone who trusts in Christ to be made right.

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So introduces the logical result of Paul’s argument in 3:6–8.

Some other ways to translate this conjunction are:

So then (ESV)

This means that (CEV)

Therefore

those who have faith: The phrase have faith describes people who “believe” or “trust” in Christ for their salvation.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

all who put their faith in Christ (NLT)

people who believe (GW)

those who trust in Christ to be saved

See faith, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

are blessed: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as are blessed is the basic form of the word “will be blessed” in 3:8d. As there, this word means “are given something good” or “something good is done to them.” When a person believes, God makes him right/straight with him. God makes him righteous. He justifies him. It is in this sense that God blesses him.

This verb is passive. Some ways to translate it are:

- As a passive verb. For example:

are given something good

- As an active verb. For example:

God blesses

God does/gives something good to him/them

See bless, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

3:9b

along with Abraham, the man of faith.

- together with Abraham who had faith.
- together with Abraham who also believed.
- He will do good to them together with Abraham who trusted in God.

along with Abraham: This phrase means “together with Abraham.” People who believe share a blessing with Abraham. This phrase means more than that they are blessed as Abraham was blessed.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

together with Abraham (GW)

share in the blessings that were given to Abraham (CEV)

share the same blessing Abraham received (NLT)

the man of faith: The phrase of faith means that Abraham “had faith” or “believed.” He believed in God.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

who had faith (RSV)

who believed in God

who was a believer

See also faith, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

Galatians 3:10

Section 3:1–14: We are justified by believing, not by obeying the law

In this section, Paul contrasted “doing” and “believing.” He began by rebuking the Galatians because they had forgotten something. They had forgotten that they had been made right with God (justified) and had received the Holy Spirit by believing. They should not then begin to do/obey the law to be made right with God.

Being made right with God (justification) has always been an issue of believing. Abraham himself was justified because he believed. People who are Abraham’s children are those who believe. They are the ones who are blessed. People who try to be made right with God by obeying the law are cursed, because no one can obey the entire law.

Paul wanted the Galatians to change their ways. He was convinced that if they thought about their actions and understood the truth, they would change.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

Justification by Law or by Faith? (NET)

Law or Faith

Paragraph 3:10–14

In this paragraph, Paul stated that people who want to be justified through obedience to the law are under a curse. But Christ freed us from the curse of the law by his death on the cross. People who have faith in Christ receive a blessing instead of a curse. It was God’s purpose that by faith the Gentiles would share in the blessing of Abraham and receive the Spirit.

3:10a**All who rely on works of the law are under a curse.**

- ¶ However, all people who follow the law are condemned,
- ¶ But everyone who tries to be justified through obeying the law will be judged.
- ¶ God will punish everyone who tries to follow the law of Moses in order to be made right with him.

In 3:8–9, Paul said that God will bless people who have faith. In 3:10, he gave the reason why it is necessary to rely on faith: a person who tries to rely on the law must keep the entire law or else be cursed. To show that he was giving a reason, Paul introduced this verse with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “for.” Most English versions translate it that way.

However, it is also possible to focus on the contrast between 3:8–9 and 3:10. There is a contrast between a blessing and a curse. There is also a contrast between people who have faith and people who follow the law.

Some ways to introduce the contrast are:

But (NLT)

However

On the other hand

The BSB has not translated this conjunction, and some other versions, such as the CEV and GNT, also do not translate it. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either. Connect 3:10a to 3:9b in a way that is natural in your language.

All who rely on works of the law: The phrase works of the law refers to obeying the law (to be justified). (This same phrase occurs in 2:16a.) People who rely on works of the law are those who rely/depend on their obedience to the law for their justification. In other words, they think that when they obey the law, they will be put right with God.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

those who depend on following the law to make them right (NCV)

Anyone who tries to please God by obeying the Law (CEV)

Everyone who thinks that God will consider him right because he obeys the law of Moses

are under a curse: This phrase means “are condemned,” “will be judged,” or “will be punished.” God is the one who will judge and punish. A curse is the opposite of the blessing that God gives to the people who have faith.

In this context, a curse may be different than a curse in animistic societies. In many societies, a person puts a curse on someone when he does sorcery or witchcraft against another person. Often this is done even when the person has not done anything wrong. Here, it is God, not witchcraft or sorcery, who will judge and punish a person for the wrong that he actually has done.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

are condemned

are under God’s anger

will be punished by God

God will judge that person

3:10b**For it is written:**

- because the Scripture says,
- They will be judged because in God’s Holy Book it is written,
- We know this because the Scriptures say,

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For introduces Paul’s basis/support for saying that the people in 3:10a are under a curse. They are under a curse (3:10a) because the Bible says that they are under a curse (3:10b).

Some other ways to introduce the reason are:

They are under a curse because

We know this because

In some languages, it will be more natural to put the reason first. For example:

^{10b}It is written, ^{10c}“Cursed is everyone who does not continue to do everything written in the Book of

the Law.” ^{10a}So all who rely on works of the law are under a curse.

it is written: This phrase introduces a quotation from the Old Testament. The quotation is from Deuteronomy 27:26.

Some other ways to introduce this quotation are:

here is what the Scripture says

in God’s Holy Book it is written

we read in the Scriptures that

Paul quoted this verse in order to prove that God will judge everyone who tries to be justified by keeping the law. God, through Moses, had warned his people that the result of not completely obeying the law is condemnation.

3:10c

“Cursed is everyone who does not continue to do everything written in the Book of the Law.”

- “All people who do not follow everything written in the law book are condemned.”
- “Everyone who does not keep all the laws in the books that Moses wrote will be judged.”
- “God will punish anyone who does not obey all the commandments that Moses wrote in the law books.”

Cursed is: This phrase is the verb form of the noun “curse” in 3:10a. It has the same meaning of “judge” or “punish.” It is God who will judge and punish.

In some languages, it is natural to put this phrase at the end of the sentence. For example:

Whoever does not always obey everything that is written in the book of the Law is under God’s curse! (GNT)

everything written in the Book of the Law: The phrase the Law refers to the laws/commandments that God gave to Moses. Moses wrote these laws in the first five books of the Old Testament.

Some other ways to translate these phrases are:

all the laws in the books that Moses wrote

all the commands written in the law of God

3:10a–c

(reordered) It is written, “God will punish anyone who does not obey all the commandments that Moses wrote in the law books.” So God will punish everyone who tries to follow the law of Moses in order to be made right with him.

Galatians 3:11

Section 3:1–14: We are justified by believing, not by obeying the law

In this section, Paul contrasted “doing” and “believing.” He began by rebuking the Galatians because they had forgotten something. They had forgotten that they had been made right with God (justified) and had received the Holy Spirit by believing. They should not then begin to do/obey the law to be made right with God.

Being made right with God (justification) has always been an issue of believing. Abraham himself was justified because he believed. People who are Abraham’s children are those who believe. They are the ones who are blessed. People who try to be made right with God by obeying the law are cursed, because no one can obey the entire law.

Paul wanted the Galatians to change their ways. He was convinced that if they thought about their actions and understood the truth, they would change.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

Justification by Law or by Faith? (NET)

Law or Faith

Paragraph 3:10–14

In this paragraph, Paul stated that people who want to be justified through obedience to the law are under a curse. But Christ freed us from the curse of the law by his death on the cross. People who have faith in Christ receive a blessing instead of a curse. It was God’s purpose that by faith the Gentiles would share in the blessing of Abraham and receive the Spirit.

3:11a

Now it is clear that no one is justified before God by the law,

- It is evident that no one is put/made right before God by obeying the law,
- Doing what the law of Moses commands never makes a person righteous/blameless in God’s sight. That is evident,

- It is clear that God does not consider a person right/straight because he obeys the law of Moses.

Now: In 3:11–12, Paul briefly interrupted his new discussion about being cursed (in 3:10). He did this to remind his readers of one of his main themes: we are justified by faith, not by works. He then returned to the idea of curse in 3:13.

The Greek indicates this brief interruption with a conjunction that the BSB translates as *Now*.

Some English versions, such as the CEV and NIV, do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, no conjunction will be necessary either.

it is clear that: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

it is evident (ESV)

it is obvious

we see/understand that

no one is justified before God: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as justified means “cause/make to be acceptable/right.” This same word occurs in 3:8b.

This verb is passive. Some ways to translate it are:

- Use a passive. For example:

no one can be made right with God (NCV)

no one can be regarded as righteous/straight in front of God

- Use an active. For example:

obeying the law cannot put/make a person right with God

God does not consider a person right

See also *justify* in the Glossary for more information.

by the law: The phrase *by the law* means the same thing as “by the works of the law” in 3:2b. It means “by keeping/obeying the law.”

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

by obeying/following the law

through keeping the law

if/when he obeys the law

because of his following the law

following the law

3:11b

because, “The righteous will live by faith.”

- because the person who is put/made right by faith will live well.
- because the word of God says “It is through believing that a person becomes righteous/blameless and gets real/eternal life.”
- This is clear because the Scriptures say, “God makes a person upright/straight because he believes. This person will sit/walk well.”

because: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *because* introduces the basis for the statement in 3:11a. The basis for 3:11a is a verse from Scripture.

Some other ways to show the connection are:

for (NASB)

because the scripture says (GNT)

In some languages, it is natural to put the basis first. For example:

^{11b}“The righteous shall live by faith.” ^{11a}So no one is justified by the law.

The righteous will live by faith: There are two ways to interpret the phrase *by faith*:

1. It is connected with the noun *righteous*. It means that those people whom God declares righteous because of their faith will live. For example:

Only the person who is put right with God through faith shall live (GNT) (GNT, RSV, REB, CEV, NLT)

1. It is connected with the verb *live*. It means that those people who are righteous will live because of their faith. For example:

Those who are right with God will live by faith (NCV) (BSB, NIV, ESV, NET, NRSV, NJB, KJV, NASB, GW, JBP, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Throughout Galatians, Paul has connected righteousness and faith. God makes people righteous because of their faith, not because they follow the law.

It appears that more versions follow interpretation (2). But it is possible that some are simply ambiguous and do not intend to exclude interpretation (1).

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

The person whom God makes right because of his faith will live.

The people who believe in God are made right. These people will live.

The righteous: The phrase that the BSB translates as The righteous refers to a righteous person. It is a person whom God has declared right/straight. The word righteous is the noun form of the verb “justified” in 3:11a.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

The person who is justified

The person who is blameless

The one who is made right/straight

In some languages, it may be more natural to use the plural word “people” here. For example:

The people who are made right/straight

See also righteous in the Glossary.

will live: The verb will live refers to living/being in a good relationship with God. It is living for and with God both here on earth and after death. It does not refer to remaining alive on the earth.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

will really live

will have true/genuine life

lives in right relationship with God (The Message)

will live forever (Easy-to-Read Version)

Languages have many ways to express the idea of live. In some languages, the idea of live is expressed by the verb “sit,” “stay,” or “be with someone.” Other languages use a metaphor such as “walk.” Those languages may have to translate will live by something like:

will sit/stay/be well

will walk with God

will have a relationship with God

by faith: The phrase by faith means that a person will be made righteous because of his faith/belief in God.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

through faith

because of his faith/believing

See faith, Meaning 1 in the Glossary.

Galatians 3:12

Section 3:1–14: We are justified by believing, not by obeying the law

In this section, Paul contrasted “doing” and “believing.” He began by rebuking the Galatians because they had forgotten something. They had forgotten that they had been made right with God (justified) and had received the Holy Spirit by believing. They should not then begin to do/obey the law to be made right with God.

Being made right with God (justification) has always been an issue of believing. Abraham himself was justified because he believed. People who are Abraham’s children are those who believe. They are the ones who are blessed. People who try to be made right with God by obeying the law are cursed, because no one can obey the entire law.

Paul wanted the Galatians to change their ways. He was convinced that if they thought about their actions and understood the truth, they would change.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

Justification by Law or by Faith? (NET)

Law or Faith

Paragraph 3:10–14

In this paragraph, Paul stated that people who want to be justified through obedience to the law are under a curse. But Christ freed us from the curse of the law by his death on the cross. People who have faith in Christ receive a blessing instead of a curse. It was God's purpose that by faith the Gentiles would share in the blessing of Abraham and receive the Spirit.

3:12a**The law, however, is not based on faith;**

- But obeying the law is not a matter of believing in God,
- There is a difference between the person who obeys the law and the person who believes in God.
- Faith does not go together with obeying the law.

The law, however, is not based on faith: In 3:12, Paul developed his argument that a person who is righteous by faith will live. He did this by stating that faith and the law do not go together. Paul introduced this contrast between “faith” (in 3:11b) and the law (in 3:12) by beginning this verse with a Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as however. Here are some other ways to introduce this contrast:

But (ESV)

Yet (NKJV)

Some English versions, such as the NIV and the NLT, do not explicitly show this contrast with a conjunction. In some languages, no conjunction will be necessary here either. Connect 3:12a to 3:11b in a way that is natural in your language.

The law...is not based on faith: The word law refers to “obeying/keeping the law in order to be made right with God.” So this clause means that obeying the law is not a matter of faith/believing/trusting in Jesus. As the next clause says, obeying the law is a matter of what a person “does.” The law focuses only on doing things. The law excludes faith.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

The law does not depend on faith (NAB)

obeying the law is not a matter of having faith in God/Jesus.

Belief does not go together with obeying the law.

There is a difference between obeying the law and believing.

faith: See faith, Meaning 1 in the Glossary.

3:12b**on the contrary,**

- rather, it is a matter of doing/obedience, as the Scripture says,
- Instead of believing, the law is based on obedience. It is written in Scripture,
- It is written in the Scripture,

on the contrary: There is a contrast between 3:12a and 3:12b–c. The contrast is between what the law is not (it is not of faith), and what the law is (it is doing/obeying the commandments). Languages have different ways to indicate this negative-positive type of contrast. One of the functions of the Greek conjunction *ἀλλά* is to signal this negative-positive type of contrast. Some of the ways are:

- With the conjunction “but.”
- With a conjunction other than “but.” This is a common way in English to show this type of contrast. For example:

rather (ESV)

on the contrary (BSB, NIV)

Instead (GNT)

- With no conjunction. For example:

^aThe Law isn't based on faith. ^cIt promises life only to people who obey its commands. (CEV)

In some languages, it may be necessary to include some implicit information to make this contrast more understandable. For example:

On the contrary, it is a matter of doing/obeying

Instead of faith, the law is based on obedience to it

3:12c**“The man who does these things will live by them.”**

- “The person who does/obeys laws will live well because of them.”
- “He who does/obeys all the commandments in the law of Moses will have real/eternal life because of the commandments he obeys.”
- “The person who obeys the laws will sit/walk well because he obeyed them.”

Verse 3:12c is a quote from Leviticus 18:5. In some languages, it may be good to make explicit that this is a quote from the Old Testament. For example:

as the scripture says (GNT)

Paul quoted this Scripture to support his statement that obeying the law does not include faith. The law has always focused on what a person does.

The man who does these things will live by them:

The phrase does these things means “does/obeys the commandments in the law of Moses.” The phrase will live by them means “will live well because of obeying these laws.” People who diligently obeyed all the laws of Moses would find a good life both here on earth and eternally.

Some other ways to translate this quote are:

He who does/obeys all the commandments will have a good life because he obeyed them.

Whoever does everything the Law requires will live. (GNT)

A person who obeys these things will live because of them. (NCV)

If you wish to find life by obeying the law, you must obey all of its commands. (NLT96)

The man who: This is a way to refer to people in general. You should use a natural way in your language to make a general statement.

Some possible ways are:

The person/people who

Anyone who

You who

He who

will live by them: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as will live by them means “will live well because of obeying these laws.” In the context of Leviticus, these words probably meant that people who diligently obeyed all the laws would find a good life here on earth. They would have peace within their community, and God would bless them. But this phrase could also refer to an eternal life with God. Moo says, “The ‘life’ in view here, as typically in the Pentateuch in these kinds of texts, is the blessing of God’s covenant promises: health, fruitful crops, security in the land (‘a happy life in which a man enjoys God’s bounty of health, children, friends, and prosperity’...). This verse is frequently quoted later in the OT and in Judaism with a similar purpose; in places it takes on a more spiritual interpretation of ‘life,’ even at times explicitly eternal life...” (p. 208).

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

will live because of them (NCV)

will live because of the laws he obeys (GW)

will have a good life because he did/obeyed all the laws

As with the words “will live” in 3:11b, languages have many ways to talk about will live here. Some other ways that languages may translate this phrase are:

will sit/stay well because he obeyed the laws

will walk well because of obeying the laws

Galatians 3:13**Section 3:1–14: We are justified by believing, not by obeying the law**

In this section, Paul contrasted “doing” and “believing.” He began by rebuking the Galatians because they had forgotten something. They had forgotten that they had been made right with God (justified) and had received the Holy Spirit by believing. They should not then begin to do/obey the law to be made right with God.

Being made right with God (justification) has always been an issue of believing. Abraham himself was jus-

tified because he believed. People who are Abraham's children are those who believe. They are the ones who are blessed. People who try to be made right with God by obeying the law are cursed, because no one can obey the entire law.

Paul wanted the Galatians to change their ways. He was convinced that if they thought about their actions and understood the truth, they would change.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

Justification by Law or by Faith? (NET)

Law or Faith

Paragraph 3:10–14

In this paragraph, Paul stated that people who want to be justified through obedience to the law are under a curse. But Christ freed us from the curse of the law by his death on the cross. People who have faith in Christ receive a blessing instead of a curse. It was God's purpose that by faith the Gentiles would share in the blessing of Abraham and receive the Spirit.

3:13a

Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law

- But now, Christ has released us^(incl) from the condemnation that comes through the law
- Jesus Christ paid the price to free us from God's anger at us for not obeying the law.
- We do not obey the law, and/so we deserve/merit that God curse/punish us. But Christ freed/saved us from that curse/punishment.

In 3:13, Paul returned to the idea of "curse" that he first mentioned in 3:10c.

Christ redeemed us: The Greek word that the BSB translates as redeemed means "released a prisoner or slave by paying the price (a ransom) necessary to free him." The "price" that Christ had to pay to release us was to suffer pain and humiliation and to die on the cross for us. Jesus freed us from the curse of the law by means of his death on the cross.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

released/freed

rescued (CEV)

saved

paid the price to free us (GW)

See also redeem in the Glossary.

from the curse of the law: This phrase refers to the condemnation/punishment that the law demands for the people who are not able to completely obey it. Christ has freed us from this punishment.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

from the condemnation of not obeying the law

from God's anger that came through the law

from God's punishment/judgment for not obeying all the law

In some languages, it may be natural to make this phrase a separate clause or sentence. For example:

God will curse/punish/judge those who do not obey all of the law

In addition, it may be natural to put this phrase before Christ redeemed us. For example:

We do not obey all the law, and/so we deserve/merit that God punish us. But Christ saved/rescued us from this curse/punishment.

3:13b

by becoming a curse for us.

- when he was condemned in our place,
- He did that by accepting that God punish him instead of us.
- He changed places with us and received our punishment when he died on the cross.

by becoming a curse for us: This phrase is the means by which Christ redeemed us. He redeemed us by becoming a curse in our place. He did this when he allowed himself to be condemned/punished for us and died on the cross.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

by being condemned/punished in our place

when God punished him instead of us

He was our replacement/substitute for receiving punishment.

3:13c

For it is written:

- because it is written in the Scriptures,
- The Scriptures say,
- We see this in the writings that say that

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *For* introduces Paul's basis/support for saying that Christ became a curse for us (in 3:13b). That basis/support is a verse of Scripture.

Some other ways to introduce this basis are:

This is because (CEV)

because

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, no conjunction will be necessary here either.

In other languages, it will be more natural to put the basis first. For example:

^cIt is written, ^d“Cursed is everyone who is hanged on a tree.” ^bSo, Christ became a curse for us, ^awhen he redeemed us from the curse of the law.

it is written: This phrase introduces a quotation from the Old Testament. The quotation is from Deuteronomy 21:23.

Some other ways to introduce this quotation are:

here is what the Scripture says

in God's Holy Book it is written

we read in the Scriptures that

3:13d

“Cursed is everyone who is hung on a tree.”

- “Anyone who is hung on a tree is condemned.”
- “A person who is hung on a wooden post has been punished by God.”
- if they hang someone on a tree/post, it shows that God has punished that person.

Cursed is everyone who is hung on a tree: In the Old Testament, some crimes were so terrible that the

people who committed them were punished by being killed. Then the body of the dead person was hung on a tree or post for all to see. In that way, the people were reminded that sin was disgusting to God. God condemned and punished sin.

Paul applied this verse to Christ. Christ died by being crucified. Death by crucifixion means that his body was hung on a cross. A cross can be referred to as a tree since it is made from wood. The fact that Christ was crucified is God's way of showing us that Christ became the curse for us.

By the time of Christ, a person was hung on a tree/cross in order to kill him. In the Old Testament, the person hung on a tree was already dead. So be careful to translate this verse so that it applies to both situations.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Anyone who is hung on a tree is condemned.

A person who is hung on a tree is cursed/punished by God.

If someone is condemned to die and hung on a tree/post, it shows that God has punished him.

tree: This word does not necessarily refer to a living tree. It could be a dead tree, or the wood from a tree, such as a post or pole.

Galatians 3:14

Section 3:1–14: We are justified by believing, not by obeying the law

In this section, Paul contrasted “doing” and “believing.” He began by rebuking the Galatians because they had forgotten something. They had forgotten that they had been made right with God (justified) and had received the Holy Spirit by believing. They should not then begin to do/obey the law to be made right with God.

Being made right with God (justification) has always been an issue of believing. Abraham himself was justified because he believed. People who are Abraham's children are those who believe. They are the ones who are blessed. People who try to be made right with God by obeying the law are cursed, because no one can obey the entire law.

Paul wanted the Galatians to change their ways. He was convinced that if they thought about their actions and understood the truth, they would change.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

Justification by Law or by Faith? (NET)

Law or Faith

Paragraph 3:10–14

In this paragraph, Paul stated that people who want to be justified through obedience to the law are under a curse. But Christ freed us from the curse of the law by his death on the cross. People who have faith in Christ receive a blessing instead of a curse. It was God's purpose that by faith the Gentiles would share in the blessing of Abraham and receive the Spirit.

3:14a

He redeemed us in order that

- Christ did this so that
- Christ redeemed us in order that
- He freed us so that

in order that: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as in order that indicates that 3:14a is the purpose of 3:13a. He means that Christ became a curse for us and redeemed us from the curse of the law (3:13a) so that the blessing of Abraham might come to the Gentiles (3:14a).

3:14b

the blessing promised to Abraham would come to the Gentiles in Christ Jesus,

- the blessing of justification given to Abraham might be received by the Gentiles through Christ Jesus,
- the blessing that God gave to Abraham, he would give this same blessing to the non-Jews. This blessing comes because of what Christ Jesus did.
- God would bless people who are not Jews because of their trust in Jesus Christ as he blessed Abraham long ago.

the blessing promised to Abraham: This phrase refers to the blessing that God gave to Abraham. This blessing was that Abraham could be put right (justified) with God by trusting in him. God did not require him to obey laws to be justified. That was his blessing.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the blessing given to Abraham (NIV)

the blessing which God promised to Abraham (GNT)

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate blessing as a verb. For example:

God blessed Abraham

See bless, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

would come to the Gentiles: This phrase means that the Gentiles would have/receive the same blessing as Abraham. The meaning is very similar to 3:9a–b, “those who have faith are blessed along with Abraham.”

You should use a verb in your language that is natural to use with the word “blessing.” In some languages, blessings do not come to people. They are “given” or “received.” For example:

might be received by the Gentiles

God might give the same blessing to the Gentiles

God has blessed the Gentiles with the same blessing he promised to Abraham (NLT)

Gentiles: The word Gentiles refers to all people who were not Jews.

Some ways to translate this word are:

the people who are not Jews

non-Jews

See Gentiles, Meaning 1 in the Glossary.

in Christ Jesus: The phrase that the BSB translates as in Christ Jesus is the means by which God blessed the Gentiles. He blessed them “by” or “through” Christ Jesus.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

by believing in Christ Jesus

through that which Christ Jesus has done

In some languages, it will be more natural to put this phrase earlier in 3:14b. For example:

in Christ Jesus the blessing of Abraham might come to the Gentiles (ESV)

Christ Jesus: In the phrase Christ Jesus, Christ is his title and Jesus is his personal name.

One way to show this is:

the Christ/Messiah Jesus

Most English versions follow the Greek order here and translate these two words as Christ Jesus. However, in 1:1c, Paul used the phrase “Jesus Christ.” Both Christ Jesus and “Jesus Christ” refer to the same person. So here it is also possible to put Jesus before Christ. For example:

Jesus Christ (CEV)

3:14c so that

- and so that
- Christ also redeemed us in order that
- He also did this so that

so that: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as so that introduces the second purpose for which Christ redeemed us (in 3:14d).

^{13a}He redeemed us

^{14a}in order that

^{14b}we might receive the blessing promised to Abraham

^{14c}and so that

^{14d}we might receive the Spirit.

Some ways to connect this part of the verse to the rest of the verse are:

and so that

He also redeemed us so that

3:14d by faith we might receive the promise of the Spirit.

- we might receive the promised Spirit by means of our faith.
- we would receive the Holy Spirit that God promised to give to us because of our believing.
- God would send us the Holy Spirit that he promised. We receive this Holy Spirit because we believe.

by faith: This phrase refers to the way a person receives the Spirit. He receives it by/through believing.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

through faith (ESV)

because of our faith

because we believe in Jesus

We receive this Spirit because we have believed.

See faith, Meaning 1 in the Glossary.

we might receive the promise of the Spirit: The phrase the promise of the Spirit refers to the Holy Spirit. God promised to give the Holy Spirit to those who believe. The promise referred to is probably the passage from Joel 2:28–29 that is quoted in Acts 2:17–18.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

we could receive the Spirit that God promised (NCV)

we might receive the Spirit whom God promised to give us

The Spirit is another blessing of justification by faith. The Galatians received the Spirit by faith. Paul had already said this in 3:2 and 3:5.

we: The pronoun we includes all Christians, both Jews and Gentiles.

Galatians 3:15

Section 3:15–25: The law did not cancel God’s promise to Abraham

This section has two parts. In the first part (3:15–18), Paul explained what the law was not intended to do. It was not intended to cancel or replace the blessing that God had promised to give to Abraham.

In the second part (3:19–25), Paul explained what the law was meant to do, how it was given, and how it was limited. It was limited as to what it could accomplish in people’s lives. And it was limited as to the time period during which it would govern God’s people.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

The law and the promise

The promise preceded the law

The law does not change the promise

3:15a

Brothers, let me put this in human terms.

- ¶ Brothers, here is a situation/issue from daily life to explain this:
- ¶ My friends, I will use an everyday example to explain what I mean. (CEV)
- ¶ Fellow believers in Christ, I will talk about something you know to show you what I want to say.

Brothers: The word Brothers refers to the Galatian believers. Paul used this word to show that he loved them, even though he had just rebuked them.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

My dear fellow believers

Fellow believers in Christ

My dear friends

Relatives

let me put this in human terms: This clause indicates that Paul wanted to explain something. He wanted to further explain that believing is more important than doing/obeying the law. He did this by giving them an example from everyday life.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Here is an example from one of our customs

I will speak about something that happens on the earth so you will understand what I want to say

I will explain to you what I want to say by using something that you already know

3:15b

Even a human covenant, once it is ratified, cannot be canceled or amended.

- after a human contract has been signed, it cannot be cancelled or added to.
- When a letter of promise between two people has been stamped/sealed, no one else can change it or cancel/end it.
- After two people write their names on an agreement, other people cannot cancel/break it or add to it.

Even a human covenant: The Greek word that the BSB translates as covenant refers to an official agreement or contract. The contract is between two individuals or two groups. Previously, these agreements/promises could be verbal. In today's world, such agreements are written documents that are signed by both parties.

One example is a loan document. In this document, a person who has borrowed money and the person who loaned the money agree to the terms of paying back the loan.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

With a human contract

Even with a letter of promise between two people

When two people make an agreement

Some English versions translate the word covenant as "will." This refers to a "last will" or "testament." The problem with the English word "will" is that the person who made the will must die before the will comes into effect. God would not make a will, but he did make contracts/promises.

See also covenant in the Glossary.

once it is ratified: The Greek word that the BSB translates as ratified refers to making the agreement/promise legally binding. In verbal agreements, this could be done by shaking hands. Written documents are ratified when the people sign their names or put their fingerprints on the document in front of witnesses. A document can also be ratified when someone puts a stamp or seal on it.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

after the people sign their names on the document

once it has been stamped/sealed

cannot be canceled: The Greek word that the BSB translates as canceled means "rejected" or "annulled." A third person cannot cancel an agreement that two other people have made.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

no one else can...cancel the agreement (CEV)

a third person cannot break it

no other person can say that it has no strength/
force

This same word occurs in 2:21a, where the BSB translates it as “set aside.”

or amended: The Greek word that the BSB translates as amended refers to adding words to the document to change it.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

add anything to it (NCV)

change (CEV)

Galatians 3:16

Section 3:15–25: The law did not cancel God’s promise to Abraham

This section has two parts. In the first part (3:15–18), Paul explained what the law was not intended to do. It was not intended to cancel or replace the blessing that God had promised to give to Abraham.

In the second part (3:19–25), Paul explained what the law was meant to do, how it was given, and how it was limited. It was limited as to what it could accomplish in people’s lives. And it was limited as to the time period during which it would govern God’s people.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

The law and the promise

The promise preceded the law

The law does not change the promise

3:16a

The promises were spoken to Abraham and to his seed.

- The promises were made/given to Abraham and to his descendant.
- God made promises to Abraham and to his descendant.

Before Paul continued in 3:17 with the spiritual application of his example, he first explained in this verse, as background information, that Christ was the focus of the promise to Abraham. Paul introduced this back-

ground information with a Greek conjunction that most English versions translate as “now.” In this context, “now” is not a time word.

The BSB has not translated this conjunction, and some other versions, such as the NIV and NLT, also do not translate it. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either. Connect 3:16a to 3:15b in a way that is natural in your language.

The promises were spoken to Abraham: Here Paul compared a “covenant” that men make (in 3:15b) to the promises that God made to Abraham. Paul had referred to that promise in 3:8d when he quoted Genesis 12:3.

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as were spoken is passive. Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Use a passive clause. For example:

the promises were made to Abraham (RSV)

- Use an active clause. For example:

God made his promises to Abraham (GNT)

and to his seed: The word that the BSB translates as seed means “descendant” in this context. This word is singular. Paul used the singular of seed because he was referring to Jesus Christ. You must use a singular form for this word in your language. For example:

and to his descendant (GNT)

3:16b

The Scripture does not say, “and to seeds,” meaning many,

- Scripture does not say the words “and to his descendants,” as if it talks about many of them.
- God did not say, “and to your descendants.” That would mean many people. (NCV)
- The Bible does not say “descendants” as if it were a matter of many people.

The Scripture does not say: In some languages, it may not be natural to speak of the Scripture as saying something. If that is the case in your language, you can say:

The scripture does not use the plural (GNT)

God did not say (NCV)

“and to seeds,” meaning many: In this clause, Paul explained the last phrase of the Scripture quotation that he referred to in 3:16a. He said that Scripture did not use the plural seeds. It did not refer to many people. You must use a plural form for seeds here.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

“to his descendants,” as if it meant many of them

“and to your descendants.” That would mean many people. (NCV)

3:16c

but “and to your seed,” meaning One, who is Christ.

- Rather, Scripture talks about one person. It says, “And to his descendant.” That descendant is Christ.
- But God said, “and to your descendant.” That means only one person; that person is Christ. (NCV)
- Instead, the Bible says “descendant.” It is one person. That person is Christ.

but: There is a contrast between 3:16b and 3:16c. The contrast is between what Scripture did not say (“seeds”) and what it did say (seed). Languages have different ways to indicate this negative-positive order of contrast. As in 3:12b, one of the functions of the Greek conjunction *ἀλλά* is to signal this negative-positive type of contrast. Some of the ways are:

- With the conjunction “but.”
- With a conjunction other than “but.” For example:

Rather (NLT)

Instead

- With no conjunction. For example:

^bThe Scripture did not say “and to descendants.”
^cIt said “and to your descendant.”

“and to your seed,” meaning One, who is Christ: In this clause Paul stated that Scripture used the singular word seed. This refers to one person. He explicitly said who is the one descendant of Abraham through whom the promise comes. That descendant is Jesus Christ.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

it says “to his descendant.” It is one person. That person is Christ.

God said, “and to your descendant.” That means only one person; that person is Christ. (NCV)

your seed: The BSB literally translates the Greek pronoun *your* here. However, in some languages, it may be more natural to use the pronoun “his” here. This will correspond better with the quote “his seed” in 3:16a. An example is given in the first Meaning Line of the Display.

Galatians 3:17

Section 3:15–25: The law did not cancel God’s promise to Abraham

This section has two parts. In the first part (3:15–18), Paul explained what the law was not intended to do. It was not intended to cancel or replace the blessing that God had promised to give to Abraham.

In the second part (3:19–25), Paul explained what the law was meant to do, how it was given, and how it was limited. It was limited as to what it could accomplish in people’s lives. And it was limited as to the time period during which it would govern God’s people.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

The law and the promise

The promise preceded the law

The law does not change the promise

3:17a

What I mean is this:

- My point is this: (REB)
- Here is the meaning of my example:
- Here is what I want you to understand:

In this verse Paul gave his spiritual application of the human example. He said (in 3:15) that a human document could not be changed. In the same way, God’s covenant promises cannot be changed. God established and ratified the covenant long before the law was given. This means that “believing” came before “doing/obeying” the law.

What I mean is this: This clause introduces the thing that Paul wanted to explain to the Galatians when he gave his human example (in 3:15b).

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Here is the meaning of my example

The thing that I want you to understand about God's promise to Abraham is thi

Here is what I want you to understand

3:17b-d

(reordered) God made a covenant with Abraham and promised to keep it. The Law, which was given four hundred and thirty years later, cannot break that covenant and cancel God's promise. (GNT)

Before you translate 3:17b-d, consider what is the most natural order in your language for these clauses. In some languages, it will be natural to change the order. Compare the order of the clause in the BSB and GNT below:

^bThe law that came 430 years later ^cdoes not revoke the covenant previously established by God, ^dso as to nullify the promise. (BSB)

^cGod made a covenant with Abraham and promised to keep it. ^bThe Law, which was given four hundred and thirty years later, ^ccannot break that covenant ^dand cancel God's promise. (GNT)

3:17b

The law that came 430 years later

- The law came 430 years after the covenant/promise.
- God made a covenant/agreement with Abraham. Then 430 years later he gave the law to Moses.

The law that came 430 years later: This clause means that God gave the law to Moses 430 years after God made his covenant with Abraham. God established the covenant first. Much later he gave the law.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

The law was given to Moses 430 years after God established the covenant with Abraham.

God gave the covenant to Abraham 430 years before he gave the law.

God made his promise with Abraham first. Then, 430 years later, he gave the law of Moses for the people.

3:17c

does not revoke the covenant previously established by God,

- The law does not cancel the contract that God had already made
- The law does not set aside the agreement that God had already promised.

does not revoke: The Greek word that the BSB translates as revoke is a different word than the word that the BSB translates as "canceled" in 3:15b. But the meaning is very similar. Many English versions translate the two Greek words with the same English word or expression.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

does not cancel/break

cannot set aside

the covenant: This word refers to the agreement/promise that God made with Abraham. This same word occurs in 3:15b. If possible, use the same term here as you did there.

In some languages, it will be necessary to use one word for a human covenant and another word or term for a covenant that God makes. When God made a covenant with Abraham, he did not sign a paper.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

a contract

a promise

the agreement

See covenant in the Glossary.

previously established by God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as established is the same word used in 3:15b. God had ratified or established his covenant with Abraham (before he gave the law). He established it by verbally promising to keep it.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

that God made

and promised to keep it (GNT)

that God sealed

In this verse, you should not translate established with a word that only refers to signing an agreement. God did not literally sign an agreement with Abraham.

3:17d

so as to nullify the promise.

- and destroy/break his promise.
- The law did not cause God to break his promise.

so as to nullify the promise: The Greek word that the BSB translates as nullify means “cancel,” “destroy,” or “abolish.” The law did not break or cancel God’s promise with Abraham. This implies that the covenant promises are still in effect.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

and cancel God’s promise (GNT)

and break the agreement

General Comment on 3:17c–d

The clause “revoke the covenant” in 3:17c is similar to “nullify the promise” in 3:17d. In some languages, both clauses can be translated as one. The one clause is underlined below.

The laws given to Moses 430 years after God had already put his promise to Abraham into effect didn’t cancel the promise to Abraham. (GW)

Galatians 3:18

Section 3:15–25: The law did not cancel God’s promise to Abraham

This section has two parts. In the first part (3:15–18), Paul explained what the law was not intended to do. It was not intended to cancel or replace the blessing that God had promised to give to Abraham.

In the second part (3:19–25), Paul explained what the law was meant to do, how it was given, and how it was limited. It was limited as to what it could accomplish in people’s lives. And it was limited as to the time period during which it would govern God’s people.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

The law and the promise

The promise preceded the law

The law does not change the promise

3:18a–b

For: Verse 3:18 is an explanation of 3:15–17. In this verse Paul explained why the law cannot cancel God’s promises. The Greek introduces this explanation with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For.

Another way to introduce this explanation is:

I say this because

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

if the inheritance depends on the law, then it no longer depends on a promise:

This sentence has a special type of “if” clause. In this “if” clause, Paul stated the opposite of what is true. The truth is that the inheritance (blessing) does not come by obeying the law. If it did come by the law, that would cancel the promise.

Some languages have a special way to translate this type of “if” sentence. Some examples are listed below. After the examples, each part of this verse is discussed.

Some ways to translate this sentence are:

- Use an “if” clause that indicates the opposite of what is true. For example:

If we received the inheritance by obeying the law (but we do not), then we would not receive it by God’s promise.

If we inherit/receive what God gives because we obey the law, then we do not receive it because God promised it to us, but because of what we do.

- Express the meaning without using an “if” clause. For example:

God does not bless people because they obey the law. He blesses them because he promised to do it.

3:18a

For if the inheritance depends on the law,

- For if the inheritance could be received by keeping the law, (NLT)
- If we have to obey the Law in order to receive God’s blessings, (CEV)

- I say this because inheriting/receiving God's blessing does not depend on obeying the law. If it did,

if the inheritance: In the Old Testament, the word inheritance referred to inheriting/receiving the Promised Land. When God gave the Jews the land, it showed his favor and blessing. Paul used this word to refer to God's blessing in giving his people salvation. God's people receive this inheritance/blessing as a result of his promise to bless them through Jesus, the special descendant of Abraham.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

if inheriting God's blessings

If...God's blessings (CEV)

if we received God's blessing

if God's gift (GNT)

The word inheritance does not refer to a human inheritance that is passed on to a person's descendants after he dies.

depends on the law: This clause means that the inheritance "comes by keeping the law of Moses."

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

is based on the law (NET)

could be received by keeping the law (NLT)

comes from obeying the law of Moses

because we obey the law

3:18b

then it no longer depends on a promise;

- then it would not be the result of accepting God's promise. (NLT)
- those blessings don't really come to us because of God's promise. (CEV)
- it would not depend on God's promise. It would depend on doing something.

then it no longer depends on a promise: Here the pronoun it refers to the inheritance. The word promise refers to God's promise to bless people through Abraham.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

then the inheritance does not come to us because God promised it

then we do not receive/inherit God's blessings because he promised it, but because of what we have done

3:18c

but God freely granted it to Abraham through a promise.

- But God kindly gave the inheritance to Abraham by/through a promise.
- But Abraham received the blessing because God promised to bless him.
- But God was kind and gave Abraham a blessing because he had made a promise.

but: There is a contrast between 3:18a-b and 3:18c. The contrast is between the way that the inheritance would not come (in 3:18b) and the way it actually came (in 3:18c). The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction but.

God freely granted it to Abraham through a promise: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as freely granted means "graciously/kindly gave." God kindly gave the inheritance to Abraham simply because he promised it to him. This truth proves that the inheritance does not depend on obeying the law.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

God kindly gave the blessing/gift to Abraham because he made a promise to give it to him

it was because of his promise that God gave that gift to Abraham (GNT)

God was kind and gave Abraham a blessing because he promised it to him

Galatians 3:19

Section 3:15–25: The law did not cancel God's promise to Abraham

This section has two parts. In the first part (3:15–18), Paul explained what the law was not intended to do. It was not intended to cancel or replace the blessing that God had promised to give to Abraham.

In the second part (3:19–25), Paul explained what the law was meant to do, how it was given, and how it was

limited. It was limited as to what it could accomplish in people's lives. And it was limited as to the time period during which it would govern God's people.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

The law and the promise

The promise preceded the law

The law does not change the promise

3:19a

Why then was the law given?

- ¶ So then, why did God give the law?
- ¶ So, since it's like that, what is the purpose of the law?
- ¶ So, here is the purpose/function of the law.

Why then was the law given?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used this rhetorical question to begin a new section. He had just talked about the things that the law cannot do. Here he stated the purpose of the law.

Some ways to translate this rhetorical question are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

What purpose then does the law serve? (NKJV)

What, then, was the purpose of the Law? (GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

So, here is the purpose/function of the law.

Use whichever form is most natural in your language to call someone to think.

then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as then connects 3:19a to the previous section. The previous section shows that God blessed Abraham because of a promise. He did not bless him because he obeyed the law. (The law had not yet been given.) That being the case, the logical question is, "Why was the law given?" For example:

Since God blessed Abraham because of a promise, then what is the purpose of the law?

So, if that's the case, what is the function of the law?

So what was the law for? (NCV)

3:19b

It was added because of transgressions,

- He added/gave it to show what sin is,
- God gave the law to make known sin.
- God gave the law to tell us what sin is.

It was added: This clause means that God gave the law in addition to the covenant/promise. It was added many years later.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

The law was added to the covenant

It was given later (CEV)

God also gave the law to people

because of transgressions: There are several ways to interpret the phrase that the BSB translates as because of transgressions. Two of the main ways are:

1. The purpose of the law is to define transgressions/sins. It identifies sin and tells us what sin is. For example:

in order to show what wrongdoing is (GNT)

to show people their sins (NLT) (GNT, NLT, GW, CEV)

1. The purpose of the law is to deal with transgressions/sins. The law told the Jews what sacrifices to make to atone for their sins. It also told them what the punishment was for sin. For example:

to deal with crimes (NJB) (NJB)

It is recommended that you choose interpretation (1). In the previous section, Paul told the Galatians what the law could not do. It is unlikely that he would now tell them that the law can deal with sin (interpretation (2)).

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

to make known sin

to tell us what sin is

transgressions: The Greek word that the BSB translates as transgressions means “wrongdoing,” “disobedience,” or “sins.” For example:

sins (NLT)

3:19c

until the arrival of the seed

- and it continued until the descendant came,
- It was valid until Christ, that descendant of Abraham, came.
- People were supposed to obey the law until the descendant came.

until the arrival of the seed: This clause indicates how long the law was in effect. It indicates that the law had an end point. It was in force until the seed (Christ) came. This statement would have surprised the Jews. They expected the law to last forever.

The word that the BSB translates as seed is the same word that Paul used in 3:16. It refers to Jesus Christ the offspring or descendant of Abraham. You should translate it in the same way here.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

And the law continued until the descendant came

The law was valid until Christ, that descendant of Abraham had come

God wanted people to obey the law until Christ, the descendant of Abraham came

3:19d

to whom the promise referred.

- the descendant to whom the promise had been made.
- God made a promise to this descendant.
- This is the descendant of Abraham to whom God had made a promise.

to whom the promise referred: In Greek this phrase is more literally “to whom the promise has been made.” This clause repeats part of 3:16a, “The promises were spoken to Abraham and to his seed.” This is a relative clause. In some languages, it will be necessary to make this a separate sentence.

This clause is passive in Greek. Some ways to translate it are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

The promise had been made to this descendant.

- Use an active verb. For example:

God had made a promise to this descendant of Abraham.

This is the descendant to whom God had made a promise.

3:19e

It was administered through angels by a mediator.

- The law was delivered through angels to the people by a mediator.
- God sent/passed his law through angels to Moses. He was the go-between between God and the people.
- God gave the law through angels. They gave it to Moses a middleman, and he gave it to the people.

It was administered through angels: The pronoun It refers to the law. The words administered mean “commanded” or “ordered.” You should use a term that is natural to describe “establishing” a law.

This clause indicates how the law is inferior to the promise. God gave the law to men. But he did not give it directly. He gave it to angels. Then angels gave it to Moses. Then Moses gave it to the people.

This is a passive clause. God is the one who put the law into effect through the angels. Some ways to translate this clause are:

- As a passive clause:

The law was put in place through angels

The Law was handed down by angels (GNT)

The law was given through angels (NCV)

- As an active clause:

God gave his law through angels (NLT)

through angels: It is not stated in Exodus that the law was given to Moses through angels. However, in Acts 7:38 and 7:53, Stephen mentions that the law was given through an angel speaking on God’s behalf.

The word angel first occurs in 1:8a. See also angel in the Glossary.

by a mediator: The word that the BSB translates as mediator refers to an “in-between person” or an “intermediary.” A mediator stands between two people. Moses was the mediator whom God used to give his law. The use of a mediator also shows that the law was inferior to the promise.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

by a middleman

using a go-between

who used Moses for a mediator to give the law to people (NCV)

to Moses, and he gave it to the people (CEV)

Galatians 3:20

Section 3:15–25: The law did not cancel God’s promise to Abraham

This section has two parts. In the first part (3:15–18), Paul explained what the law was not intended to do. It was not intended to cancel or replace the blessing that God had promised to give to Abraham.

In the second part (3:19–25), Paul explained what the law was meant to do, how it was given, and how it was limited. It was limited as to what it could accomplish in people’s lives. And it was limited as to the time period during which it would govern God’s people.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

The law and the promise

The promise preceded the law

The law does not change the promise

3:20

In this verse Paul contrasted the work of a mediator (which involves two parties) and the oneness of God. Paul used this contrast to say that the law is inferior to the promise. God did not give the law directly to his people. He gave it through Moses, the mediator. But with the promise, God alone made a promise. And

made it directly with Abraham. This shows that the promise is more important than the law.

3:20a

A mediator is unnecessary, however, for only one party;

- A mediator does not work with only one person.
- So the law did not come directly from God. There was a go-between.
- But with/concerning the promise, there was no middleman.

A mediator is unnecessary, however, for only one party:

In 3:20, Paul interrupted his discussion about the law to make a comment on the word “mediator.” He provided background information about the role of a mediator. Paul introduced this background information with a Greek conjunction that most English versions translate as “now.” In this context, “now” is not a time word. The BSB translates this conjunction as however, as does the NIV.

Some other versions, such as the CEV and GW, do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate it either. Connect 3:20a to 3:19e in a way that is natural in your language.

A mediator is unnecessary...for only one party: In Greek, this clause is more literally “the intermediary is not of one.” This means that when a mediator is involved, there is more than one side/party in the agreement or discussion.

This implies that when God gave the law, he gave it through a mediator (Moses) to his people. He did not give it directly.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

A mediator does not work with just one person.

Now a mediator is helpful if more than one party must reach an agreement. (NLT)

God gave the law to his people through Moses, a middleman

3:20b

but God is one.

- But God is one person. He alone made the promise with Abraham.
- But with the promise, God made it directly with Abraham.
- God made the promise alone/himself.

but God is one: In this clause Paul contrasted God's oneness with the more than one person with whom a mediator works. Paul used the truth stated in Deut. 6:4 to make this contrast.

This clause implies that with the promise, God alone made it. He did not use an intermediary. He made it directly with Abraham.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

But God, who is one, did not use a mediator when he gave his promise to Abraham. (NLT)

but God alone made the promise

but with the promise, God alone made it directly with Abraham

Galatians 3:21

Section 3:15–25: The law did not cancel God's promise to Abraham

This section has two parts. In the first part (3:15–18), Paul explained what the law was not intended to do. It was not intended to cancel or replace the blessing that God had promised to give to Abraham.

In the second part (3:19–25), Paul explained what the law was meant to do, how it was given, and how it was limited. It was limited as to what it could accomplish in people's lives. And it was limited as to the time period during which it would govern God's people.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

The law and the promise

The promise preceded the law

The law does not change the promise

3:21a

Is the law, then, opposed to the promises of God?

- ¶ Well then, is there a conflict between God's law and God's promises? (NLT96)
- ¶ So, is the law against God's promises?
- ¶ Do not think that the law is against the promises of God.

Is the law, then, opposed to the promises of God?:

This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes that the law is not contrary to the promises. Paul used this

rhetorical question to correct a wrong conclusion that some readers might have drawn from what he had just said.

The words opposed to mean that the law is not "contrary to" or "against" the promises.

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Is the law then against the promises of God? (RSV)

Well then, is there a conflict between God's law and God's promises? (NLT96)

- As a statement. For example:

Now then, the law is certainly not opposed to the promises of God.

- As a command. For example:

Do not think/conclude that the law is against the promises of God.

Use whichever form is most natural in your language to emphasize something.

then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB here translates as then can also be translated as "therefore" (as in the NIV). This conjunction introduces a conclusion. Here the idea is, "Can we conclude that the law is against the promises of God?"

Some other ways to translate this conjunction are:

Does this mean (GNT)

therefore (NET)

So

3:21b

Certainly not!

- Absolutely not!
- Not at all! But it is different.
- It is not! But the function of the law is different than the function of the promises.

Certainly not!: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Certainly not! is a strong response "No!" to the rhetorical question.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Never!

Absolutely not!

No, no, no! But it is different.

This clause also occurs in 2:17. You can translate it in the same way here.

3:21c–d

For: Verse 3:21c–d explains why it is wrong to conclude that the law is against the promise (3:21a). It explains more about the relationship between the law and the promise. They do not have the same function. They are both part of God’s plan, but the law does not give life. The Greek introduces this explanation with a conjunction that the BSB translates as *For*.

In some languages, it may be necessary to make this more explicit. For example:

They are not opposed, but they are different, because

The purpose of the law is different than the purpose of the promise. I say this because

(In the Display, this implicit information has been put in 3:21b.)

if a law had been given that could impart life, then righteousness would certainly have come from the law: This sentence has a special type of “if” clause. In this “if” clause, Paul stated the opposite of what is true. The truth is that there is no law given that can give life.

Some languages have a special way to translate this type of “if” sentence. Some examples are listed below. After the examples, each part of this verse is discussed.

Some ways to translate this sentence are:

- As an “if” sentence. For example:

if human beings had received a law that could bring life, then everyone could be put right with God by obeying it (GNT)

- As a true statement followed by the conclusion. For example:

Righteousness certainly does not come by means of the law that was given, so the law cannot give life.

- By stating the conclusion first and then stating the conditional clause. For example:

The law that was given cannot give life. If it could give life, then righteousness would certainly have come by means of obeying the law.

- As a rhetorical question followed by the consequence. For example:

Do you think that the law that was given can give life? Then righteousness would certainly come by means of the law. But it does not.

3:21c

For if a law had been given that could impart life,

- Because if a law had been given that could give eternal life to people/us,
- I say this because if God had given a law that could cause people to live forever,
- The law that God gave does not give spiritual life. If it could give spiritual life,

if a law had been given: The verb had been given is passive. Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Use a passive verb. For example

if a law had been established

- Use an active verb. For example:

if God had given a law

if human beings had received a law (GNT)

that could impart life: This clause refers to spiritual life, not physical life.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

that could give eternal life to us

that could give life that never ends

3:21d

then righteousness would certainly have come from the law.

- then righteousness would indeed be/come by keeping/obeying the law.
- then if they obeyed that law, they could be made right with God.
- then people could become right/straight with God because they kept/obeyed the law.

righteousness would certainly have come: The word righteousness refers to the character trait of being “upright,” “straight,” or “blameless.”

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

we could become acceptable to God (CEV)

everyone could be put right with God (GNT)

we could be made right with God (NLT)

It is the same word as in 2:21b. See also righteous in the Glossary.

from the law: This phrase means “by obeying the law.”

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

because of the law

because we obeyed them (GW)

if we obeyed it

Galatians 3:22

Section 3:15–25: The law did not cancel God’s promise to Abraham

This section has two parts. In the first part (3:15–18), Paul explained what the law was not intended to do. It was not intended to cancel or replace the blessing that God had promised to give to Abraham.

In the second part (3:19–25), Paul explained what the law was meant to do, how it was given, and how it was limited. It was limited as to what it could accomplish in people’s lives. And it was limited as to the time period during which it would govern God’s people.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

The law and the promise

The promise preceded the law

The law does not change the promise

3:22a

But the Scripture pronounces all things confined by sin,

- However, as Scripture says, the whole world is a prisoner of sin,
- But the law cannot give life. Rather in the Holy Book it says that sin controls everyone
- Instead the Scripture declares that the desire to sin has power over everyone.

But: There is a contrast between 3:21 and 3:22. The contrast is between what the law cannot do (give life) and what the law does (imprisons/confines). Languages have different ways to indicate this negative-positive order of contrast. Some of the ways are:

- With the conjunction “but.”
- With a conjunction other than “but.” For example:

Rather

Instead (NCV)

- With no conjunction.

the Scripture pronounces all things confined by sin:

In this clause, Paul spoke about the Scripture as if it were a judge who condemns people to prison/jail, and Paul spoke about sin as if it were a jailer who has control over prisoners. Fung says, “The positive aspect of the law’s function is stated with the help of the figure of a jail sentence, with Scripture as the magistrate... and sin as the jailer who carries out the sentence” (p. 164). These are two figures of speech called personification. In some languages, it will not be possible to translate one or both of these personifications.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

the Scriptures have declared that we are all prisoners of sin (NLT96)

the Scriptures say that sin controls everyone (CEV)

They wrote in God’s book that that sin ties up all people

God in his holy book says that the desire to sin has power over everyone

the Scripture: When Paul used the phrase the Scripture, he often referred to a particular verse in Scripture. For example, Galatians 4:30 says, “But what does the Scripture say? ‘Expel the slave woman and her son, for the slave woman’s son will never share in the inheritance with the free woman’s son.’” Here, the phrase “the Scripture” refers to Genesis 21:10. Here, he was probably referring to Deuteronomy 27:26, “Cursed is he who does not put the words of this law into practice.” This verse is part of the law that God gave to Moses. So here the phrase the Scripture is a way to refer to the law.

The law tells people what sin is. It says that when someone sins, he is guilty. In that sense, Scripture is like a judge who says/declares that people are guilty. The law also shows people that they are under the power of sin.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the scripture says that (GNT)

the law written in Scripture tells us that

God in his holy book says that

they wrote in God’s book that

all things: The Greek word that the BSB translates as all things refers to everything that God created. In this passage, the focus is on people. So here the word refers particularly to “everyone.”

Some other ways to translate this word are:

everyone (CEV)

the whole world (NIV)

we are all (NLT)

confined by sin: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as confined by sin means “under the power of sin” or “controlled by sin.” By using the word confined, Paul was using imprisonment terminology and speaking of sin as if it were a jailer who controls human beings as a jailer controls prisoners. Just as prisoners do what the jailer says, human beings do what sin tells them to do. Sin controls them.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

a prisoner of sin (NIV)

controlled by the power of sin (GW)

under the power of sin (GNT)

the desire to sin controls everyone

3:22b

so that by faith in Jesus Christ the promise might be given to those who believe.

- in order that what was promised through faith in Jesus Christ might be given to those who believe.
- so that God might give the blessing to those who believe. This is the blessing that he promised through faith in Jesus Christ.
- This has happened so that God might give the blessing that he promised to those who believe in Jesus Christ.

so that: There are two ways to interpret the Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as so that:

1. It introduces God’s purpose for imprisoning people under sin. His purpose is to give people the promise by means of their faith in Jesus. For example:

so that (NIV) (BSB, NIV, ESV, NET, RSV, CEV, NCV, KJV, NASB, REB, JBP)

1. It introduces the result of our being a prisoner under sin.

Therefore (GW) (GNT, GW, NLT, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The majority of English versions follow this interpretation.

Some other ways to introduce this purpose are:

This was so (NCV)

He did this so that

by faith in Jesus Christ the promise might be given to those who believe: The word faith is the noun form of the Greek verb that English versions translate as believe. So in these phrases, to have faith in Jesus Christ is the same thing as to believe in him. The same idea is repeated. People receive the promise by (or

because of) their faith/belief in Jesus Christ. And God gives the promise to people who believe.

Paul repeated the idea of believing to add emphasis. He emphasized that believing in Jesus is what is important. It is more important than obeying the law.

In some languages, it will not be natural to repeat the idea of believing. So the phrase faith in Jesus Christ and the phrase those who believe can be translated as one. For example:

God's promises will be for anyone who has faith in Jesus Christ (CEV)

God will give the blessing that he promised to people who believe in Jesus Christ.

faith: See faith, Meaning 1, in the Glossary.

the promise might be given: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as might be given is passive.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the promise would be given (NCV)

- Use an active verb. For example

God might give the promise

God might give the blessing that he promised

the promise: This phrase refers to the promise that God made to Abraham. More specifically, it refers to what God promised Abraham. He promised to bless all the nations through him.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

what was promised (RSV)

what God promised

the promised blessing (REB)

the blessing that God promised

Galatians 3:23

Section 3:15–25: The law did not cancel God's promise to Abraham

This section has two parts. In the first part (3:15–18), Paul explained what the law was not intended to do. It was not intended to cancel or replace the blessing that God had promised to give to Abraham.

In the second part (3:19–25), Paul explained what the law was meant to do, how it was given, and how it was limited. It was limited as to what it could accomplish in people's lives. And it was limited as to the time period during which it would govern God's people.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

The law and the promise

The promise preceded the law

The law does not change the promise

Paragraph 3:23–25

In this paragraph, Paul's main point is that we are sons of God through faith in Christ. The role of the law is finished because Christ has come. He pointed out that once people have become children of God, they are entitled to all the blessings of the new life in Christ. He reminded the Christians in Galatia that they became children of God through faith. Because they were now children of God there was no longer a dividing line between Jew or non-Jew, male or female, slave or free.

3:23a

Before this faith came,

- ¶ Before the way of faith came,
- ¶ Before the time arrived when people believe/trust in Christ,
- ¶ At the time when Christ in whom people should believe/trust had not yet come,

In 3:23, Paul continued his discussion about the law and the promise/faith. He connected this verse to the previous verses with a Greek conjunction that many English versions translate as "now." In this context, "now" is not a time word.

The BSB has not translated this conjunction, and some other versions, such as the NIV and NLT, also do not translate it. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either. Connect 3:23a to 3:22b in a way that is natural in your language.

Before this faith came: The word faith refers to “faith in Jesus Christ” (from 3:22b). So this clause refers to the time before people could be made right with God through faith/believing in Christ.

Another way to translate this clause is:

Before the way of faith in Christ came

In some languages, it is not natural to say that faith came. In other languages, faith must be translated as a verb. In those languages, some ways to translate this clause are:

before the time of believing/trusting in Christ

before the time arrived when people could believe/trust in Christ

When Christ in whom people should believe/trust had not yet come

See faith, Meaning 1 in the Glossary.

3:23b

we were held in custody under the law,

- we were held by the law
- the law was like a guard who kept us in prison.
- we were like prisoners whom the law guarded.

we were held in custody under the law: The words held in custody mean “held captive,” “held prisoners,” “confined,” or “guarded.”

This is a passive clause. Some ways to translate this clause are:

- As a passive clause. For example:

we were held prisoners by the law (NIV)

we were placed under guard by the law (NLT)

- As an active clause. For example:

the Law kept us all locked up as prisoners (GNT)

The Law controlled us and kept us under its power (CEV)

This clause is also a figure of speech called personification. In this figure of speech, Paul spoke of the law as if it were a prison guard who guarded people in

prison. In some languages, it is not natural to keep this personification. Some ways to translate this clause without using personification are:

the law was like a guard who held us in prison

we were like prisoners whom the law guarded

In your translation, do not use a word that implies “protected.”

3:23c

locked up until faith should be revealed.

- as prisoners until the coming way of faith was made known.
- The law controlled us until the time came when believing/trusting in Christ was shown to us.
- It had power over us until the time came when God revealed/showed to us that we should/must believe in Christ.

locked up: The Greek word that the BSB translates as locked up is the same Greek word as in 3:22a, where the BSB translates it as “confined.” You should translate it in a similar way or in the same way as you did there. For example:

confined

under the power of

controlled

In some languages, it may be necessary to begin a new sentence here. For example:

We were locked up

The law kept us in prison

until faith should be revealed: This clause refers to a particular period of time. It is the time that lasted up to the time when God revealed/showed the way of faith in Christ. That time happened when Christ came. When it happened, the time ended during which people were prisoners to the law. The time of the law ended.

This is a passive clause. Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Use a passive clause. For example:

until the coming way of faith in Christ was revealed

until the time came when believing/trusting in Christ was shown to us

- as an active clause

until the time came when God revealed/showed to us that we should believe in Christ

Galatians 3:24

Section 3:15–25: The law did not cancel God's promise to Abraham

This section has two parts. In the first part (3:15–18), Paul explained what the law was not intended to do. It was not intended to cancel or replace the blessing that God had promised to give to Abraham.

In the second part (3:19–25), Paul explained what the law was meant to do, how it was given, and how it was limited. It was limited as to what it could accomplish in people's lives. And it was limited as to the time period during which it would govern God's people.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

The law and the promise

The promise preceded the law

The law does not change the promise

Paragraph 3:23–25

In this paragraph, Paul's main point is that we are sons of God through faith in Christ. The role of the law is finished because Christ has come. He pointed out that once people have become children of God, they are entitled to all the blessings of the new life in Christ. He reminded the Christians in Galatia that they became children of God through faith. Because they were now children of God there was no longer a dividing line between Jew or non-Jew, male or female, slave or free.

3:24a

So the law became our guardian to lead us to Christ,

- The law was also our guardian until Christ came,
- In other words, the law was like a person who watches a child. It was in charge of us until Christ came,
- The law controlled us until Christ came.

So: In 3:24, Paul used another figure of speech to explain further what he had already said about the law in the previous verses.

The Greek conjunction that Paul used here normally indicates result. That is why some English versions begin this verse with the conjunction So. However, here, it is better to see 3:24 as simply another figure of speech to explain the role of the law.

Some ways to introduce this verse are:

Let me put it another way (NLT)

In other words (NCV)

Or, to change the metaphor (JBP)

Also

Some English versions do not use a conjunction here. In some languages, a conjunction will not be necessary either.

the law became our guardian: This is a metaphor. In this metaphor, the law is compared to a guardian. The word guardian refers to a slave who was put in charge of his master's child. This word is further defined below.

The law and a guardian are similar in that both (harshly) control someone for a temporary period of time. Just as a guardian controlled a child until he became an adult, so also the law controlled people until Christ came.

Some ways to translate this metaphor are:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

Moses' laws served as our guardian (GW)

the law of Moses watched over us

- Translate it as a simile. For example:

the law can be compared to someone who watches over a child

the law was like a slave who was in charge of a child

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

The Law controlled us (CEV)

guardian: The word guardian refers to a slave who was put in charge of his master's child. (The child was about 6 to 16 years of age.) The slave's job was to discipline the child. He made sure that the child did what he was required to do, including going to school. He did this until the child became an adult. Guardians were often very strict. Sometimes they would slap, beat, whip, or pinch the child to punish and correct him.

It was not the responsibility of a guardian to teach the child formally. Other people were the child's teachers. So words such as "teacher" or "schoolmaster" are not good words to translate this Greek word.

Some other ways to translate the word guardian are:

child-watcher

slave in charge of a child

In some languages, it may be more natural to translate the noun guardian as a verb. For example:

the Law was in charge of us until Christ came (GNT)

the law was like a person who was in control of us until Christ came

to lead us to Christ: The phrase that the BSB translates as to lead us to Christ is literally just "to Christ." There are two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. It refers to the time of Christ's coming. For example:

until Christ came (NIV11) (NIV11, RSV, ESV, GNT, CEV, NET, REB, NLT)

1. It refers to the purpose of having the law as a guardian. The purpose was to lead people to Christ. For example:

to lead us to Christ (NIV) (BSB, NIV, KJV, NASB, NCV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation fits the context well. In this paragraph, Paul was talking about the temporary role of the law. The time of the law ended when the time of faith in Christ came.

3:24b

that we might be justified by faith.

- so that we could be justified through faith.
- so that, when he came, we could be made right/blameless through faith.
- It did this so that after he came God would make us right because of our faith.

that we might be justified by faith: This is a purpose clause. There are two things that this could be the purpose of:

1. It is the purpose of all of 3:24a. The law had a role, but it was only temporary. It was temporary so that we might be justified by faith. We could not be justified by following the law. For example:

^athe Law was in charge of us until Christ came, ^bin order that we might then be put right with God through faith (GNT) (BSB, NIV11, ESV, GNT, RSV, NET)

1. It is the purpose of Christ's coming. For example:

^aBefore Christ came, Moses' laws served as our guardian. ^bChrist came so that we could receive God's approval because of faith. (GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is a suitable way to understand the Greek grammar.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

so that, when Christ arrived, we might be justified by faith

The law did this so that we might be justified by faith.

we might be justified by faith: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as justified means "cause/make to be acceptable/right." This same verb occurs in 3:8b and 3:11a.

This verb is passive. Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

we might be made right by/through faith in him/
God

we could be accepted as righteous by God be-
cause of our faith

- As an active. For example:

God would make us right through faith

God would consider us straight because of our
faith

See also justify in the Glossary.

by faith: The phrase by faith means that a person will
be made righteous because of his faith/belief in God.
This same phrase occurs in 3:11b.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

through faith

because of his faith/believing

See faith, Meaning 1 in the Glossary.

Galatians 3:25

Section 3:15–25: The law did not cancel God's promise to Abraham

This section has two parts. In the first part (3:15–18),
Paul explained what the law was not intended to do.
It was not intended to cancel or replace the blessing
that God had promised to give to Abraham.

In the second part (3:19–25), Paul explained what the
law was meant to do, how it was given, and how it was
limited. It was limited as to what it could accomplish
in people's lives. And it was limited as to the time
period during which it would govern God's people.

Some other examples for a heading for this section
are:

The law and the promise

The promise preceded the law

The law does not change the promise

Paragraph 3:23–25

In this paragraph, Paul's main point is that we are sons
of God through faith in Christ. The role of the law is
finished because Christ has come. He pointed out that
once people have become children of God, they are
entitled to all the blessings of the new life in Christ. He
reminded the Christians in Galatia that they became
children of God through faith. Because they were now
children of God there was no longer a dividing line
between Jew or non-Jew, male or female, slave or free.

3:25a

Now that faith has come,

- But now that the way of faith has come,
- But now the time of faith/believing in Christ has
come/arrived,
- Now Christ has come/arrived, and people believe in
him to be made right with God.

There is a contrast between 3:24 and 3:25. The contrast
is between needing a guardian and no longer needing
a guardian. Paul introduced this contrast with a Greek
conjunction that most English versions translate as
“but.” Another way to begin this clause is:

And (NLT)

The BSB has not translated this conjunction, and some
other versions, such as the NIV and GNT, also do not
translate it. In some languages, it will not be neces-
sary to translate this conjunction either. Connect 3:25a
to 3:24b in a way that is natural in your language.

Now that faith has come: This clause refers to the
fact that the period of time has arrived when people
have faith/belief in Jesus Christ to be justified. The
time of the law is finished.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Now the way of faith has come (NCV)

now that the time for believing in Christ has come

now that the time for faith is here (GNT)

now Christ has come, and people believe in him
to be justified

3:25b

we are no longer under a guardian.

- we are not under the control/power of a guardian
any more.

- and the law is no longer like a person who is in charge of us.
- The law is finished controlling us.

we are no longer under a guardian: This clause indicates that we are no longer under the control/power of the law. The role of the law as our guardian has come to an end. The law was a temporary guardian.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

we are no longer under the control of a guardian (GW)

the Law is no longer in charge of us (GNT)

the law is finished being like someone who watches over us

Galatians 3:26

Section 3:26–4:7: A child of God is not a slave of the law

In the previous section, Paul talked about people from a Jewish background. In this section, he returned to focus on the non-Jews whom he had talked about earlier.

This section has two parts. In the first one (3:26 to 3:29), Paul reminded the non-Jewish Christians in Galatia that they had become children of God through faith. When people become children of God, there is no longer a difference between Jew or non-Jew, male or female, slave or free. He further pointed out that once people have become children of God, they are entitled to all the blessings of the new life in Christ.

In the second part (4:1 to 4:7), Paul compared the time under the law to a time of slavery. But when Christ came, he freed people from slavery. The time under the law ended. So believers in Jesus Christ are God's sons. They are not slaves to the law. It is no longer necessary to follow the law.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

By faith we are sons of God and are rescued from the law

You are not slaves but children of God

No longer prisoners to the law but sons

3:26

You are all sons of God through faith in Christ Jesus.

- ¶ In/Through Christ, all of you are sons of God by means of believing.
- ¶ All of you who are united with Christ Jesus are God's children because you believe in Jesus.

In 3:26, Paul further explained the faith in Christ that he had talked about in 3:24–25. He introduced this further explanation with a Greek conjunction that most English versions translate as “for.” Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

So (NIV)

The BSB has not translated this conjunction, and some other versions, such as the GNT and GW, also do not translate it. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either. Connect 3:26 to 3:25b in a way that is natural in your language.

You are all sons of God through faith in Christ Jesus:

There are two ways to interpret how the phrase in Christ Jesus fits in this clause:

1. It modifies the whole clause. This means that the believer is united with Christ and this makes him a son/child. For example:

So in Christ Jesus you are all children of God through faith. (NIV11) (NIV11, NET, RSV, REB, ESV, NJB)

1. It modifies through faith. It states that the object of faith is Jesus Christ. For example:

You are all sons of God through faith in Christ Jesus. (NIV) (BSB, NIV, KJV, NASB, CEV, GNT, GW, NCV, NLT, JBP)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Here Paul used the phrase in Christ as in other passages to mean “in union with Christ.”

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

In/Through Christ Jesus you are all sons of God through faith in him.

All of you who are united with Christ Jesus are sons of God because you believe in Christ.

sons of God: This phrase refers to all people who believe in Christ. They are both male and female. After a person has believed in Christ, God considers him as his child.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

children of God (NRSV)

sons and daughters of God

through faith: Some other ways to translate through faith are:

because of your faith (CEV)

because you believe in Jesus

by believing (GW)

A similar phrase also occurs in 3:14d. See also faith, Meaning 1 in the Glossary.

Christ Jesus: In the phrase Christ Jesus, Christ is his title and Jesus is his personal name. One way to show this is:

the Christ/Messiah Jesus

In 1:1c, Paul used the phrase “Jesus Christ.” Both Christ Jesus and “Jesus Christ” refer to the same person. Either order may be used in your translation.

This phrase also occurs in 3:14a. You should translate it here as you did there.

Galatians 3:27

Section 3:26–4:7: A child of God is not a slave of the law

In the previous section, Paul talked about people from a Jewish background. In this section, he returned to focus on the non-Jews whom he had talked about earlier.

This section has two parts. In the first one (3:26 to 3:29), Paul reminded the non-Jewish Christians in Galatia that they had become children of God through faith. When people become children of God, there is no longer a difference between Jew or non-Jew, male or female, slave or free. He further pointed out that once people have become children of God, they are entitled to all the blessings of the new life in Christ.

In the second part (4:1 to 4:7), Paul compared the time under the law to a time of slavery. But when Christ came, he freed people from slavery. The time under the law ended. So believers in Jesus Christ are God’s sons. They are not slaves to the law. It is no longer necessary to follow the law.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

By faith we are sons of God and are rescued from the law

You are not slaves but children of God

No longer prisoners to the law but sons

3:27a

For all of you who were baptized into Christ

- All of you who were baptized in union with Christ
- You all who they baptized and so are united with Christ,
- All you who received baptism and are united with Christ,

For: Verse 3:27 further explains what Paul has just said in 3:26. The Greek introduces this explanation with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For.

Many English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

all of you who: This phrase refers to the Galatian believers.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

as many of you as (ESV, NKJV)

everyone among you who

You (GNT)

were baptized into Christ: This phrase refers to believers being united with Christ through baptism. Baptism was a sign that a person had entered into a new relationship.

This clause is passive. Some ways to translate it are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

You were baptized into union with Christ (GNT)

All of you who were baptized and so now are united with Christ

- Use an active verb. For example:

All of you whom they baptized and who are united with Christ

All of you who received baptism and are united with Christ

baptized: You can use the same expression for “baptize” here as you used in the gospels.

See also baptize in the Glossary for more information.

3:27b

have clothed yourselves with Christ.

- have clothed yourselves with Christ. (NIV)
- it was as though you had put on Christ in the same way you put on new clothes. (CEV)
- you have become like Christ.

have clothed yourselves with Christ: The verb that the BSB translates as have clothed yourselves means “to clothe,” “to put on” or “to wear something.” This is a metaphor. In this metaphor, Paul talked about people who put on certain clothes to show who they are. He compared these people to believers putting on Christ. They are similar in that both “take on the characteristics of what they are wearing” or “become like what they wear.”

Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

have put on Christ (ESV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

it was as though you had put on Christ in the same way you put on new clothes (CEV)

- Translate the meaning without a figure of speech. For example:

you have become like Christ

you have identified yourselves with Christ

have been made like him (NLT96)

Galatians 3:28

Section 3:26–4:7: A child of God is not a slave of the law

In the previous section, Paul talked about people from a Jewish background. In this section, he returned to focus on the non-Jews whom he had talked about earlier.

This section has two parts. In the first one (3:26 to 3:29), Paul reminded the non-Jewish Christians in Galatia that they had become children of God through faith. When people become children of God, there is no longer a difference between Jew or non-Jew, male or female, slave or free. He further pointed out that once people have become children of God, they are entitled to all the blessings of the new life in Christ.

In the second part (4:1 to 4:7), Paul compared the time under the law to a time of slavery. But when Christ came, he freed people from slavery. The time under the law ended. So believers in Jesus Christ are God’s sons. They are not slaves to the law. It is no longer necessary to follow the law.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

By faith we are sons of God and are rescued from the law

You are not slaves but children of God

No longer prisoners to the law but sons

3:28a

There is neither Jew nor Greek,

- There is no difference/distinction between Jews and Gentiles,
- It doesn’t matter if a person is a Jew or a non-Jew,
- If you^(sing) are a Jew, if you are a Greek,

There is neither Jew nor Greek: This clause means that among believers, everyone is equal. There is no distinction between the races of Jew and Greek. Both Jews and Greeks are sons of God because they believe in Jesus Christ.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

there is no difference between Jew and Greek (NCV)

there is no distinction between Jew and Greek

it does not matter whether a person is a Jew or a Greek

In some languages, it may be more natural to make the nouns Jew and Greek plural. For example:

there is no difference between Jews and Greeks

If you use the plural form for Jews and Greeks, you should also use plural forms for slaves, free men, men, and women.

Greek: In this context, the word Greek refers to a non-Jew.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

non-Jew

Gentile

3:28b

slave nor free,

- slaves and free men,
- it doesn't matter if a person is a slave or not a slave,
- if you^(sing) are a boss, if you are a worker,

slave nor free: This clause is another example that among believers, everyone is equal. There is no distinction between a slave and a free man. Both slaves and free men are sons of God because they believe in Jesus Christ.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

there is no difference between a slave and a free man

it does not matter whether one is a slave or not a slave

there is no distinction between a boss and a worker

3:28c

male nor female,

- men and women,
- it doesn't matter if a person is a man or a woman.
- if you are a man, if you are a woman, none of that counts/matters.

male nor female: This clause is the third example that among believers, everyone is equal. There is no

distinction between men and women. Both men and women are sons of God because they believe in Jesus Christ.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

there is no distinction between a man and a woman

it does not matter whether a person is a man or a woman

3:28d

for you are all one in Christ Jesus.

- because you^(plur) are all one through faith in Jesus Christ.
- You are all equal because you believe in Jesus Christ.
- You are all the same because you are united in Christ Jesus.

for: Verse 3:28d is the reason why Paul can say that there is no difference between various categories of people (in 3:28a–c). There is no difference for/because everyone is one in Christ Jesus. The Greek introduces this reason with a conjunction that the BSB translates as for.

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. For example:

You are all the same in Christ Jesus. (GW)

In some languages, no conjunction will be necessary here either.

you are all one: This clause indicates that all believers are equal.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

you are all equal

You are all the same (GW)

in Christ Jesus: This phrase refers to being united to or joined with Christ Jesus. Believers are united to Christ Jesus because they believe in him.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

in union with Christ Jesus (GNT)

through faith in Christ Jesus (NCV)

because you believe in Christ Jesus

General Comment on 3:28

In some languages, it may be more natural to put 3:28d first in the verse. For example:

^{28d}You are all one in Christ Jesus, ^{28a}so there is neither Jew nor Greek, ^{28b}slave nor free, ^{28c}male nor female.

Galatians 3:29

Section 3:26–4:7: A child of God is not a slave of the law

In the previous section, Paul talked about people from a Jewish background. In this section, he returned to focus on the non-Jews whom he had talked about earlier.

This section has two parts. In the first one (3:26 to 3:29), Paul reminded the non-Jewish Christians in Galatia that they had become children of God through faith. When people become children of God, there is no longer a difference between Jew or non-Jew, male or female, slave or free. He further pointed out that once people have become children of God, they are entitled to all the blessings of the new life in Christ.

In the second part (4:1 to 4:7), Paul compared the time under the law to a time of slavery. But when Christ came, he freed people from slavery. The time under the law ended. So believers in Jesus Christ are God's sons. They are not slaves to the law. It is no longer necessary to follow the law.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

By faith we are sons of God and are rescued from the law

You are not slaves but children of God

No longer prisoners to the law but sons

3:29

In this verse, Paul used an “if” clause to conclude the argument that he began in 3:6. He pointed out that once a person has trusted in Christ, then he is a true descendant of Abraham.

3:29a

And if you belong to Christ,

- Since you^(plur) belong to Christ,

- Now that you belong to Christ,
- So because you are connected to Christ,

And if you belong to Christ: In this “if” clause, Paul stated a true fact. The Galatians, as believers, did belong to Christ. Paul was not questioning whether the Galatians belonged to Christ. He was stating that they did belong to Christ and therefore certain other things were true.

In some languages, the word “if” might suggest doubt about whether the Galatians belonged to Christ. So, it may be more natural to avoid beginning this clause with the word “if.” For example:

Since you belong to Christ

So because you are connected to Christ

And now that you belong to Christ (NLT)

You belong to Christ (NCV)

3:29b

then you are Abraham's seed

- you^(plur) are Abraham's descendants
- you are counted as descendants of Abraham,

then you are Abraham's seed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as seed means “descendants.” Here it refers to “spiritual children/descendants.” The same word occurs in 3:16c.

The result of belonging to Christ is that we become offspring/children of Abraham. Paul already stated in 3:7 that those who believe in Christ are sons of Abraham.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

then you are the descendants of Abraham (GNT)

then you are counted as descendants of Abraham

3:29c

and heirs according to the promise.

- and his heirs, as God promised.
- and you inherit/receive the thing/blessing that God promised to him.
- and God's promise to Abraham belongs to you. (NLT)

and heirs according to the promise: This phrase indicates that believers are also Abraham's heirs. They

are his heirs because that is what God promised. They inherit the same promise that God made to Abraham: they are justified by faith. This is one of Abraham's blessings.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

and inherit/receive what God has promised to him

and will receive what God has promised (GNT)

and God's promise to Abraham belongs to you (NLT)

heirs: The word heirs refers to the people who will receive the inheritance.

Another way to translate this word is:

people who receive the inheritance

Galatians 4:1

Section 3:26–4:7: A child of God is not a slave of the law

In the previous section, Paul talked about people from a Jewish background. In this section, he returned to focus on the non-Jews whom he had talked about earlier.

This section has two parts. In the first one (3:26 to 3:29), Paul reminded the non-Jewish Christians in Galatia that they had become children of God through faith. When people become children of God, there is no longer a difference between Jew or non-Jew, male or female, slave or free. He further pointed out that once people have become children of God, they are entitled to all the blessings of the new life in Christ.

In the second part (4:1 to 4:7), Paul compared the time under the law to a time of slavery. But when Christ came, he freed people from slavery. The time under the law ended. So believers in Jesus Christ are God's sons. They are not slaves to the law. It is no longer necessary to follow the law.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

By faith we are sons of God and are rescued from the law

You are not slaves but children of God

No longer prisoners to the law but sons

Paragraph 4:1–7

In this paragraph, Paul further explained that the period of the law was temporary. He compared the period under the law to a period of slavery. When Christ came, he redeemed the people who were in slavery. They are no longer slaves. Instead, they are now adopted as God's sons and are his heirs. The time of the law is over.

4:1a

What I am saying is that

- ¶ I mean that (ESV)
- ¶ Let me explain further. (GW)

What I am saying is that: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as What I am saying is that introduces an explanation of what it means to be an heir of God (in 3:29b).

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Let me explain further. (GW)

Think of it this way. (NLT)

My point is this: (NRSV)

In 3:17a and 5:16a, Paul used a similar expression to introduce an explanation of a previous statement.

4:1b

as long as the heir is a child,

- during the time that the heir is a child,
- When the son who will receive his father's possessions is very young,

as long as the heir is a child: The word child refers to a young person who is not yet an adult. This entire clause refers to the time when a child is too young to receive the inheritance.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

when the heir is a young child

during the time when the son who will receive his father's possessions is very young

before the boy who will one day own his father's possessions becomes an adult

the heir: The Greek word that the BSB translates as heir refers to the son who will eventually receive his father's possessions. In this case, it probably does not mean that the father has already died. This is perhaps a situation where the father has decided to give some of his possessions to his son when the son becomes an adult. The father will do this even if he is still alive.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

the son who will later inherit/get his father's possessions

the son who will receive his father's property (GNT)

the son who will one day own his father's possessions

This same word occurs in 3:29c.

4:1c

he is no different from a slave,

- his situation is no different/better than that of a slave,
- he is like a slave/servant,
- he is under authority as a slave is under authority.

he is no different from a slave: The clause he is no different from a slave is a figure of speech called a hyperbole. Paul exaggerated to make a point. In one sense, a boy who will inherit possessions is very different from a slave. But they are similar in that both are under rules and regulations. While the heir is a child, he has no control over what will one day be his.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

is like a slave

it is as if he were just a servant/worker

he is under authority like a slave who is under authority

is no better than a slave (RSV)

4:1d

although he is the owner of everything.

- even though he owns everything.
- even if everything that the father possesses/owns will someday be his.

- The son will one day own his father's property, but he does not yet have authority over anything.

although he is the owner of everything: This clause refers to the fact that the child will one day become the owner of his father's property. This will happen when the father chooses to give it to him. The son's status of being like a slave is only temporary. In some languages, it may be more natural to use the future tense here.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

even though he owns everything (GW)

even though everything the father owns/has will someday be his

General Comment on 4:1b–d

In some languages, it is more natural to reorder the clauses of 4:1b–d. For example:

^dThe heir will eventually get all his father's possessions. ^bBut while he is a child, ^che is no different than a slave.

Galatians 4:2

Section 3:26–4:7: A child of God is not a slave of the law

In the previous section, Paul talked about people from a Jewish background. In this section, he returned to focus on the non-Jews whom he had talked about earlier.

This section has two parts. In the first one (3:26 to 3:29), Paul reminded the non-Jewish Christians in Galatia that they had become children of God through faith. When people become children of God, there is no longer a difference between Jew or non-Jew, male or female, slave or free. He further pointed out that once people have become children of God, they are entitled to all the blessings of the new life in Christ.

In the second part (4:1 to 4:7), Paul compared the time under the law to a time of slavery. But when Christ came, he freed people from slavery. The time under the law ended. So believers in Jesus Christ are God's sons. They are not slaves to the law. It is no longer necessary to follow the law.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

By faith we are sons of God and are rescued from the law

You are not slaves but children of God

No longer prisoners to the law but sons

Paragraph 4:1–7

In this paragraph, Paul further explained that the period of the law was temporary. He compared the period under the law to a period of slavery. When Christ came, he redeemed the people who were in slavery. They are no longer slaves. Instead, they are now adopted as God's sons and are his heirs. The time of the law is over.

4:2a

He is subject to guardians and trustees

- He is under the authority of people taking care of him and people in charge of the property
- He must obey those who care for him and the possessions/wealth

There is a contrast between 4:1 and 4:2. The contrast is between the future promise and the present reality. Paul introduced this contrast with a Greek conjunction that most English versions translate as “but.” Some other ways to translate this conjunction are:

Instead

Rather

The BSB has not translated this conjunction, and some other versions, such as the NIV and NLT, also do not translate it. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either. Connect 4:2a to 4:1d in a way that is natural in your language.

He is subject to guardians and trustees: In this clause, Paul clarified how the heir is no different from a slave when he is a child. He is no different because he too is under the authority of other people. (The words guardians and trustees are explained below.)

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

He is placed under the control of guardians and trustees (GW)

He must obey guardians and managers

It is possible to translate the two terms guardians and trustees as one term. For example:

He must obey the people who take care of him

guardians: The Greek word that the BSB translates as guardians refers to people whom the father has appointed to look after his son when he is young. These people have authority to give the son orders.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

men who take care of him (GNT)

people who are in charge of him

protectors

This word is similar to the word translated as “guardian” in 3:24a. But it is a different Greek word.

trustees: The word that the BSB translates as trustees refers to those who are responsible for looking after what the son will inherit.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

men who manage the property

men who are in charge of his possessions/wealth

stewards/administrators

4:2b

until the date set by his father.

- until he reaches the time/day decided by his father.
- until the time comes when he will become the owner. His father decides when that will be.

until the date set by his father: This clause refers to the time when the heir would no longer be under the authority of guardians and managers. His father had decided when that would be. It was at that time that the heir would control the property that belonged to his father.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

until he reaches the age set by his father

until the day that his father has decided for him to receive his possessions

until the time which his father has chosen for him to receive his inheritance (JBP)

Galatians 4:3

Section 3:26–4:7: A child of God is not a slave of the law

In the previous section, Paul talked about people from a Jewish background. In this section, he returned to focus on the non-Jews whom he had talked about earlier.

This section has two parts. In the first one (3:26 to 3:29), Paul reminded the non-Jewish Christians in Galatia that they had become children of God through faith. When people become children of God, there is no longer a difference between Jew or non-Jew, male or female, slave or free. He further pointed out that once people have become children of God, they are entitled to all the blessings of the new life in Christ.

In the second part (4:1 to 4:7), Paul compared the time under the law to a time of slavery. But when Christ came, he freed people from slavery. The time under the law ended. So believers in Jesus Christ are God's sons. They are not slaves to the law. It is no longer necessary to follow the law.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

By faith we are sons of God and are rescued from the law

You are not slaves but children of God

No longer prisoners to the law but sons

Paragraph 4:1–7

In this paragraph, Paul further explained that the period of the law was temporary. He compared the period under the law to a period of slavery. When Christ came, he redeemed the people who were in slavery. They are no longer slaves. Instead, they are now adopted as God's sons and are his heirs. The time of the law is over.

4:3–7

In 4:3–7, Paul explained the meaning of his illustration in 4:1–2. In the same way that a future heir is surrounded by guardians and is like a slave when he is a child, Jewish and Gentile believers had been slaves of sin. God the Father decided the right time to change this situation. This happened when he sent his Son. After God's Son had redeemed us, believers became

sons and received the full inheritance as sons. They were no longer slaves.

4:3a

So also, when we were children,

- It was the same way with us^(incl) also. Previously, we^(incl) were like children and
- It was the same with us too before Christ came. We were like children.

So also, when we were children: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as So also, when we were children introduces Paul's explanation of his illustration in 4:1–2. In his explanation, Paul compared Jewish and Gentile believers to the heir in 4:1–2. He referred to their lives before they believed as a time when they were like children. He compared their lives at that time to the life of an heir when he is a child.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

That is how it was with us. We were like children (CEV)

It is the same for us. We were once like children (NCV)

And that's the way it was with us before Christ came. We were like children (NLT)

we: There are two ways to interpret the pronoun we here:

1. It refers to all believers. It refers to both Jewish and non-Jewish believers and should be an inclusive we.
2. It refers to Jewish believers only and should be an exclusive we.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as the majority of commentators do. Here Paul was no longer talking about Jewish slavery under the law of Moses. He was talking about a more general slavery to the "basic principles of the world" (4:3b).

Also in support of this interpretation is the fact that in 4:9, Paul rebuked the Gentiles for returning to the basic principles of the world. Therefore, the Gentiles must have been included in we who had been slaves to those principles in 4:3b. In 4:4b and 4:5a, Paul mentioned those who are required to obey the law. This might suggest that here in 4:3a Paul was thinking of the Jews only. However, being required to obey the Jewish law is a specific example of living in slavery to religious rules.

4:3b**we were enslaved under the basic principles of the world.**

- were in slavery to the laws and customs of this world.
- We were like slaves to the customs of our ancestors.

Before Jewish and Gentile believers believed in Christ, they were like children. They were the same as slaves who are under the authority of a master.

we were enslaved under: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as we were enslaved under can also be translated as “we were slaves to/of.”

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

we were in slavery under (NIV)

we were slaves to (NLT)

We were...ruled by (CEV)

the basic principles of the world: There are two main ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the basic principles of the world:

1. It refers to the rules, laws, customs, and principles of this world. For example:

the...rules of this world (NCV) (BSB, NIV, ESV, NJB, GW, NLT, NCV, JBP)

1. It refers to spiritual beings. For example:

the ruling spirits of the universe (GNT) (NIV11, RSV, GNT, REB, CEV, NLT96)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

customs and laws in this world

the customs/teachings of our ancestors

Galatians 4:4**Section 3:26–4:7: A child of God is not a slave of the law**

In the previous section, Paul talked about people from a Jewish background. In this section, he returned to

focus on the non-Jews whom he had talked about earlier.

This section has two parts. In the first one (3:26 to 3:29), Paul reminded the non-Jewish Christians in Galatia that they had become children of God through faith. When people become children of God, there is no longer a difference between Jew or non-Jew, male or female, slave or free. He further pointed out that once people have become children of God, they are entitled to all the blessings of the new life in Christ.

In the second part (4:1 to 4:7), Paul compared the time under the law to a time of slavery. But when Christ came, he freed people from slavery. The time under the law ended. So believers in Jesus Christ are God's sons. They are not slaves to the law. It is no longer necessary to follow the law.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

By faith we are sons of God and are rescued from the law

You are not slaves but children of God

No longer prisoners to the law but sons

Paragraph 4:1–7

In this paragraph, Paul further explained that the period of the law was temporary. He compared the period under the law to a period of slavery. When Christ came, he redeemed the people who were in slavery. They are no longer slaves. Instead, they are now adopted as God's sons and are his heirs. The time of the law is over.

4:4a**But when the time had fully come,**

- But when the right time finally came, (GNT)
- Then, when the time/day that God had chosen came/arrived,

But: There is a contrast between 4:3 and 4:4–5. The contrast is between the time when we were under the law and the time when we were redeemed from being under the law. The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction But.

when the time had fully come: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as when the time had fully come refers to the time that God had chosen to end the slavery. God decided when it was the right time for Jesus to come into the world.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

when the right time finally came (GNT)

when God's chosen time arrived

at the time which God had previously decided

4:4b

God sent His Son, born of a woman,

- God sent his Son to earth. He was born of a woman.
- he sent out his Son into the world. A human mother gave birth to him.

God sent His Son: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as sent can also be translated as "sent out." This verb implies that God's Son, Jesus, was with God in heaven. God sent him from heaven to earth at the time he had chosen.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

God sent out his Son (NET)

God sent his Son to come here

God sent his Son into the world (GW)

His Son: See how you translated His Son at 1:16. For further information, see the note on this phrase at 1:16.

born of a woman: The clause born of a woman is an idiom. This idiom indicates that God's Son became a human being.

Some ways to translate this phrase are:

a woman gave birth to him (CEV)

he was born a human being

he became a human being by being born of a woman

4:4c

born under the law,

- He was born under the authority of the law.
- He was born a Jew and followed/obeyed the law of Moses.

born under the law: The clause born under the law means that God's Son, as a human being, was required to obey the law. As a Jewish boy, he was under the authority of the law of Moses.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

born under the authority of the law

he came under the control of God's laws (GW)

His Son obeyed the Law (CEV)

born as a Jew who followed the law of Moses

Galatians 4:5

Section 3:26–4:7: A child of God is not a slave of the law

In the previous section, Paul talked about people from a Jewish background. In this section, he returned to focus on the non-Jews whom he had talked about earlier.

This section has two parts. In the first one (3:26 to 3:29), Paul reminded the non-Jewish Christians in Galatia that they had become children of God through faith. When people become children of God, there is no longer a difference between Jew or non-Jew, male or female, slave or free. He further pointed out that once people have become children of God, they are entitled to all the blessings of the new life in Christ.

In the second part (4:1 to 4:7), Paul compared the time under the law to a time of slavery. But when Christ came, he freed people from slavery. The time under the law ended. So believers in Jesus Christ are God's sons. They are not slaves to the law. It is no longer necessary to follow the law.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

By faith we are sons of God and are rescued from the law

You are not slaves but children of God

No longer prisoners to the law but sons

Paragraph 4:1–7

In this paragraph, Paul further explained that the period of the law was temporary. He compared the period

under the law to a period of slavery. When Christ came, he redeemed the people who were in slavery. They are no longer slaves. Instead, they are now adopted as God's sons and are his heirs. The time of the law is over.

4:5a

to redeem those under the law,

- He came to release/free those who were under the authority of the law
- God sent him to pay for the freedom of us^(incl) who were slaves to the law

to redeem those under the law: This clause states God's purpose for sending his Son to earth. He sent his Son (4:4b)...in order to redeem all his children from the authority of the law (4:5a).

It may be helpful in your language to begin a new sentence here and restate that God sent Jesus, so that it will be clear that this clause expresses God's purpose in doing that. Some ways to translate this clause are:

His Son came to redeem those who were under the authority/control of the law

God sent him to buy freedom for us who were slaves to the law (NLT)

He send his Son as a human being under the law in order to redeem the people who followed/obeyed the law

to redeem: The Greek word that the BSB translates as redeem means "release a prisoner or slave by paying the price (a ransom) necessary to free him." The price that Christ had to pay to release us was to die on the cross for us. God's Son freed us from slavery to the law.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

buy freedom (NLT)

pay for the freedom (GW)

to release/free by becoming a sacrifice

This same word occurs in 3:13a. See also redeem in the Glossary.

those under the law: This clause refers to being under the authority or control of the law. This clause certainly refers to Jews who were required to obey the many commandments in the law of Moses. This clause

may also refer to Gentiles, who also lived under certain religious laws. These laws were like their master. They were like slaves to the law.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

those who were controlled by these laws (GW)

us who were slaves to the law (NLT)

4:5b

that we might receive our adoption as sons.

- so that we^(incl) might be adopted as sons.
- in order that he/God might make us^(incl) his children.

that we might receive our adoption as sons: This clause states the purpose for which Christ redeemed us. He redeemed us (4:5a) so that we might receive our adoption as sons of God (4:5b).

The phrase adoption as sons refers to the fact that God adopts us as his sons/children. We, as believers, receive all the benefits and rights of children of God. We are counted as heirs. We are no longer slaves.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

so that we would be adopted as his children (GW)

so that he could adopt us as his very own children (NLT)

Christ redeemed us so that we would become God's children.

our adoption as sons: The Greek word that the BSB translates as our adoption as sons means that God makes us his spiritual children. The word does not exclude women, so it is better to translate sons as "children."

Some other ways to translate this word are:

we might become God's children (GNT)

made/considered God's children

counted as God's children

Galatians 4:6

Section 3:26–4:7: A child of God is not a slave of the law

In the previous section, Paul talked about people from a Jewish background. In this section, he returned to focus on the non-Jews whom he had talked about earlier.

This section has two parts. In the first one (3:26 to 3:29), Paul reminded the non-Jewish Christians in Galatia that they had become children of God through faith. When people become children of God, there is no longer a difference between Jew or non-Jew, male or female, slave or free. He further pointed out that once people have become children of God, they are entitled to all the blessings of the new life in Christ.

In the second part (4:1 to 4:7), Paul compared the time under the law to a time of slavery. But when Christ came, he freed people from slavery. The time under the law ended. So believers in Jesus Christ are God's sons. They are not slaves to the law. It is no longer necessary to follow the law.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

By faith we are sons of God and are rescued from the law

You are not slaves but children of God

No longer prisoners to the law but sons

Paragraph 4:1–7

In this paragraph, Paul further explained that the period of the law was temporary. He compared the period under the law to a period of slavery. When Christ came, he redeemed the people who were in slavery. They are no longer slaves. Instead, they are now adopted as God's sons and are his heirs. The time of the law is over.

4:6a

And because you are sons,

- Because you^(plur) are sons,
- And now that we^(incl) are his children,

And: Verse 4:6 is an additional point in Paul's discussion about being sons of God. The BSB connects this verse to the previous verse with the conjunction And.

Some English versions do not begin this sentence with such a conjunction. In some languages, it will not be

necessary to begin this sentence with such a conjunction either.

because you are sons: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as because:

1. It means because. According to this interpretation, this word is a conjunction and introduces the reason why God has given us the Spirit. Paul is saying that because we are his children, God has given us the Spirit. Elsewhere in his writings, "Paul has argued from his converts' reception of the Spirit (3:2–5, 14b) to their being "sons of God" (3:26), which is also the order of his presentation in Rom 8:15–17. Here, however, that relationship seems to be reversed in saying 'because you are sons, God sent the Spirit of his son into your hearts' (4:6)...The argument as to whether the proper order is first sonship and then the gift of the Spirit, or first the reception of the Spirit and then sonship, has been fervent and heated....Clearly, *ὅτι* here is causal (because, since)...Paul is not here setting out stages in the Christian life, whether logical or chronological. Rather his emphasis is on the reciprocal relation or correlational nature of sonship and the reception of the Spirit" (Longenecker, p. 173). For example:

Because you are sons (NIV) (BSB, ESV, NIV, NET, RSV, KJV, NASB, GW, NLT, NCV, JBP)

1. It means that. According to this interpretation, God gives us his Spirit, and that confirms that we are his children. So this verse should read, "That which shows that we are his children is that God gave us the Spirit." For example:

To show that you are his children (GNT) (GNT, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Most English versions follow this interpretation.

Another way to translate this clause is:

Now that you are sons

you: Paul used the pronoun you to address the Galatians directly. He then changed to the pronoun "our" in 4:6b to focus on the fact that all believers are sons and have the Spirit. In some languages, it may not be natural to change pronouns in this way. If that is true in your language, you may use the pronoun "we" here. For example:

And because we are his children, God has sent the Spirit of his Son into our hearts (NLT)

4:6b

God sent the Spirit of His Son into our hearts,

- God sent the Spirit of his Son to live/stay in our hearts,
- God has sent the Spirit of his Son, the Holy Spirit, to live in us.

God sent: The Greek verb that the BSB here translates as sent is the same Greek word as in 4:4b.

Another way to translate this is:

God gave us

the Spirit of His Son: The phrase the Spirit of His Son refers to the Holy Spirit. In other passages, he is also called “the Spirit of God” and “the Spirit of Christ.” Your word for the Spirit of His Son must make it clear that this is the Holy Spirit, the third person of the Trinity.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the Spirit of his Son, that is, the Holy Spirit

the Holy Spirit, the Spirit that his Son promised

See Spirit in the Glossary.

into our hearts: The word that the BSB translates as hearts refers to the inner being of a person. It is who we are as a person.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

to live in our hearts/minds

to stay in us

to be with us

Many languages use a different part of the body such as “liver,” “kidney,” “intestines,” or “mind” to refer to the inner being of a person.

4:6c

crying out, “Abba, Father!”

- enabling us to call out “Abba, Father.”
- It is the Spirit who says, “Abba” which means “Father.”

crying out: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as crying out refers to earnest, intense “calling out.” It describes what the Holy Spirit does in our hearts. He enables us to call God “Father.” It does not refer to weeping.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

It’s the Spirit living in us who urgently calls out

The Spirit enables us to say

“Abba, Father!”: The word Abba is the Aramaic word that means Father. Jesus called God “Abba.” Jesus is God’s Son. Now we are God’s sons, so we too can call him “Abba.” Before Christ came, people did not address God as “Father.”

Some ways to translate these words are:

- Transliterate the word “Abba” and use the word for “Father” in your language. This is what many English versions do. For example:

Abba, Father If you choose this option, you may want to include a footnote explaining that “Abba” means “Father” in Aramaic.

- Transliterate the word “Abba” and then explain that it means “Father.” For example:

“Abba,” which means Father.

- Use only one term. Either transliterate “Abba” or use your word for “Father.” For example:

Abba

Father (NCV)

If the word “Abba” is already a word in your language that means something else, you should not transliterate that word.

Galatians 4:7

Section 3:26–4:7: A child of God is not a slave of the law

In the previous section, Paul talked about people from a Jewish background. In this section, he returned to focus on the non-Jews whom he had talked about earlier.

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In the second part (4:1 to 4:7), Paul compared the time under the law to a time of slavery. But when Christ came, he freed people from slavery. The time under the law ended. So believers in Jesus Christ are God's sons. They are not slaves to the law. It is no longer necessary to follow the law.

Some other examples for a heading for this section are:

By faith we are sons of God and are rescued from the law

You are not slaves but children of God

No longer prisoners to the law but sons

Paragraph 4:1–7

In this paragraph, Paul further explained that the period of the law was temporary. He compared the period under the law to a period of slavery. When Christ came, he redeemed the people who were in slavery. They are no longer slaves. Instead, they are now adopted as God's sons and are his heirs. The time of the law is over.

4:7a

So you are no longer a slave, but a son;

- Therefore, you^(sing) are no longer a slave but rather a son.
- So then we^(incl) are not slaves any more. Instead, we are sons.

So: Verse 4:7 is the conclusion of this paragraph: Believers are no longer slaves, but are sons and heirs. The Greek introduces this conclusion with a conjunction that the BSB translates as So.

Some other ways to connect this verse are:

Therefore (NASB)

So then

you are no longer a slave, but a son: In this clause Paul stated that the believer's status has changed. The believer is no longer a slave to the law. He is a son.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

You are no longer a slave but instead you are a child of God

You are not a slave anymore, rather you are a son

You are a son. You are no longer a slave.

you: In Greek, the pronoun you is singular. This form emphasizes that each believer is a son. In some languages, it may be more natural to use "we" or "you" plural. For example:

we are no longer slaves

you^(plur) are no longer slaves

4:7b

and since you are a son, you are also an heir through God.

- And since you^(sing) are a son/child of God, he has made you^(sing) his heir.
- And now that God has made us^(incl) his sons, we will receive everything that he promised.

and: The conjunction and introduces a second part of the conclusion. Not only are believers sons, they are also heirs.

Some other ways to connect this clause are:

also

So

since you are a son, you are also an heir through God:

This sentence declares a truth and the consequence of that truth. The truth is that we are sons. There is no doubt about that. The consequence of that truth is that we are also heirs.

Some other ways to translate this sentence are:

since you are his child, God has made you his heir (NLT)

because you are a son/child, God has made you his heir

an heir through God: The phrase an heir through God indicates that God is the one who made you his heir.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

God has made you his heir (NLT)

everything he has belongs to you (NLT96)

heir: This is the same word that Paul used in 3:29c. It refers to those who will receive an inheritance.

Some ways to translate this word are:

one who receives the inheritance

the person who receives the blessing

Galatians 4:8

Section 4:8–20: Paul begged the Galatians not to turn away from the true gospel

In this section, Paul again rebuked the Galatians for turning to the law and turning away from the true gospel. He begged them to change their thinking and their actions. He said that turning to the law put them back into the slavery that they were in before they knew Christ. He equated obeying the law with paganism. This is a startling and shocking comparison.

Paul appealed to the Galatians on the basis of the emotional bond between him and them. He reminded them of how that bond had developed and that it had resulted in their full acceptance of the true gospel. But now their turning away from the true gospel had perplexed him. He said that they were now like enemies because they followed the false teachers and had turned away from the true gospel.

But the false teachers were the real enemies. For selfish reasons, they taught the Galatians to add something to their faith. They taught them to obey the law. They were not working for the good of the Galatians.

Some possible headings for this section are:

The folly of turning to the law

Paul's concern for the Galatians

Paragraph 4:8–11

In Greek this paragraph begins with a conjunction that introduces a contrast. The contrast is between the Galatians' position as adopted sons in the family of God and their pre-Christian past. Some ways to begin this paragraph are:

But

However, (NASB)

Many English versions, including the BSB, do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate it either.

4:8a

Formerly, when you did not know God,

- ¶ But in the past, when you^(plur) did not yet know God,
- ¶ Before you knew God, (CEV)

Formerly, when you did not know God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Formerly also means “then” or “back then.” This word, together with the clause when you did not know God, refers to the time before the Galatians were believers.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

In the past, before you knew God

Back then, when you did not know God

4:8b

you were slaves to those who by nature are not gods.

- you^(plur) were slaves of idols/spirits which are not really/truly God.
- you^(plur) served things that should not be worshiped.

you were slaves to: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as you were slaves to can also be translated as “you were slaves of.” Paul reminded the Galatians that before they believed in Christ, they were not free. They were like slaves.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

it was as if you were in slavery to

you were controlled by

you served

those who by nature are not gods: This clause refers to:

- The idols that the Galatians worshiped. In the books of Romans and 1 Corinthians, Paul taught that idols in themselves are not gods/spirits. Their nature is wood and stone, and men carve them.
- The spirits/beings that the Galatians worshiped. These spirits are fallen angels or demons, and their nature is evil. They are false gods. They do not merit worship.

Some challenges in translating this verse are:

- In some languages, the word for “idols/fetishes” is the same as the word for gods. So it is not possible to say that these things are not really gods when people can see them. If that is true in your language, you may need to translate this as:

idols that should not be worshiped

- In others languages, the word “God” cannot be made plural. If that is true in your language, you may need to translate this as:

those spirits/idols that are not God

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

things which are really not gods at all (GW)

things/beings that are only false gods

by nature: The Greek word that the BSB translates as by nature means “has the character of.”

Another way to translate this word is:

really/truly

Galatians 4:9

Section 4:8–20: Paul begged the Galatians not to turn away from the true gospel

In this section, Paul again rebuked the Galatians for turning to the law and turning away from the true gospel. He begged them to change their thinking and their actions. He said that turning to the law put them back into the slavery that they were in before they knew Christ. He equated obeying the law with paganism. This is a startling and shocking comparison.

Paul appealed to the Galatians on the basis of the emotional bond between him and them. He reminded

them of how that bond had developed and that it had resulted in their full acceptance of the true gospel. But now their turning away from the true gospel had perplexed him. He said that they were now like enemies because they followed the false teachers and had turned away from the true gospel.

But the false teachers were the real enemies. For selfish reasons, they taught the Galatians to add something to their faith. They taught them to obey the law. They were not working for the good of the Galatians.

Some possible headings for this section are:

The folly of turning to the law

Paul’s concern for the Galatians

Paragraph 4:8–11

In Greek this paragraph begins with a conjunction that introduces a contrast. The contrast is between the Galatians’ position as adopted sons in the family of God and their pre-Christian past. Some ways to begin this paragraph are:

But

However, (NASB)

Many English versions, including the BSB, do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate it either.

4:9a

But now that you know God,

- But now you^(plur) know God,
- However, at this time you know God.

But: There is a contrast between 4:8 and 4:9. The contrast is between not knowing God (4:8a) and knowing God. The BSB introduces this contrast with the conjunction But.

Another way to translate this is:

However

now that you know God: This clause indicates that these Galatians had become believers.

Another way to translate this clause is:

now that you have come to know God (ESV)

4:9b**or rather are known by God,**

- or, I should say, you^(plur) are known by God.
- Actually, it is God who knows you.

or rather: The Greek word that the BSB translates as or rather indicates that Paul wanted to clarify what he had just said.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

or, I should say (GNT)

or better still (CEV)

actually

are known by God: The verb are known is a passive verb. Some other ways to translate this clause are:

- As a passive. For example:

are known of God (KJV)

- As an active. For example:

God knows you (GNT)

4:9c**how is it that you are turning back to those weak and worthless principles?**

- So why are you^(plur) returning again to obey those laws and customs of this world that are weak and useless?
- You should not turn back and start again to obey the customs of our ancestors. They have no power to save you and no value.

how is it that you are turning back to those weak and worthless principles?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used this question to rebuke the Galatians strongly. He indicated that when the Galatians obey the laws of Moses such as circumcision, it was the same as returning to the pagan religion of their former lives. This was a startling and shocking statement.

Some ways to translate this rhetorical question are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

why are you turning back to those weak and worthless elementary principles again?

- As statement followed by a question. For example:

surely you do not wish to turn back and obey those weak and worthless elementary principles, do you?

- As a statement. For example:

I am shocked that you should turn back to obey/follow those weak and worthless rules and laws. You should never do that!

Use whichever form is most natural in your language to express a rebuke.

are turning back: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as are turning back indicates that the Galatians were returning to their pagan ways. They were abandoning the gospel and starting to follow the laws of Moses. It was the same as returning to customs that they previously obeyed before they became believers.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

return to follow/obey

turn back and become the slaves (CEV)

those weak and worthless principles: The adjectives weak and worthless indicate that the weak and worthless principles have no power to save us and are of no value.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as principles refers to the rules, laws, customs, and principles of this world. It is the same Greek word that was used in 4:3b. You should translate here as you did there.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

customs and law in this world that are weak and useless

those weak and useless rules (NCV)

those customs/teaching of our ancestors that have no power to save people and have no value

4:9d**Do you wish to be enslaved by them all over again?**

- Why do you^(plur) want to be slaves of them again?
- You are becoming their slaves again.

Do you wish to be enslaved by them all over again?:

This is a second rhetorical question, after the one in 4:9c. It continues Paul's rebuke of the Galatians.

In Greek, 4:9c and 4:9d are part of the same sentence. Some ways to translate the rhetorical question here in 4:9d are:

- As a separate rhetorical question. For example:

Why do you want to become their slaves all over again? (GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

When you do that, you are enslaving yourselves to them all over again.

You are becoming their slaves again!

Use whichever form is most natural in your language to express a rebuke.

Galatians 4:10**Section 4:8–20: Paul begged the Galatians not to turn away from the true gospel**

In this section, Paul again rebuked the Galatians for turning to the law and turning away from the true gospel. He begged them to change their thinking and their actions. He said that turning to the law put them back into the slavery that they were in before they knew Christ. He equated obeying the law with paganism. This is a startling and shocking comparison.

Paul appealed to the Galatians on the basis of the emotional bond between him and them. He reminded them of how that bond had developed and that it had resulted in their full acceptance of the true gospel. But now their turning away from the true gospel had perplexed him. He said that they were now like enemies because they followed the false teachers and had turned away from the true gospel.

But the false teachers were the real enemies. For selfish reasons, they taught the Galatians to add something to their faith. They taught them to obey the law. They were not working for the good of the Galatians.

Some possible headings for this section are:

The folly of turning to the law

Paul's concern for the Galatians

Paragraph 4:8–11

In Greek this paragraph begins with a conjunction that introduces a contrast. The contrast is between the Galatians' position as adopted sons in the family of God and their pre-Christian past. Some ways to begin this paragraph are:

But

However, (NASB)

Many English versions, including the BSB, do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate it either.

4:10**You are observing special days and months and seasons and years!**

- You^(plur) celebrate Jewish festivals such as special days, months, seasons, and years!
- When you observe special Jewish days, months, seasons, and years, then you are becoming slaves again!

You are observing special days and months and seasons and years: This clause tells how the Galatians were enslaving themselves. They were celebrating festivals in the Jewish calendar as a way to be made right with God.

The word days probably refers to keeping the Sabbath. The word months could refer to the monthly new moon celebration. The word seasons could refer to the various Jewish festivals throughout the year such as Passover. The word years may refer to the sabbatical years or the year of Jubilee.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

You are celebrating the Jewish festivals, which include the days, the months, the seasons, and the years, as if you could earn your salvation by doing this!

When you observe Jewish festivals, the days, the months, the season, and the years, then you are becoming slaves again!

Why do you observe days, months, seasons, and years commanded by the law?

When the Galatians started to follow the law of Moses in order to be made right with God, they were required

to celebrate these festivals. Paul confronted the Galatians with the foolishness of what they were doing.

Galatians 4:11

Section 4:8–20: Paul begged the Galatians not to turn away from the true gospel

In this section, Paul again rebuked the Galatians for turning to the law and turning away from the true gospel. He begged them to change their thinking and their actions. He said that turning to the law put them back into the slavery that they were in before they knew Christ. He equated obeying the law with paganism. This is a startling and shocking comparison.

Paul appealed to the Galatians on the basis of the emotional bond between him and them. He reminded them of how that bond had developed and that it had resulted in their full acceptance of the true gospel. But now their turning away from the true gospel had perplexed him. He said that they were now like enemies because they followed the false teachers and had turned away from the true gospel.

But the false teachers were the real enemies. For selfish reasons, they taught the Galatians to add something to their faith. They taught them to obey the law. They were not working for the good of the Galatians.

Some possible headings for this section are:

The folly of turning to the law

Paul's concern for the Galatians

Paragraph 4:8–11

In Greek this paragraph begins with a conjunction that introduces a contrast. The contrast is between the Galatians' position as adopted sons in the family of God and their pre-Christian past. Some ways to begin this paragraph are:

But

However, (NASB)

Many English versions, including the BSB, do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate it either.

4:11

I fear for you, that my efforts for you may have been in vain.

- I am afraid for you that all my work/ministry among you^(plur) has been wasted.
- I am worried that all the work that I did teaching you was useless.

I fear for you, that my efforts for you may have been in vain:

The Greek clause that the BSB translates as my efforts for you refers to the hard work that Paul did in teaching the gospel to the Galatians. Paul was afraid that all his efforts may not have produced the results that he wished.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I am afraid that all my hard work of teaching you has been wasted.

I fear for you. I am afraid that all my hard work for you was worth nothing. (NLT96)

I am worried about you! Can it be that all my work for you has been for nothing? (GNT)

Be careful that the word for labor/work does not imply physical labor. If it does, you may have to translate it with another expression. For example:

I am worried that all that I have done for you is in vain.

I am concerned that all the teaching I gave you has not achieved/accomplished anything.

Galatians 4:12

Section 4:8–20: Paul begged the Galatians not to turn away from the true gospel

In this section, Paul again rebuked the Galatians for turning to the law and turning away from the true gospel. He begged them to change their thinking and their actions. He said that turning to the law put them back into the slavery that they were in before they knew Christ. He equated obeying the law with paganism. This is a startling and shocking comparison.

Paul appealed to the Galatians on the basis of the emotional bond between him and them. He reminded them of how that bond had developed and that it had resulted in their full acceptance of the true gospel. But now their turning away from the true gospel had perplexed him. He said that they were now like enemies because they followed the false teachers and had turned away from the true gospel.

But the false teachers were the real enemies. For selfish reasons, they taught the Galatians to add something to their faith. They taught them to obey the law. They were not working for the good of the Galatians.

Some possible headings for this section are:

The folly of turning to the law

Paul's concern for the Galatians

4:12a

I beg you, brothers, become like me,

- ¶ Brothers, I beg you, be as I am,
- ¶ My friends, I plead with you to do as I do and not be slaves to the law,
- ¶ My fellow believers, please follow my example.

I beg you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as beg means “entreat” or “plead.” Paul used this word to strongly request the Galatians to do what he wanted them to do.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I urge you (NKJV)

I plead with you (NIV)

I urgently ask you

Please

brothers: The word brothers refers to fellow believers. It includes both men and women. It shows Paul's love and respect for the Galatian believers. He used this word to get their attention.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

My dear fellow believers

Friends (NRSV)

become like me: This clause states what Paul wanted the Galatians to do. He wanted them to be like him. Paul was no longer a slave to the law. Instead, he had freedom in Christ. He wanted them to be free, as he was.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

be as I am

follow my example

live as I do in freedom from these things (NLT)

do as I do and live free from the law

4:12b

for I became like you.

- because I became like you^(plur) were.
- I became like you were and am free from the law.

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for introduces the basis for the command “become as I am.” Some other ways to translate this conjunction are:

because (NET)

I say this for this reason

In some languages, it will be more natural to state the basis of the command before the command. For example:

I became like you, so I beg you to become like me. (NCV)

I became like you: Paul became like the Galatians in the sense that he became free from slavery to the law of Moses. This happened when he met Christ and was converted.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I have become like you Gentiles (NLT)

I became like you were (GW)

I have become like you Gentiles were—free from the law (NLT96)

4:12c

You have done me no wrong.

- You^(plur) did not do anything bad to me.
- You^(plur) did not cause me to suffer.
- When I first came to you, you^(plur) treated me well.

You have done me no wrong: This clause means that the Galatians had not done anything bad to Paul in the

past. They had not harmed him or caused him trouble. It refers to the time when he first preached the gospel to the Galatians. They showed much love for him.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

You did not cause me to suffer

You did not mistreat me when I first preached to you. (NLT)

You were very good to me before. (NCV)

Galatians 4:13

Section 4:8–20: Paul begged the Galatians not to turn away from the true gospel

In this section, Paul again rebuked the Galatians for turning to the law and turning away from the true gospel. He begged them to change their thinking and their actions. He said that turning to the law put them back into the slavery that they were in before they knew Christ. He equated obeying the law with paganism. This is a startling and shocking comparison.

Paul appealed to the Galatians on the basis of the emotional bond between him and them. He reminded them of how that bond had developed and that it had resulted in their full acceptance of the true gospel. But now their turning away from the true gospel had perplexed him. He said that they were now like enemies because they followed the false teachers and had turned away from the true gospel.

But the false teachers were the real enemies. For selfish reasons, they taught the Galatians to add something to their faith. They taught them to obey the law. They were not working for the good of the Galatians.

Some possible headings for this section are:

The folly of turning to the law

Paul's concern for the Galatians

4:13

You know that it was because of an illness that I first preached the gospel to you.

- You^(plur) know that it was because of an illness that I stayed with you the first time and preached the gospel to you.
- You know that the first time that I preached to you the good news, I had come to you because I was sick.

You know: The clause You know indicates that Paul was going to tell the Galatians something that they already knew. It does not imply that they had forgotten it. It implies that Paul wanted to remind them of it.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

You remember (NCV)

I want to remind you of what you already know

it was because of an illness: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as an illness refers to some physical difficulty that Paul had. He may have been sick, but he did not mention the exact illness. Paul may have intended to go to another place, but because of his illness he was forced to stop in Galatia. According to Fung (p. 196), the emphatic position of the phrase “because of an illness” “suggests that Paul’s original plan had been to go elsewhere (perhaps westward toward Ephesus) and that his missionary visit to the Galatians was due solely to his illness and his need for recuperation.” While there, he preached the gospel.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

You remember that it was because of an illness (NCV)

You know how sick I was and for that reason

You know that I came to you because I was sick

I first preached the gospel to you: In this clause Paul stated that as a result of his physical difficulty, he had the opportunity to preach the gospel among the Galatians.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I declared to you the Good News the first time

I first told you the message of the gospel

See also gospel in the Glossary.

Galatians 4:14

Section 4:8–20: Paul begged the Galatians not to turn away from the true gospel

In this section, Paul again rebuked the Galatians for turning to the law and turning away from the true gospel. He begged them to change their thinking and

their actions. He said that turning to the law put them back into the slavery that they were in before they knew Christ. He equated obeying the law with paganism. This is a startling and shocking comparison.

Paul appealed to the Galatians on the basis of the emotional bond between him and them. He reminded them of how that bond had developed and that it had resulted in their full acceptance of the true gospel. But now their turning away from the true gospel had perplexed him. He said that they were now like enemies because they followed the false teachers and had turned away from the true gospel.

But the false teachers were the real enemies. For selfish reasons, they taught the Galatians to add something to their faith. They taught them to obey the law. They were not working for the good of the Galatians.

Some possible headings for this section are:

The folly of turning to the law

Paul's concern for the Galatians

4:14a-b

although my illness was a trial to you, you did not despise or reject me: The word *although* introduces the first clause in a pair of clauses, and it indicates that the second clause is unexpected. This logical relationship has traditionally been called “concession-contraexpectation.” The unexpected clause is 4:14b.

Some ways to translate this pair of clauses are:

- Indicate in the first clause that an unexpected clause is coming. For example:

^a even though my illness was a trial to you, ^byou did not treat me with contempt or scorn (NIV)

- Indicate in that second clause that it is unexpected. For example:

^amy condition was a trial to you, but ^bin spite of that, you did not scorn or despise me

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

^byou did not scorn or despise me, ^aeven though my condition was a trial to you

The individual parts of these two clauses are explained below.

4:14a

And although my illness was a trial to you,

- And even though my illness was difficult for you^(plur),
- My sickness was hard on you.

my illness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *illness* refers to Paul's condition. This same word also occurs in 4:13.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

my condition (ESV)

my sickness (NCV)

was a trial to you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *trial* means hardship or difficulty. Paul's difficult illness could have led the Galatians to reject Paul and his message, but instead they developed a close relationship with him.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

was a trouble for you (NCV)

was a hardship for you

was difficult for you (GW)

4:14b

you did not despise or reject me.

- you did not reject me and refuse to receive me.
- In spite of that, you^(plur) did not look down on me or despise me.

you did not despise or reject me: The words *despise* and *reject* are a doublet. This means that these words are similar in meaning. The word *despise* means “loathe someone,” “be disgusted by someone” or “reject someone.” The word *reject* means “dismiss someone as inadequate” or “dismiss someone because they do not meet a certain standard.”

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

you did not treat me with contempt or scorn (NIV)

you did not look down on me or be disgusted/repulsed

you didn't hate me or turn me away (CEV)

4:14c

Instead, you welcomed me as if I were an angel of God,

- You^(plur) welcomed me as if I were a messenger from God,
- Rather, you^(plur) received me in the same way that you would receive one of God's angels.

Instead: There is a contrast between 4:14b and 4:14c. The contrast is between the negative way that the Galatians could have treated Paul and the positive way that they actually did treat him. Languages have different ways to indicate this negative-positive type of contrast. Some of the ways are:

- With the conjunction "but."
- With a conjunction other than "but." This is a common way in English to show this type of contrast. For example:

rather

on the contrary

Instead (BSB, NIV)

- With no conjunction. For example:

^byou didn't hate me or turn me away because of it.
^cYou welcomed me as though I were one of God's angels or even Christ Jesus himself. (CEV)

you welcomed me as if I were an angel of God:

The verb that the BSB translates as welcomed means "received." In this clause Paul stated that the Galatians welcomed him with great honor and respect. He compared the welcome they gave him to the welcome they might give to a messenger from heaven.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

You welcomed me as though I were one of God's angels (CEV)

you took me in and cared for me as though I were an angel from God (NLT)

angel of God: The word angel means "messenger." It can be either a human messenger or a divine messenger.

The phrase of God shows that here it refers to a divine messenger. It is a spirit being who serves God.

Some ways to translate angel of God are:

messenger of/from God

holy/good spirit-being from God

The word angel first occurs in 1:8a. See also angel in the Glossary for more information.

4:14d

as if I were Christ Jesus Himself.

- or/and as if I were Christ Jesus himself.
- You received me in the same way that you would receive Jesus the Christ himself.

as if I were Christ Jesus Himself: The words "you welcomed me" from 4:14c are implied here. Paul said that his welcome could also be compared to the way the Galatians would welcome Jesus Christ.

Some ways to translate this comparison are:

as though I were Christ Jesus himself (NET)

You received me in the same way that you would have received Jesus Christ himself.

Your translation should not imply that Paul thought of himself as equal to an angel of God or to Jesus Christ.

Christ Jesus Himself: The BSB translates the phrase Christ Jesus Himself in the same order as in Greek. Remember that Christ is a title, and Jesus is a name.

Another way to translate this phrase is:

Jesus the Christ/Messiah

Galatians 4:15

Section 4:8–20: Paul begged the Galatians not to turn away from the true gospel

In this section, Paul again rebuked the Galatians for turning to the law and turning away from the true gospel. He begged them to change their thinking and their actions. He said that turning to the law put them back into the slavery that they were in before they knew Christ. He equated obeying the law with paganism. This is a startling and shocking comparison.

Paul appealed to the Galatians on the basis of the emotional bond between him and them. He reminded

them of how that bond had developed and that it had resulted in their full acceptance of the true gospel. But now their turning away from the true gospel had perplexed him. He said that they were now like enemies because they followed the false teachers and had turned away from the true gospel.

But the false teachers were the real enemies. For selfish reasons, they taught the Galatians to add something to their faith. They taught them to obey the law. They were not working for the good of the Galatians.

Some possible headings for this section are:

The folly of turning to the law

Paul's concern for the Galatians

4:15a

What then has become of your blessing?

- What has happened to all your joy? (NIV)
- Your hearts were full of joy then. What happened?
- But you have lost the joy/happiness that you once had.

What then has become of your blessing?: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as then introduces a conclusion in the form of a rhetorical question. This conclusion is based on some implied information. The following chart shows the implied information:

4:14c-d	You joyfully received me
implied	but now you would not do that
4:15a	So, you have lost your joy. What has become of it?

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. For example:

What has happened to all your joy? (NIV)

In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either. Connect 4:15a to 4:14d in a way that is natural in your language.

What...has become of your blessing?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used this rhetorical question to encourage the Galatians to think about their present situation. They had been joyful when they first heard the gospel, but their joy had disappeared.

Some ways to translate this question are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

What has happened to all your joy? (NIV)

- As a statement, followed by a question. For example:

You were very happy then, but where is that joy now? (NCV)

You were so happy! What has happened? (GNT)

- As a statement. For example:

Consider this: you have lost the joy that you once had.

In some languages, it is more natural to put this rhetorical question after 4:15c. See the General Comment below under 4:15c for examples.

blessing: The Greek word that the BSB translates as blessing refers to the state of well-being that results from having a right relationship with God.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

joy (NIV)

happiness (NET)

See bless, Meaning 2 in the Glossary for more information.

4:15b

For I can testify that, if it were possible,

- For I am a witness that, if it had been possible,
- I know that you^(plur) loved me so much that, if you could have done it,

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces some more information. It is background information about the joy/blessedness that the Galatians felt when Paul first preached to them.

Another way to show what 4:15b is talking about is to put it before 4:15a. See the General Comment below under 4:15c for an example.

I can testify that: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as I can testify means “I am a witness.” Paul used it to introduce a statement that demonstrates the joy and love that the Galatians had for him.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

I am a witness that

I know (NLT96)

I am sure that (CEV)

4:15c

you would have torn out your eyes and given them to me.

- you^(plur) would even have pulled out your eyes and given them to me.
- you would have removed your own eyes and given them to me.

you would have torn out your eyes and given them to me: The clause torn out your eyes means “removed your eyes” or “taken out your eyes.” Paul used this expression to refer to the extreme acts that the Galatians would have done to provide for his needs. They would have sacrificed anything, even giving him their own eyes, if it could have helped him. Paul used this expression to remind the Galatians of the deep love they had for him. A few commentators say that this clause indicates that Paul’s physical problem was an eye disease. This is not an issue for the translator to decide. The translation should remain neutral on this issue.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

you would have pulled out your eyes and given them to me (NET)

you would have taken out your own eyes and given them to me to show how much you loved me

General Comment on 4:14–15

In some languages, 4:15 will better connect to 4:14 if 4:15a is put after 4:15b–c. For example:

^{14b}you did not scorn or despise me, ^{14c}but you received me as if I were an angel of God, ^{14d}You received me as if I were Christ Jesus. ^{15b}I testify to you that, if possible, ^{15c}you would have gouged out your eyes and given them to me. ^{15a}What then has become of the joy you felt?

Galatians 4:16

Section 4:8–20: Paul begged the Galatians not to turn away from the true gospel

In this section, Paul again rebuked the Galatians for turning to the law and turning away from the true gospel. He begged them to change their thinking and their actions. He said that turning to the law put them

back into the slavery that they were in before they knew Christ. He equated obeying the law with paganism. This is a startling and shocking comparison.

Paul appealed to the Galatians on the basis of the emotional bond between him and them. He reminded them of how that bond had developed and that it had resulted in their full acceptance of the true gospel. But now their turning away from the true gospel had perplexed him. He said that they were now like enemies because they followed the false teachers and had turned away from the true gospel.

But the false teachers were the real enemies. For selfish reasons, they taught the Galatians to add something to their faith. They taught them to obey the law. They were not working for the good of the Galatians.

Some possible headings for this section are:

The folly of turning to the law

Paul’s concern for the Galatians

4:16

Have I now become your enemy by telling you the truth?

- Can it be that I have become your enemy for telling you the truth? (GW)
- So then, I am amazed that I have now become your^(plur) enemy because I told you the truth!

Have I now become your enemy by telling you the truth?: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as now introduces a conclusion in the form of a rhetorical question. This conclusion is based on 4:14–15. Another way to translate this conjunction is:

So then, have I become your enemy by telling you the truth? (NET)

Have I...become your enemy by telling you the truth?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used this rhetorical question to show the Galatians his disappointment and disbelief. From the beginning, he had told them the truth, and they treated him as their friend. But when they later rejected the true gospel that he taught and turned to a false gospel, they rejected him and his message. So, in effect, they considered Paul to be their enemy.

Some ways to translate this are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Can it be that I have become your enemy for telling you the truth? (GW)

So you now consider me to be your enemy because of that same truth I told you then?

- As a statement. For example:

I cannot believe that I have now become your enemy by telling that truth.

by telling you the truth: From the beginning, Paul had taught the true gospel to the Galatians. This was in contrast to the false teaching that they heard from the false teachers.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

by telling you the true gospel

because I spoke the truth to you

for telling you the truth

Galatians 4:17

Section 4:8–20: Paul begged the Galatians not to turn away from the true gospel

In this section, Paul again rebuked the Galatians for turning to the law and turning away from the true gospel. He begged them to change their thinking and their actions. He said that turning to the law put them back into the slavery that they were in before they knew Christ. He equated obeying the law with paganism. This is a startling and shocking comparison.

Paul appealed to the Galatians on the basis of the emotional bond between him and them. He reminded them of how that bond had developed and that it had resulted in their full acceptance of the true gospel. But now their turning away from the true gospel had perplexed him. He said that they were now like enemies because they followed the false teachers and had turned away from the true gospel.

But the false teachers were the real enemies. For selfish reasons, they taught the Galatians to add something to their faith. They taught them to obey the law. They were not working for the good of the Galatians.

Some possible headings for this section are:

The folly of turning to the law

Paul's concern for the Galatians

4:17a

Those people are zealous for you, but not in a good way.

- Those people show concern for you^(plur), but their intentions/motives are not good.
- Those false teachers show/have interest in you, but what they are doing is not good.

Those people: The phrase Those people refers to the false teachers. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this more explicit. For example:

those false teachers (NLT)

those people who want you to obey the Jewish law

are zealous for you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as are zealous for you means “are deeply concerned about” or “show a great interest in.” It refers to the attitude that the false teachers had toward the Galatians. They seemed to care about them, but in reality they did not care about them.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

show a deep interest in you (GNT)

show concern for you

appear to want to help you

behave as if they are devoted to you

but not in a good way: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as not in a good way refers to the intentions of the false teachers. Their intentions/motives were not good. They wanted the Galatians to accept the law. This would have made them slaves to the law. It would not have been good for them.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

but their intentions are not good (GNT)

but their motives are not good

but it isn't for your good (CEV)

but it will not really help you

4:17b

Instead, they want to isolate you from us,

- They want to separate you^(plur) from me
- They don't want you to associate with me (GW)

they want to isolate you from us: This clause means that the false teachers wanted to separate the Galatians from Paul and his co-workers. In this clause Paul stated what the false teachers were really doing in contrast to what they appeared to be doing.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

They only want to keep you away from me (CEV)

They don't want you to associate with me (GW)

all they want is to separate you from me (GNT)

4:17c

so that you may be zealous for them.

- so that you^(plur) will show concern for them.
- so that you will show/have interest in them.

so that you may be zealous for them: This clause states the purpose for 4:17a-b.

The false teachers make much of you (4:17a) and want to shut you out (4:17b), so that you may be zealous for them (4:17c).

The Greek word that the BSB translates as be zealous for is the same word as in 4:17a. If possible, you should use the same expression here. This word indicates that the false teachers wanted the Galatians to accept their teaching and thus honor them and be devoted to them.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

in order that you will show a great interest in them

so that you show concern for them

so that you help them

so that you will be devoted to them

Galatians 4:18

Section 4:8–20: Paul begged the Galatians not to turn away from the true gospel

In this section, Paul again rebuked the Galatians for turning to the law and turning away from the true gospel. He begged them to change their thinking and their actions. He said that turning to the law put them back into the slavery that they were in before they knew Christ. He equated obeying the law with paganism. This is a startling and shocking comparison.

Paul appealed to the Galatians on the basis of the emotional bond between him and them. He reminded them of how that bond had developed and that it had resulted in their full acceptance of the true gospel. But now their turning away from the true gospel had perplexed him. He said that they were now like enemies because they followed the false teachers and had turned away from the true gospel.

But the false teachers were the real enemies. For selfish reasons, they taught the Galatians to add something to their faith. They taught them to obey the law. They were not working for the good of the Galatians.

Some possible headings for this section are:

The folly of turning to the law

Paul's concern for the Galatians

4:18a

Nevertheless, it is good to be zealous if it serves a noble purpose

- It is always good to be shown concern by someone when his purpose/motive is good,
- If people's motives are good/proper, it is always good for them to show/have interest in you.

it is good to be zealous: There are several ways to interpret the Greek clause that the BSB translates as it is good to be zealous. The two main ones are:

1. It is passive. It is always good for the Galatians to be shown interest in by other people. To state it in an active way, it is good when other people show an interest in the Galatians. For example:

It is good for people to show interest in you (NCV) (ESV, NET, RSV, JBP, NLT, NCV, NASB, REB)

1. It is middle with an active sense. It is good when the Galatians show an interest in issues. For example:

It is...good to give your attention to something worthwhile (CEV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, GW, CEV, NLT96, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Paul was saying that it is fine if other people show an interest in the Galatians, but their motives must be good. The motives of the false teachers were not good. So Paul warned the Galatians not to trust them.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

- As a passive. For example:

It is...good to be made much of (ESV)

It is good when you are shown a deep interest in by someone

- As an active. For example:

It is good when someone shows a deep interest in you

It is good when people show concern for you

if it serves a noble purpose: This phrase refers to a person's motive/intentions. It is the opposite of "not in a good way" in 4:17a.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

but only if their purpose is good (NCV)

if their motives are good

4:18b

—at any time, and not only when I am with you.

- and not only when I am with you.
- This should be/happen even when I am not present with you^(plur).

at any time, and not only when I am with you: This clause indicates that it is good for people to show real concern for the Galatians at all times. It should not only happen when Paul is with them. And it should not only be Paul who shows concern for them.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

all the time, not just when I'm with you (NLT)

This should happen even when I am not with you.

Galatians 4:19

Section 4:8–20: Paul begged the Galatians not to turn away from the true gospel

In this section, Paul again rebuked the Galatians for turning to the law and turning away from the true gospel. He begged them to change their thinking and their actions. He said that turning to the law put them back into the slavery that they were in before they knew Christ. He equated obeying the law with paganism. This is a startling and shocking comparison.

Paul appealed to the Galatians on the basis of the emotional bond between him and them. He reminded them of how that bond had developed and that it had resulted in their full acceptance of the true gospel. But now their turning away from the true gospel had perplexed him. He said that they were now like enemies because they followed the false teachers and had turned away from the true gospel.

But the false teachers were the real enemies. For selfish reasons, they taught the Galatians to add something to their faith. They taught them to obey the law. They were not working for the good of the Galatians.

Some possible headings for this section are:

The folly of turning to the law

Paul's concern for the Galatians

4:19a

My children,

- My children in Christ,
- You are like my children.

My children: Paul used this phrase to remind the Galatians of their close relationship with him.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

My little children (ESV)

My own children in Christ

If the word children is only used literally and would be misunderstood, then you can say something like:

You are like my children

4:19b

for whom I am again in the pains of childbirth

- I feel as if I'm going through labor pains for you again, (NLT)
- Just like a woman who feels pain during childbirth, so I am once more suffering for you.

for whom I am again in the pains of childbirth: This clause is a metaphor. In this metaphor, Paul compared his ministry among the Galatians to childbirth. Paul had brought the Galatians to Christ. This was like giving birth to a child. They are similar in that both are difficult and painful.

Paul had already done this one time during his first visit. But the Galatians were turning away from their faith. So he had to bring them to the truth again. It was like Paul was giving birth to them again.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

I am suffering birth pains for you again (GW)

again I feel the pain of childbirth for you (NCV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

I feel as if I'm going through labor pains for you again (NLT)

Like a woman who has pain when she gives birth, I am again suffering for you

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

I am suffering terrible pain on your behalf once more

until Christ is formed in you: This clause refers to Christ changing the lives of the Galatians. Paul stated that his birth pains would continue until the Galatians were mature in Christ. According to the commentaries, there are at least two ways to interpret this clause: (1) It is a complete change of the metaphor in 4:19a. According to this interpretation, the Galatians are now pictured as the pregnant mother. Christ's nature is forming in them. Paul would be in pain until Christ was fully developed in them. Those who follow this interpretation are: Schreiner, p. 289; George, p. 330; Longenecker, p. 195; and Burton, pp. 248-249. (2) It continues the metaphor in 4:19b. According to this interpretation, Paul continues to be pictured as the pregnant mother. He would continue to be in the

agony of childbirth until the Galatians developed and became like Christ. For example: "until you take the shape of Christ" (NEB). Even though the majority of commentators follow interpretation (1), there are many difficulties in finding a good way to translate this clause according to that interpretation. So it is recommended that translators follow interpretation (2) or translate the meaning of this clause without trying to keep the metaphor.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

until you truly become like Christ (NCV)

until Christ is shown/revealed in you

until Christ's nature is formed in you (GNT)

4:19c

until Christ is formed in you,

- until you truly become like Christ. (NCV)
- I will continue to suffer until you are more mature in Christ.

Galatians 4:20

Section 4:8-20: Paul begged the Galatians not to turn away from the true gospel

In this section, Paul again rebuked the Galatians for turning to the law and turning away from the true gospel. He begged them to change their thinking and their actions. He said that turning to the law put them back into the slavery that they were in before they knew Christ. He equated obeying the law with paganism. This is a startling and shocking comparison.

Paul appealed to the Galatians on the basis of the emotional bond between him and them. He reminded them of how that bond had developed and that it had resulted in their full acceptance of the true gospel. But now their turning away from the true gospel had perplexed him. He said that they were now like enemies because they followed the false teachers and had turned away from the true gospel.

But the false teachers were the real enemies. For selfish reasons, they taught the Galatians to add something to their faith. They taught them to obey the law. They were not working for the good of the Galatians.

Some possible headings for this section are:

The folly of turning to the law

Paul's concern for the Galatians

4:20a

how I wish I could be with you now and change my tone,

- I wish that I were there with you now and could change my manner of speaking to you,
- I would like to be there with you now so that I could speak more gently to you.

how I wish I could be with you now: In this clause Paul stated that he wished that he could talk to the Galatians face to face. He wanted personal interaction with them.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I would like to be with you now

I desire to be there with you now so that we could talk together

and change my tone: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as change my tone means that Paul wished that he could change the way in which he was writing/talking to them. He wanted to change from being harsh to being more gentle.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

and could change the way I am talking to you (NCV)

so that I could be more gentle with you (NLT96)

4:20b

because I am perplexed about you.

- because I do not know what to think about you. (NCV)
- You have puzzled/worried me.
- I do not understand why you^(plur) are acting this way.

because: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as because indicates that 4:20b is the reason for 4:20a. Paul wanted to be with the Galatians, for/ because he was perplexed about them.

In some languages, it will be more natural to state the reason first. For example:

^bI am perplexed about you, ^aso I wish I could be present with you now...

I am perplexed about you: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as am perplexed means that Paul was “very puzzled” or “uncertain.” He was puzzled because the Galatians had accepted obedience to the law.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

because I do not know what to think about you (NCV)

I'm completely puzzled by what you've done! (GW)

I am so worried about you! (GNT)

Galatians 4:21

Section 4:21–31: Because the Galatians are spiritual sons of Abraham they are free from slavery

In this section, Paul explained why the Galatians should return to freedom and reject the teaching of the false teachers. He contrasted two sons of Abraham: the son of the slave woman and the son of the free woman. The son of the slave woman represented slavery to the law. The son of the free woman represented the freedom of living in the grace of Christ. Living in slavery to the law is in conflict with living in the grace of Christ. Those who live in the grace of Christ must reject slavery to the law.

Some possible headings for this section are:

Hagar and Sarah

The covenant of the promise is better than the covenant of the law

Choose grace, not the law

Paragraph 4:21–23

In this paragraph, Paul explained the difference between Abraham's two sons.

4:21a

Tell me, you who want to be under the law,

- ¶ Tell me, those of you who want to obey the law,
- ¶ Listen to me! Some of you want to obey/follow the law of Moses.

Tell me: This is a command. Paul used this command to focus the Galatians' attention on what he was going to say next.

Another way to translate this command is:

Listen to me (NLT96)

you who want to be under the law: The clause want to be under the law means “want to obey the law of Moses.”

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

you who want to live under the law

those of you who want to obey the law

you who want to follow the law of Moses for your salvation

4:21b

do you not understand what the law says?

- do you know what the law actually says? (NLT)
- It must be that you do not understand what the law of Moses says.

do you not understand what the law says?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used this rhetorical question to challenge the Galatians. He used this rhetorical question to tell the Galatians that they did not listen to and understand the law. They did not understand what they were doing.

Some ways to translate this rhetorical question are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

do you know what the law really says? (NLT96)

- As a tag question. For example:

You do not understand what the law says, do you?

- As a statement. For example:

It must be that you do not understand what the law says.

You should understand what the law says.

the law: Here the phrase the law refers to the five books that Moses wrote. Some other ways to translate this are:

the Jewish law

the law of Moses

the law that Moses gave/wrote

Galatians 4:22

Section 4:21–31: Because the Galatians are spiritual sons of Abraham they are free from slavery

In this section, Paul explained why the Galatians should return to freedom and reject the teaching of the false teachers. He contrasted two sons of Abraham: the son of the slave woman and the son of the free woman. The son of the slave woman represented slavery to the law. The son of the free woman represented the freedom of living in the grace of Christ. Living in slavery to the law is in conflict with living in the grace of Christ. Those who live in the grace of Christ must reject slavery to the law.

Some possible headings for this section are:

Hagar and Sarah

The covenant of the promise is better than the covenant of the law

Choose grace, not the law

Paragraph 4:21–23

In this paragraph, Paul explained the difference between Abraham’s two sons.

4:22a

For it is written that Abraham had two sons,

- It is written in the Scriptures that Abraham had two sons.
- God’s Holy book says that Abraham had two sons.

For: Verse 4:22 is an explanation of what the law says. The Greek introduces this explanation with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For.

Some other ways to translate this conjunction are:

Let me explain

What I mean is

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

it is written: The clause it is written means “the Bible/Scripture says.” This clause introduces a reference to Genesis 16 and Genesis 21. Paul used this quotation

to explain to the Galatians what he wanted them to understand about the law.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

in God's Holy book it is written

Moses wrote

the Scripture says

we read in the Scriptures

4:22b

one by the slave woman

- One son was the child of a slave woman,
- A slave woman gave birth to one son,

4:22c

and the other by the free woman.

- and the other son was the child of a free woman.
- and a woman who was not a slave gave birth to the other son.

4:22b–c

one by the slave woman and the other by the free woman: In this sentence Paul introduced the contrast between the two sons of Abraham. One son was born to his slave Hagar. The other son was born to his wife Sarah. Sarah was a free woman. She was not a slave.

Some other ways to translate this sentence are:

One son came from a slave woman. The other son came from a free woman.

The mother of one was a slave; the mother of the other was his wife, a free woman.

The slave woman gave birth to one son, and his wife who was not a slave woman, gave birth to the other son.

Galatians 4:23

Section 4:21–31: Because the Galatians are spiritual sons of Abraham they are free from slavery

In this section, Paul explained why the Galatians should return to freedom and reject the teaching of the false teachers. He contrasted two sons of Abraham: the son of the slave woman and the son of the free woman. The son of the slave woman represented slavery to the law. The son of the free woman repre-

sented the freedom of living in the grace of Christ. Living in slavery to the law is in conflict with living in the grace of Christ. Those who live in the grace of Christ must reject slavery to the law.

Some possible headings for this section are:

Hagar and Sarah

The covenant of the promise is better than the covenant of the law

Choose grace, not the law

Paragraph 4:21–23

In this paragraph, Paul explained the difference between Abraham's two sons.

4:23a

His son by the slave woman was born according to the flesh,

- His son by the slave woman was born in the usual way, (GNT)
- The son of the slave woman was born because humans tried to fulfill God's promise.

His son by the slave woman was born according to the flesh: The phrase was born according to the flesh refers to the way that the son of the slave woman was conceived. God had promised Abraham a son. But he had no children with his wife. So he took the slave woman, Hagar, and had a child with her. This child was born because Abraham attempted to fulfill God's promise on his own. The child was conceived and born in the normal, human way.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Abraham's son from the slave woman was born in the normal human way. (NCV)

The son of the slave wife was born in a human attempt to bring about the fulfillment of God's promise. (NLT)

His son from the slave woman was conceived and born because of the plan of people.

The birth of the son of the slave woman was only a natural birth.

See flesh, Meaning 5 in the Glossary for more information.

4:23b

but his son by the free woman was born through the promise.

- but his son by the free woman was born as a result of God's promise. (GNT)
- But the son of the woman who was not a slave was born because God fulfilled his promise.

but his son by the free woman was born through the promise: The phrase was born through the promise refers to the way that the son of the free woman was conceived. Abraham's wife Sarah was too old to have a child. But God had promised to give Abraham many descendants. As a result of that promise, Sarah miraculously became pregnant and gave birth.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

But the son from the free woman was born because of the promise God made to Abraham. (NCV)

But the son of the freeborn wife was born as God's own fulfillment of his promise. (NLT)

But the birth of the son of the free woman was possible only because God promised he would do this.

Galatians 4:24

Section 4:21–31: Because the Galatians are spiritual sons of Abraham they are free from slavery

In this section, Paul explained why the Galatians should return to freedom and reject the teaching of the false teachers. He contrasted two sons of Abraham: the son of the slave woman and the son of the free woman. The son of the slave woman represented slavery to the law. The son of the free woman represented the freedom of living in the grace of Christ. Living in slavery to the law is in conflict with living in the grace of Christ. Those who live in the grace of Christ must reject slavery to the law.

Some possible headings for this section are:

Hagar and Sarah

The covenant of the promise is better than the covenant of the law

Choose grace, not the law

Paragraph 4:24–27

In this paragraph, Paul explained why he introduced the contrast between Abraham's two sons. He wanted the Galatians to understand the contrast between two covenants. One covenant is the covenant of law. This covenant results in slavery. God gave the covenant of law at Mount Sinai. The other covenant is the covenant of grace. This covenant results in freedom. God gave the covenant of grace to Abraham and completed it in Christ. Paul had introduced the contrast between the two covenants in 3:17.

4:24a

These things serve as illustrations,

- ¶ All of this has another meaning as well.
- ¶ This story teaches something else:
- ¶ These two women are a parable.

A few English versions, such as the ESV, introduce this verse with the conjunction "now" in order to show that Paul is providing background information to explain how his example of Abraham applies to what he has been saying about faith and the law. The Greek does not have a conjunction, and most English versions do not have one. In some languages, a conjunction may not be needed here either.

These things serve as illustrations: This clause means that the things that Paul said in 4:21–23 can be interpreted/explained in another way. In Greek this phrase is more literally "these things are allegorized." The word "allegorized" comes from the noun "allegory." An allegory is a story in which the characters represent something with a deeper meaning. An allegory is like a parable.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

This story teaches something else: (NCV)

All of this has another meaning as well. (CEV)

These events have a deeper meaning

I will explain this story as a parable

4:24b

for the women represent two covenants.

- The two women represent two different agreements that God made with his people.
- Each of the two women can be compared to a treaty/contract that God made with his people.

for: In Greek, 4:24b begins with a conjunction that the BSB translates as *for*. This conjunction introduces an explanation of 4:24a. Many English translations do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

the women represent two covenants: In Paul's allegory, Hagar and Sarah represent two covenants. The word *covenants* is the same word that Paul used in 3:17c. A covenant is a strong, binding agreement between two groups or two people. God established covenants or agreements with people. One covenant was the promise that God made to Abraham. The other covenant was the law that God gave to Moses.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

these women represent/show two treaties/contracts

Each of the two women stands for one of the agreements God made with his people. (CEV)

The word "covenant" first occurs in 3:15b. See also covenant in the Glossary for more information.

4:24c

One covenant is from Mount Sinai and bears children into slavery:

- One agreement is the law that God gave on Mount Sinai. This agreement bears children who are slaves.
- One of the treaties/contracts is the law given at the mountain called Sinai. The people who follow/obey this treaty/contract are like slaves.

One covenant is from Mount Sinai: This is the covenant of the law. God gave the law to Moses on a mountain called Mount Sinai.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

One covenant comes from Mount Sinai

One agreement is the law that God gave on Mount Sinai

One treaty/contract is the law given to Moses at Mount Sinai

Mount Sinai: The phrase Mount Sinai refers to a mountain whose name is Sinai. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the mountain of Sinai

the mountain called Sinai

bears children into slavery: This clause is a figure of speech called personification. In this personification, the covenant of the law is spoken of as if it were a woman who bears children. The children whom this woman bears are slaves.

In this figure of speech, the word *children* refers to those who follow and obey the law. The covenant of the law results in slavery to the law.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Keep the personification. For example:

and bears children who are to be slaves (NIV)

- Translate the meaning without the personification. For example:

and those who follow the law are slaves to that law.

and the people who are under this agreement are like slaves (NCV)

4:24d

This is Hagar.

- Hagar represents this agreement.
- The slave mother named Hagar represents that treaty.
- Hagar, the slave woman, corresponds to this contract.

This is Hagar: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as *This is Hagar* can mean:

1. This covenant is Hagar, or
2. This woman is Hagar

Both are correct. Hagar represents the covenant of the law. She is the slave woman referred to in 4:23a.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

This covenant is Hagar.

This woman is Hagar.

The slave woman named Hagar represents that covenant.

The mother named Hagar is like that agreement.
(NCV)

General Comment on 4:24a–d

In some languages, it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses in 4:24. For example:

^aAll of this has another meaning as well. ^bEach of the two women stands for one of the agreements God made with his people. ^cHagar, the slave woman, ^dstands for the agreement that was made at Mount Sinai. Everyone born into her family is a slave. (CEV)

Galatians 4:25

Section 4:21–31: Because the Galatians are spiritual sons of Abraham they are free from slavery

In this section, Paul explained why the Galatians should return to freedom and reject the teaching of the false teachers. He contrasted two sons of Abraham: the son of the slave woman and the son of the free woman. The son of the slave woman represented slavery to the law. The son of the free woman represented the freedom of living in the grace of Christ. Living in slavery to the law is in conflict with living in the grace of Christ. Those who live in the grace of Christ must reject slavery to the law.

Some possible headings for this section are:

Hagar and Sarah

The covenant of the promise is better than the covenant of the law

Choose grace, not the law

Paragraph 4:24–27

In this paragraph, Paul explained why he introduced the contrast between Abraham's two sons. He wanted the Galatians to understand the contrast between two covenants. One covenant is the covenant of law. This covenant results in slavery. God gave the covenant of law at Mount Sinai. The other covenant is the covenant of grace. This covenant results in freedom. God gave the covenant of grace to Abraham and completed it in Christ. Paul had introduced the contrast between the two covenants in 3:17.

4:25

In Paul's allegory, Hagar represents Mount Sinai. Mount Sinai was where the law was given. Mount Sinai is in the land of Arabia. Arabia was where the

descendants of Hagar's son lived. They were descendants of the slave woman. So Paul associated the law with slavery.

Hagar also represents Jerusalem. Jerusalem is a figure of the Jewish religion. Paul said that the people who follow the Jewish religion are like Jerusalem's children. They are slaves to the law.

So Paul equated the law-keeping Jews with Hagar and her son. They were all slaves. The law-keeping Jews were outside of the covenant of promise, just like the Gentiles.

4:25a

Now Hagar stands for Mount Sinai in Arabia

- Hagar represents Mount Sinai in Arabia
- She represents the mountain of Sinai in the land of Arabia
- Hagar illustrates the mountain called Sinai in the country of Arabia.

Now: In Greek, 4:25 begins with a conjunction that the BSB translates as Now. This conjunction introduces another point. Here, this conjunction is not a time word.

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate it either.

Hagar stands for Mount Sinai in Arabia: There is a textual issue here. Some Greek manuscripts do not have the word Hagar. The NLT and REB follow these manuscripts. For example, the REB says, "Sinai is a mountain in Arabia..." The other English versions follow the manuscripts that include the word Hagar. This clause means that Hagar represents the covenant of the law that was given at Mount Sinai. Mount Sinai is in the land of Arabia. This is the land where the descendants of Hagar's son Ishmael lived.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Hagar, who stands for Mount Sinai in Arabia (GNT)

Hagar represents Mount Sinai in the land of Arabia

Hagar illustrates Mount Sinai in Arabia

4:25b

and corresponds to the present-day Jerusalem,

- and is a figure of today's Jerusalem,
- and Jerusalem of today.

- She can be compared to Jerusalem of our^(incl) time.

and corresponds: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as corresponds is literally “she stands in the same line” or “she belongs to the same category.” Here this verb means she “is a figure of.”

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

She is like (GW)

she can be compared to

to the present-day Jerusalem: The phrase the present-day Jerusalem refers to the earthly Jerusalem in Paul’s time. This earthly Jerusalem is in contrast with the heavenly Jerusalem in 4:26a.

The city of Jerusalem was the center of the Jewish religion. So Jerusalem represents obedience to the law of Moses as a means of being made right with God.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

to the earthly city of Jerusalem of our day

to the Jerusalem of today

4:25c

because she is in slavery with her children.

- because Jerusalem and her children are slaves to the law.
- This city and its people, the Jews, are slaves to the law. (NCV)
- The people of this city are slaves to the law of Moses.

because: Verse 4:25c is an explanation of what is similar between Hagar and Jerusalem. The Greek introduces this explanation with a conjunction that the BSB translates as because.

Another way to introduce this explanation is:

for (ESV)

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate the conjunction either.

she is in slavery with her children: This clause is a figure of speech called personification. In this personification, Paul spoke of Jerusalem as a mother who has children. Both the mother and the children are slaves.

In this allegory, Jerusalem represents the Jewish religion. The people who follow the Jewish religion are the children of Jerusalem. Here Paul implied that everyone who follows the law as a means of justification is a slave. Just as Hagar and her child were slaves, so also the unbelieving Jews of Jerusalem and all who attempt to keep the law are slaves to the law.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

- Keep the personification. For example:

she and her children live in slavery to the law (NLT)

the city and her children are slaves to the law

- Translate the meaning without using personification. For example:

The people of this city are those who are slaves to the law.

Galatians 4:26

Section 4:21–31: Because the Galatians are spiritual sons of Abraham they are free from slavery

In this section, Paul explained why the Galatians should return to freedom and reject the teaching of the false teachers. He contrasted two sons of Abraham: the son of the slave woman and the son of the free woman. The son of the slave woman represented slavery to the law. The son of the free woman represented the freedom of living in the grace of Christ. Living in slavery to the law is in conflict with living in the grace of Christ. Those who live in the grace of Christ must reject slavery to the law.

Some possible headings for this section are:

Hagar and Sarah

The covenant of the promise is better than the covenant of the law

Choose grace, not the law

Paragraph 4:24–27

In this paragraph, Paul explained why he introduced the contrast between Abraham’s two sons. He wanted the Galatians to understand the contrast between two covenants. One covenant is the covenant of law. This covenant results in slavery. God gave the covenant of

law at Mount Sinai. The other covenant is the covenant of grace. This covenant results in freedom. God gave the covenant of grace to Abraham and completed it in Christ. Paul had introduced the contrast between the two covenants in 3:17.

4:26

In this verse, Paul continued the contrast between slave and free that he introduced in 4:21. In 4:25 he said that the slave woman and her offspring represent the covenant of the law. Here he contrasted them with the free woman and her offspring who represent the covenant of promise and grace. All those who believe in Christ as the means of justification are free and under the covenant of grace. They are not slaves. The “Jerusalem above” and Sarah, the free woman, represent the believers in the same way that “the present-day Jerusalem” and Hagar represented those who followed the law.

4:26a

But the Jerusalem above is free,

- But the Jerusalem in heaven is free,
- But the heavenly Jerusalem represents freedom,
- But the woman who is not a slave is/represents the Jerusalem above.

But: There is a contrast between 4:25 and 4:26. The contrast is between the present Jerusalem (slavery) and the Jerusalem above (freedom). The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction But.

the Jerusalem above is free: This clause refers to the heavenly Jerusalem. The free woman (Sarah) corresponds to this Jerusalem. This Jerusalem represents those who believe in Jesus Christ as the means of being made right with God. It is contrasted with “the present-day Jerusalem” and with Hagar, which represent those who obey the law to be justified. Those who trust in Jesus for their salvation are free. They are not slaves.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

the Jerusalem in heaven represents freedom.

the heavenly Jerusalem is free.

the Jerusalem above is not a slave.

the free woman represents the Jerusalem that is above

4:26b

and she is our mother.

- and this city is like our^(incl) mother.
- and this city is like the mother of us who believe.
- We are people of this city.

and she is our mother: This clause is also personification (like the clause “she is in slavery with her children” in 4:25c). In this personification, Paul spoke of the heavenly Jerusalem as the mother of the people who are free.

In this allegory, the heavenly Jerusalem represents salvation by faith. The people who believe in Christ to make them right with God are the children of this Jerusalem. These people are free from the law. Just as Sarah was a free woman, so the people who believe in Christ are free.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Keep the personification. For example:

this city is our mother

our mother is the city of Jerusalem (CEV)

- Translate this as a simile. For example:

and this city is like our mother

- Translate the meaning without the personification. For example:

we are people of this city

Galatians 4:27

Section 4:21–31: Because the Galatians are spiritual sons of Abraham they are free from slavery

In this section, Paul explained why the Galatians should return to freedom and reject the teaching of the false teachers. He contrasted two sons of Abraham: the son of the slave woman and the son of the free woman. The son of the slave woman represented slavery to the law. The son of the free woman represented the freedom of living in the grace of Christ. Living in slavery to the law is in conflict with living in the grace of Christ. Those who live in the grace of Christ must reject slavery to the law.

Some possible headings for this section are:

Hagar and Sarah

The covenant of the promise is better than the covenant of the law

Choose grace, not the law

Paragraph 4:24–27

In this paragraph, Paul explained why he introduced the contrast between Abraham's two sons. He wanted the Galatians to understand the contrast between two covenants. One covenant is the covenant of law. This covenant results in slavery. God gave the covenant of law at Mount Sinai. The other covenant is the covenant of grace. This covenant results in freedom. God gave the covenant of grace to Abraham and completed it in Christ. Paul had introduced the contrast between the two covenants in 3:17.

4:27

Verse 4:27 is a quote from Isaiah 54:1. In Isaiah, these words refer to Jerusalem. Jerusalem is commanded to rejoice because God would bring back from captivity the people of this “barren” city. Paul connected Sarah to this verse. She had also been barren.

Paul applied this quotation to the heavenly Jerusalem. The heavenly Jerusalem is like the rejoicing woman. It is free, and those who belong to it are free. Paul wanted the Galatians to recognize that they also belong to the heavenly Jerusalem and are free. They too should rejoice and be glad.

4:27a

For it is written:

- For the Scriptures say,
- It is written in the book of Isaiah:
- As God's word says,

For: Verse 4:27 supports Paul's point in 4:26 that people who believe are free and belong to the Jerusalem in heaven. The Greek introduces this supporting statement with a conjunction that the BSB translates as **For**.

Another way to translate this conjunction is:

because

Some English versions do not translate this word. In some languages, it may not be necessary to translate this word either.

it is written: This clause introduces the quotation from Isaiah.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

It is written in the Scriptures (NCV)

the scripture says (GNT)

as God's word says

Isaiah wrote

4:27b–c

This quote from Isaiah contains a form of poetry called parallelism. In this parallelism, the first part of 4:27b is similar in meaning to the first part of 4:27c. And the second part of 4:27b is similar in meaning to the second part of 4:27c.

^{27b} Rejoice, **O barren woman, who bears no children;**

^{27c} break forth and cry aloud, **you who have never travailed;**

In this parallelism, Isaiah described Jerusalem in two ways:

1. O barren woman, who bears no children
2. you who have never travailed

If a parallel structure in your language wrongly implies that these two clauses refer to two towns or two women, you may need to combine the parallel parts in these lines. For example:

^{b-c}You who have never given birth, rejoice!

4:27b

“Rejoice, O barren woman, who bears no children;

- “Rejoice, you barren woman, you who have never been pregnant.
- “You childless woman who has never given birth, be happy!
- “Be glad, you who have never given birth.

Rejoice: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Rejoice means “be glad/happy.” For example:

Be happy (GNT)

be glad (CEV)

O barren woman, who bears no children: The phrases O barren woman and who bears no children are two ways of describing a woman who cannot have

children. It is common in Hebrew poetry to say the same thing in two ways.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

childless woman, you who have never given birth (NLT)

You childless woman having a closed womb

woman who has not given birth, woman who has not known pregnancy

In some languages, it is too repetitive or poor style to repeat the same idea. If that is the case in your language, you could combine the two expressions into one expression. For example:

you childless woman (GNT)

4:27c

break forth and cry aloud, you who have never travailed;

- Raise your voice and shout for joy, you who have not experienced the pains of childbirth,
- Make your voice strong and declare your happiness, you who have never had birth pains,
- Shout for/with joy, you who have never borne a child,

break forth and cry aloud: The commands break forth and cry aloud both mean “shout.” (As in 4:27b, it is common in Hebrew poetry to say the same thing in two ways.) It is implied that the shouting is for joy. You may need to make this explicit. For example:

raise your voice and shout for joy

make your voice strong and declare your happiness

break into a shout of joy (REB)

raise your voice to make known your joy

Here the word cry does not mean “weep.”

As in 4:27b, if it would be considered too repetitive or poor style in your language to translate both expressions, you could combine the two expressions into one. For example:

shout with/for joy

you who have never travailed: The word travailed refers to the pain that a woman has when she gives birth. This clause is another way to refer to a childless woman. If you have an idiom to say this in your language, you can use it.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

you who never felt the pains of childbirth (GNT)

you who have never suffered birth pains

4:27d

because more are the children of the desolate woman than of her who has a husband.”

- because the deserted/abandoned woman will have more children than the woman who has a husband.”
- because the woman whose husband had left her will have many children. She will have more children than the woman who has a husband.”

because: Verse 4:27d is the basis for the commands to rejoice in 4:27b–c. The Greek introduces this basis with a conjunction that the BSB translates as because. Another way to translate this word is:

for (ESV)

more are the children of the desolate woman than of her who has a husband: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as desolate woman means “deserted woman” or “forsaken woman.” It refers to a woman whose husband has left her. In Isaiah, the desolate woman refers to Jerusalem, which God abandoned.

Isaiah prophesied that God would bring back the exiles. The new Jerusalem would be bigger than the old one, the one who had a husband.

Paul applied this verse to the heavenly Jerusalem. The heavenly Jerusalem will have more people than the earthly Jerusalem.

Some other ways to translate these clauses are:

the deserted woman will have many more children than the woman who has a husband

many are the children of the forsaken woman. They are more than those of the woman who has a husband

are: In Greek, there is no verb in 4:27d. So English versions add a verb. Some use the future “will be” or “will have.” Others use the present are. For example:

the woman who was deserted will have more children (GNT)

more are the children of the desolate woman (NIV)

In this verse from Isaiah, the idea is that the woman had many children after her time of being desolate. So, in many languages, the future tense will be better.

Galatians 4:28

Section 4:21–31: Because the Galatians are spiritual sons of Abraham they are free from slavery

In this section, Paul explained why the Galatians should return to freedom and reject the teaching of the false teachers. He contrasted two sons of Abraham: the son of the slave woman and the son of the free woman. The son of the slave woman represented slavery to the law. The son of the free woman represented the freedom of living in the grace of Christ. Living in slavery to the law is in conflict with living in the grace of Christ. Those who live in the grace of Christ must reject slavery to the law.

Some possible headings for this section are:

Hagar and Sarah

The covenant of the promise is better than the covenant of the law

Choose grace, not the law

Paragraph 4:28–31

In this paragraph, Paul showed the Galatians how the allegory about the free woman and the slave woman applied to their situation.

4:28a

Now you, brothers,

- ¶ So then my brothers,
- ¶ And so, my friends,
- ¶ My fellow believers,

Now: In this verse, Paul began to apply his allegory of the previous paragraph. Begin this verse in a way that shows that Paul is going to make an application. For example:

And so

So then

Here is the point

In some languages, you may not need to use a connecting word or phrase.

you, brothers: Paul used the pronoun you and the word brothers to directly address the Galatians. He wanted them to pay attention to what he was about to say.

Some ways to translate these words are:

you, my dear fellow believers

you, fellow believers in Christ

you, my dear friends

you: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have you. For example:

you (GNT) (BSB, ESV, CEV, GW, NASB, NCV, NET, NIV, NJB, NLT, NRSV, REB, GNT)

1. Other Greek manuscripts have we. For example:

we (RSV) (JBP, KJV, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), with the majority of English versions.

4:28b

like Isaac, are children of promise.

- you are like Isaac. You are children of the promise.
- you are like Isaac. You are counted as Abraham's children because of what God promised.
- you are Abraham's children because of the promise that God made, in the same way as Abraham's son Isaac was born because God made a promise to Abraham.

like Isaac: Isaac was the name of the son of Abraham and Sarah, the free woman whom Paul spoke of in 4:22–23. He was free. Paul compared the Galatian believers to Isaac.

Some ways to translate this phrase are:

just like Isaac, the son of the free woman

in the same way as Isaac

are children of promise: Isaac was born because of God's promise to give Abraham a son. In the same way, the Gentiles have been born spiritually because of God's promise to bless all nations through Abraham. The Gentiles are Abraham's spiritual children. They are free.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

are counted as Abraham's children because of God's promise

you have become Abraham's children because of the promise that God made

Galatians 4:29

Section 4:21–31: Because the Galatians are spiritual sons of Abraham they are free from slavery

In this section, Paul explained why the Galatians should return to freedom and reject the teaching of the false teachers. He contrasted two sons of Abraham: the son of the slave woman and the son of the free woman. The son of the slave woman represented slavery to the law. The son of the free woman represented the freedom of living in the grace of Christ. Living in slavery to the law is in conflict with living in the grace of Christ. Those who live in the grace of Christ must reject slavery to the law.

Some possible headings for this section are:

Hagar and Sarah

The covenant of the promise is better than the covenant of the law

Choose grace, not the law

Paragraph 4:28–31

In this paragraph, Paul showed the Galatians how the allegory about the free woman and the slave woman applied to their situation.

4:29

In 4:29, Paul used a story from the Old Testament to represent what was happening in Galatia. The story from the Old Testament is about Abraham's two sons Ishmael and Isaac. He called Ishmael "the son born

according to the flesh." Ishmael represents the false teachers. Ishmael persecuted Isaac, who was born "by the Spirit." In the same way, the false teachers were persecuting the believers in Galatia.

In some languages, it may be more natural to make parts of this verse explicit. Compare the BSB and the NLT below.

^aAt that time, however, ^bthe son born by the flesh ^cpersecuted the son born by the Spirit. ^dIt is the same now. (BSB)

^dBut you are now being persecuted by those who want you to keep the law, ^ajust as Ishmael, ^bthe child born by human effort, ^cpersecuted Isaac, the child born by the power of the Spirit. (NLT)

4:29a

At that time, however,

- But at that time
- However, what happened then is like what is happening now.

At that time: This phrase introduces a comparison between what happened at the time of Isaac and what was happening in Galatia.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

Just like at that time

And what happened then

just as at that time (ESV)

however: There is some contrast between 4:28 and 4:29. The contrast is between the way we would expect people to treat the children of promise and the way they actually treat them. The Greek indicates this contrast with a conjunction that the BSB translates as however.

Another way to introduce 4:29 is:

But

Many English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

4:29b

the son born by the flesh

- the son who was born in the usual way (GNT)
- The son of Hagar who was born because humans tried to fulfill God's promise

the son born by the flesh: This clause refers to Abraham's son Ishmael. He was the son of Hagar. Here Ishmael represents the false teachers.

The phrase by the flesh refers to the fact that the child was conceived and born in the normal, human way. Abraham tried to fulfill God's promise on his own. He did that by taking the slave woman Hagar and having a child with her. It is the same phrase that Paul used in 4:23a.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

The son who was born in the normal way (NCV)

he who was born in a human attempt to fulfill God's promise

the son of Hagar who was born because of the plan of people

the one who had only a natural birth

See flesh, Meaning 5 in the Glossary for more information.

4:29c

persecuted the son born by the Spirit.

- caused suffering to the son who was born because of the work of God's Spirit.
- was cruel to Isaac, the one who was born by the help/power of God's Spirit.

persecuted: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as persecuted means "cause to suffer."

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

made trouble (CEV)

treated...badly (NCV)

caused to suffer

was cruel to

This verb also occurs in 1:13b

the son born by the Spirit: This clause refers to Isaac. Here Isaac represents the believers in Galatia.

The phrase by the Spirit refers to the fact that Isaac was born because of God's promise to Abraham. God's Spirit allowed the elderly Sarah to become pregnant. Believers, who are also children of the promise, receive life through God's Spirit.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

him who was born because of the work of the Spirit

him who was born by means of the power/help of God's Spirit

Isaac, the one who came by means of the Spirit fulfilling God's promise

the Spirit: This phrase refers to the Spirit of God.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

the Holy Spirit

the Spirit of God

See Spirit, Meaning 1 in the Glossary.

4:29d

It is the same now.

- The same thing is happening today. (CEV)
- (translated in 4:29a)

It is the same now: This clause states that the situation between Ishmael and Isaac was similar to the situation in Galatia. The Galatian believers, like Isaac, were persecuted by those who were slaves to the law.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

That's exactly what's happening now. (GW)

The same thing is happening today. (CEV)

It is the same today. (NCV)

It's just like that now.

In some languages, it will be more natural to put this phrase with 4:29a. For example:

^aWhat happened then ^dis like what is happening now.

Galatians 4:30

Section 4:21–31: Because the Galatians are spiritual sons of Abraham they are free from slavery

In this section, Paul explained why the Galatians should return to freedom and reject the teaching of the false teachers. He contrasted two sons of Abraham: the son of the slave woman and the son of the free woman. The son of the slave woman represented slavery to the law. The son of the free woman represented the freedom of living in the grace of Christ. Living in slavery to the law is in conflict with living in the grace of Christ. Those who live in the grace of Christ must reject slavery to the law.

Some possible headings for this section are:

Hagar and Sarah

The covenant of the promise is better than the covenant of the law

Choose grace, not the law

Paragraph 4:28–31

In this paragraph, Paul showed the Galatians how the allegory about the free woman and the slave woman applied to their situation.

4:30a

But what does the Scripture say?

- But what does God's word say? It says,
- But consider what is written in the Scripture:

But: There is a contrast between 4:29 and 4:30. The contrast is between the way that the false teachers were treating the Galatians (persecuting them) and the way that the Galatians should treat the false teachers (cast them out). The Greek indicates this contrast with a conjunction that the BSB translates as But.

Many English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

what does the Scripture say?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used this rhetorical question to emphasize what the Scripture says.

Some ways to translate this emphasis are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

what do the Scriptures say about that? (NLT)

- As a statement. For example:

consider what God's word says:

Use whichever form is most natural in your language.

4:30b

“Expel the slave woman and her son,

- “Send the slave woman and her son away.
- “Cast out/Banish the slave woman and her son.

Expel the slave woman and her son: This is a quotation from Genesis 21:10. God told Abraham to send Hagar and her son away from the household.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Send away the slave woman and her son

Throw out the slave woman and her son. (NCV)

Cast out/Banish the slave woman and her son

Paul probably quoted this verse to tell the Galatian Christians to expel those people who were telling them to follow the law.

4:30c

for the slave woman's son will never share in the inheritance

- because the slave woman's son will not be an heir
- The slave woman's son will not inherit/receive the father's possessions.

for: Verse 4:30c is the basis for the command to send away the slave woman and her son (in 4:30b). The Greek introduces this basis with a conjunction that the BSB translates as for. Another way to translate this conjunction is:

^bGet rid of the slave woman and her son, ^cbecause the son of the slave woman must never share the inheritance ^dwith the son of the free woman. (GW)

In some language, no conjunction is needed to introduce the basis for the command. For example:

^bGet rid of the slave woman and her son! ^cHe won't be given anything. ^dThe son of the free woman will receive everything. (CEV)

In other languages, it is more natural to put the basis before the command. For example:

^cThe son of the slave woman must never share the inheritance ^dwith the son of the free woman. ^bSo throw out the slave woman and her son.

the slave woman's son will never share in the inheritance: In the case of Abraham, his possessions that were to be inherited as part of the inheritance included the spiritual blessing of the covenant that God made with him. The son of the slave woman was not part of that covenant.

Some other ways to translate the phrase will never share in the inheritance are:

will not be an heir

will not have a part of the father's property (GNT)

will not receive the blessing

**4:30d
with the free woman's son."**

- together with the free woman's son."
- The son of the woman who is not a slave will inherit/receive everything."

with the free woman's son: In some languages, it may be more natural to make this phrase a separate sentence. For example:

The son of the free woman will be the heir of everything.

The son of the free women will inherit/receive all his father's possessions.

Galatians 4:31

Section 4:21–31: Because the Galatians are spiritual sons of Abraham they are free from slavery

In this section, Paul explained why the Galatians should return to freedom and reject the teaching of the false teachers. He contrasted two sons of Abraham: the son of the slave woman and the son of the free woman. The son of the slave woman represented slavery to the law. The son of the free woman represented the freedom of living in the grace of Christ. Living in slavery to the law is in conflict with living in the grace of Christ. Those who live in the grace of Christ must reject slavery to the law.

Some possible headings for this section are:

Hagar and Sarah

The covenant of the promise is better than the covenant of the law

Choose grace, not the law

Paragraph 4:28–31

In this paragraph, Paul showed the Galatians how the allegory about the free woman and the slave woman applied to their situation.

4:31a

Therefore, brothers, we are not children of the slave woman,

- So then, my brothers, we^(incl) are not children of the slave woman.
- Therefore, my fellow believers, we are not the slave woman's children.

4:31b

but of the free woman.

- Rather, we^(incl) are children of the free woman,
- We are children of the woman who was not a slave.

4:31a–b

Therefore, brothers: Verse 4:31 is the conclusion to this section. The Greek introduces this conclusion with a conjunction that the BSB translates as Therefore.

Some other ways to translate this conjunction are:

So, brothers, (ESV)

In conclusion, fellow believers

we are not children of the slave woman, but of the free woman: In this clause, Paul concluded this section by repeating the main point of his illustration. His main point is the contrast between the two branches of Abraham's family and who they are.

The slave woman and her slave children represent the Jewish law and those who are slaves to the law. The free woman represents righteousness by faith apart from the law. Her children are free through faith in Christ. The Galatian believers are children of the free woman.

In some languages, it may be necessary to make parts of this explicit. For example:

we are not children of the slave woman and slaves to the law. We are children of the free woman, and sons of God by faith.

we are not children of the slave woman, obligated to the law. We are children of the free woman, acceptable to God because of our faith. (NLT96)

Galatians 5:1

Section 5:1–12: Remain in the freedom you have in Christ

In this section, Paul tried to persuade the Galatians believers not to yield to the pressure from the false teachers to get circumcised. He warned them that if they became circumcised in order to receive God's approval, then they would have rejected the grace and freedom that God had given them. They would become slaves again. He encouraged them to refuse circumcision and remain free.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Keep your freedom (NCV)

Do not become slaves again

Paragraph 5:1

In this paragraph, Paul told the Galatians to remain free. He told them not to become slaves again to the law.

5:1a

It is for freedom that Christ has set us free.

- ¶ Christ freed us^(incl) so that we^(incl) might truly be free from the law.
- ¶ Christ delivered/rescued us^(incl) from the law so that we would not be its slaves.
- ¶ We have freedom now, because Christ made us free. (NCV)

It is for freedom that Christ has set us free: There are several ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as It is for freedom. The two main interpretations are:

1. It indicates the purpose for which Christ freed us. He freed us in order that we would have freedom from the law. For example:

Christ has freed us so that we may enjoy the benefits of freedom. (GW) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NASB, NET, RSV, ESV, REB, GW)

1. It emphasizes the verb set us free in the sentence. For example:

So Christ has truly set us free. (NLT) (GNT, CEV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The majority of English versions and many commentaries follow this interpretation.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Christ has set us free so that we might really be free from the law.

Christ has delivered/rescued us from the law so that we would not be slaves to it.

We have freedom now, because Christ made us free. (NCV)

us: The pronoun us refers to both Paul and the Galatians.

5:1b

Stand firm, then, and do not be encumbered once more by a yoke of slavery.

- Therefore, stand firm and do not let a slave's yoke burden you again.
- So stand strong. Do not change and go back into the slavery of the law. (NCV)
- Therefore/So, remain free and do not ever become slaves again to religious laws.

Stand firm, then: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Stand firm means "persevere." Paul told the Galatians to persevere in the freedom that they had. They were to remain/continue in that freedom.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Therefore persevere in this freedom

So stand strong (NCV)

Therefore be firm in this freedom (GW)

So be strong

So remain/continue in this freedom

and do not be encumbered once more: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as be encumbered means “be loaded down with” or “be burdened by.” Trying to obey religious laws is like being weighed down by a heavy load.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

and do not let yourselves be burdened again (NIV)

and do not accept again

and do not again surrender

once more: The phrase once more indicates that the Galatians had previously been slaves to religious laws when they worshiped idols. Obeying the law of Moses was no different than their former idol worship. Both made people slaves.

by a yoke of slavery: This is a figure of speech. A yoke is a piece of wood that is put over the necks of two oxen to join them together so that they work together. A yoke is also a piece of wood that one person wears around his neck to balance and carry two heavy loads. In this context, yoke refers to the type of yoke that a person wears. It was usually slaves who wore yokes. A yoke itself could be heavy, but it also represented the hard work of a slave. Obeying religious laws is like being a slave and wearing a yoke to carry a heavy load. They are similar in that both are miserable and undesirable.

Some ways to translate this figure of speech are:

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:

by a yoke such as slaves wear

- Modify the figure of speech. For example

into the slavery of the law (NCV)

to obeying religious laws again. This is like being a slave

Do not let laws tie you.

- Translate the meaning without the figure of speech. For example:

Do not think that you must follow certain religious laws to be right with God

Galatians 5:2

Section 5:1–12: Remain in the freedom you have in Christ

In this section, Paul tried to persuade the Galatians believers not to yield to the pressure from the false teachers to get circumcised. He warned them that if they became circumcised in order to receive God’s approval, then they would have rejected the grace and freedom that God had given them. They would become slaves again. He encouraged them to refuse circumcision and remain free.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Keep your freedom (NCV)

Do not become slaves again

Paragraph 5:2–6

In this paragraph, Paul warned the Galatians what would happen if they agreed to be circumcised.

5:2a

Take notice: I, Paul, tell you that

- ¶ Listen^(plur)! I, Paul, tell you^(plur) that
- ¶ Listen^(plur) to me! I, Paul, assure you that
- ¶ I, Paul, promise you that

Take notice: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Take notice indicates that what follows is important.

Some other ways to translate this are:

Listen! (GNT)

Look! (NASB)

This is important:

Pay attention to this:

I, Paul, tell you that: In this clause, Paul included his name because he wanted to emphasize his authority as an apostle. Jesus Christ had called him to be an apostle, so what he says has the authority of God. The Galatians should listen to him instead of those false teachers.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I, Paul, say to you that (ESV)

I, Paul, can guarantee that (GW)

I, Paul, promise you that (CEV)

5:2b

if you let yourselves be circumcised,

- if you^(plur) get circumcised,
- if you allow yourselves to be circumcised in order to be made right with God,

if you let yourselves be circumcised: This clause means “if you allow yourselves to be circumcised in order to become right with God.” You may need to make some of this information explicit. For example:

If you are counting on circumcision to make you right with God (NLT)

If you allow yourselves to be circumcised to be made right with God

It is important to remember that Paul did not say that “circumcision” in itself was bad. What was wrong was to insist that people must be circumcised and become like Jews in order for God to accept them.

be circumcised: For help on translating circumcised, see 2:3a.

5:2c

Christ will be of no value to you at all.

- Christ will be of no value to you at all. (NIV)
- then what Christ did is of no benefit to you.

Christ will be of no value to you at all: This clause indicates that Christ’s work on the cross and his resurrection will not benefit those who try to be saved by following the law.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

then Christ will be of no benefit to you (NLT)

then you will not receive any benefit from the death of Christ

then what Christ did is absolutely no use/help to you

Galatians 5:3

Section 5:1–12: Remain in the freedom you have in Christ

In this section, Paul tried to persuade the Galatians believers not to yield to the pressure from the false teachers to get circumcised. He warned them that if they became circumcised in order to receive God’s approval, then they would have rejected the grace and freedom that God had given them. They would become slaves again. He encouraged them to refuse circumcision and remain free.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Keep your freedom (NCV)

Do not become slaves again

Paragraph 5:2–6

In this paragraph, Paul warned the Galatians what would happen if they agreed to be circumcised.

5:3a

Again I testify to every man who gets himself circumcised

- Again, I want to tell every man who agrees to be circumcised
- Again, I insist that everyone who allows himself to be circumcised (GW)
- I’ll say it again to each one of you^(plur) men. If you^(sing) accept circumcision,

Again I testify: Paul used the word testify to put a strong emphasis on the truth of the statement that he was about to make. The word Again shows that Paul was repeating his warning in 5:2 to those who allowed themselves to be circumcised.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Once more, I want to say

I’ll say it again. (NLT)

Once more I warn (GNT)

to every man who gets himself circumcised: The phrase to every man is a more emphatic way of speaking than just saying “you.”

Another way to translate this phrase is:

to anyone who allows someone to circumcise him

5:3b**that he is obligated to obey the whole law.**

- that he must obey all the rest of the law.
- must realize that he obligates himself to do everything Moses' Teachings demand. (GW)
- then you^(sing) are required to obey the whole law of Moses.

that he is obligated to obey the whole law: This clause indicates that people who trust in circumcision for justification must perfectly keep the whole law of Moses. This is a solemn warning.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

that he is required to obey all of the law

that he must keep the whole law of Moses

In some languages, it may be natural to change the pronoun from he to "you." For example:

you must obey every regulation in the whole law of Moses (NLT)

Galatians 5:4**Section 5:1-12: Remain in the freedom you have in Christ**

In this section, Paul tried to persuade the Galatians believers not to yield to the pressure from the false teachers to get circumcised. He warned them that if they became circumcised in order to receive God's approval, then they would have rejected the grace and freedom that God had given them. They would become slaves again. He encouraged them to refuse circumcision and remain free.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Keep your freedom (NCV)

Do not become slaves again

Paragraph 5:2-6

In this paragraph, Paul warned the Galatians what would happen if they agreed to be circumcised.

5:4

In 5:4, there are two consequences of following the law of Moses:

1. you are severed from Christ
2. you have fallen away from grace

In some languages, it is more natural to change the order of the Greek in order to put these two consequences together (as in the BSB). Compare the ESV (which follows the Greek) and the BSB below.

^{4a} You are severed from Christ, you who would be justified by the law; ^{4b} you have fallen away from grace. (ESV)

^{4a} You who are trying to be justified by law have been severed from Christ; ^{4b} you have fallen away from grace. (BSB)

5:4a**You who are trying to be justified by the law have been severed from Christ;**

- You^(plur) have cut yourselves off from Christ if you are seeking to be justified by the law,
- Any of you who think that God accepts you as blameless because you follow the law, you are separated from Christ,
- If you^(plur) try to obey the law of Moses in order to try to become right with God, you have separated yourselves from Christ.

You who are trying to be justified by the law: This clause identifies the people who are severed from Christ. It is those who want to be made right with God by following/obeying the law of Moses.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Whoever among you attempts to be straight before God by keeping the law

Any of you who try to follow the law of Moses in order to be made right with God

And if you try to please God by obeying the Law (CEV)

justified: The word justified is the verb form of the noun "righteous." This word also occurs in 2:16a. See also justify in the Glossary.

have been severed from Christ: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as have been severed means "cut off" or "completely separated" from Christ. This verb points out the serious consequences of adding circumcision to our faith in Christ as a requirement to be saved/justified.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

have cut yourselves off from Christ (NRSV)

have separated yourselves from Christ

your life with Christ is over (NCV)

5:4b

you have fallen away from grace.

- and you turned your back on the grace of God.
- and you have refused/rejected the favor/goodness of God.
- You have abandoned the kindness/gift of God towards you.

you have fallen away from grace: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as have fallen away from means that the Galatians “have left” or “abandoned” God’s grace. It does not mean that God took his grace away from them.

It is another way of saying “you are separated from Christ.” A person who is separated from Christ is separated from the grace of God. This is the fourth time that Paul has warned about the consequences of accepting circumcision.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

you have turned your back on God’s grace

you have abandoned/rejected the kindness of God towards you

you have gone out of God’s grace

grace: The word grace refers to God’s kindness, generosity, or favor in justifying us through faith in Christ.

Some ways to translate grace are:

God’s favor

God’s kindness

God’s goodness

See grace, Meaning 2 in the Glossary.

Galatians 5:5

Section 5:1–12: Remain in the freedom you have in Christ

In this section, Paul tried to persuade the Galatians believers not to yield to the pressure from the false teachers to get circumcised. He warned them that if they became circumcised in order to receive God’s approval, then they would have rejected the grace and freedom that God had given them. They would become slaves again. He encouraged them to refuse circumcision and remain free.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Keep your freedom (NCV)

Do not become slaves again

Paragraph 5:2–6

In this paragraph, Paul warned the Galatians what would happen if they agreed to be circumcised.

5:5

But by faith we eagerly await through the Spirit the hope of righteousness.

- But through the power of the Holy Spirit, we^(incl) eagerly wait for the righteousness that we hope to receive by means of our faith in Christ.
- (reordered) As for us, the Holy Spirit helps/encourages us to excitedly wait for the final day when we hope/expect that God will declare us right/blameless. He will do this because we believe/trust in Christ.
- (reordered) As for us, it is because we believe in Christ that one day God will declare us^(incl) completely righteous. We hope/expect this to happen. The Holy Spirit gives us the power to wait for that day with all our heart.

In this verse, Paul wrote about the people who had not separated themselves from Christ. They continued to believe in Christ for justification. They had rejected circumcision as a means of justification. They would attain righteousness by means of faith in Christ.

But: Verse 5:5 begins with a conjunction that is normally translated as “for.” Understood that way, it would introduce the reason why people who try to be justified by the law have fallen away from grace (5:4b). Some English versions translate it that way. For example:

For (ESV)

However, this conjunction can also be understood as introducing a contrast between “you” (who obey the law to be made right with God) and “we” (who believe in Christ to be made right with God). The BSB and some other English versions translate this conjunction as But in order to focus on the contrast.

Some other ways to begin 5:5 are:

But we

However, as for us

As for us (GNT)

by faith: There are three ways to interpret what the phrase by faith is connected to:

1. It is connected to righteousness:. According to this interpretation, “righteousness by faith” is in contrast with “justified by the law” in 5:4a. For example:

But we...eagerly wait to receive everything promised to us who are right with God through faith. (NLT96) (NLT96, CEV)

1. It is connected with eagerly wait for. For example:

faith causes us to wait eagerly (GW) (BSB, NLT, GW)

1. It is connected with the Spirit. For example:

The power of God’s Spirit working through our faith (GNT) (GNT)

Most English versions translate by faith literally and it is not possible to tell which interpretation they follow. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). One scholar who follows this interpretation is Fung, who says, “The whole weight of the verse is on the two phrases ‘through the Spirit, by faith,’ (RSV) which are brought forward for emphasis since they stand for the two aspects that distinguish the Christian hope from the Jewish. There is in ‘through the Spirit’ an implied contrast with ‘the flesh’ which is the active principle of legal righteousness (cf. 3:3), while ‘by faith’ stands in explicit and decisive contrast with ‘by way of law’ (v. 4). The two phrases are not, strictly speaking, predicated of ‘righteousness’: it is not explicitly stated here that it is ‘through the Spirit’ and ‘by faith’ that believers are justified, but only that it is ‘through the Spirit, by

faith’ that ‘we wait for the hope of righteousness.’ But since the expectation of this ‘hope’ to which believers are pointed forward by their justification is grounded in their present experience of the Spirit and in faith it is plainly not, and cannot be, based on works of the law, because justification, which gives rise to the hope in question, cannot itself be achieved by works of the law, but is attained only ‘by faith.’ The clear contrast between faith and law in the immediate context (as well as in the epistle as a whole) shows beyond doubt that in Paul’s thinking there can be no such thing as a hope which is being awaited on the basis of faith while the ground of that hope (namely, justification) is itself based on works of the law. We may therefore conclude that v. 5 unmistakably implies that justification is ‘by faith’ and not ‘by way of law,’ even though the full expression ‘justified by faith,’ which might have been expected, is lacking” (Fung, p. 227).

The final goal of a believer’s life is righteousness. It is by means of faith in Christ that believers attain this righteousness.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

we are made right with God by our faith

we are righteous because we believe/trust

faith: See faith, Meaning 1 in the Glossary.

we: The pronoun we refers to Paul and the other people who were not following the law in order to be made righteous. These are the people who had not fallen away from grace. You may need to make this explicit. For example:

we who have not fallen away from grace , we

we who reject circumcision for justification , we

The we is neither completely inclusive nor completely exclusive. It includes the majority of the Galatians, but it excludes those who have fallen from grace. If a choice has to be made, it is best to use the inclusive form, because Paul still considered the Galatians to be his brothers in Christ.

eagerly await: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as eagerly await refers to waiting for and looking forward to the end of the age when Christ will return.

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

eagerly wait for the final day

wait for that day with our whole heart

through the Spirit: There are at least two ways to interpret what the phrase through the Spirit is connected to:

1. It is connected to the verb eagerly await. According to this interpretation, the Holy Spirit helps us and encourages us to eagerly wait for the final day when we will be made completely righteous. For example:

this is what we wait for by the power of God's Spirit (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NCV)

1. It is connected to the word hope. According to this interpretation, the Holy Spirit causes us to hope or be sure that God will make us righteous. For example:

the Spirit makes us sure (CEV) (CEV)

Most English versions are literal and it is not possible to tell which interpretation they follow. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

In 3:3, Paul said that believers begin their lives with the Spirit. They must continue to live their lives and wait for the day when the Lord returns. They can do this through the power of the Holy Spirit.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

we, by the help of the Spirit, are eagerly waiting (TCNT)

through the power of the Holy Spirit

by the Spirit we wait eagerly for this hope (NCV)

the Holy Spirit helps/encourages us to wait for

the hope of righteousness: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as the hope of righteousness refers to the righteousness that believers hope to receive on judgment day. The word righteousness refers to being "upright," "blameless" or "just" before God.

The word hope refers to something good that a person expects to happen. He is sure/certain that it will happen. In this context, believers expect to be declared

righteous because God promised it. It is different from the modern use of the word "hope" in English.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the righteousness for which we hope

the righteousness that we expect

the righteousness God has promised to us (NLT)

we are eagerly waiting for God to declare us blameless. This is what we hope for/expect.

Galatians 5:6

Section 5:1–12: Remain in the freedom you have in Christ

In this section, Paul tried to persuade the Galatians believers not to yield to the pressure from the false teachers to get circumcised. He warned them that if they became circumcised in order to receive God's approval, then they would have rejected the grace and freedom that God had given them. They would become slaves again. He encouraged them to refuse circumcision and remain free.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Keep your freedom (NCV)

Do not become slaves again

Paragraph 5:2–6

In this paragraph, Paul warned the Galatians what would happen if they agreed to be circumcised.

5:6

In this verse, Paul clearly stated that Christ Jesus is the basis of our hope of righteousness. Because faith in Christ is sufficient for righteousness, circumcision is without meaning. Faith working through love is what really matters.

5:6a

For in Christ Jesus neither circumcision nor uncircumcision has any value.

- When we are in Christ Jesus, it is not important if we are circumcised or not. (NCV)
- When we believe in Christ Jesus, there is no benefit/value in being circumcised or being uncircumcised.

For: In 5:6, Paul continued to explain how a person becomes righteous. A person becomes righteous by faith

in Jesus, not by being circumcised. Paul had already explained in 5:4 that obeying the law does not make a person right with God. Here he talked about a specific example: circumcision does not make a person right with God.

The Greek introduces this explanation with a conjunction that the BSB translates as *For*.

Another way to translate this conjunction is:

because

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

in Christ Jesus: The phrase in Christ Jesus describes our relationship to Christ. We are in Christ Jesus in the sense that we are united with him. We have died with him, and we are resurrected with him. We believe in him and trust in him.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

When we are in Christ Jesus (NCV)

If you are a follower of Christ Jesus (CEV)

when we place our faith in Christ Jesus (NLT)

neither circumcision nor uncircumcision has any value: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as *has any value* means “has force/strength.” Neither circumcision nor uncircumcision has any importance, meaning, or power in a believer’s life. The church includes both those who are circumcised and those who are not circumcised.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

neither circumcision nor uncircumcision means anything (NASB)

it is not important if we are circumcised or not (NCV)

it makes no difference whether you are circumcised or not (CEV)

there is no benefit in being circumcised or being uncircumcised (NLT)

circumcision: For help on translating circumcision, see 2:3a.

5:6b

All that matters is faith, expressed through love.

- What is important is our faith that makes/causes us to love others.
- But the important thing is our faith in Christ that shows itself when we love other people.
- What is of benefit/value is that we believe/trust in Christ Jesus. This is shown/seen when we love others.

All that matters is: There is a contrast between 5:6a and 5:6b. The contrast is between what is of no value (circumcision and uncircumcision) and what is of value (faith working through love). Languages have different ways to indicate this negative-positive type of contrast. Some of the ways are:

- With the conjunction “but.”
- With a conjunction other than “but.” This is a common way in English to show this type of contrast. For example:

Rather

Instead

- With a connecting phrase. For example:

What does matter

The only thing that counts is (NIV)

faith: Here the word faith refers to faith/trust in Christ.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

your faith (CEV)

you/we believe in Christ

See faith, Meaning 1 in the Glossary.

expressed through: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as *expressed* can also be translated as “shows” or “makes/causes.” For example:

The only thing that really counts is faith that shows itself through love. (NIRV)

All that matters is your faith that makes you love others. (CEV)

This verb also occurs in 2:8a, 2:8b, and 3:5a.

love: The word love refers to a believer's love for other people.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

What is important is that we believe/trust in Christ. We show this when we love other people.

All that matters is your faith that makes you love others. (CEV)

Galatians 5:7

Section 5:1–12: Remain in the freedom you have in Christ

In this section, Paul tried to persuade the Galatians believers not to yield to the pressure from the false teachers to get circumcised. He warned them that if they became circumcised in order to receive God's approval, then they would have rejected the grace and freedom that God had given them. They would become slaves again. He encouraged them to refuse circumcision and remain free.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Keep your freedom (NCV)

Do not become slaves again

Paragraph 5:7–10

In this paragraph, Paul warned the Galatians about the false teachers. They were dangerous. But God would judge them.

5:7a

You were running so well.

- ¶ You^(plur) were running the race well.
- ¶ You were following Christ well in the same way that a person runs a race well.
- ¶ You were obeying Christ so well

You were running so well: This clause is a metaphor. In this metaphor, Paul compared the Galatians' life of faith in Christ to running a race. They are similar in that both had been done well. They had started well. Paul implied that the Galatians were no longer living the Christian life well.

Some ways to translate this metaphor are:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

You were running the race so well. (NLT)

- Make the topic explicit. For example:

You were running well in your life with Christ.

- Make the topic explicit and change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

You were following Christ well in the same way that a person runs a race well.

- Translate the meaning without the metaphor. For example:

You were obeying Christ well.

You were doing so well! (GNT)

You were progressing so well.

5:7b

Who has obstructed you from obeying the truth?

- Why did you permit someone to hinder you from obeying the truth?
- You should not allow someone to stop you from following the true way!
- until someone made you turn from the true message of God.

Who has obstructed you from obeying the truth?:

This is a rhetorical question. Paul used this rhetorical question to rebuke the Galatians. He stated that they were no longer living according to the truth of the gospel.

Some ways to translate this rebuke are:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Who stopped you from following the true way? (NCV)

Why did you permit someone to hinder you from obeying the truth?

- As an exclamation. For example:

You should not have stopped obeying the truth!

- As a statement. For example:

until someone made you turn from the truth (CEV)

has obstructed you: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as obstructed means “prevent” or “stop someone.” In this metaphor of a race, it refers to someone getting in front of a runner and blocking his way. Some versions translate this verb in such a way as to reflect the racing idiom. For example:

cut in on you (NIV)

Some other ways to translate this verb are:

stopped you (NCV)

prevented you (NET)

interfered and held you back

the truth: The phrase the truth refers to the true gospel that Paul preached.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

the true gospel

the true message from God

Galatians 5:8

Section 5:1–12: Remain in the freedom you have in Christ

In this section, Paul tried to persuade the Galatians believers not to yield to the pressure from the false teachers to get circumcised. He warned them that if they became circumcised in order to receive God’s approval, then they would have rejected the grace and freedom that God had given them. They would become slaves again. He encouraged them to refuse circumcision and remain free.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Keep your freedom (NCV)

Do not become slaves again

Paragraph 5:7–10

In this paragraph, Paul warned the Galatians about the false teachers. They were dangerous. But God would judge them.

5:8

Such persuasion does not come from the One who calls you.

- This teaching is not from God who called you.
- The teaching of the people who persuaded you to stop obeying the truth is not from God who called/invited you to follow him.
- That way of thinking is not from God. He called you to believe.

Such persuasion: This phrase refers to the teaching of the false teachers who were trying to persuade the Galatians to stop obeying the truth of the gospel (in 5:7). Specifically, it refers to the teaching that the Galatians needed to be circumcised.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

Those arguments

That teaching

Their persuading you

The teaching of those who are trying to persuade you to be circumcised

does not come from the One who calls you: The phrase the One who calls you refers to God. He is the one who called the Galatians to himself.

Paul stated that the false teaching was the idea of those leading the Galatians astray. It was not from God.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

are not from God who called you to believe

is not from God. He invited you to be his followers.

Be careful that your translation of the clause who calls you does not imply that there is another God who does not call you.

Galatians 5:9

Section 5:1–12: Remain in the freedom you have in Christ

In this section, Paul tried to persuade the Galatians believers not to yield to the pressure from the false teachers to get circumcised. He warned them that if they became circumcised in order to receive God's approval, then they would have rejected the grace and freedom that God had given them. They would become slaves again. He encouraged them to refuse circumcision and remain free.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Keep your freedom (NCV)

Do not become slaves again

Paragraph 5:7–10

In this paragraph, Paul warned the Galatians about the false teachers. They were dangerous. But God would judge them.

5:9

A little leaven works through the whole batch of dough.

- As they say, "A little leaven penetrates and changes the whole lump of dough."
- As the proverb warns, "Even a little bit of yeast spreads through the whole batch of bread dough."
- Watch out. Remember the proverb that says: "A little bit of yeast makes a lot of flour rise/swell." And this teaching is like yeast.

A little leaven works through the whole batch of dough: This is a proverb. People used this proverb to refer to a small amount of something having a large effect. Paul used this proverb to warn the Galatians about the false teaching.

The word leaven refers to a product like yeast that makes bread rise. It only takes a small amount of yeast to make a large amount of bread dough rise. In the Bible, leaven is almost always a symbol of evil. So here it means that just as leaven affects bread, a small amount of false teaching will affect the churches throughout Galatia and do great harm to them.

Some ways to translate this proverb are:

- Make it explicit that it is a proverb. For example:

"It takes only a little yeast to make the whole batch of dough rise," as they say. (GNT)

- Make it explicit that it is a warning. For example:

Be careful! "Just a little yeast makes the whole batch of dough rise." (NCV)

- Make it explicit that the proverb refers to the false teaching. For example:

This false teaching is like a little yeast that spreads through the whole batch of dough! (NLT)

- Make it explicit that it is a proverb, a warning, and refers to false teaching. For example:

The teaching that is not true is spreading. As the proverb warns, "Even a little bit of leaven affects the whole lump of dough."

Watch out. Remember the proverb that says: "A little yeast makes a lot of flour rise." And this false teaching is like yeast.

leaven: The Greek noun that the BSB translates as leaven refers to a product that makes bread dough rise. The most common type of leaven is yeast. Most of the more modern English versions translate this word as "yeast."

This word also occurs in Matthew 13:33, Mark 8:15, and Luke 13:21. If you have translated any of these passages, you should use the same word here.

If you have not yet translated the word "leaven" or "yeast", here are some ways to translate it:

- Use an expression that describes the yeast. For example:

what spreads to make bread rise

bread-expanding substance

- Use a term from the national language and indicate its meaning. For example:

yisti that spreads to make bread swell

- Borrow a word and explain it in a footnote. Here is an example of a possible footnote:

Yeast is something that spreads in flour dough and causes it to rise so that after the dough is baked it is soft to eat.

works through the whole batch of dough: The Greek word that the BSB translates as works through is more literally “leavens.” The word “leavens” is the verb form of the noun “leaven.” This verb refers to the process whereby leaven/yeast makes bread rise.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as batch of dough refers to an amount of clay or dough.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

to make the whole batch of dough rise (GNT)

spreads through the whole batch of dough (GW)

makes a lot of flour rise/swell

Galatians 5:10

Section 5:1–12: Remain in the freedom you have in Christ

In this section, Paul tried to persuade the Galatians believers not to yield to the pressure from the false teachers to get circumcised. He warned them that if they became circumcised in order to receive God’s approval, then they would have rejected the grace and freedom that God had given them. They would become slaves again. He encouraged them to refuse circumcision and remain free.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Keep your freedom (NCV)

Do not become slaves again

Paragraph 5:7–10

In this paragraph, Paul warned the Galatians about the false teachers. They were dangerous. But God would judge them.

5:10a

I am confident in the Lord

- I am trusting in the Lord about you,
- The Lord gives me confidence concerning you

I am confident in the Lord: In Greek, this clause is more literally “I have confidence in you in the Lord.” Paul had confidence in the Galatians that they would

turn back to the truth. This confidence came from the Lord.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I am confident in the Lord concerning you

The Lord gives me confidence (GW)

I am trusting the Lord (NLT)

5:10b

that you will take no other view.

- that you will think no other way.
- that you will not think differently than the way I do.
- that you will not believe differently than I do about these issues.

that you will take no other view: This clause means that the Galatians will have the same point of view as Paul. This includes:

1. They will agree with all that he has written in this letter.
2. They will agree with what he has said in 5:8–9: the teaching of these other men about circumcision does not come from God, and this teaching is dangerous.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

that you will agree with what I am saying

that you will not think differently than I do about these issues

that you will not believe those different ideas (NCV)

5:10c

The one who is troubling you will bear the judgment, whoever he may be.

- Whoever is causing trouble for you will be punished. (CEV)
- Whoever is confusing you with such ideas will be judged/punished.
- God will judge the one who is unsettling your minds.

The one who is troubling you: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as The one who is troubling is singular. In 1:7b and 5:12, Paul spoke of people (plural) who were troubling the Galatians. These people were the false teachers. Because of these two previous

verses, there are several ways to interpret to whom the phrase The one who is troubling refers:

1. It refers to any one of the false teachers. According to this interpretation, Paul was saying that if anyone among the false teachers troubles you, he will be punished. For example:

anyone who makes trouble with you (NJB)

whoever troubles you

1. It refers to one particular individual. According to this interpretation, Paul was referring to the leader of the false teachers. So this phrase should be translated as:

the/that person who is troubling you

1. It refers to the group of false teachers. According to this interpretation, Paul was referring to all the false teachers together as one group. So it should be translated as:

the group who are troubling you

the people who are troubling you

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). One scholar who follows this interpretation is Baker, who says, “The probable meaning is: ‘There are several disturbers. Be on your guard, therefore, so that if one— anyone at all—of these creators of confusion approaches, you resist him, bearing in mind that, whoever he may be, he will have to pay the penalty’” (p. 203). This interpretation is also followed by Burton, p. 285.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

the one who is confusing you (GW)

whoever upsets/disturbs you

The Greek word that the BSB here translates as troubling also occurs in 1:7b.

will bear the judgment: Paul reminded the Galatians that God will judge those who lead believers astray. He has already stated this in 1:7–9.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

will be punished (CEV)

will be judged/condemned

God will judge (NLT)

whoever he may be: There are two ways to interpret this clause:

1. It means anyone who. According to this interpretation, this clause clarifies the phrase “the one who” in the first part of 5:10c. It can even be combined with it. For example:

Whoever is causing trouble for you will be punished. (CEV)

1. It means no matter how important he is. According to this interpretation, this clause is additional information about the phrase “the one who” in the first part of 5:10c. For example:

regardless of who he is (GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

Galatians 5:11

Section 5:1–12: Remain in the freedom you have in Christ

In this section, Paul tried to persuade the Galatians believers not to yield to the pressure from the false teachers to get circumcised. He warned them that if they became circumcised in order to receive God’s approval, then they would have rejected the grace and freedom that God had given them. They would become slaves again. He encouraged them to refuse circumcision and remain free.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Keep your freedom (NCV)

Do not become slaves again

Paragraph 5:11–12

In this paragraph, Paul concluded his discussion about circumcision. He made it clear that he was not preaching that people should be circumcised to be made right with God. He strongly condemned the false teachers who did teach this.

5:11a–b

if I am still preaching circumcision, why am I still being persecuted?: This is a rhetorical question. Paul used this rhetorical question to prove that he did not preach that a person needs to be circumcised.

The word *if* introduces a statement that is not true. If Paul were still preaching circumcision, then he would not be persecuted. But since he was being persecuted, the Galatians should know that he did not preach circumcision.

It appears that the false teachers had accused Paul of being inconsistent. They perhaps said that in some circumstances he still taught circumcision.

Some ways to translate this proof are:

- As a rhetorical question. In this rhetorical question, it may be necessary to make it clearer that Paul does not preach circumcision. For example:

if I were still preaching that you must be circumcised—as some say I do—why am I still being persecuted? (NLT)

- As statement followed by a rhetorical question. For example

I do not teach that a man must be circumcised. If I teach circumcision, why am I still being attacked? (NCV)

Some people say that I am still preaching that it is necessary to be circumcised. But if that were true, why am I still being persecuted?

- As statement followed by a tag question. For example:

if I still preached that circumcision is necessary, I would not still be persecuted, would I?

- As a statement. For example:

if I still preached circumcision, then I would not still be persecuted.

if I were continuing to preach that people must be circumcised, then I would not be persecuted. However, I am still being persecuted. So you can be sure I am not preaching circumcision.

Use whichever form is natural in your language for Paul to prove that he did not preach circumcision.

5:11a

Now, brothers, if I am still preaching circumcision,

- ¶ As for me, brothers, if I am still preaching that circumcision is necessary/important,
- ¶ My dear fellow believers, some people said that I still preach that a person must be circumcised to become right with God. If that were true,
- ¶ My dear friends, I am not teaching that men must be circumcised in order to be right with God. If I were teaching that,

brothers: As in 1:11a, the word *brothers* refers to “spiritual brothers.” They were Paul’s “fellow believers.” The word includes both men and women. It does not refer to Paul’s biological brothers.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

brothers and sisters (NET)

fellow believers

my friends (NRSV)

In some languages, it will be natural to put this word first in the verse. See the Display for an example.

if I am: In 5:11, Paul switched from talking about the false teachers to talking about himself. He used the emphatic form of the pronoun *I* in Greek to focus on his actions.

Some other ways to begin this verse are:

But as for me..., if I (GNT)

As for me, if I

if I myself

preaching circumcision: The clause *preaching circumcision* means “announcing or proclaiming that a person must be circumcised in order for God to accept him.”

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

preach that circumcision is necessary (GNT)

preach that people need to be circumcised (CEV)

preach that a person must be circumcised to be made right with God

5:11b

why am I still being persecuted?

- why are people still persecuting me?
- how is it that people/Jews are still persecuting me?
- I would not be made to suffer as I do.

why am I still being persecuted: The verb being persecuted means “made to suffer because of one’s religious beliefs.” This verb first occurred in 1:13b.

This verb is passive. Some ways to translate it are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

why am I still being made to suffer

how is it that I am still persecuted

- Use an active verb. For example:

why are the Jews persecuting me

5:11c

In that case the offense of the cross has been abolished.

- Then, the cross would not be offensive anymore.
- If what they said were true, then people/Jews would not be offended by the message of the cross.
- If I were teaching such a message, then no one would be upset that I teach that Jesus died on the cross to save us.

In that case: The phrase In that case is the translation of one Greek conjunction. This conjunction introduces what would happen if it were true that Paul still preached circumcision.

Some other ways to connect 5:11c to the rest of the verse are:

In such a case

If that were true (GNT)

If I still taught circumcision (NCV)

the offense of the cross has been abolished: The Greek word that the BSB translates as offense is often translated “stumbling block” (as in the RSV) or “stumbling stone.” It is a figure of speech that refers to

something that causes opposition, disapproval, anger, or revulsion. The message of the cross does that.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

the cross wouldn’t be offensive anymore (GW)

no one would be offended that I preach about Christ’s death on the cross

my preaching about the cross would not be a problem (NCV)

cross: Here the word cross is a figure of speech called a metonymy. The cross represents the gospel message. This message teaches that the only thing that a person needs to do to be saved is to believe that Christ died on the cross for his sins. The true gospel does not include circumcision.

Some ways to translate cross are:

Christ’s death on the cross

the message of Christ’s death

salvation through the cross of Christ alone

the gospel of Christ’s death on the cross for salvation

Galatians 5:12

Section 5:1–12: Remain in the freedom you have in Christ

In this section, Paul tried to persuade the Galatians believers not to yield to the pressure from the false teachers to get circumcised. He warned them that if they became circumcised in order to receive God’s approval, then they would have rejected the grace and freedom that God had given them. They would become slaves again. He encouraged them to refuse circumcision and remain free.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Keep your freedom (NCV)

Do not become slaves again

Paragraph 5:11–12

In this paragraph, Paul concluded his discussion about circumcision. He made it clear that he was not preaching that people should be circumcised to be made right with God. He strongly condemned the false teachers who did teach this.

5:12

As for those who are agitating you, I wish they would proceed to emasculate themselves!

- I wish that those who trouble you would castrate themselves.
- I wish that those people who are confusing you about circumcision would cut off their own testicles.
- I wish that everyone who is upsetting you would not only get circumcised, but would cut off much more! (CEV)

Paul concluded his discussion about circumcision by condemning those who were troubling the Galatians.

As for those who are agitating you, I wish: The Greek word that the BSB translates as agitating also means “disturbing,” “upsetting,” or “troubling.”

The clause those who are agitating you refers to the false teachers whom Paul has criticized in this letter. He has also called them “false brothers” (2:4), people who had “bewitched” the Galatians (3:1), and those who were “zealous” for them (4:17). These people disturbed the Galatian believers by telling them that they needed to be circumcised in order to be made right with God.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I wish that those who are troubling you (NASB)

I wish that the people who are upsetting you (GNT)

I wish the people who are bothering you (NCV)

would proceed to emasculate themselves: The Greek word that the BSB translates as emasculate is literally “cut off.” In this discussion about circumcision, it is an allusion to castration. A second interpretation of this word is that it also has the sense of one being cut off from believers. It links back to the curse Paul pronounced in 1:9, that those who preach a false gospel are eternally condemned. The KJV and JBP follow this interpretation. For example: “I wish those who are so eager to cut your bodies would cut themselves off from you altogether!” (JBP) It refers to cutting off their testicles.

Some other ways to translate this verse are:

would castrate themselves (NRSV)

would cut off their own testicles

would not only get circumcised, but would cut off much more (CEV)

Galatians 5:13**Section 5:13–26: Let the Spirit of God lead you**

In this section, Paul talked about what freedom means. He no longer focused on how a person is made righteous. He focused on how a person who has received the righteousness of Christ should live.

Paul told the Galatians that choosing to live their lives in the power of the Holy Spirit would keep them from living sinful lives. It would keep them from living as slaves to the law. A life lived in the Spirit is a life of love for each other.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Follow closely the Spirit of God

Obey God’s Spirit, not your sinful desires

Paragraph 5:13–15

In this paragraph, Paul stated that the freedom that the Galatians had in Christ did not mean that they could do whatever they wished. Their freedom did not permit them to live sinful lives. Instead, they should lovingly serve each other.

5:13a

For you, brothers, were called to freedom;

- ¶ My brothers, you were called to be free.
- ¶ Fellow believers, God’s plan/will for you is not to be slaves.
- ¶ My friends, God told you that he wants you to be free from religious laws.

For: Paragraph 5:13–15 is an explanation of the previous section. It connects back to the statement in 5:1 that “it is for freedom that Christ has set us free.” The Greek introduces this explanation and connection with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For.

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to use a conjunction here either.

brothers: As in 5:11a, the word brothers refers to “spiritual brothers.” They were Paul’s “fellow believers.” The word includes both men and women. It does not refer to Paul’s biological brothers.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

brothers and sisters (NET)

fellow believers

my friends (GNT)

were called to freedom: The verb called means that God “strongly invited,” “summoned,” or “chose” the Galatians to be free from religious laws. God chose/invited the Galatians to be his people, and he wants them to live in freedom. In some languages, it may be necessary to make some of this information explicit. For example:

were called to be God’s people, and he wants you to be free

In some languages, the word called is only used when someone calls another person to come to a physical location. It cannot be used when someone asks another person to do something or be something. If your language is like that, you may have to use another verb, as in the examples below.

The verb were called is a passive verb. Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

You were indeed called to be free (GW)

you were chosen to be free (CEV)

You were told to be free

- Use an active verb. For example:

God called you to be free (NCV)

God told you that he wants you to be free from religious laws.

God’s plan is that you be free.

God called you to be his people, and he wants you to be free from religious laws

The verb called also occurs in 1:6b.

5:13b

but do not use your freedom as an opportunity for the flesh.

- Only do not let^(plur) that freedom become an excuse for obeying the sinful nature,
- But do not let this be a reason for you to satisfy your evil desires.
- Now that you are free, do not think that you can do whatever you want.

but do not use your freedom as an opportunity for the flesh: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as opportunity for the flesh means “occasion/time to do whatever your body desires.” Freedom from the law does not give a person an excuse to live a sinful, wicked life.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

don’t use your freedom to satisfy your sinful nature (NLT)

don’t use your freedom as an excuse to do anything you want (CEV)

now that you are free, do not think that you can do whatever you desire

flesh: The word flesh refers to human nature. That human nature is full of sin.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

sinful nature

your sinful self

what your body desires

See flesh, Meaning 5 in the Glossary.

5:13c

Rather, serve one another in love.

- but serve one another in/with love.
- Rather, use your freedom to help one another and in that way show your love for one another.
- Instead, serve/help one another because you love one another.

Rather: There is a contrast between 5:13b and 5:13c. The contrast is between the command to not use your freedom “as an opportunity for the flesh” and the command to serve one another in love. Languages have different ways to indicate this negative-positive type of contrast. Some of the ways are:

- With the conjunction “but.”
- With a conjunction other than “but.” This is a common way in English to show this type of contrast. For example:

Rather (BSB, NIV)

On the contrary

Instead (GNT)

- With no conjunction. For example:

^bdo not use your freedom as an excuse to do what pleases your sinful self. ^cServe each other with love. (NCV)

serve one another in love: This clause states how the Galatians should use their freedom. They are to serve each other. This means that they are to help one another. And they are to help one another in love. This means “lovingly” or “in a loving manner” or “because you love one another.”

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

serve each other with love (CEV)

love and help each other

help one another because you love one another

Galatians 5:14

Section 5:13–26: Let the Spirit of God lead you

In this section, Paul talked about what freedom means. He no longer focused on how a person is made righteous. He focused on how a person who has received the righteousness of Christ should live.

Paul told the Galatians that choosing to live their lives in the power of the Holy Spirit would keep them from living sinful lives. It would keep them from living as slaves to the law. A life lived in the Spirit is a life of love for each other.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Follow closely the Spirit of God

Obey God’s Spirit, not your sinful desires

Paragraph 5:13–15

In this paragraph, Paul stated that the freedom that the Galatians had in Christ did not mean that they could do whatever they wished. Their freedom did not permit them to live sinful lives. Instead, they should lovingly serve each other.

5:14a

The entire law is fulfilled in a single decree:

- For all that the law requires is fulfilled/covered in the one command:
- You^(plur) should do this because the following one command satisfies the requirements of the entire law:
- Here is a command that covers/fulfills all the laws of Moses:

In 5:14, Paul gives the reason why the Galatians should serve one another through love. They should do it because love is a fulfilment of the law. Paul introduces this reason with a Greek conjunction that most English versions translate as “for.”

Another way to begin this verse is:

You should do this because

The BSB has not translated this conjunction, and some other versions, such as the CEV and NCV, also do not translate it. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either. Connect 5:14a to 5:13c in a way that is natural in your language.

The entire law is fulfilled in a single decree: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as fulfilled:

1. It means fulfilled. According to this interpretation, obeying the command to “love your neighbor” satisfies the requirements of the entire law. For example:

For the entire law is fulfilled in keeping this one command (NIV11) (BSB, NIV11, ESV, RSV, NASB, KJV, NCV)

1. It means sums up. According to this interpretation, the command to “love your neighbor” is a summary

of other laws such as “do not steal,” “do not murder,” and “do not commit adultery.” For example:

The entire law is summed up in a single command (NIV) (NIV, GNT, NET, NJB, NRSV, GW, CEV, NLT, REB, JBP)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This word is often translated as “fulfilled,” and many commentators follow this interpretation. Some commentators who follow interpretation (1) are Burton, p. 294; Betz, pp. 275–276; Fung, pp. 245–246; Longenecker pp. 242–243; and Lightfoot, p. 209.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

This one law fulfills/covers all the laws of Moses

Keeping this one law satisfies the requirements of the entire law of Moses

if you obey this one command, it is the same as obeying the entire law of Moses

in a single decree: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in a single decree means “in one statement” or “in one command.”

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

in a single statement (GW)

in a single command (NIV)

5:14b

“Love your neighbor as yourself.”

- “You^(sing) must love your neighbour as you love yourself.”
- “Love^(sing) others as much as you love yourself.”
- “Love^(sing) your neighbour as much as you love yourself.”

Love your neighbor as yourself: This clause is a quotation from Lev. 19:18.

Some other ways to translate this quotation are:

You must love your neighbor as you love yourself.

Love your neighbor as much as you love yourself.

In the way that you love yourself, show love also to your neighbor.

This same clause occurs in Matthew 19:19, 22:39, Mark 12:31, and Luke 10:27. You should translate it here as you did there.

your neighbor: The word neighbor refers to people who are around you. It does not only refer to the person who lives close to you.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

those you live among

others

your fellow man

General Comment on 5:14

In some languages, it will be more natural to change the order of some of the phrases in this verse. For example:

If you keep the command “love your neighbor as yourself,” you have fulfilled the entire law.

Galatians 5:15

Section 5:13–26: Let the Spirit of God lead you

In this section, Paul talked about what freedom means. He no longer focused on how a person is made righteous. He focused on how a person who has received the righteousness of Christ should live.

Paul told the Galatians that choosing to live their lives in the power of the Holy Spirit would keep them from living sinful lives. It would keep them from living as slaves to the law. A life lived in the Spirit is a life of love for each other.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Follow closely the Spirit of God

Obey God’s Spirit, not your sinful desires

Paragraph 5:13–15

In this paragraph, Paul stated that the freedom that the Galatians had in Christ did not mean that they could do whatever they wished. Their freedom did not permit them to live sinful lives. Instead, they should lovingly serve each other.

5:15a

But if you keep on biting and devouring one another,

- But if you^(plur) act like wild animals/dogs who bite and devour/eat each other,
- If you go on hurting each other and tearing each other apart (NCV)
- But when you^(plur) criticize and fight each other,

But: There is a contrast between 5:14b and 5:15. The contrast is between the command to love one another and the way that the Galatians were actually treating one another. The BSB indicates this contrast with the conjunction But.

if you keep on biting and devouring one another:

This clause is a metaphor. In this metaphor, the way that the Galatians were treating one another is compared to the kinds of actions that wild animals do. Paul implied that the actions of the sinful nature are as destructive as the actions of wild animals.

Paul used two words, biting and devouring (that is, eating), to emphasize how serious the situation in Galatia was.

Some ways to translate this metaphor are:

- Keep the metaphor but make the image explicit. For example:

if you are wild animals that bite and devour/eat one another

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make the image explicit. For example:

when you act like wild animals that bite and eat each other

if you act like wild animals, hurting and harming each other (GNT)

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

if you criticize and attack each other (GW)

devouring: The Greek word that the BSB translates as devouring is a word used for wild animals eating food. They eat greedily and swallow food without chewing it. This is not the normal word used to describe humans eating.

5:15b

watch out, or you will be consumed by one another.

- watch out, or you will completely destroy one another.
- be careful, or you will completely destroy each other. (NCV)
- be careful that you do not ruin the lives of each other.

watch out, or you will be consumed by one another:

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as consumed means “destroyed.” It refers to the results of biting and devouring one another. Paul asked the Galatians to stop and think about the effects of not loving one another.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

watch out or you will be destroyed by each other (NIV)

look out! Beware ruining one another.

be careful that you don’t destroy each other (GW)

Galatians 5:16

Section 5:13–26: Let the Spirit of God lead you

In this section, Paul talked about what freedom means. He no longer focused on how a person is made righteous. He focused on how a person who has received the righteousness of Christ should live.

Paul told the Galatians that choosing to live their lives in the power of the Holy Spirit would keep them from living sinful lives. It would keep them from living as slaves to the law. A life lived in the Spirit is a life of love for each other.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Follow closely the Spirit of God

Obey God’s Spirit, not your sinful desires

Paragraph 5:16–18

In this paragraph, Paul told the Galatians to allow the Holy Spirit to guide their lives. The Holy Spirit enables believers to not live sinful lives and not live as slaves to the law.

5:16a

So I say, walk by the Spirit,

- ¶ What I want to say is: walk/live^(plur) by following the Spirit,
- ¶ What I am trying to say is: submit to the Holy Spirit,
- ¶ What I mean is: let the Holy Spirit guide/lead you,

So I say: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as So I say introduces a further explanation of what 5:13–15 means.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

Let me explain further. (GW)

What I mean is this: (REB)

But I say, (ESV)

This same Greek expression occurs in 4:1a, where the BSB translates it as “What I am saying is.”

walk by the Spirit: This is a command. The word walk means “live” or “allow the Spirit to direct one’s life.” Paul wanted the Galatians to follow the Spirit’s leading.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Live by following the Spirit. (NCV)

let the Holy Spirit guide your lives (NLT)

submit yourselves to the Holy Spirit

Spirit: The word Spirit refers to the “Holy Spirit.” See Spirit, Meaning 1 in the Glossary.

5:16b

and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh.

- and you^(plur) will not do what your sinful nature desires/wants.
- and you will not do the acts that your corrupt human nature wants to do.
- then you will definitely not obey/satisfy what your evil heart/mind wants to do.

and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as will not gratify means “will not do” or “will not fulfill.” Those who follow the Spirit will not do what they would otherwise selfishly want to do.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Then you will not do what your sinful selves want. (NCV)

you won’t obey your selfish desires (CEV)

the desires of the flesh: This phrase refers to the desires/wants that come from our human nature.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

what your sinful nature craves (NLT)

what your corrupt nature wants (GW)

what your evil heart/mind wants

what you want because of your sinful nature

See flesh, Meaning 5 in the Glossary.

Galatians 5:17

Section 5:13–26: Let the Spirit of God lead you

In this section, Paul talked about what freedom means. He no longer focused on how a person is made righteous. He focused on how a person who has received the righteousness of Christ should live.

Paul told the Galatians that choosing to live their lives in the power of the Holy Spirit would keep them from living sinful lives. It would keep them from living as slaves to the law. A life lived in the Spirit is a life of love for each other.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Follow closely the Spirit of God

Obey God’s Spirit, not your sinful desires

Paragraph 5:16–18

In this paragraph, Paul told the Galatians to allow the Holy Spirit to guide their lives. The Holy Spirit enables believers to not live sinful lives and not live as slaves to the law.

5:17a

For the flesh craves what is contrary to the Spirit,

- For what the sinful nature desires/wants is against what the Spirit desires/wants,
- Our^(incl) corrupt human nature wants us to do what the Spirit does not want,

- The sinful self wants to do evil. This is opposed to what the Holy Spirit wants.

For: Verse 5:17 explains Paul's command and statement in 5:16. The Greek introduces this explanation with a conjunction that the BSB translates as *For*.

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to use a conjunction here either.

the flesh craves what is contrary to the Spirit: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as the flesh craves is similar to the phrase in 5:16b that the BSB translates as "the desires of the flesh." The difference is that here the word translated as craves is a verb in Greek. The entire clause means that our sinful human nature desires/wants what is against the Holy Spirit.

Some other ways to translate this clause are

What the evil heart/mind desires/wants is against what the Spirit desires/wants

The sinful nature wants to do evil, which is just the opposite of what the Spirit wants. (NLT)

the flesh: This is the same word as in 5:16b. You should translate it the same way.

See flesh, Meaning 5 in the Glossary.

5:17b

and the Spirit what is contrary to the flesh.

- and what the Spirit desires/wants is against what the sinful nature desires/wants.
- and the Spirit wants us to do what our^(incl) corrupt human nature does not want us to do.
- Likewise, what the Spirit wants is opposed to what the evil heart/mind wants.

and the Spirit what is contrary to the flesh: In this clause Paul focused on the Spirit's desires. Just as the sinful nature is opposed to the Spirit, so also the Spirit is opposed to the sinful nature. Paul stated that following the Spirit and gratifying the desires of the sinful nature cannot occur together.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

likewise what the Spirit desires/wants is against what the evil mind/heart desires/wants

And the Spirit gives us desires that are the opposite of what the sinful nature desires. (NLT)

Since 5:17a and 5:17b are parallel statements, your translation should also have parallel statements.

flesh: This is the same word as in 5:16b and 5:17a. You should translate it in the same way.

See flesh, Meaning 5 in the Glossary.

5:17c

They are opposed to each other,

- They are always fighting each other. (CEV)
- The Spirit and the corrupt human nature are against one other.
- They are enemies.

They are opposed to each other: The word *They* refers to the flesh and the Spirit. They are opposed to one another.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

These two are against each other

The Spirit and the sinful flesh are hostile to each other

These two things are enemies of each other

These two disagree with each other

5:17d

so that you do not do what you want.

- Therefore, you^(plur) do not do what you want to do.
- That is why you^(plur) cannot do what you want to do.
- As a result, you^(plur) cannot do the things that you want to do.

so that: Verse 5:17d further explains 5:17a–c. The Greek introduces this explanation with a conjunction that the BSB translates as *so that*.

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

you do not do what you want: There are several ways to interpret the way this clause is connected to "they are opposed to each other" in 5:17c. The two main interpretations are:

1. This clause expresses result. The flesh and the Spirit are opposed to each other, and as a result, you cannot do the things you want. For example:

As a result, you don't always do what you intend to do. (GW) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NET, REB, GW, NLT, KJV,

NCV, JBP) Many English versions are like the BSB, which translates 5:17d as “so that you do not do what you want.” This translation may appear to indicate purpose, but the verb is indicative, not subjunctive. Commentators tell us that this construction indicates result, i.e. “so that (as a result) you do not do what you want.”

1. This clause expresses purpose. The flesh and the Spirit are opposed to each other so that you cannot do the things you want to do. For example:

to prevent you from doing what you would (RSV)
(ESV, RSV, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), with the majority of English versions.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

therefore, you cannot do the things that you want to do

and that is why you are not free to do what you want to do (JBP)

Galatians 5:18

Section 5:13–26: Let the Spirit of God lead you

In this section, Paul talked about what freedom means. He no longer focused on how a person is made righteous. He focused on how a person who has received the righteousness of Christ should live.

Paul told the Galatians that choosing to live their lives in the power of the Holy Spirit would keep them from living sinful lives. It would keep them from living as slaves to the law. A life lived in the Spirit is a life of love for each other.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Follow closely the Spirit of God

Obey God’s Spirit, not your sinful desires

Paragraph 5:16–18

In this paragraph, Paul told the Galatians to allow the Holy Spirit to guide their lives. The Holy Spirit enables believers to not live sinful lives and not live as slaves to the law.

5:18a

But if you are led by the Spirit,

- If you are led/guided by the Spirit,
- If the Spirit leads you,
- If you obey the Holy Spirit,

5:18b

you are not under the law.

- you are not under the authority of the law.
- the Law of Moses has no control over you. (CEV)
- you are not required to follow/obey the law of Moses.

5:18a–b

But: In 5:17, the topic was both the flesh and the Spirit. In 5:18, the topic is only the Spirit. The Greek indicates this change with a conjunction that the BSB translates as But.

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

if you are led by the Spirit, you are not under the law: In this verse, Paul stated a further benefit of following the Spirit. That benefit is freedom from the law.

The verb are led is passive. Some ways to translate it are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

when you are directed by God’s Spirit, you are not under the authority of the law.

- Use an active verb. For example:

If the Spirit leads you, then you are not subject to the Law. (GNT)

if you allow the Holy Spirit to lead you, the law has no control over you.

you are not under the law: This phrase refers to being obligated to follow/obey the law of Moses.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

you are not under the authority of the law

you are not required to follow/obey the law of Moses

the Law of Moses has no control over you (CEV)

This phrase also occurs in 4:4c.

Galatians 5:19

Section 5:13–26: Let the Spirit of God lead you

In this section, Paul talked about what freedom means. He no longer focused on how a person is made righteous. He focused on how a person who has received the righteousness of Christ should live.

Paul told the Galatians that choosing to live their lives in the power of the Holy Spirit would keep them from living sinful lives. It would keep them from living as slaves to the law. A life lived in the Spirit is a life of love for each other.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Follow closely the Spirit of God

Obey God's Spirit, not your sinful desires

Paragraph 5:19–21

In this paragraph, Paul reminded the Galatians that they should not live sinful lives. He gave a list of examples of sinful actions. The list can be divided into several groups: sexual sins, wrong relationships to spiritual powers other than God, wrong relationships between people, and drunken living.

Paul's list is not intended as a complete list of sins. Paul listed sins that represent the kinds of actions that come from the sinful nature. There are many more such sins.

5:19a

The acts of the flesh are obvious:

- ¶ Now, the effects of the corrupt nature are obvious. (GW)
- ¶ The deeds of a evil heart/mind are clearly seen.
- ¶ The wrong things the sinful self does are clear: (NCV)

In 5:19, Paul began a new topic. He introduced this new topic with a Greek conjunction that most English versions translate as “now.” In this context, “now” is not a time word.

The BSB has not translated this conjunction, and some other versions, such as the NIV and NLT, also do not translate it. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either. Connect 5:19a to 5:18b in a way that is natural in your language.

The acts of the flesh are obvious: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as acts of the flesh refers to the sinful actions/deeds that a person does when he follows/obeys his corrupt human nature.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as obvious means “are clearly seen.”

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

The wrong things the sinful self does are clear (NCV)

Anyone can see the behaviour that belongs to the unspiritual nature (REB)

When you follow the desires of your sinful nature, the results are very clear (NLT)

Now, the effects of the corrupt nature are obvious (GW)

See flesh, Meaning 5 in the Glossary.

5:19b

sexual immorality, impurity, and debauchery;

- adultery, unclean acts, indecent conduct;
- They are fornication, filthy/evil thoughts, shameful deeds,
- being sexually unfaithful, not being pure, taking part in sexual sins, (NCV)

Paul's list of sinful actions begins here. Some ways to introduce this list are:

For example:

They are deeds such as:

The sinful nature shows itself in

sexual immorality, impurity, and debauchery:

In Greek, the three words that the BSB translates as sexual immorality, impurity, and debauchery all refer to sexual sins. They include sins of thought, sins of actions, and sinful desires.

In some languages, it will be possible to translate these three Greek words with three words or phrases. In other languages, it may be possible to use two terms to translate these three Greek terms.

sexual immorality: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sexual immorality refers to having sexual relations with someone you are not married to.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

fornication/adultery

being sexually unfaithful (NCV)

immoral...actions (GNT)

all kinds of immoral behavior with someone who is not your spouse

impurity: The Greek word that the BSB translates as impurity is more literally “uncleanness.” In the Bible, immoral acts are referred to as “unclean.” This word refers to any shameful or wrong activity in the area of sex.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

indecent

filthy thoughts (CEV)

filthy...actions (GNT)

disgusting sexual habits/thoughts

debauchery: The Greek word that the BSB translates as debauchery refers to indulging in wrong sexual desires, or being preoccupied with illicit sexual acts.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

perversion/indecency

taking part in sexual sins (NCV)

shameful deeds (CEV)

indecent actions (GNT)

Galatians 5:20

Section 5:13–26: Let the Spirit of God lead you

In this section, Paul talked about what freedom means. He no longer focused on how a person is made righteous. He focused on how a person who has received the righteousness of Christ should live.

Paul told the Galatians that choosing to live their lives in the power of the Holy Spirit would keep them from living sinful lives. It would keep them from living as

slaves to the law. A life lived in the Spirit is a life of love for each other.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Follow closely the Spirit of God

Obey God’s Spirit, not your sinful desires

Paragraph 5:19–21

In this paragraph, Paul reminded the Galatians that they should not live sinful lives. He gave a list of examples of sinful actions. The list can be divided into several groups: sexual sins, wrong relationships to spiritual powers other than God, wrong relationships between people, and drunken living.

Paul’s list is not intended as a complete list of sins. Paul listed sins that represent the kinds of actions that come from the sinful nature. There are many more such sins.

5:20a

idolatry and sorcery;

- the worship of idols, the practice of sorcery/witchcraft,
- worshipping the shrine, calling on evil spirits,
- worshipping gods, doing witchcraft, (NCV)

idolatry and sorcery: The two Greek words that the BSB translates as idolatry and sorcery refer to a wrong relationship to spiritual powers other than God.

idolatry: The word idolatry refers to the worship of idols. It refers to worshipping false gods and their images or statues.

(In a broader sense, it also refers to honoring something above God. Paul says in Colossians 3:5 that greed is idolatry.)

Some other ways to translate this word are:

worshipping idols

worship of the shrine

worshipping that which it is not proper to worship

sorcery: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sorcery refers to the use of magic words, objects, or rituals to interact with spirits.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

witchcraft (NIV)

calling on evil spirits

using the power which Satan gives

5:20b–21a

hatred, discord, jealousy, and rage; rivalries, divisions, factions: These words refer to wrong relationships between people. They result in conflict between people.

Paul used eight different words to describe these sinful actions. Some of these words are very close in meaning. In some languages, it may be possible to find eight words that match the general range of meaning of these eight sins. In other languages, one word or term may include the meaning of two of Paul's words. In other words, in some languages, it may be possible to translate the eight Greek words with fewer than eight terms. The meanings of the words that Paul used should guide your choices of words.

5:20b

hatred, discord, jealousy,

- hatred, quarrelling, jealousy, (JBP)
- hating, making trouble, being jealous, (NCV)
- becoming enemies, arguing/fighting, envy,

hatred: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hatred refers to being an enemy of someone and having hostile feelings and actions toward that person.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

People become enemies (GNT)

enmity (ESV)

people hate each other

discord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as discord refers to fights and conflicts between people.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

making trouble (NCV)

quarrelling (JBP)

people argue/fight

jealousy: The word jealousy refers to bad feelings toward another person because that person has something (including status or success) that you want. Some languages have idioms for these feelings, like “bitter stomach,” “black stomach,” or “evil eye.”

Some other ways to translate this word are:

being jealous

people are jealous/envious

5:20c

and rage; rivalries,

- anger, selfishness,
- having a bad temper, being selfish,
- being angry, thinking only about themselves/one-self,

rage: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rage refers to intense anger and a tendency to express that anger in a way that hurts other people.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

outbursts of anger (NET)

being angry (NCV)

bad temper (JBP)

anger (RSV)

people are angry

rivalries: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rivalries refers to a selfish desire to be more important than others.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

being selfish (NCV)

selfish ambition (NIV)

selfishness (RSV)

people want their own way

5:20d

divisions, factions,

- conflicts, divisions/factions
- separating into different parties and groups,
- being angry with each other, dividing into rival groups,

divisions: The Greek word that the BSB translates as divisions refers to people dividing into opposing groups. It refers to people separating themselves from people whom they do not agree with. They do this because they are angry with one another.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

conflict (GW)

dissensions (NASB)

making people angry with each other (NCV)

This word is very similar to the next word, which the BSB translates as factions.

factions: The Greek word that the BSB translates as factions refers to people dividing into different groups that are against one another. People unite with those people whom they agree with, and they are against the group that they disagree with.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

causing divisions among people (NCV)

division (NLT)

General Comment on 5:20d

Because the words “dissensions” and “divisions” are so similar, it is possible in some languages to translate these two words as one term. For example:

people divide into opposing groups

Galatians 5:21

Section 5:13–26: Let the Spirit of God lead you

In this section, Paul talked about what freedom means. He no longer focused on how a person is made righteous. He focused on how a person who has received the righteousness of Christ should live.

Paul told the Galatians that choosing to live their lives in the power of the Holy Spirit would keep them from living sinful lives. It would keep them from living as slaves to the law. A life lived in the Spirit is a life of love for each other.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Follow closely the Spirit of God

Obey God’s Spirit, not your sinful desires

Paragraph 5:19–21

In this paragraph, Paul reminded the Galatians that they should not live sinful lives. He gave a list of examples of sinful actions. The list can be divided into several groups: sexual sins, wrong relationships to spiritual powers other than God, wrong relationships between people, and drunken living.

Paul’s list is not intended as a complete list of sins. Paul listed sins that represent the kinds of actions that come from the sinful nature. There are many more such sins.

5:21a

and envy; drunkenness, orgies,

- envy, drunkenness, carousing,
- being envious, drinking bouts, celebrating in immoral ways,
- wanting the possessions of other people, being drunk, having wild parties,

envy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as envy refers to bad feelings toward others because you want something they have. It is very close in meaning to the word above that the BSB translates as “jealousy.” In some languages, there may be only one word for these two Greek words.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

envying (NET)

feeling envy (NCV)

people want the possessions of others

drunkenness, orgies: These words refer to drunken living. Such a person ignores his responsibilities to others.

drunkenness: The word drunkenness refers to drinking too much alcohol so that one is unable to think clearly.

Some ways to translate this word are:

being drunk (NCV)

get drunk (CEV)

drinking too much alcohol

orgies: The Greek word that the BSB translates as orgies refers to wild parties with much drinking in which many evil things occur. They often result in people committing sexual sins and other sins.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

carousing

having wild and wasteful parties (NCV)

evil celebrations

5:21b and the like.

- and many other sins like these.
- and other evil deeds like these.
- and doing other wrong actions like these.

and the like: The phrase and the like indicates that there are many more actions that come from the sinful nature. They are like the ones Paul listed. The Galatians would be able to recognize other “works of the flesh” not included in his list.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

and doing other things like these (NCV)

and do other evil things as well (CEV)

and many other sins like these

and similar things (NET)

5:21c I warn you, as I did before,

- I am warning you, as I had warned you before: (NET)
- I’ve told you in the past and I’m telling you again: (GW)
- I told you before, and I am telling you again: (CEV)

I warn you, as I did before: The clause as I did before probably refers to some of Paul’s teaching when he was with them in person. The warning in this letter is not the first time that Paul has warned the Galatians about the consequences of doing the sins that he just listed.

Some other ways to translate these clauses are:

I am warning you, as I had warned you before (NET)

I told you before, and I am telling you again (CEV)

5:21d that those who practice such things will not inherit the kingdom of God.

- people who do things like that will not live in the kingdom of God.
- no one who does these things will be included in God’s kingdom.
- people who behave like this will have no part/portion in God’s ruling/reigning of his people.

that those who practice such things will not inherit the kingdom of God: The word inherit means “receive” something that has been promised. People who do the works of the flesh will not inherit/receive God’s kingdom. This means that they will not enter/live in God’s kingdom. They will not be citizens of the kingdom.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

those who do such things will not have a part/portion in the kingdom of God

those who do these things will not enter into God’s kingdom

that those who indulge in such things will never be included in God’s kingdom

no one who does these sins will live in God’s kingdom

kingdom of God: The phrase kingdom of God refers to God’s activity of ruling and caring for his people as their king. It does not refer to a land or country that he rules over. It refers to the relationship that he has with his people. He leads, protects, and cares for them. They obey, trust, and submit to him as their king.

Some ways to translate this phrase are:

- As a noun. For example:

God’s rule/reign

- God's kingship
- God's chieftaincy
- God's government
- As a verbal expression:
 - God rules his people
 - God cares for his people as king

See also kingdom in the Glossary.

Galatians 5:22

Section 5:13–26: Let the Spirit of God lead you

In this section, Paul talked about what freedom means. He no longer focused on how a person is made righteous. He focused on how a person who has received the righteousness of Christ should live.

Paul told the Galatians that choosing to live their lives in the power of the Holy Spirit would keep them from living sinful lives. It would keep them from living as slaves to the law. A life lived in the Spirit is a life of love for each other.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

- Follow closely the Spirit of God
- Obey God's Spirit, not your sinful desires

Paragraph 5:22–23

In this paragraph, Paul reminded the Galatians that following the Spirit results in godly character. That godly character is in contrast to the works of the sinful nature.

5:22a

But the fruit of the Spirit is

- ¶ But what comes from the Spirit is
- ¶ However, the Spirit causes a person to
- ¶ But when the Spirit of God leads a person, that person

But: There is a contrast between 5:19–21 and 5:22. The contrast is between the “the acts of the flesh” and the “fruit of the Spirit.” The BSB indicates this contrast with the word But.

Some other ways to show this contrast are:

In contrast

However

the fruit of the Spirit is: Here the word fruit is used in a figurative sense. It refers to the characteristics of a person whom the Spirit leads. The Holy Spirit living in a person produces these characteristics. In most languages, it will not be possible to use the word fruit in this figurative way.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

the Spirit causes a person to

if a person is led by the Spirit, he is

what comes from the Spirit is

when the Spirit leads/guides a person, that person has the following behavior/characteristics:

5:22b–d

In this list, the focus is on Christian character. It is not a list of actions. In some languages, there are idioms for these characteristics.

Some of these words are similar, and some languages may have a term that covers two of these Greek words.

5:22b

love, joy, peace,

- love, joy/happiness, peace/harmony,
- love others, rejoice, be at peace with others,
- loves others, he is joyful/happy, he lives in peace/harmony with others,

love: Here the word love refers primarily to loving other people.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

to love others

he loves others

joy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as joy means “gladness” and “happiness” that come from the presence of the Holy Spirit in us.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

to rejoice

gladness

he is happy

peace: The Greek word that The BSB translates as peace refers to harmony and well-being.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

to be at peace

calmness

he lives in harmony with others

5:22c

patience, kindness, goodness,

- patience, helpfulness, goodness,
- be patient with others, be kind, be good,
- he endures whatever happens, he is kind, he is good/generous to others,

patience: The Greek word that the BSB translates as patience refers to endurance or longsuffering. It characterizes a person who does not easily become angry, even when he is insulted. He is ready to forgive other people when they do wrong to him. He does not complain.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

to be patient

tolerant with others

he endures whatever happens

kindness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as kindness refers to kind actions towards other people.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

to be kind to others

he is helpful/generous

to be considerate of people

goodness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as goodness is similar to kindness. This word refers to moral excellence, an upright character. Nothing bad

can be said about such a person. It also includes generosity.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

uprightness

generosity

he does good to others

5:22d

faithfulness,

- trustworthiness,
- be faithful,
- he does what he says he will do,

faithfulness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as faithfulness refers to dependability and reliability.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

to be faithful

he is dependable/reliable

people can trust him

he does what he says he will do

See faith, Meaning 3 in the Glossary for more information.

Galatians 5:23

Section 5:13–26: Let the Spirit of God lead you

In this section, Paul talked about what freedom means. He no longer focused on how a person is made righteous. He focused on how a person who has received the righteousness of Christ should live.

Paul told the Galatians that choosing to live their lives in the power of the Holy Spirit would keep them from living sinful lives. It would keep them from living as slaves to the law. A life lived in the Spirit is a life of love for each other.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Follow closely the Spirit of God

Obey God's Spirit, not your sinful desires

Paragraph 5:22–23

In this paragraph, Paul reminded the Galatians that following the Spirit results in godly character. That godly character is in contrast to the works of the sinful nature.

5:23a**gentleness, and self-control.**

- humility and control of oneself.
- be gentle and be self-disciplined.
- he is humble, and he can refuse what his body wants.

gentleness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gentleness refers to humility and considerateness.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

humility

to be gentle

he is humble/meek

self-control: The Greek word that the BSB translates as self-control refers to being disciplined. It is the strength of character to do what is right to do.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

control of oneself

to be self-disciplined

he controls his desires

he can refuse what his body wants

5:23b**Against such things there is no law.**

- There is no law against these things.
- There is no law that says these things are wrong. (NCV)
- There are no laws against things like that. (GW)

Against such things there is no law: The phrase such things refers to the fruits of the Spirit mentioned above. There is no law against doing these things. Everyone agrees that these characteristics are good.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

There is no law against behaving in any of these ways. (CEV)

There are no laws against things like that. (GW)

There is no law that says these things are wrong. (NCV)

Galatians 5:24**Section 5:13–26: Let the Spirit of God lead you**

In this section, Paul talked about what freedom means. He no longer focused on how a person is made righteous. He focused on how a person who has received the righteousness of Christ should live.

Paul told the Galatians that choosing to live their lives in the power of the Holy Spirit would keep them from living sinful lives. It would keep them from living as slaves to the law. A life lived in the Spirit is a life of love for each other.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Follow closely the Spirit of God

Obey God's Spirit, not your sinful desires

Paragraph 5:24–26

This paragraph is the conclusion to this section. In this paragraph, Paul reminded the Galatians that the works of the flesh have been crucified. So they should walk by the Spirit.

5:24a**Those who belong to Christ Jesus**

- ¶ Those people who belong to Christ Jesus
- ¶ Those who are Jesus the Christ's people,
- ¶ When we^(incl) are Christ Jesus' people/followers,

Those who belong to Christ Jesus: This clause is similar in meaning to "those who are in Christ" and "you are led by the Spirit" (in 5:18a). All these clauses refer to believers.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Those who are of Christ Jesus

Those who are Christ Jesus' people

Those who are united with Jesus Christ

5:24b**have crucified the flesh with its passions and desires.**

- have crucified the sinful nature together with its passions and desires.
- it's as if they have nailed to a cross their corrupt nature. They have put to death their cravings and evil desires.
- we do not allow our sinful/evil hearts to rule/command us.

have crucified the flesh: The clause that the BSB translates as have crucified the flesh means “have put the human nature to death on a cross.”

This clause is a metaphor. In this metaphor, stopping the works of the flesh is compared to crucifying a person. They are similar in that both end certain actions. Believers no longer live dominated by the sinful nature.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Keep the metaphor of crucifixion. For example:

have nailed the sinful nature to the cross

- Keep the part of the metaphor about killing the flesh. For example:

have put to death the corrupt nature

we have killed our selfish feelings (CEV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

it is as if they have crucified their sinful nature

have stopped doing what their sinful self wants.
It's as if they have nailed to the cross their sinful nature

- Translate the meaning directly without using a figure of speech. For example:

have stopped doing what their sinful self wants

their evil hearts no longer rule/command them

See flesh, Meaning 5 in the Glossary.

with its passions and desires: The two Greek nouns that the BSB translates as passions and desires are

a doublet. This means that these two words mean almost the same thing. These words refer to the longings that come naturally from the sinful nature. These longings are also crucified.

Some ways to translate these two nouns are:

- Find two terms in your language to translate these two nouns. For example:

selfish feelings and desires (CEV)

evil cravings and desires

- Translate both Greek nouns with one word plus an intensifier. For example:

with its lustful affections

our evil desires

Galatians 5:25**Section 5:13–26: Let the Spirit of God lead you**

In this section, Paul talked about what freedom means. He no longer focused on how a person is made righteous. He focused on how a person who has received the righteousness of Christ should live.

Paul told the Galatians that choosing to live their lives in the power of the Holy Spirit would keep them from living sinful lives. It would keep them from living as slaves to the law. A life lived in the Spirit is a life of love for each other.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Follow closely the Spirit of God

Obey God's Spirit, not your sinful desires

Paragraph 5:24–26

This paragraph is the conclusion to this section. In this paragraph, Paul reminded the Galatians that the works of the flesh have been crucified. So they should walk by the Spirit.

5:25a**Since we live by the Spirit,**

- If the Spirit is the source of our life, (REB)
- Since we get our new life from the Holy Spirit,
- The Spirit of God has given us^(incl) new life,

Since we live by the Spirit: In Greek this phrase is more literally “If we live by the Spirit.” It is a rhetorical question in Greek. In this “if” clause, Paul stated a true fact. The Galatians, as believers, received life from the Spirit. In some languages, it may be more natural to translate the “if” by “since,” as the BSB has done. In other languages, it may be best to leave it untranslated. For example:

Since we are living by the Spirit, (NLT)

We get our new life from the Spirit (NCV)

we live by the Spirit: This clause means that believers get their new life from the Spirit. The Spirit is the source of their spiritual life.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

the Spirit is the source of our life (REB)

God’s Spirit has given us life (CEV)

We get our new life from the Spirit (NCV)

5:25b

let us walk in step with the Spirit.

- let us live as the Spirit wants us to live
- we must let the Spirit direct/guide us.
- and so we should follow the Spirit. (CEV)

let us walk in step with the Spirit: In Greek the word the BSB translates as let us walk is more literally “let us follow” or “let us be in line with.” Paul wanted the Galatians to follow closely the Spirit’s leading and allow the Spirit to direct their lives. This command is similar to 5:16a, but the Greek verbs are different.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

let us live as the Spirit wants us to live

let him be the one who leads/guides us

and so we should follow the Spirit (CEV)

Galatians 5:26

Section 5:13–26: Let the Spirit of God lead you

In this section, Paul talked about what freedom means. He no longer focused on how a person is

made righteous. He focused on how a person who has received the righteousness of Christ should live.

Paul told the Galatians that choosing to live their lives in the power of the Holy Spirit would keep them from living sinful lives. It would keep them from living as slaves to the law. A life lived in the Spirit is a life of love for each other.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Follow closely the Spirit of God

Obey God’s Spirit, not your sinful desires

Paragraph 5:24–26

This paragraph is the conclusion to this section. In this paragraph, Paul reminded the Galatians that the works of the flesh have been crucified. So they should walk by the Spirit.

5:26a

Let us not become conceited,

- Let us not become proud
- We should not be boastful.
- We must not become arrogant.

Let us not become conceited: The Greek word that the BSB translates as conceited means “proud” or “boastful.” It is what people do when they think of themselves as better than others.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

We must not be proud (GNT)

Let us not be arrogant/boastful

We must not become someone who always tells people how great he is

5:26b

provoking and envying one another.

- and irritate one another and envy one another.
- We should not make trouble with each other and be jealous of each other.
- We must not challenge one another. We must not be envious of one another.

provoking and envying one another: In Greek, this phrase is literally “provoking one another and envying one another.” The BSB has translated one another only once, and some other English versions do the same. For example:

provoke or envy each other (GW)

In some languages it will also be natural to translate this phrase only once.

provoking...one another The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as provoking...one another refers to “irritating” and “annoying” fellow believers. It was used in Greek of someone challenging another person to a fight, and it can be translated that way. For example:

challenging one another (NASB)

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

make trouble with each other (NCV)

let us not irritate each other

envying one another: The Greek word that the BSB translates as envying refers to jealousy among believers. It is the verb form of the noun used in 5:21a. It refers to emotions that lead to attempts to destroy another person or his possessions because of feelings of envy.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

let us not be jealous of one another

we must not be envious of one another

Galatians 6:1

Section 6:1–10: How to walk in the Spirit together with fellow believers

In this section, Paul asked the Galatians to continue to live a life directed by the Holy Spirit. He encouraged them to help one another and do good deeds.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Believers fulfill the law of Christ when they help each other

Help Carry Each Other's Burdens (GW)

Help Each Other (NCV)

6:1a

Brothers, if someone is caught in a trespass,

- ¶ Brothers, if one of you^(plur) yields to sin,

- ¶ My friends, if one of you is defeated by a certain sin,
- ¶ My fellow believers, if someone among you sins,

Brothers: This word refers to all the believers in Galatia. It includes both men and women. Paul used this word to show that he loved the Galatians and was concerned for them.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

Brothers and sisters (NET)

My dear fellow believers

My friends (NRSV)

if someone is caught in a trespass: There are two ways to interpret the Greek clause that the BSB translates as if someone is caught in a trespass:

1. It means that sin has overcome or overpowered a person. According to this interpretation, someone has yielded to a desire to do something wrong. For example:

if another believer is overcome by some sin (NLT) (RSV, NLT, CEV, GW, NCV, KJV)

1. It means that someone has caught or discovered another person in the act of sinning. He has surprised him.

if one of you is caught doing something wrong (NJB) (BSB, NRSV, NIV, ESV, NASB, NET, NJB, REB, GNT, JBP)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). See Longenecker, who argues that the verb in the passive voice, as it is in this verse, means “overtaken” or “entrapped” by something (p. 272). The main point is what to do when a sin is committed, not whether or how a sin is discovered.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

if someone is trapped in sin (CEV)

if a person among you yields to sin

if someone in your group does something wrong (NCV)

6:1b

you who are spiritual should restore him with a spirit of gentleness.

- you^(plur) who walk with the Spirit should gently restore that person to fellowship.
- you who submit to the Spirit, you should humbly bring him back onto the right path.
- you whom the Spirit leads/guides should help make him right again. You should do it in a humble/kind way.

you who are spiritual: This clause means “you who live/walk by the Spirit.” Some believers are more mature or advanced in following the Holy Spirit than others. They are the ones who have the proper character to restore a believer who has sinned.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

you who walk with the Spirit

you who live by the Spirit

you whom the Spirit leads/guides

you who submit to the Holy Spirit

should restore him with a spirit of gentleness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as restore means “mend, restore, set right, and make complete.” Here it means that spiritual believers should seek to lead the sinful person back into a right relationship with God and fellow believers.

They should restore him with a spirit of gentleness. This means that they should be humble and kind as they lead the sinful person back into a right relationship with God.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

you should gently lead that person back to the right path (CEV)

should go to that person and gently help make him right again (NCV)

they should bring him back to fellowship in a humble/kind manner

6:1c

But watch yourself,

- And watch yourself^(sing),
- At the same time pay attention,
- But be careful,

But watch yourself: The Greek word that the BSB translates as watch means “look at” or “pay attention to.” Paul warned the people who were to restore the sinner that they should not think too highly about themselves. They should not think that they themselves could never be tempted.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

At the same time watch yourself (GW)

But be on your guard

But be careful (NCV)

6:1d

or you also may be tempted.

- so that you^(sing) too are not tempted.
- because you too may be tempted by Satan to sin.
- lest Satan also tempt you, and you sin.

or you also may be tempted: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as or you also may be tempted can also be translated as “so that you too are not tempted to sin.” Here the verb does not only mean being tempted but actually giving in to temptation and sinning.

This verb is passive. Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

so that you are not tempted too (NET)

because you too might be tempted by Satan to sin

- Use an active or other non-passive verb. For example:

not to fall into the same temptation yourself (NLT)

so that Satan does not also tempt you, and you too sin

you: Paul changed from the plural “you” in 6:1b to the singular “you” here in order to address each person individually. However, it is acceptable to use a plural form if your language requires it. For example:

so that you^(plur) too will not be tempted

Galatians 6:2

Section 6:1–10: How to walk in the Spirit together with fellow believers

In this section, Paul asked the Galatians to continue to live a life directed by the Holy Spirit. He encouraged them to help one another and do good deeds.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Believers fulfill the law of Christ when they help each other

Help Carry Each Other's Burdens (GW)

Help Each Other (NCV)

6:2a

Carry one another's burdens,

- Help carry each other's burdens. (GW)
- Help^(plur) each other when you have difficulties and problems. These are like burdens/loads.
- If someone has difficulties/problems, help him.

Carry one another's burdens: This clause is a command that means "help to carry each other's loads."

This clause is a metaphor. In this metaphor, Paul encouraged believers to help one another. He compared the difficulties of temptations and sin in 6:1 to a burden. The word burdens also probably represents other types of difficulties such as suffering, pain, and other problems. These things are similar to burdens in that they all are difficult to experience. Paul commanded the believers to help each other in these situations.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

Help carry one another's burdens (GNT)

- Make parts of the metaphor explicit. For example:

Help each other with your heavy burdens of temptations and difficulties

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

Problems and troubles are like burdens/loads.
Help one another carry these loads.

- Translate the meaning directly without using a figure of speech. For example:

Help each other with your difficulties and sufferings

If you see that someone is suffering, help him.

6:2b

and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ.

- In this way you^(plur) will fulfill/obey Christ's law.
- By helping each other, you^(plur) will obey what the law of Christ says that you must do.
- When you help each other, you follow the law that Christ taught/commanded.

and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ:

There is a textual variant here with the tense/aspect of the verb fulfill:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the future tense of the verb fulfill. For example:

and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ (BSB, NIV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NET, NRSV, GW, CEV, NCV, REB)

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the imperative (command) form of the verb fulfill. For example:

and so fulfil the law of Christ (RSV) (ESV, RSV, NASB, KJV, NLT, JBP)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This is the choice of the UBS Greek New Testament.

you will fulfill the law of Christ: The phrase the law of Christ refers to the law that Christ taught. He taught us to love our neighbor as ourselves. When we help someone, we are fulfilling/obeying the law to love one another.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

By helping each other, you will truly fulfill/obey the law that Christ taught/commanded.

and in this way you will obey the law of Christ (GNT)

In this way you will follow Christ's teachings. (GW)

Galatians 6:3

Section 6:1–10: How to walk in the Spirit together with fellow believers

In this section, Paul asked the Galatians to continue to live a life directed by the Holy Spirit. He encouraged them to help one another and do good deeds.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Believers fulfill the law of Christ when they help each other

Help Carry Each Other's Burdens (GW)

Help Each Other (NCV)

6:3a

If anyone thinks he is something when he is nothing,

- Because if anyone thinks that he is important when he really is not important,
- I say these things because if someone thinks that he is an important/big person, when he is not,
- If you^(sing) think that you are important, but you are really not important,

In this verse, Paul described the basis for the three warnings/commands that precede it. He introduced this basis with a Greek conjunction that most English versions translate as “for.”

1. This is the basis for the warning not to be conceited in 5:26a. In other words:

^{5:26a}Do not become conceited... ^{6:3a}for/because if you think that you are something..., ^{6:3b}you deceive yourself.

1. This is the basis for the warning to watch yourself lest you be tempted in 6:1c–d. In other words:

^{6:1c–d}Do not think that you are above being tempted... ^{6:3a}for/because if you think that you are something... ^{6:3b}you deceive yourself and can be tempted.

1. This is the basis for the warning to bear one another's burdens in 6:2a. In other words:

^{6:2a}Bear one another's burdens, ^{6:3}for/because you are not more important than other people.

Some other ways to begin this verse are:

I say these things because

Follow these commands, because

The BSB has not translated this conjunction, and some other versions, such as the NIV and NLT, also do not translate it. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either. Connect 3:16a to these preceding warnings/commands in a way that is natural in your language.

If anyone thinks he is something: This clause means “if anyone thinks that he is important.” He thinks that he is more important than other people

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

If anyone thinks he is important (NCV)

Someone who thinks himself important (NJB)

If you think that you are an important/big person

when he is nothing: This clause means “when he is not an important person.” Some other ways to translate this clause are:

when he is not (NJB)

but he is not important/big

but/when you are not an important person

6:3b

he deceives himself.

- then he is deceiving himself.
- he is only fooling himself.
- you are lying to yourself.

he deceives himself: Some other ways to translate this clause are:

he is only fooling himself (NCV)

you are wrong (CEV)

Galatians 6:4

Section 6:1–10: How to walk in the Spirit together with fellow believers

In this section, Paul asked the Galatians to continue to live a life directed by the Holy Spirit. He encouraged them to help one another and do good deeds.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Believers fulfill the law of Christ when they help each other

Help Carry Each Other's Burdens (GW)

Help Each Other (NCV)

6:4a

Each one should test his own work.

- But each person should examine his own actions.
- But each person must evaluate his own deeds.
- Look^(sing) at your own conduct to see if it is good.

There is a contrast here. The contrast is between the person who deceives himself into thinking that he is something (6:3) and the person who tests his own work and accurately knows whether he has done something well. Paul introduced this contrast with a Greek conjunction that many English versions translate as “but.” The BSB has not translated this conjunction, and some other versions, such as the NIV and NET, also do not translate it. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either. Connect 6:4a to 6:3b in a way that is natural in your language.

Each one should test his own work: The Greek word that the BSB translates as test also means “examine” or “judge” in the sense of “evaluate.” The Greek word that the BSB translates as work means “deeds” or “actions.” This means that each person should evaluate his own actions to see if they are good or bad. He should not compare his actions with other people's actions.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Each of you must examine your own actions. (GW)

Let every man learn to assess properly the value of his own work. (JBP)

Each person should test/evaluate his own deeds to see if they are good.

Each person must look at his own deeds and see if they are good.

6:4b

Then he will have reason to boast in himself alone,

- Then he can be proud of what he himself has done
- If they are good, then he can be glad about what he has done.
- If it is good, then you^(sing) can rejoice in what you yourself have done.

There is some implied information here. It is “if he has seen that his deeds are good.” For example:

If it is good, then (GNT)

If his deeds are good, then

Then he will have reason to boast in himself alone:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as reason to boast means “the thing of which one is proud” or “that in which one rejoices.” The Bible often mentions that “boasting” and “pride” are sins. But here the Greek word is used in a good sense.

In many languages, the word boast is only used in a negative sense of excessive bragging. These languages may have to use a word or phrase such as “be glad” or “be happy about himself.”

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

then you can be proud of what you yourself have done (GNT)

Then you can be proud of your own accomplishments (GW)

then he can be glad/happy because of what he himself has done

6:4c

and not in someone else.

- without comparing himself to somebody else. (NIV)
- He should not compare his deeds with another person's deeds.
- Do not rejoice only when what you^(sing) did is better than what another person did.

and not in someone else: This phrase means that a person's reason for happiness should not be in comparing himself with someone else. He should not compare himself to other people and be happy only if he is better than they are.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

without having to compare it with what someone else has done (GNT)

He should not be happy that what he has done is better than what someone else has done.

But don't compare yourself with others. (CEV)

Galatians 6:5

Section 6:1-10: How to walk in the Spirit together with fellow believers

In this section, Paul asked the Galatians to continue to live a life directed by the Holy Spirit. He encouraged them to help one another and do good deeds.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Believers fulfill the law of Christ when they help each other

Help Carry Each Other's Burdens (GW)

Help Each Other (NCV)

6:5

For each one should carry his own load.

- For each of us must bear/carry our own load.
- I say this because each person must do the work that God has given him. This is like being responsible to carry his own load.
- For we are each responsible for our own conduct. (NLT)

For: Verse 6:5 is the basis for the command in 6:4a that "each person should test his own work." The Greek introduces this basis with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For.

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

each one should carry his own load: This clause is a metaphor. In this metaphor, the work/responsibilities that God has given each believer are compared to

bearing/carrying a load. Believers must concentrate on doing the work for which they themselves are responsible.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

We each must carry our own load. (CEV)

each of us are responsible for carrying the load that God has given us

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

We must each do the work that God has given each of us, like someone who is responsible/assigned to carry his own load.

- Translate the meaning directly without using a figure of speech. For example:

we are each responsible for our own conduct (NLT)

load: In some languages, it may be necessary to translate the word load here in 6:5 with the same word as "burden" in 6:2. In such a situation, there may be an apparent conflict between 6:2 and 6:5. On the one hand, we are to bear one another's burdens/loads. On the other hand, we are to bear our own loads.

The words translated as "burden" and load are different in Greek. So you may have to say something like "heavy load" in 6:2 to distinguish it from load here.

Galatians 6:6

Section 6:1-10: How to walk in the Spirit together with fellow believers

In this section, Paul asked the Galatians to continue to live a life directed by the Holy Spirit. He encouraged them to help one another and do good deeds.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Believers fulfill the law of Christ when they help each other

Help Carry Each Other's Burdens (GW)

Help Each Other (NCV)

6:6a**Nevertheless, the one who receives instruction in the word**

- ¶ The person who is taught the word of God
- ¶ Those to whom a teacher teaches the word of God
- ¶ When someone teaches you^(plur) the word of God,

Nevertheless: This verse begins with a Greek conjunction. The BSB translates it as Nevertheless in order to show that it introduces a contrast. The contrast is between “each one” carrying “his own load” (6:5) and believers helping their instructors. While the NIV also translates this conjunction as “Nevertheless” and a few other versions translate it as “But,” most English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either. Connect 6:6a to 6:5 in a way that is natural in your language.

the one who receives instruction in the word: This clause refers to a person/student who is taught the word of God.

This clause is passive. Some ways to translate it are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

The person who is taught the word of God

- Use an active verb. For example:

Anyone who is learning the teaching of God (NCV)

Each person to whom a teacher teaches the word of God

6:6b**must share in all good things with his instructor.**

- should share all the good things he has with the person who teaches him.
- must share their possessions with those who teach them.
- you^(plur) should give some money to him.

must share in all good things with his instructor:

This clause is an indirect way to say that the student should pay his teacher. He should willingly give money or goods to the teacher. This is because the teacher may not have enough time to earn his own living by other work. (See also 2 Corinthians 9:6–12 for a similar passage about giving material things to those who serve us spiritually.)

Some other ways to translate this verse are:

should share all the good things he has with his teacher (NCV)

should help their teachers by paying them (NLT96)

he should give his teacher a share in all his possessions (NJB)

Galatians 6:7**Section 6:1–10: How to walk in the Spirit together with fellow believers**

In this section, Paul asked the Galatians to continue to live a life directed by the Holy Spirit. He encouraged them to help one another and do good deeds.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Believers fulfill the law of Christ when they help each other

Help Carry Each Other's Burdens (GW)

Help Each Other (NCV)

6:7a**Do not be deceived: God is not to be mocked.**

- Do not deceive yourselves. God is not one to be mocked/ridiculed,
- Do not lie to yourselves. You cannot fool God.
- Do not fool yourselves. It is not possible to trick/cheat God.

Do not be deceived: This clause means that the Galatians should not deceive themselves. They should not deceive themselves by thinking that they can follow the old sinful habits without experiencing God's judgment.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

Do not deceive yourselves. (GNT)

Do not be fooled (NCV)

Do not lie to yourselves

God is not to be mocked: This clause means that God is not one to be mocked/ridiculed. Those who live in sin ridicule God. God will not overlook sin. So the Galatians deceive themselves if they think that God will not see their sin and punish them.

Some other ways to translate this sentence are:

no one makes a fool of God (GNT)

You cannot cheat God. (NCV)

Do not try to trick/outwit God.

6:7b

Whatever a man sows, he will reap in return.

- because a person will harvest exactly what he has sown.
- I say this because what a man plants in his field, that's also what he will harvest.
- The type of seed that you sow/plant on your farm, that is the type of seed that you will harvest.

In this verse part, Paul gave the reason for what he said in 6:7a. We should not deceive ourselves into thinking that we can trick God, for/because we will reap what we sow. Paul introduced this explanation with a Greek conjunction that most English versions translate as “for.” The BSB has not translated this conjunction, and some other versions, such as the NIV and NLT, also do not translate it. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either. Connect 6:7b to 6:7a in a way that is natural in your language.

Whatever a man sows, he will reap in return: This was a well-known proverb/saying. Paul used it to explain that God will reward those who live a godly life. He will punish those who sin. This proverb is further explained in 6:8.

Some other ways to translate this proverb are:

whatever a person sows, that is what he will reap.

what someone plants, that's also what he will harvest.

Galatians 6:8

Section 6:1–10: How to walk in the Spirit together with fellow believers

In this section, Paul asked the Galatians to continue to live a life directed by the Holy Spirit. He encouraged them to help one another and do good deeds.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Believers fulfill the law of Christ when they help each other

Help Carry Each Other's Burdens (GW)

Help Each Other (NCV)

6:8a

The one who sows to please his flesh,

- If you plant in [the soil of] your corrupt nature (GW)
- The person who does what pleases his sinful self is like a person who sows/plants in corrupt/contaminated soil.
- Those who live only to satisfy their own sinful nature (NLT)

In this verse, Paul explained the meaning of the proverb that he quoted in 6:7b, “Whatever a man sows, he will reap in return.” Paul introduced this explanation with a Greek conjunction that most English versions translate as “for.” Some other ways to introduce this explanation are:

because (NET)

This means that

The BSB has not translated this conjunction, and some other versions, such as the NIV and NLT, also do not translate it. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either. Connect 6:8a to 6:7b in a way that is natural in your language.

The one who sows to please his flesh: This clause is the negative side of a metaphor. In this metaphor, Paul compared a person doing things that please his evil desires to a person sowing seeds in corrupted/contaminated soil. The person's own flesh (or sinful human nature) is the corrupted soil.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Keep the entire metaphor of sowing in corrupted soil. For example:

If you plant in the field of your natural desires (GNT)

If you plant in the soil of your corrupt nature (GW)

- Keep only the part of the metaphor about sowing. For example:

The one who sows to please his sinful nature (NIV)

If they plant to satisfy their sinful selves (NCV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

The person who does what pleases his sinful self is like a person who sows seeds in contaminated soil.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

Those who live only to satisfy their own sinful nature (NLT)

If you follow your selfish desires (CEV)

6:8b

from the flesh will reap destruction;

- from it you will gather the harvest of death. (GNT)
- He will reap/harvest death.
- will die and be punished forever.

from the flesh will reap destruction: This clause continues the metaphor. In this part of the metaphor, the person reaps/harvests a crop from the soil/field of his flesh. What he reaps is corruption. The word destruction refers to eternal destruction. It is the opposite of eternal life. So the results of living to please one's sinful desires are death and destruction.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Keep the metaphor of reaping. For example:

from it you will gather the harvest of death (GNT)

you will harvest destruction (GW)

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

his reward will be to die and be punished forever

See flesh, Meaning 5 in the Glossary.

6:8c

but the one who sows to please the Spirit,

- But if you plant in the soil of the Holy Spirit,
- But the person who does what pleases the Spirit of God is like a person who sows/plants in good soil.

- But those who live to please the Spirit (NLT)

but the one who sows to please the Spirit: This clause is the positive side of the metaphor. In this part, Paul compared a person who does things that please the Holy Spirit to a person who sows in good soil. The Holy Spirit is the good soil.

Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Keep the metaphor of sowing in good soil. For example:

if you plant in the field of the Spirit (GNT)

- Keep the part of the metaphor about sowing. For example:

the one who sows to please the Spirit (BSB, NIV)

if they plant to please the Spirit (NCV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

The person who does what pleases the Spirit is like a person who sows seeds in good soil.

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

those who live to please the Spirit (NLT)

6:8d

from the Spirit will reap eternal life.

- from the Spirit you will gather the harvest of eternal life. (GNT)
- He will reap/harvest eternal life.
- will live forever.

from the Spirit will reap eternal life: This clause is the last part of the metaphor. In this part, the person reaps/harvests a crop from the field of the Holy Spirit. What he reaps is eternal life. So the result of living to please the Holy Spirit is life everlasting.

Some ways to translate this sentence are:

- Keep the metaphor of reaping. For example:

from the Spirit you will gather the harvest of eternal life (GNT)

you will harvest everlasting life (GW)

- Translate the meaning without using a figure of speech. For example:

they will receive eternal life from the Spirit (NCV)

he will get/have eternal life

See Spirit in the Glossary.

Galatians 6:9

Section 6:1–10: How to walk in the Spirit together with fellow believers

In this section, Paul asked the Galatians to continue to live a life directed by the Holy Spirit. He encouraged them to help one another and do good deeds.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Believers fulfill the law of Christ when they help each other

Help Carry Each Other's Burdens (GW)

Help Each Other (NCV)

6:9a

Let us not grow weary in well-doing,

- Let us not become weary in doing good, (NIV)
- So don't get tired of doing what is good. (NLT96)
- We must not become discouraged in doing what is good.

This verse begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “and.” Some English versions, such as the ESV, translate it that way. The BSB has not translated this conjunction, and some other versions, such as the NIV and NASB, also do not translate it. In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either. Connect 6:9a to 6:8d in a way that is natural in your language.

Let us not grow weary in well-doing: This clause means “let us not become tired” or “we should continue/persevere.” Believers must not become discouraged in doing what is good, noble, and praiseworthy. They should not give up.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

We must not become tired of doing good. (NCV)

Let us not lose heart in doing good (NASB)

We must not become discouraged and stop doing good deeds.

6:9b

for in due time we will reap a harvest if we do not give up.

- for at the proper time we will reap a harvest if we do not give up. (NIV)
- I say this because if we do not stop doing what is good, we will reap eternal life at the appropriate time.
- If we do not quit, God will give us a good reward when the time is right.

for: Verse 6:9b is the basis for the command in 6:9a. We must not grow weary, for/because in due season we will reap. The Greek introduces this basis with a conjunction that the BSB translates as for.

In some languages, it is more natural to put the basis before the command. For example:

^{9b}If we do not give up, we will reap in due season.

^{9a}So let us not grow weary of doing good.

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it may not be necessary to introduce this basis with a conjunction either.

in due time we will reap a harvest: This clause is a metaphor. In this metaphor, receiving an eternal reward is compared to reaping a harvest. They are similar in that both will happen when the time is right. And both will happen if we do not give up.

The phrase in due time means “at the right time” or “when the time is right.”

Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Keep the metaphor of reaping. For example:

we will reap the harvest (GNT)

- Keep the metaphor of reaping and explain it. For example:

we will reap a harvest of blessing at the appropriate time (NLT96)

We will receive our harvest of eternal life at the right time (NCV)

- Translate the meaning directly without using a figure of speech. For example:

Certainly, each of us will receive everlasting life at the proper time (GW)

the time will come in the future when God will give us a good reward

if we do not give up: This clause is very similar in meaning to the clause “let us not grow weary” in 6:9a. This idea is repeated for emphasis.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

if we do not quit

if we do not stop doing what is good

In some languages, it is more natural to put this clause before in due time we will reap. For example:

for if we do not give up, the time will come when we will reap the harvest (GNT)

Galatians 6:10

Section 6:1–10: How to walk in the Spirit together with fellow believers

In this section, Paul asked the Galatians to continue to live a life directed by the Holy Spirit. He encouraged them to help one another and do good deeds.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Believers fulfill the law of Christ when they help each other

Help Carry Each Other's Burdens (GW)

Help Each Other (NCV)

6:10a

Therefore, as we have opportunity, let us do good to everyone,

- So then, while we have the opportunity, let us do good to all people,
- Therefore each time we can help someone, let us help him,
- Whenever we have the chance, we should treat every person well.

Therefore: Verse 6:10 concludes the previous discussion about helping fellow believers. The Greek intro-

duces this conclusion with two conjunctions that the BSB translates with the term Therefore.

Another way to translate these conjunctions are:

So then (ESV)

as we have opportunity: The Greek word that the BSB translates as opportunity is literally “time.” It refers to times/occasions for doing good.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

whenever we can (CEV)

as often as we have the chance (GNT)

whenever it is possible

let us do good to everyone: Some other ways to translate this clause are:

let us treat everyone well

we should help every person

6:10b

and especially to the family of faith.

- especially to those in the family of faith (NLT)
- particularly those who are fellow believers.
- We should especially treat well our fellow believers in Christ.

and especially to the family of faith: The clause to the family of faith refers to fellow believers. It speaks of these fellow believers as being part of the same house or family. It is their faith that makes them part of the same household. We should do good to everyone and give particular attention to fellow believers.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

especially to those in the family of faith (NLT)

especially to those who are fellow believers

particularly if they are followers of the Lord

We should give special attention to those who are in the family of believers.

See faith, Meaning 1 in the Glossary for more information.

Galatians 6:11

Section 6:11–18: Paul repeated his warning not to listen to false teachers

This section is Paul's conclusion to his letter. In this section he again contrasted circumcision and true faith. Those who teach that believers must be circumcised have a false basis for boasting. The only true basis for boasting is Christ's death on the cross. Through the cross, believers are new creations in Christ. That is what matters. The Galatians should follow these truths. They must not follow false teachers who want to add circumcision to faith.

Paul ended his letter with a blessing/prayer.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Final Warning and Benediction (ESV)

Paul's Final Advice (NLT)

Paul Summarizes His Teachings About Circumcision (GW)

6:11

See what large letters I am using to write to you with my own hand!

- ¶ I see how I myself write to you^(plur) now with my own hand using these large letters!
- ¶ I am writing the last part of this letter to you myself. You can see it by the large letters/writing that I am using.

See what large letters I am using to write to you with my own hand!: This clause indicates that at this point in the letter to the Galatians, Paul himself started to write. Up to this point, Paul had an assistant write what he told him to write. This is what he normally did. The main purpose for Paul to start to write here with his own hand was to prove that he was indeed the person behind this letter.

Some other ways to translate this verse are:

See what big letters I make as I write to you now with my own hand! (GNT)

Notice how big my writing is. I have written these words myself.

I myself am writing the last part of this letter. You can see it by the large letters that I am using.

Galatians 6:12

Section 6:11–18: Paul repeated his warning not to listen to false teachers

This section is Paul's conclusion to his letter. In this section he again contrasted circumcision and true faith. Those who teach that believers must be circumcised have a false basis for boasting. The only true basis for boasting is Christ's death on the cross. Through the cross, believers are new creations in Christ. That is what matters. The Galatians should follow these truths. They must not follow false teachers who want to add circumcision to faith.

Paul ended his letter with a blessing/prayer.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Final Warning and Benediction (ESV)

Paul's Final Advice (NLT)

Paul Summarizes His Teachings About Circumcision (GW)

6:12–13

In these verses, Paul stated that the false teachers were only thinking about themselves and how they could avoid persecution for the cross of Christ. This is the exact opposite of what Paul said about himself in 5:11. The false teachers were preaching circumcision to avoid persecution. If Paul had preached circumcision, he could have avoided persecution as well, but since he refused to do so, he was persecuted. There was no godly zeal in what the false teachers were doing.

6:12a–b

(reordered) Those who are trying to force you to be circumcised want to look good to others. (NLT)

Those who want to make a good impression outwardly are trying to compel you to be circumcised:

In some languages, it will be more natural to change the order of the clauses in 6:12a–b. For example:

^aThose who ^bare trying to force you to be circumcised ^awant to look good to others. (NLT)

6:12a

Those who want to make a good impression outwardly

- Those who want to make a good impression outwardly
- Some people want to show their goodness by the way their bodies appear.
- Those people who want to look good to others,

Those: The word that the BSB translates as Those is literally “as many as.” This word refers to the people who were deceiving the Galatians.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

Those people

And as for those people

Some people

who want to make a good impression outwardly:

This clause refers to the false teachers. They put on a good outward appearance in order that other people would think well of them and accept them. Here outwardly refers generally to external matters and specifically to circumcision. The false teachers wanted other Jews to think well of them. They themselves were circumcised, and they tried to force other people to get circumcised. They focused on the physical and external rather than the spiritual.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

want to look good to others (NLT)

who want to show off and boast about external matters (GNT)

they want to show their goodness by the way their bodies appear to others

6:12b

are trying to compel you to be circumcised.

- are trying to force you to get circumcised.
- They are trying to force you to get circumcised.
- they are trying to force you to get/be circumcised.

are trying to compel you to be circumcised: This clause also refers to the false teachers. They were trying to force the Galatian believers to get circumcised. The word compel is the same word that Paul used in 2:3a and 2:14d.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

who are trying to force you to be circumcised (GNT)

Such persons are insisting that you be circumcised (SSA)

6:12c

They only do this to avoid persecution

- They only do this so that they will not be persecuted
- They do this only so that people will not cause them to suffer
- The only reason they do this is because they do not want the Jews to persecute them.

They only do this to avoid persecution: In Greek this phrase is more literally “they only do this that they might not be persecuted.” In Greek this phrase contains the verb “persecuted,” which the BSB translates with the noun persecution. The verb “persecuted” means “causing people to suffer” because of their religious beliefs. The false teachers were afraid that the Jews would persecute them if they did not force believers to be circumcised. The false teachers were more concerned about avoiding persecution than about preaching the truth of the gospel.

The verb “persecuted” is passive. Some ways to translate this clause are:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

They don’t want to be persecuted (NLT)

They are afraid they will be attacked (NCV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

They do not want the Jews to persecute them

And they don’t want to get into trouble (CEV)

Their only aim is to avoid persecution (GW)

This verb also occurs in 1:13b and 5:11b.

They only do this to: These words introduce the false teachers’ purpose in forcing the Galatians to be circumcised. They forced the Galatians to be circumcised so that they (the false teachers) would not be persecuted.

Some other ways to introduce this purpose are:

They only do this so that

Their only purpose is

In some languages, it may be natural to translate this as the reason. For example:

The only reason they do this is (NIV)

6:12d for the cross of Christ.

- for teaching the cross of Christ.
- for preaching only about Christ's death on the cross.
- They know that if they tell people to believe only on Christ's death on the cross for salvation, they will be persecuted.

for the cross of Christ: This phrase refers to preaching only one thing: Christ died on a cross as the sacrifice for our sins. It refers to the complete gospel message of salvation by faith in Christ instead of by obeying the law. The false teachers were evidently preaching two things: people had to believe in the Messiah and also be circumcised.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

for preaching about the cross of Christ (CEV)

for teaching that the cross of Christ alone can save (NLT)

because they only tell people about Christ's death on the cross for salvation

The word the cross also occurs in 5:11c with the same meaning.

Galatians 6:13

Section 6:11–18: Paul repeated his warning not to listen to false teachers

This section is Paul's conclusion to his letter. In this section he again contrasted circumcision and true faith. Those who teach that believers must be circumcised have a false basis for boasting. The only true basis for boasting is Christ's death on the cross. Through the cross, believers are new creations in Christ. That is what matters. The Galatians should follow these truths. They must not follow false teachers who want to add circumcision to faith.

Paul ended his letter with a blessing/prayer.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Final Warning and Benediction (ESV)

Paul's Final Advice (NLT)

Paul Summarizes His Teachings About Circumcision (GW)

6:13a For the circumcised do not even keep the law themselves,

- Those who are circumcised do not even obey the law.
- Even those circumcised ones do not themselves follow the whole law.
- These false teachers are circumcised and yet they do not even follow the whole law of Moses themselves.

For: Verse 6:13 adds another point to the discussion in 6:12 about the purposes of the false teachers. The false teachers forced the Galatians to be circumcised so that:

1. they would not be persecuted (6:12c)

and

1. they could boast. (6:13c)

The Greek introduces this point with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For. Here, this conjunction does not introduce a reason. So many versions do not translate it. For example:

Not even those who are circumcised obey the law (NIV)

In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

the circumcised do not even keep the law themselves: The clause the circumcised refers to the false teachers. They are the same people to whom Paul referred in 6:12a as "those who want to make a good impression outwardly." They forced the Galatians to keep one part of the law: circumcision. But they did not bother to try to keep other parts of the law. They themselves did not keep the whole law. They were hypocrites.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

They are circumcised, but they don't obey the Law of Moses. (CEV)

even those who advocate circumcision don't keep the whole law themselves (NLT)

6:13b

yet they want you to be circumcised

- Nevertheless, they want you to be circumcised
- But they desire you to be circumcised
- But they want you to get circumcised

yet: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between the fact that the false teachers did not obey the law themselves (6:13a), and the fact that they wanted to force the Galatians believers to obey the law by being circumcised (6:13b). The Greek indicates this contrast with a conjunction that the BSB translates as yet.

they want you to be circumcised: Some other ways to translate this clause are:

they desire to have you circumcised (ESV)

they want you to get circumcised

6:13c

that they may boast in your flesh.

- so that they may boast about what was done to your flesh/body.
- so that they may boast about having/getting you circumcised.
- in order that they may brag to others because of what they forced you to do.

that they may boast: The Greek word that the BSB translates as that indicates that 6:13c is the purpose of 6:13b. The false teachers desire to have you circumcised so that they may boast.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

so that they can brag (GW)

in order that they may boast

in your flesh: The Greek phrase that the BSB literally translates as in your flesh refers to "what was done to your flesh/body." In other words, it refers to "your circumcision."

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

about what was done to your body (GW)

about what they forced you to do (NCV)

about having you circumcised (CEV)

In this clause, Paul repeated the point he made in 6:12a. That is, the false teachers want the Galatians to be circumcised because outward appearances were important to them. They wanted to boast/brag about their converts. They want others to praise them for their work.

See flesh, Meaning 4 in the Glossary for more information.

Galatians 6:14

Section 6:11–18: Paul repeated his warning not to listen to false teachers

This section is Paul's conclusion to his letter. In this section he again contrasted circumcision and true faith. Those who teach that believers must be circumcised have a false basis for boasting. The only true basis for boasting is Christ's death on the cross. Through the cross, believers are new creations in Christ. That is what matters. The Galatians should follow these truths. They must not follow false teachers who want to add circumcision to faith.

Paul ended his letter with a blessing/prayer.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Final Warning and Benediction (ESV)

Paul's Final Advice (NLT)

Paul Summarizes His Teachings About Circumcision (GW)

6:14a

But as for me, may I never boast,

- But may I never boast about anything
- But it's unthinkable for me to boast about anything
- But as for me, I will only be proud of

But as for me, may I never: Paul began verse 6:14 with a phrase that emphatically contrasted his actions with the actions of the false teachers. Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

But may I never (NET)

But far be it from me (ESV)

But it's unthinkable for me

boast: The word boast is the same word as in 6:13c.

6:14b

except in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ,

- except the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ.
- other than the death on the cross of Jesus our Lord and Christ.
- our Lord Jesus the Christ/Messiah dying on the cross to save us. Nothing else.

except in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ: This clause means that Paul will only boast about Christ's death on the cross to save us. This refers to the complete gospel message of Christ's death as the means of justification.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

about anything except the death of our Lord Jesus Christ on the cross for salvation

I will only boast about our Lord Jesus Christ dying on the cross for us.

The death of our Lord Jesus Christ on the cross to save us is the only thing I will boast about.

To many people, the cross was something to be ashamed of. But to Paul, it was something to be proud of.

our Lord Jesus Christ: In this phrase, the words Lord and Christ are titles for Jesus. In some languages, it may be necessary to make this clearer. For example:

our Lord the Christ Jesus

Jesus our Lord and Christ

our Lord Jesus. He is the Christ/Messiah

6:14c

through which the world has been crucified to me,

- By/Through that cross the world is dead to me,
- By means of his death, the world has no value/importance to me,
- Because Christ died on the cross, I no longer want what people of this world want,

through which: This phrase means "by means of the cross" or "because of the cross." As in 6:14b, the phrase "the cross" represents Christ's death on the cross.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

By his cross (GW)

by means of his cross (GNT)

Because of his cross (CEV)

Because of his death on the cross

the world: The phrase the world refers to values that exclude God. It also refers to everyone and everything that oppose God.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

values of the world

influences of the world

what people of the world value

the evil things that people in the world do

has been crucified to me: In this context, the word crucified is a figure of speech. It refers to "dying" to the world or "no longer being influenced by" the world. Paul used it to show clearly the separation between himself and the world. The world no longer had influence or power over him. He no longer valued or wanted the things that the world wants.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

is dead to me

my interest in this world died (NLT96)

the world is dead as far as I am concerned (CEV)

I no longer value/want the things of the world

6:14d

and I to the world.

- and I am dead to the world.
- and I have no value/importance to the world.
- and the people of this world do not want what I want.

and I to the world: The complete form of this phrase is "and I have been crucified to the world." This continues the figure of speech. It means "I am like a dead

person to the world.” In other words, the world does not value or want what is important to Paul.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

and the world’s interest in me is also...dead
(NLT96)

and I am dead as far as the world is concerned
(CEV)

the world no longer values/wants what I value/
want.

Galatians 6:15

Section 6:11–18: Paul repeated his warning not to listen to false teachers

This section is Paul’s conclusion to his letter. In this section he again contrasted circumcision and true faith. Those who teach that believers must be circumcised have a false basis for boasting. The only true basis for boasting is Christ’s death on the cross. Through the cross, believers are new creations in Christ. That is what matters. The Galatians should follow these truths. They must not follow false teachers who want to add circumcision to faith.

Paul ended his letter with a blessing/prayer.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Final Warning and Benediction (ESV)

Paul’s Final Advice (NLT)

Paul Summarizes His Teachings About Circumcision (GW)

6:15a

For neither circumcision nor uncircumcision means anything.

- Whether a man is circumcised or he is not circumcised does not matter.
- Circumcision is of no value, neither is not being circumcised of any value.
- It is not important if a man is circumcised or uncircumcised. (NCV)

For: Verse 6:15 further explains what Paul said in 6:14. Paul explained that being dead to the world means that the things of the world, such as circumcision, are no longer important. The Greek introduces this expla-

nation with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For.

Many English versions do not translate this conjunction. In some languages, it may not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

neither circumcision nor uncircumcision means anything: In Greek, this clause is more literally “neither is circumcision anything, nor uncircumcision.” The BSB adds the word means to make the meaning clearer. It does not matter whether a person is circumcised or not. Paul had said this in 5:6 as well.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

It is not important if a man is circumcised or uncircumcised. (NCV)

Certainly, it doesn’t matter whether a person is circumcised or not. (GW)

Circumcision is of no value, neither is not being circumcised of any value.

6:15b

What counts is a new creation.

- But what does matter is being a new creation.
- What is of value is being changed into new and different people.
- The important thing is being the new people God has made. (NCV)

What counts is a new creation: The phrase a new creation refers to the new creatures/people that God makes. God completely changes a person when he becomes a believer. The important thing is the change that God makes in believers. They live their lives through the power of the Spirit.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

All that matters is that you are a new person.
(CEV)

what does matter is being a new creature (GNT)

The important thing is being the new people God has made. (NCV)

What counts is whether we really have been changed into new and different people. (NLT96)

Galatians 6:16

Section 6:11–18: Paul repeated his warning not to listen to false teachers

This section is Paul's conclusion to his letter. In this section he again contrasted circumcision and true faith. Those who teach that believers must be circumcised have a false basis for boasting. The only true basis for boasting is Christ's death on the cross. Through the cross, believers are new creations in Christ. That is what matters. The Galatians should follow these truths. They must not follow false teachers who want to add circumcision to faith.

Paul ended his letter with a blessing/prayer.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Final Warning and Benediction (ESV)

Paul's Final Advice (NLT)

Paul Summarizes His Teachings About Circumcision (GW)

6:16

In 6:16, the BSB does not follow the order of the Greek clauses. Other versions, such as the ESV, do follow the Greek order. In some languages it will be more natural to follow the Greek clause order and in some languages it will be more natural to use the same clause order as the BSB. Compare the order of the BSB and ESV below.

^bPeace and mercy ^ato all who walk by this rule,
^ceven to the Israel of God. (BSB)

^aAnd as for all who walk by this rule, ^bpeace and mercy be upon them, ^cand upon the Israel of God. (ESV)

6:16a

Peace and mercy to all

- May peace and mercy be upon all
- May God's peace and mercy/pity be on
- May God give them peace in their hearts and pity them.

Peace and mercy to all: In this clause, Paul wished/prayed that God would bless those who live as a new creation in Christ. The word Peace refers to God's gift of wholeness and well-being. The word mercy refers to God's kindness and compassion.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

may God show them undeserved kindness and bless them with peace

peace be on them, and mercy (KJV)

God's peace and mercy be upon them

I ask God to give them peace in their hearts and pity/mercy

Peace: The Jewish concept of Peace includes both an absence of war and a state of well-being, safety, health, and economic prosperity. All this comes from God for those who are in a relationship with him.

Few languages will have a word for "peace" that is as broad as the Jewish concept. Some languages will have a word to describe the absence of war or conflict and a different word to describe a general state of well-being. If possible, choose your word that has the broadest range of meaning. (If you must make a choice, a word that describes a state of well-being is preferable in this context.)

Some other ways to translate this word are:

well-being

good situation

harmony

The word for Peace first occurs in 1:3.

mercy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mercy refers to God showing kindness, compassion, or pity on people because they suffer or are needy. Mercy has a similar meaning to the word "grace." But "grace" focuses more on the goodness of God towards people even when they do not deserve it.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

pity

compassion

This is the only time in Galatians that the word "mercy" occurs.

6:16b**who walk by this rule,**

- those who live according to this principle,
- all who follow/obey this teaching,
- That is what I pray for all people who walk according to this rule.

who walk by this rule: This clause refers to “every-one who follows this rule/principle.” This is the rule/principle that is in 6:15: what is important is the new creation, not circumcision.

Here the word rule does not refer to a rule or commandment in the law of Moses.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

As for those who follow this rule in their lives
(GNT)

all those who live by this principle (NLT96)

Everyone who follows what I just said

All who walk according to this teaching

6:16c**even to the Israel of God.**

- even upon the true Israel of God.
- They are God’s true Israel/people.

even to the Israel of God: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as even.

1. It means even or that is. According to this interpretation, the phrase the Israel of God is another way to talk about “those who walk by this rule.” It is the same group of people described in two ways. Believers are the spiritual Israel. For example:

They are the Israel of God. (GW) (BSB, NIV, RSV, REB, GW, CEV, NLT, JBP)

1. It means and or also. According to this interpretation, the phrase the Israel of God refers to a different group of people than “those who walk by this rule.” There are two groups. For example:

may peace and mercy be with them—with them and with all of God’s people (GNT) (GNT, ESV, NRSV, KJV, NASB, NJB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is the most common interpretation of this verse. Those who follow this interpretation are Moo, pp. 400–403; Fung, pp. 310–311, Schreiner, pp. 381–383; George, pp. 439–440; Lightfoot, p. 225; Hendriksen, p. 247; and Lührmann, p. 122.

the Israel of God: This phrase refers to those who are children of Abraham by faith. It includes all Jews and Gentiles who believe in Jesus Christ for salvation. These believers are those who walk as a new creation in Christ. These people are the true sons of Abraham and thus the true Israel. (See 3:29.)

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

the true Israel of God (JBP)

to God’s true people (CEV)

the true Israel, the people of God who believe in Christ

Israel: The word Israel refers to God’s chosen people. Abraham had a son named Jacob. Jacob was also called Israel. God gave Israel twelve sons who became the twelve tribes of Israel, that is, the Jewish nation. This nation was also called Israel. God set that nation apart as his people.

Galatians 6:17**Section 6:11–18: Paul repeated his warning not to listen to false teachers**

This section is Paul’s conclusion to his letter. In this section he again contrasted circumcision and true faith. Those who teach that believers must be circumcised have a false basis for boasting. The only true basis for boasting is Christ’s death on the cross. Through the cross, believers are new creations in Christ. That is what matters. The Galatians should follow these truths. They must not follow false teachers who want to add circumcision to faith.

Paul ended his letter with a blessing/prayer.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Final Warning and Benediction (ESV)

Paul’s Final Advice (NLT)

Paul Summarizes His Teachings About Circumcision (GW)

6:17a**From now on let no one cause me trouble,**

- ¶ Starting today, do^(plur) not give me any more trouble.
- ¶ Beginning from now, do not cause me any more trouble/problems,
- ¶ From now on, don't make any trouble for me! (GW)

From now on: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as From now on is literally “of the remainder.” There are two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. It means from now on (and continuing into the future). For example:

From now on, don't let anyone trouble me (NLT)
(BSB, ESV, NIV11, RSV, REB, NASB, NET, KJV, GW, NLT)

1. It means Finally. For example:

Finally, let no one cause me trouble (NIV) (NIV, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The majority of commentators and most English versions follow this interpretation.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

Beginning from now

Starting today

let no one cause me trouble: This clause is a command from Paul to the Galatians. He commands them to stop causing him problems. They had already caused him enough trouble. They should stop causing him trouble by no longer following the false teachers.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

do not give me any more trouble (NCV)

do not cause me to suffer anymore

6:17b**for I bear on my body the marks of Jesus.**

- I have scars on my body that show I belong to Christ Jesus. (NCV)
- because the scars I have on my body show that I am the slave of Jesus. (GNT)

- I say this because on my body are scars. These scars are from people beating me because I preach about Jesus.

for: Verse 6:17b is the basis for the command in 6:17a not to cause Paul any more trouble. The Greek introduces the basis for this command with a conjunction that the BSB translate as for.

Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. For example:

I have scars on my body that show I belong to Christ Jesus. (NCV)

In some languages, it will not be necessary to translate this conjunction either.

In other languages, it will be more natural to put the basis for the command before the command itself. For example:

^bOn my own body are scars that prove I belong to Christ Jesus. ^aSo I don't want anyone to bother me anymore. (CEV)

I bear on my body the marks of Jesus: The phrase the marks of Jesus refer to the physical scars that Paul had on his body. He got these scars because he was beaten for preaching the true gospel of Jesus.

Some other ways to translate this clause are:

I have scars on my body that show I belong to Christ Jesus. (NCV)

On my own body are scars that prove I belong to Christ Jesus. (CEV)

I have scars on my body. These scars are from people beating me because I preach about Jesus.

Galatians 6:18**Section 6:11–18: Paul repeated his warning not to listen to false teachers**

This section is Paul's conclusion to his letter. In this section he again contrasted circumcision and true faith. Those who teach that believers must be circumcised have a false basis for boasting. The only true basis for boasting is Christ's death on the cross. Through the cross, believers are new creations in Christ. That is what matters. The Galatians should fol-

low these truths. They must not follow false teachers who want to add circumcision to faith.

Paul ended his letter with a blessing/prayer.

Some other possible headings for this section are:

Final Warning and Benediction (ESV)

Paul's Final Advice (NLT)

Paul Summarizes His Teachings About Circumcision (GW)

Paragraph 6:18

Verse 6:18 is Paul's final prayer for the Galatians. He prayed that they would enjoy the gracious presence of Jesus in their lives.

6:18a

The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with your spirit, brothers.

- ¶ May the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ will be with you, my brothers.
- ¶ My fellow believers, I pray that Jesus our Lord the Christ will favor/bless you.
- ¶ My friends, I pray that the Lord Jesus Christ will be kind to you. (CEV)

The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ: The word grace means "favor" or "good will." Paul's prayer for the Galatians was that they would know God's favor and blessing.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

I pray that the grace/favor of our Lord Jesus Christ

May Jesus our Lord the Christ/Messiah bless

See grace, Meaning 1 in the Glossary.

our Lord Jesus Christ: This phrase is the same phrase as in 6:14b. As there, the words Lord and Christ are titles. In some language, it will be necessary to make it clear that these words are titles. For example:

our Lord the Christ Jesus

Jesus our Lord the Christ/Messiah

be with your spirit: The words your spirit refer to the Galatians. In many languages, it will be clearer to simply say "be with you." For example:

be with you all (GNT)

In some languages, it will be natural to combine this phrase with the word "grace." For example:

I pray that the Lord Jesus Christ will be kind to you! (CEV)

brothers: As in 6:1a, the word brothers refers to all the believers in Galatia. It includes both men and women.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

brothers and sisters (NET)

my fellow believers

my friends (GNT)

In some languages, it will be more natural to put this word first in the verse. For example:

My dear brothers and sisters, may the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you all. (NLT96)

6:18b

Amen.

- So be it.
- May it be so.

Amen: The word Amen means "let it be so." Many languages transliterate this word.

Some other ways to translate this word are:

Let it be so.

May it be so.